

NOVEL

9

Written by
Tenichi

Illustrated by
Suzunosuke

THE MOST
HERETICAL
LAST BOSS QUEEN

FROM VILLAINNESS TO SAVIOR

Table of Contents

[Color Inserts](#)

[Table of Contents Page](#)

[Title Page](#)

[Characters](#)

[Copyrights and Credits](#)

[Chapter 1: The Unconcerned Princess Reflects on the Past](#)

[Chapter 2: The Prime Minister's Concerns](#)

[Chapter 3: The Deliveryman's and the Trade Prince's Concerns](#)

[Chapter 4: The Vice Captain of the Eighth Squadron's Concerns](#)

[Chapter 5: The Royal Prince's Concerns](#)

[Chapter 6: A Story Worthy of a Prequel](#)

[Chapter 7: Opening Curtain](#)

[Chapter 8: "But All of That Wouldn't Happen for Ten More Years, on the Day of Tiara's Sixteenth Birthday."](#)

[Changing Hearts](#)

[Marionettes](#)

[Afterword](#)

[Newsletter](#)



Stay up to date On Light Novels by Downloading our mobile App

[Zerobooks Universal](#)

[Zerobooks USA ONLY](#)

[Zerobooks IOS](#)

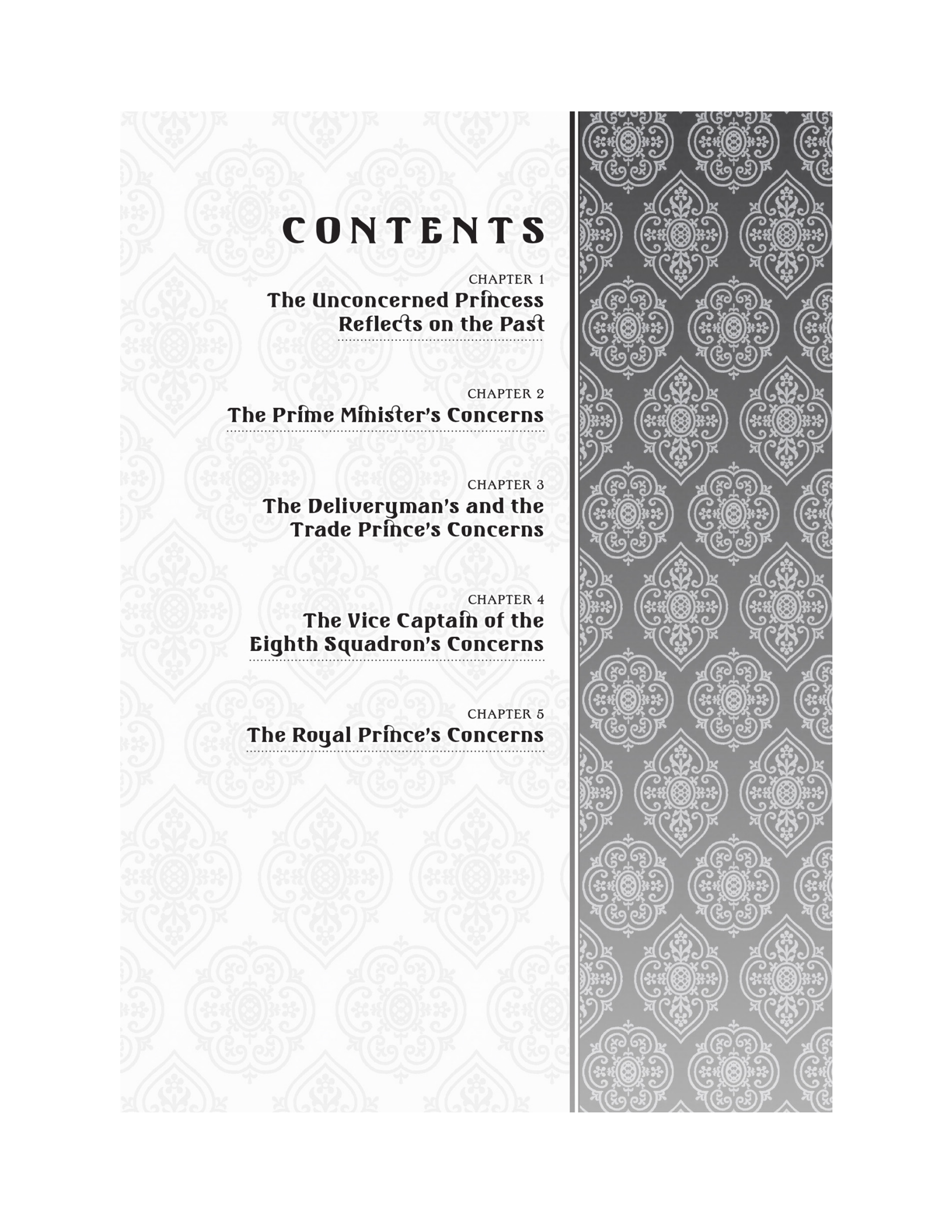
Download all your Favorite Light Novels

[Jnovels.com](#)

[Join our Discord and meet Thousands of LN readers to chat with](#)







CONTENTS

CHAPTER 1

The Unconcerned Princess Reflects on the Past

CHAPTER 2

The Prime Minister's Concerns

CHAPTER 3

The Deliveryman's and the Trade Prince's Concerns

CHAPTER 4

The Vice Captain of the Eighth Squadron's Concerns

CHAPTER 5

The Royal Prince's Concerns



CHAPTER 6

A Story Worthy of a Prequel

CHAPTER 7

Opening Curtain

CHAPTER 8

**“But All of That Wouldn’t Happen
for Ten More Years, on the Day
of Tiara’s Sixteenth Birthday.”**

Changing Hearts

Marionettes

Afterword

THE MOST
HERETICAL
LAST BOSS QUEEN
FROM VILLAINESS TO SAVIOR

NOVEL
9

WRITTEN BY
Tenichi
ILLUSTRATED BY
Suzunosuke



Seven Seas Entertainment

Characters



❧Pride❧

The firstborn princess of the kingdom of Freesia. At age eight, she realized she'd been reborn as the last boss queen from an otome game called "ORL" that she played in her past life. Pride is determined to do all she can to prevent the tragedies the love interests experience in the game, as well as work tirelessly for her country and people. Her wit and combat skills endow her with such extraordinary power, it's like she's cheating. Pride possesses the special power of precognition.

❧Stale❧

The firstborn prince and Pride's younger adoptive brother. A love interest in the original otome game. Stale possesses the special power of teleportation. He signed a subordination contract with Pride.

❧Arthur❧

Captain of the Eighth Squadron of the Freesian royal order of knights. A love interest in the original otome game. Arthur possesses the special power to cure all diseases. He serves as one of Pride's imperial knights.

❧Tiara❧

The second-born princess and Pride's younger sister. Delicate and beautiful, Tiara is also the heroine of the otome.

❧Rosa❧

Pride's mother and queen of Freesia. Rosa possesses the special power of precognition.

❧Albert❧

Pride's father and prince consort of Freesia.

❧Vest❧

Pride's uncle and the queen's adoptive younger brother. Serves as the Freesian seneschal.

❧Gilbert❧

Prime minister of Freesia. A love interest in the original otome game. Gilbert possesses the special power of age control.

❧Roderick❧

Commander of the Freesian royal order of knights and Arthur's father. Possesses the special power to nullify all attacks with bladed weapons.

❧Clark❧

Vice commander of the Freesian royal order. A good friend of Roderick's.

Alan

Captain of the First Squadron of the royal order. One of Pride's imperial knights.

Eric

Vice captain of the First Squadron of the royal order. One of Pride's imperial knights.

Callum

Captain of the Third Squadron of the royal order. One of Pride's imperial knights.

Harrison

Vice captain of the Eighth Squadron of the royal order.

Val

A former thief who entered into a fealty contract with Pride. Currently works as a delivery-man. Possesses the special power of earth sculpting.

Khemet

A former orphan. Possesses the power to amplify others' special abilities. Sefekh's little brother.

Sefekh

A former orphan. Possesses the power to produce water. Khemet's older sister.

The Kingdom of Anemone

Leon

The firstborn prince of Anemone. Pride's ex-fiancé. One of the love interests in the original otome game.

Rajah Empire

Adam

Crown prince of Rajah. Has conquered many lands and expanded the empire's domain.

The United Hanazuo Kingdom

Cedric

The prince and younger brother of the Cercian king. A love interest in the original otome game. Cedric came to Freesia himself to first propose the alliance.

Lance

King of Cercis. Cedric's older brother. A good friend of Yohan's.

Yohan

King of Chinensis and a very religious man. A good friend of Lance's.

Vocabulary

The Kingdom of Freesia: A great kingdom ruled by queens with the special power of precognition. The only country in the world where people with special powers are born.

The Kingdom of Anemone: A neighboring country of Freesia. One of the biggest trading hubs in the world.

The United Hanazuo Kingdom: A country founded by the union of Cercis, a land rich with gold, and Chinensis, a land famous for its minerals.

Rajah Empire: The largest slave-producing country. They expand their territory by enslaving people and invading other lands.

Our Ray of Light (ORL): The otome game Pride played in her past life. This title was so popular, it was expanded into a series.

Higeki no Genkyoutonaru Saikyou Gedou Rasubosu
Joou wa Taminotameni Tsukushimasu. Vol. 9
© 2024 Tenichi. All rights reserved.
First published in Japan in 2024 by Ichijinsha Inc., Tokyo.
Publication rights for this English edition arranged
through KODANSHA LTD., Tokyo.

No portion of this book may be reproduced or transmitted
in any form without written permission from the copyright
holders. This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places,
and incidents are the products of the author's imagination
or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual events,
locales, or persons, living or dead, is entirely coincidental.
Any information or opinions expressed by the creators of this
book belong to those individual creators and do not necessarily
reflect the views of Seven Seas Entertainment or its employees.

Seven Seas press and purchase enquiries can be sent to
Marketing Manager Lauren Hill at press@gomanga.com.
Information regarding the distribution and purchase of
digital editions is available from Digital Manager
CK Russell at digital@gomanga.com.

Seven Seas and the Seven Seas logo are trademarks of
Seven Seas Entertainment. All rights reserved.

Follow Seven Seas Entertainment online at
sevenseasentertainment.com.

TRANSLATION: Emma Schumacker
ADAPTATION: Michelle McGuinness
LOGO DESIGN: H. Qi
COVER DESIGN: Mariel Dágá
INTERIOR DESIGN: Clay Gardner
INTERIOR LAYOUT: Tanya Sokolovskaya
COPY EDITOR: Meg van Huygen
PROOFREADER: Cheri Ebisu
EDITOR: T. Anne
PREPRESS TECHNICIAN: Salvador Chan Jr., April Malig, Jules Valera
MANAGING EDITOR: Alyssa Scavetta
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF: Julie Davis
PUBLISHER: Lianne Sentar
VICE PRESIDENT: Adam Arnold
PRESIDENT: Jason DeAngelis

ISBN: 979-8-89561-546-1
Printed in Canada
First Printing: September 2025
10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

Chapter 1:
The Unconcerned Princess Reflects on the Past
PRIDE

“WELCOME HOME, Big Sister, Big Brother!”

We begin this story two months after my birthday party, where the new system of marriage candidacy had been introduced to the public.

Our carriage had slowed to a stop in front of the royal residence. Tiara, our kingdom’s second-born princess and my adorable little sister, stood in the center of a large crowd awaiting our return. The fifteen-year-old beamed at me with a smile as sunny and bright as her wavy golden hair and golden eyes.

An attendant opened the carriage doors so Arthur and Vice Captain Eric, two of my imperial knights, could exit first. Each knight acknowledged Tiara’s enthusiastic greeting.

Then Stale, the prince and our adoptive brother, stepped out as well. “We’re back, Tiara,” he said. “Were you a good girl while we were away?”

Stale padded forth, waving to the crowd with regal bearing. He had jet-black hair and dark eyes behind black-framed glasses. With a small smile for his cute little sister, he stopped beside the carriage.

Finally, it was my turn to emerge. I, Pride Royal Ivy, was crown princess of our nation. My wavy crimson hair spilled down my back, and my purple eyes tapered into a sharp point at the corners.

I took Stale's proffered hand and carefully descended from the carriage. "It's good to see you again, Tiara," I said as I alighted. "How have things been? I really missed you while we were gone."

"Big Sister!" Tiara cried, flinging her arms wide and leaping toward me.

Stale and I embraced her together, as we often did. I looked up and spotted Jack, my guard, among the onlookers. My personal maids, Mary and Lotte, and my other imperial knights, Captain Callum and Captain Alan, had already exited from a separate carriage. All of them smiled at the three of us. We were royals of the great Kingdom of Freesia, the only country in this world where people were born with special powers.

"Are King Lance and King Yohan doing well?" Tiara asked me.

My smile fell when Tiara nonchalantly excluded Cedric. "Yes, as is Cedric..." I understood why she didn't want to discuss a man she hated, but I couldn't leave him out.

Cedric was the second-born prince—now royal prince, with his brother as king—of the United Hanazuo Kingdom. Stale and I had traveled to his country to attend his birthday party, but Tiara had stayed behind, as she hadn't yet come of age. We had no choice but to leave her at home during the trip, which included a ten-day journey each way.

In a chipper voice, I added, "He was pleased with our birthday present!"

"That's good," she murmured into my chest.

Stale and I exchanged a glance. Tiara's anger toward Cedric clearly hadn't dwindled since she'd last seen him.

In this world, poor Cedric's feelings went unrequited, but in the game, Cedric was the go-to love interest for Tiara. The game version of Cedric Silva Lowell was a romanceable character and the prince who sold out his kingdom. He was also the heroine's fiancé and a toy for the last boss queen to use as she pleased.

This whole world came from the otome game *Our Ray of Light*, or "ORL" for short. The game got so popular, it was turned into a series. Throughout the story, the heroine healed the wounds inflicted on the love interests' hearts until they were strong enough to stand together against the evil last boss queen. I was only eight years old when I regained my memories of my past life and realized I'd been reborn into the first game in that series.

"There's more I'd like to discuss with you later," I said to Tiara. "Could you come to my room after I report to Mother?"

"Of course! I already asked the maids to prepare tea! I even have your favorite cake ready to eat!"

Tiara Royal Ivy was the game's protagonist. The evil queen locked her in an isolated tower until her sixteenth birthday, but through all that, she remained a gentle princess who brought salvation to the grieving love interests.

Stale and I entered the royal residence with Tiara's arms looped through ours. Though I had considered taking the carriage straight to the main palace and delivering my report to Mother, I'd opted to stay

with Tiara and the welcoming party. We headed through the halls toward the palace, which allowed me to spend more time catching up.

"Everyone really missed you two!" Tiara told us. "I'm sure Prince Leon is eager to see you too! Aren't you excited for his next visit?!"

Leon Adonis Coronaria was another of ORL's love interests. The brokenhearted prince—pitiful fiancé of the last boss queen herself—spent his days shut away inside his room in the game.

"Yes, I hope to see him soon," I said.

"I need to speak with Uncle Vest after we report to Mother, so the two of you should begin the tea party without me," Stale said.

Stale was also a love interest in the game. He served as Freesia's seneschal, and the last boss queen controlled him through a subordination contract. And just as he was here, game-Stale was the heroine's adoptive older brother.

"Huh?" Arthur cut in. "Is something goin' on, Sta—erm, *Prince* Stale?"

Arthur Beresford was yet another romanceable character. After watching the last boss queen leave his father to die on a whim, he threw himself into training, eventually becoming the strongest knight in the kingdom and commander of the royal order at a very young age.

Here and now, he only barely managed to stop himself from speaking to Stale in his usual familiar manner. Arthur repeated his question properly, concerned what the others would think of such an informal address. As close friends, Arthur and Stale didn't concern

themselves with politeness when they were alone, though Stale was just as cautious as Arthur while in public.

"I simply want to check in with him," Stale said. "I'd like to return to being his assistant as soon as possible and see if there's anything I can assist with."

"Say hello to Prime Minister Gilbert for me too, Big Brother!"

According to the game's lore, Gilbert Butler had lost his true body after his beloved partner died. He had a secret route in the game, and he was a pawn for the last boss to manipulate.

I then turned to Captain Alan and Captain Callum. "Are you two making your reports at the royal order after this?"

"Yes, but we're in no rush, so we'll escort you to the palace first," Captain Alan said. The upbeat and reliable leader of the First Squadron didn't appear in the game. "Or we could have Arthur and Eric take over for us at this point."

"Stop trying to make the younger knights do our work for us, Alan," Captain Callum said. He didn't appear in the game either, though here he served as the clever and caring leader of the Third Squadron.

"There's still plenty of time before we're supposed to change shifts," Vice Captain Eric cut in. This kind and gentle member of the First Squadron was absent from the game as well.

"I agree with Vice Captain Eric!" Tiara said. "Besides, the First Squadron's missing both its captain and vice captain! You should really get back sooner rather than later!"

"Right, so you're saying it doesn't matter if it's me or Eric who goes back," Captain Alan said.

His hearty laugh echoed off the walls. Captain Callum warned him about being too informal in the royal residence, but Tiara and I were already giggling. Even Stale, as he pushed up his black frames, couldn't help but smile at our failed attempts to hide our laughter.

The Pride Royal Ivy of the game did no such thing. She was the wicked and devious last boss queen who gouged wounds into the love interests' hearts before they managed to overcome her.

I thanked my jovial knights with a heartfelt smile. "Our expedition went off without a hitch thanks to the hard work of my imperial knights. I'll be sure to thank Commander Roderick as well when I see him. I'm so happy we all made it back safely!"

At this point in my life, I was treading a different path from the Pride in the game. Here, I walked with the people I loved at my side.

And I knew they felt the same.



Chapter 2:
The Prime Minister's Concerns
GILBERT

"DID YOU CATCH A COLD, Prime Minister Gilbert?" Prince Stale asked.

His face was perfectly neutral, his eyes, hair, and glasses all jet-black. He'd come to my office to assist with work that had piled up while I focused on my prime minister duties. Even as he spoke, he sorted through the mountain of paperwork before him like it was second nature.

"No, my throat's just a bit dry," I said. "Perhaps I'm starting to show my age."

In lieu of a response, the prince cast a glance out the window. My throat spasmed before I could say anything else, causing me to sputter and cough.

"It must be because the temperature has been fluctuating so much during the day," Prince Stale said then. "Wouldn't it be better for you to live here in the castle? You wouldn't have to commute."

I was grateful that he was looking out for me in his own way. And he was right: I could easily obtain permission to reside in the castle if I wanted to. It was a natural solution for me, as I had nowhere to call home in my current state, yet...

"I appreciate your concern, but I'm quite fond of my current living arrangements."

"You *enjoy* living among the lowest classes of society, without so much as a modest house to live in? Even as the prime minister?"

I fell silent. Though he wasn't mocking me, Prince Stale clearly didn't agree with my decision. Stern as he was, his blank expression and bluntness carried nothing but honest curiosity.

Studying my aged, wrinkled hands, I rasped, "You have sharp ears. I'd expect nothing less from you, Seneschal Stale."

"I don't know what's being done to you, but you should stay out of such matters. You won't simply walk away if these violent people learn you're the Freesian prime minister."

He needn't have concerned himself with that. No one would ever suspect a mere "child" and the old man who served as prime minister were one and the same. I checked my reflection in the window. My ponytail of light-blue locks fell over my shoulder. Wrinkles nearly obscured my eyes, which were the same color as my hair. That unsightly old man staring back at me looked nothing like the child I could transform into with my special power.

But if the prince knew I was going to the slums, perhaps Her Majesty had figured it out too.

"The queen doesn't know about this," Prince Stale said, immediately dispelling my worries. "Even I've only heard rumors."

"I'm simply...living a life that's appropriate for me."

I sorted through my documents and checked them over before signing and stamping them. It was a tedious process, and I'd have to repeat it for every last document in the stack. I set the most pressing

papers on my desk as I took a seat. Standing for so long was hard on my elderly body. Prince Stale sat at another desk, reviewing the papers in order of urgency. He remained standing while he worked, his eyes devoid of any warmth when they flicked up to me.

"Don't overexert yourself, Prime Minister Gilbert. You're already doing the work of both a prime minister and prince consort."

"I appreciate your concern, Seneschal Stale. It pains me to rely on your assistance."

This young man was the seneschal, and he served at the queen's beck and call. Yet he somehow found time to help me with my work. At first, he visited solely to deliver the queen's orders—that I was to finish up urgent matters at once—but somewhere along the way, the two of us had joined forces to conquer the tasks of seneschal, prime minister, and prince consort. We even carried out the public duties of the queen herself.

"I'm not doing this for you," he said. "It's my job too. Besides... you're the one who assisted me when I first became seneschal and didn't have a clue what to do. Even after what I did to you..."

"Hm? What could you be referring to? Goodness, my memory is so spotty these days," I replied, trying to keep the conversation flowing.

The queen had secretly executed Vest, leaving the young Prince Stale to take up the mantle of seneschal. Both the queen and the prince had been children at the time. There was little I could do for Prince Stale, but I was already juggling two roles, so adding on another didn't make much of a difference.

However, that was when Her Majesty ordered Prince Stale to investigate why I was keeping Maria hidden in a room in the castle. I couldn't stand by as the boy drowned in the new seneschal duties that were completely foreign to him, even if he represented a threat to my family.

Another violent coughing fit came over me, and I hunched over my desk, hoping to quell it. It was too much for my elderly body. A fresh bout of coughing followed fast on the heels of the first, and I struggled to apologize to Prince Stale when it passed.

His response was curt. "Sign this."

"Of course. Wait, this is..."

I squinted my blurry eyes at the paperwork he'd asked me to review and sign as the acting prince consort, only to find that it was a document I hadn't looked over yet. I recognized it nonetheless. As I scanned the pages, I felt even more paperwork stacking up in my future.

"My birthday party was a month ago," he said. "This is a list of palace officials who misappropriated their gifts to me, as well as a declaration of the punishment they'll receive. I intend to show it to Her Majesty as well, but first, I need your permission."

Prince Stale's reports about punishing palace officials were nothing new. His special power of teleportation was useful in bringing their corruption to light and purging them in the name of the queen. Laying a hand on the royal family or any Freesian resources was a grave crime in and of itself, but the current queen took the punishment for such acts even further. She would execute the culprits,

or maybe even punish entire families. Prince Stale was fully aware of this, but he continued to expose new offenders.

"It's hard to believe people of such high rank are still falling victim to simple greed," I said.

"I have no interest in receiving presents, but they're useful for exposing corruption like this."

It was the first time Prince Stale's lips curved toward a smirk. His jet-black eyes turned darker still, like roiling black smoke was billowing inside them. The prince only smiled in times like these, when exercising his own free will in exposing officials or deciding their fates. Considering the circumstances of his birth and the life he'd lived up to this point, perhaps it was only natural that he wanted to eliminate every last official who filled their pockets with the citizens' hard-earned tax money. Even so, it was hard to deny that the current dictatorship was *why* people were resorting to stealing government resources.

Commoners weren't the only ones struggling under this system; high-ranking nobles, including palace officials, watched their coffers dry up. They needed funds to maintain land and employ workers, lest they fail to protect their families and their pride as nobles. Ordinarily, the upper echelons of society could use a dictatorship as a means to seize the opportunity to indulge in luxuries while they let the common folk starve, but Prince Stale refused to accept that. He made sure every last fool taking advantage of the political landscape would be punished. That was how he'd managed to eliminate even more greedy higher-ups than the queen tasked him with finding. All the while, the

royal family's wealth—or rather, the queen's—only grew. Prince Stale was defending the wealth of the one person he likely wanted to punish more than anyone else in the world.

“Please take good care of yourself, Prince Stale. You’re overworking just as much as I am.”

I didn’t want to stop him, not really. Through his efforts, fewer and fewer nobles picked the pockets of innocent Freesians. He and I were of a similar mind there. However, I couldn’t help worrying about his well-being. He’d become seneschal while still a child and frequently abused his body in service of the queen. I wasn’t certain if she’d brainwashed him, if she was blackmailing him, if Prince Stale had some other objective, or if he’d signed a subordination contract with her. In any case, he worked obediently for the queen and took extra measures that left him with even more blood on his hands.

The handsome young man’s face had an ill pallor. Dark circles shadowed his eyes, betraying his lack of sleep. Prince Stale pushed his glasses up and turned his face away when I pleaded with him to look after himself, but there was no hiding the deep fatigue plaguing him.

In the face of his determined silence, I changed the subject. “I see you’ve grown accustomed to wearing those glasses.”

He regarded me once more with that blank, unsmiling face of his, the fingers on his glasses relaxing for just a moment. Then he pinched the frames as if to remind himself they were still there. “Thank you very much.”

Prince Stale once had excellent vision, but it had withered away with his seneschal work. Young as he was, the days spent poring over

unfamiliar paperwork had put a strain on him—especially his eyes. Initially, not even the prince had realized his sight was deteriorating; I had been the one to suggest he get glasses.

My vision was also foggy in my current body, but I could get by if I squinted. I'd watched for too long as Prince Stale hunched closer to the papers on his desk and wrinkled the brow of his usually expressionless face before I called for an eyewear specialist to make him a pair of glasses. Once he finally got them, the permanent crease in his forehead eased away. He'd asked how I noticed the change in the first place, but after that day, I never saw him without those glasses.

I finished signing and stamping the documents, then returned them to Prince Stale. He looked them over with perfect composure, then thanked me. "All right. I'm going to submit these to Her Majesty. I'll be back once these people have been dealt with."

With that final declaration, the prince teleported away. I could sense his eagerness to eliminate the corruption as quickly as possible.

I picked up the dozens of documents still needing my attention. I read them over, signed them, and stamped them. This simple, never-ending process was the same one Albert had conducted before me.

Then I erupted into another coughing fit, covering my mouth as my shoulders shook. The longer it went on, the more I struggled to breathe between desperate, wheezing inhales. I had been slightly feverish when I awoke this morning, and I must have let my defenses down once Prince Stale left. My vision blurred, and I gripped the desk

with my craggy fingers. I probably would have felt much better if I could only turn my body to a different age, but that was impossible. I couldn't return to my child form while there was a risk of Prince Stale teleporting into the room at any moment.

"If anything...it's fitting for a criminal like me to suffer."

I kept my hands moving. Even with my breath ragged and my eyes watering, I read the documents, signed them with trembling hands, and pressed my stamp to the pages as best I could. I needed to finish the batch before the end of the day.

By the time I left that night, the starving Freesian citizens would be waiting outside of my residence again. One was a young girl on the verge of selling her body to pay her taxes. Another was a mother whose child had been kidnapped by human traffickers. There was a father ready to resort to crime if it meant supporting his family. Children and the elderly came in search of food after living off nothing more than muddy water. I had to find money and food for them again tonight, even if only a little.

"I have...to keep living... I have...to make up for what I've done..."

I took unsteady breaths and repeated those words to myself. I would never have a moment's rest. Because I had cast so many citizens into despair, yet couldn't save the one woman I loved, this was the only way I had to atone for my sins.

"Are you sick, Gilbert?"

Prince Stale asked this in a low voice, clearly restraining some emotion. His question snapped me out of the fever-induced haze I'd been lost in, and I found the prince staring me down with a scowl. He'd received some time off from Vest and was visiting my office to study prince consort duties and assist me in my work. Anger clouded his jet-black eyes as he helped me sort documents in his limited free time.

"No, my throat's just a bit dry," I said.

"Yet it doesn't seem to stop you from talking, does it?"

As always, the prince showed me no mercy.

I smiled and said "Yes, I'm fortunate, aren't I?" to soften the blow of his anger. For that, I received a piercing glare. My throat seized, replacing any comment I might have made with a coughing fit.

"Sounds a lot worse than a simple sore throat," Prince Stale said. "What excuse are you going to give me this time?"

His eyes fell back down to the documents in his hand. After reading through some of the more urgent paperwork, he placed the stack on my desk.

"Look at all the work we still have to do. Tell me, was it Maria or Stella who got you sick?"

"Fortunately, they're both in perfect health. I believe it's the fluctuating temperature that's done me in."

While the sun beat down during the day, a chill crept through the night. I'd probably spent too much time exposed to the evening winds during my commute home.

"Then you should see a doctor as soon as possible. Knowing you, you've been keeping your sickness to yourself, haven't you?"

"A little cold isn't worth bothering the castle's doctor or apotheca —"

Drat. By the time I realized what I'd said, Prince Stale was glowering fiercely at me. The anger in his silence was palpable—as was a bit of resignation.

"I see... Now I understand. You feel ashamed of wasting our staff's talents on the likes of you."

Prince Stale's voice in that moment reminded me of the hushed, fathomless depths of the ocean. I forced a smile, but I doubted he believed it for a second. All I could do was be mature and surrender.

"My apologies," I said. "Once we complete our prince consort work, I'll head straight to the apothecary—"

"No, forget it. I give up."

His blunt rejection made my lips snap shut. My smile twitched as he basically ordered me to shut up, and a cold sweat broke out along my brow. Prince Stale checked the clock, shot me one more glare, and teleported out of the room.

Only after he was gone did I relax, but that was enough to bring on more coughing. I slumped over, hanging my head and pressing my hand to my mouth.

What happened next blew me away.

"I told you to stop pulling this crap, Gilbert!"

Prince Stale's rage echoed through the room. Whipping my head up, I found Sir Arthur hurtling in my direction with a scream. I grabbed him before we collided. Sir Arthur thankfully knew how to brace for a fall, so we suffered no worse than my back hitting the wall.

"P-Prime Minister Gilbert?! I-I-I-I'm so sorry! A-are you hurt?!"

The knight's blue eyes went wide as he gaped at me, his silver hair tied back in a high ponytail. His face paled as he hit the ground, but he scrambled to his feet and helped me away from the wall.

"I'm really, really sorry!"

I squeezed his hand and smiled. "I'm just glad you're unharmed."

"No, it'd be much worse if *you* got hurt!"

"The guards will hear you if you keep shouting, Arthur," Prince Stale calmly interjected.

Indeed, Sir Arthur was far louder than I was. He closed his mouth and nodded. Then he spun around, scowled at Prince Stale, and spoke in a whisper. "Stale! Don't just throw me like that, damn it! I could've hurt the prime minister!"

"At least he wouldn't have a cold anymore. Come on, give him a good hit to the head."

"Like hell I will!"

Sir Arthur wheeled back toward me and politely confirmed I wasn't hurt.

Really, I'm fine. I was hardly even winded, since you dropped to the floor on my behalf. Actually, I'm breathing better than I was just a minute ago. Well, I guess that shouldn't surprise me.

"I'm dropping him on your skull next time, Gilbert."

"Why's it gotta be me?!"

Prince Stale placed a hand on Sir Arthur's shoulder. The knight clearly didn't understand the situation, but Prince Stale teleported him away with a simple "I'll apologize later." I brushed the dust from my clothes once Sir Arthur returned to wherever Prince Stale had snatched him from.

Upon his return, Prince Stale crossed his arms and approached me, one slow step at a time. "Your body belongs to this country and its people. Even Arthur knows staying healthy is part of having a job. What gives you the right to neglect that?"

"You're correct," I conceded.

But the prince's icy glare did not thaw. "Why do we have doctors? Why do we have apothecaries?! If you hesitate to go to them again, I'll throw Arthur at you as many times as it takes."

Sir Arthur was the only person in this world with the special power to heal all diseases. Shame burned inside me that such a person had been summoned simply to cure my mild cold. It was an utter waste of his gifts to use them on something I'd have recovered from with a few days of rest.

"What would you do if Maria or Stella caught your cold?"

I'd hoped Prince Stale would take my silence as an answer, but not even a deferential bow cooled his ire. I told him how deeply sorry I was.

"Don't think you can keep secrets from me," he growled. It had been a long time since the prince gave me such a lecture. "Good grief... What would you say to Father if he tried to hide a cold like you did?"

"I usually call a doctor or apothecary directly to his office," I said immediately. "He's a stubborn fellow, after all."

Prince Stale blinked. "You mean it's happened before?"

A genuine smile rose to my lips. "About once a year."

The prince heaved a sigh, and for a moment he reminded me so much of Albert and Vest that I struggled not to laugh. "In that case, I *will* drop Arthur on your head next time."

"That won't be necessary. I'll seek medical care as soon as I display any symptoms."

My quick response, accompanied by a smile and a promise, finally convinced Prince Stale to relax. "Father and I will have to ask the doctor to report your visits," he said. "The apothecary will have to report any medicine you pick up. You're too good at lying."

"Very well."

That over with, the prince returned to the task at hand. He tapped twice on the paperwork he'd left on my desk, demanding I finish up quickly. I obliged, reading documents while he skillfully organized others.

"A lot of these are about trials and laws," he noted.

"The prince consort deals with more domestic affairs than matters of diplomacy. It's a bit easier to pass judgment if you memorize the text of all the laws." While committing them to memory wasn't a requirement, I felt it was my duty as the prince consort's steward to do so. The process had eaten into my own sleeping hours all those years ago.

Prince Stale examined the rows of legal books on my shelf in silence. Even he would need time to memorize them all. "My elder sister says she's learned them all by heart," he murmured, breaking the silence.

"Now that you mention it, I recall Princess Pride studying the law ever since she was little."

"She helped Tiara and me. We were so eager to read all sorts of books. She taught us about laws and other things a queen needed to know, since she already had it all in her head."

"How lovely."

The prince smiled proudly at the shelf before him. He picked up the nearest hefty tome and opened it—then took one look at the hefty paragraphs before clapping it shut. "You're telling me I'll be better at aiding the prince consort if I memorize all of these, right, Gilbert?"

I matched the prince's impish smile. "Absolutely."

"Very well," he muttered, picking up one of the books like it was a challenge. "How long did it take you?"

"Merely *acquiring* all these took time. In total, I would say about half a year."

"That's longer than I would've expected from you."

He wanted the truth, so I obliged. "It's the total time it took me to memorize every single paragraph in every single chapter."

His eyes widened, then his face hardened with annoyance as he realized I'd gotten the better of him. Not that he'd ever admit it out loud. "Half a year from now... That will be around Tiara's birthday."

"Yes, I'm looking forward to the big day."

Princess Tiara was nearly sixteen years old. It was a delight to have two members of the royal family on the cusp of adulthood. Prince Stale and Princess Pride had recently returned from a trip to Hanazuo for Prince Cedric's birthday, and Sir Arthur's birthday was only a week away. No doubt Prince Stale was looking forward to that; he was bound to be more eager for his closest friend's birthday than that of the prince of an allied country.

Despite all these happy tidings, a shadow passed across Princess Tiara's face whenever the subject of her own birthday came up. Her siblings looked similarly grim at the prospect. Princess Tiara wouldn't get engaged and have to leave her homeland immediately, but all three understood that the younger princess's birthday meant their eventual separation. Princess Pride in particular couldn't maintain eye contact during those conversations, too overcome with grief. Having doted on Princess Tiara her entire life, she would be terribly lonely after their separation. Still, every queen who had sisters had to face this reality eventually.

Prince Stale must have worked through his feelings on the matter, as he recovered quickly this time. After a beat, he donned a smirk and adjusted his glasses—the very pair he’d had made. “All right,” he said as his smile turned menacing. “I’m going to memorize all this before Tiara turns sixteen. Just you watch.”

It was like a declaration of war against me. He returned the book to the shelf, then plucked the one at the end of the row. The prince announced his intention to borrow it, and before I could grant my permission (or complain), the book vanished from his hand, likely teleported to his bedroom.

“Now what should I do?” he asked as if nothing were amiss.

I assigned him another batch of documents and got a one-word answer in response.

“Come to think of it, the deliveryman should arrive soon,” I recalled. “I’m supposed to receive something today.”

Prince Stale peered out the window. “Right.”

The deliveryman had been zipping in and out of the castle quite frequently as of late. I’d heard he was helping Princess Pride and Prince Cedric exchange letters at first, but now he was also handling letters between Queen Rosa and the United Hanazuo Kingdom.

“We made good progress on our negotiations during Prince Cedric’s birthday party,” Prince Stale said. “Everything should be settled with a few more letters.”

Despite his positive words, melancholy shadowed his tone. I suspected he couldn’t get past Prince Cedric’s prior disrespect, even

though the ever-strict Vest had praised Prince Cedric for a certain event after his birthday party. Perhaps Prince Stale envied him.

"In that case, I'm glad I asked for your help in advance," I said. "Princess Pride said she'd like to give the deliveryman a long break once he finishes with these current exchanges."

I received regular updates from an information broker named Bale. The deliveryman was our intermediary, but he'd been so busy lately that he was neglecting these updates. When I'd asked him to stick to the schedule, he'd clicked his tongue at me in irritation. While I understood he was doing all this for Princess Pride, the constant back-and-forth must have worn on him. Normally, the trip would take ten days, so I had to agree with Princess Pride's decision to grant him a break after this.

Stale gave a brief reply and we let the matter drop, returning to our desks and our work. Soon only the scratching of our pens filled the silence. My hands moved far more fluidly now that I didn't have to suppress my coughing fits.

We'd hardly gotten going before Prince Stale said under his breath, "You and Maria and Stella should just live in the castle if it means you won't catch colds anymore."

He spoke softly, as though musing aloud, but I knew he meant for me to hear. *He's actually concerned about me.*

To be fair, he had a point. Most prime ministers accepted the honor of residing in the castle. I was wasting quite a bit of time with my daily commute, even though my manor wasn't too far away. If I

lived in the castle, I'd be just a few paces away. Not only that, but I could also see a doctor and get medicine more quickly. And yet...

"I appreciate your concern, but I'm quite fond of my current living arrangements."

It was gratifying that someone like Prince Stale believed me worthy of living in the castle, but I *wanted* my house. When Maria was ill, she and I hadn't been able to go home together. Though a modest residence compared to the manors and palaces on the castle grounds, it was the one place I could call home.

Maria and I had chosen a location a short distance away from the castle so she could live comfortably without having to fret about others, and we'd grown to treasure the home over time. I'd lived there with her before, returned with her once she was well, and even invited Princess Pride and others over for parties. Once Stella was born, it became the beloved home I shared with my family. I couldn't say goodbye to it so easily.

"I figured," Prince Stale relented. He continued writing, using his free hand to point in the direction of my manor. I waited for him to explain himself, but he dropped his gaze to the papers and simply said, "Your home is too nice. It's wasted on you."

Despite his indifferent tone and blank expression, I knew this for his unique brand of compliment. I thanked the prince for his kind sentiment.

Chapter 3:

The Deliveryman's and the Trade Prince's Concerns

VAL

"HEY, VAL, do we *really* get a bunch of time off?!"

The young girl in the middle of the marketplace called out to me as I walked ahead of her. Her brown hair had grown out, bangs and all, and she held a little boy's hand. I yanked the hand of the boy between us, tugging both of them along. I could feel those sharp, light-green eyes of hers boring into my back as we wove through a street packed with familiar shops. The vendors called out to us with big smiles, hoping to win us over.

"Are you deaf? Didn't you hear what Mistress said?" I snarled. "She gave us the month off 'cause we've been workin' nonstop."

I kept my hood low over my dark-brown hair and earth-toned face as I walked, hoping no one would bother to notice me. These Freesians were frightened by my sharp, dark-brown eyes and the rest of my mean mug. The boy at my side peered up at me without hesitation, however, holding his sister's arm in one hand.

"Where are we going now, Val?" he asked. "Are we visiting Bale's shop?!"

Khemet, the young boy with the messy black hair and brown eyes, forced me to pause and consider my plan. I scratched my head over my hood. "Not a bad idea..." I muttered, calculating how much money we had on hand.

Stale had given us a monetary reward for our efforts during the defensive war six months ago, but with all the work on my plate since then, I hadn't spent more than was absolutely necessary to get by. Between that and the sweets and liquor we'd stolen from Gilbert's house, we were sitting on a hefty little hoard. I gave the brats a bit of pocket money in case of an emergency, but I held on to the rest myself. Or, more accurately, I *had* to hold on to the brats' share of the money, since my fealty contract forbade me from using anybody else's cash.

All of which gave me ample reason to go lighten that hefty coin purse I was carrying around.

"Guess we'll be livin' in Freesia for a while," I said. "Mistress gave us permission to leave during our break...but what's the point?"

We traveled out of the country all the time, passing through one foreign land after another to make deliveries. In fact, we spent more time outside Freesia than in it these days, only coming back to hand off and pick up items for shipping. My fealty contract dictated that I could never leave the kingdom without permission, yet my current job sent me beyond the borders constantly. Kinda strange, really.

Now that we finally had some time to spend in the royal capital, I wanted to indulge. Maybe I could visit the entertainment district or someplace only the upper crust went, show up in my tattered clothes, and do a little window shopping. For the time being, I led Khemet and Sefekh away from the castle at a swift clip.

"We don't have to deliver to Hanazuo anymore?!" Khemet said. "But we've been doing it for so long!"

"Yeah, Khemet's right!" Sefekh chimed in. "How can they send replies without us?"

I clicked my tongue in agitation. The recent trips between Freesia and Hanazuo made up the most of our busy schedule. After Pride's birthday party three months ago, we traveled constantly back and forth along a route that would normally take ten days, even in the royal family's carriage.

On top of that, Cedric and Pride responded way too quickly to those letters they sent each other. They should have started making the deliveries themselves. At least when Queen Rosa took over correspondence with the United Hanazuo Kingdom, the pace slowed a little. That helped with the commute, but the whole thing was still a chore.

Then there was the string of birthdays over the past three months: first Yohan's in Hanazuo, then Stale's in Freesia, and then Cedric's back in Hanazuo. Not only did we have to deliver all those letters, but we also had to haul heaps of gifts back and forth. We'd even visited Anemone the month before and received a load of items to deliver to the royal order for Arthur's birthday. Sure, we got paid, but I hated the idea of giving anything to a bunch of knights.

"They said they're pretty much done talkin' with the Hanazuo kings and that stupid prince," I said. "We're all just waitin' three more months for the queen to respond."

This pause in communications was why Pride had granted us such a long break. She never told me what she and Cedric were writing about, and I never met with Cedric directly, so I couldn't

hazard a guess about the contents. Judging by Pride's strange reactions and the occasional unhappy look from Stale, it wasn't anything good. I would've preferred to go the rest of my life without knowing, if possible.

Clicking my tongue again, I scrunched up my face. That was when Khemet grabbed my arm to get my attention. "Where do you want to go, Val? Anywhere is fine with me!"

Flicking my gaze from his grin to his sister's giddy face, I slowed down at last. "I dunno yet."

Early evening brought crowds out into the streets. Sefekh and Khemet used to disappear among them, but these days, I found it easier to spot them, even in a throng like this.

"Let's eat somethin' before we decide," I said.

The kids' eyes lit up as I reached into my breast pocket. They must have been really hungry, so I gave them each a few coins. Khemet and Sefekh raced off to their favorite food stalls; as usual, I figured they'd use me as a meeting post of sorts to regroup. They used to buy things from the same shop whenever they left my side, but lately they split up more often than not.

I never wanted anything other than meat and booze, but the kids took a long time to decide on their meals. I sighed as I waited, narrowing my eyes to scan the crowd in the direction they'd gone.

This was one of the wealthier markets in the capital, and there wasn't a beggar in sight. Overall, Freesia had become much safer in recent times. Theft was rare close to the castle, and kidnappings were almost unthinkable.

Well, that doesn't guarantee everything's warm and fuzzy, though.

I never could be sure when someone like me might be lurking nearby. Still, choosing a "safer" marketplace felt like admitting defeat, and that ticked me off. I'd always found the most dangerous places to be the ones where I could live and work with ease. Yet here I was, feeling relieved to be in a safe part of town.

I let out a deep groan, one tinged with resignation and regret, but continued to wait vigilantly for the kids.

SEFEKH

"F RUIT... Fruit..."

I repeated the word so I couldn't forget my objective. Wandering past the rows of food stalls, I was tempted by their rich offerings even though I'd already made up my mind. I didn't like wearing a hood the way Val did, so the shopkeepers called out to me as I passed. Young girls were prime targets in this market, though my clothes didn't paint me as particularly wealthy.

"Miss! I'll give you a discount!"

"Look, this is fresh out of the oven!"

Their shouting only made me walk faster. Nobody addressed me like that when I was with Khemet or Val, but being on my own always put a target on my back. I hurried from stall to stall to find what I wanted, ignoring the hawkers whenever I slowed down. I could interact with adults better now that I was older, but I never quite lost the wariness I'd cultivated throughout my life. Val and Khemet

understood, so I put on a brave face whenever I was around them, but I hadn't quite conquered my fears yet.

Here I am getting all flustered, but Khemet handles people just fine? That's so embarrassing.

I could chat with adults so long as there was distance between us, so I could handle things like shopping. Looking these adults in the eyes when I spoke to them, however, proved too much for me. After several minutes of meandering without finding what I wanted, I finally threw my hood on, even though anyone could tell from my silhouette that I was a young woman. I pulled the hood tight around my head until I finally spotted a fruit stand, then made a beeline for it...

Wham!

With my hood up and eyes on the ground, I collided with something. The impact sent me hurtling to the ground—uninjured, but definitely startled.

The other party, a man in fancy clothes, stumbled but remained on his feet. "Are you all right?" he asked, extending his hand.

Out of nowhere, immeasurable revulsion and dread crashed over me.

I couldn't understand where the feeling came from. It wasn't like I'd never bumped into someone before, and many of those people were men much larger than me. Back in my lowest days, people spit on me, pelted me with rocks, even kicked me, but I always got right back on my feet. These days, I'd gained enough courage to reply with a simple "I'm fine, sorry." Yet here I was, completely paralyzed.

My blood ran cold as I stared at the man's outstretched hand.

"Is something wrong?" he asked.

When I looked up at him, my hood slid back, revealing my ashen face and brown hair. The color drained from my cheeks; I was sure I recognized this man somehow.

"Are you all right? Are you feeling unwell?"

This guy thinks I'm sick!

He put his hand on my back and asked if I could stand, and I managed to squeak out, "I'm okay..."

I tensed, desperate to escape him, and got back on my feet. I brushed off my clothes and turned to leave, but the man helped me sweep away a few last bits of dirt. His unexpected touch shocked me, and I froze as though encased in ice.

"I'm sorry," he said, bending down to address me. "I wasn't looking in your direction at all. You're sure you're not hurt or sick?"

I offered a one-word response, but I felt like he could see in my empty eyes and pallid face that something wasn't right. He suggested we find somewhere to rest away from the bustle of the market, but I shook my head over and over as he cocked his head at me. Since he wouldn't leave, and I couldn't seem to move my legs, I opened my trembling lips and sputtered out a response.

"I'm...fine. Please, forgive me... I sincerely apologize...for hitting you?"

Even I didn't understand why *that* came out of my mouth. I'd abandoned that manner of speech when I started living in the slums,

yet some instinct kicked in at the sight of the man and told me I needed to address him this way.

Not expecting an apology, he blinked, but then his eyes flew wide. "You're...!" His voice deepened. He'd been staring at my face all this time, but now he fixated on it with fresh scrutiny. "No, it can't be... But..."

The man kept muttering to himself in disbelief as he looked me up and down. Seeming to remember something about me, he reached for my shoulders and—

"Watch it."

An even deeper voice stopped him before he could touch me. That snarl probably sounded hostile to him, but to me, it was a familiar comfort. We whipped around to find Val glaring at the man with obvious distaste. Khemet stood next to him, clutching his arm and likewise peering out from beneath his hood.

"The hell do you want with my brat?" Val snapped, staring the man down. Since his contract forbade him from making threats, he had to use his sparse words to put on the pressure. Val stomped toward me, never once breaking eye contact with the man.

"Your brat?" the man parroted. He stumbled backward, cowed by Val's menacing face.

Khemet rushed up to me. He clutched my shoulders and asked if I was all right.

Val placed himself between us and the man, bristling with anger. "I asked you what you want."

The man gulped, petrified, like he was being hunted. "Are you... her father?"

"Does she *look* like she's my kid?"

With his villainous face, one could hardly mistake Val for the father of kids our age. When he clicked his tongue and asked if he really looked that old, the man timidly replied, "No..."

Annoyed by the man and his hesitance, Val looked over at us.

"Sefekh is all right!" Khemet told him.

Val sighed, shoulders unbunching just slightly, and spun around. He called our names over his shoulder. "C'mon. Let's go."

Khemet took this cue from Val and clutched my hand. I squeezed back instinctively, finding my arms and legs strangely lighter. We took off past the man to join Val, but at the last moment, the stranger cried out, "Wait!"

At his panicked shout, several heads in the market whipped toward him—including Val's.

"What is that girl to you? Why are you...calling her 'Sefekh'?!"

Val's face contorted with irritation. Clearly he didn't think this stranger needed that information; he attempted to ignore him and walk away. But it was no use. The man yelled again, nearly loud enough to draw the attention of the guards and knights nearby. He was causing a scene.

Val pulled his hood low, looking on the verge of knocking the man out, fealty contract or no. Since that was impossible, he stopped and scowled at the guy instead. "You know this guy, Sefekh?"

The stranger *was* oddly persistent. Val glanced over his shoulder to find me all but shrinking behind him while clinging to Khemet's hand.

I shook my head. "No."

Val faced the man again. This had to be nothing more than a simple mix-up, but Val was obviously sick of all the shouting, so he addressed the man directly. "You've got the wrong girl. Her name's Sefekh. She's got nothin' to do with you, understood?"

He grabbed my other hand, and I gave it a hard squeeze.

Still, the man refused to give in. "You never answered me!" he screamed, then outright accused Val of kidnapping me.

This was getting seriously out of hand. The man seemed on the verge of siccing the guards on Val, so we needed a way out of this. Considering how much Val stood out, it was all too easy to imagine the guards siding with the stranger. Val had been accused of kidnapping a bunch of times already, based solely on his prickly outer shell.

The man continued to cry out. I wondered if Val would use his special power in front of a crowd as a last resort.

"I'm a member of the Baztert family! I can have you arrested if you refuse to answer me! Who is that girl to y—"

"She's family!"

It was Khemet's shrill, boyish voice that cut him off. He looked the stranger dead in the eye, even though he was still wary. When the man fell silent, Khemet smiled.

"Sefekh's my big sister, and Val's family too! We've got nothing to do with you, mister. I've never even seen you before. Come on, guys. Let's go."

With that, Khemet practically dragged me and Val off. I mustered the strength to walk beside him, while Val let him lead the way. The man didn't call out this time. Val peeked over his shoulder, noting that the man hadn't moved—or at least wasn't pursuing us. He looked down at me next, but I was doing my best to forget all about the strange man. Besides, my mouth was still hanging open after Khemet's bold declaration. Neither of us had ever seen him be so blunt with a stranger.

When Khemet noticed our staring, he smiled shyly. "Was I as cool as Val is when he protects you?"

He slowed his pace as we returned to our usual positions, with Val in front. Val and I both blinked at him.

"Thank you," I said, squeezing his hand.

Val looked back to confirm the man had disappeared into the crowd, and only then did he release my hand to purchase two apples at a nearby food stand. He handed them to us without another word.

"Thank you!" Khemet cheered.

Val set his hands gently on our heads in response.

Amid all the excitement, I didn't realize how hungry I'd been until I bit into the apple. Its sweet juice quenched my thirst. I thanked Val, who merely turned away and walked off. Khemet and I followed closely, silently munching on our apples. We didn't know where we

were going or if Val had something in mind, but in that moment, our destination didn't matter as long as we were together.

VAL

"HHEY, I THOUGHT we were supposed to spend our break in Freesia!" Sefekh said, stretching her legs. Beside her, an awed Khemet scoped out the room.

This was a much fancier inn than we were used to. For one thing, there were three beds, and they looked like heaven. At first, the room only had two, but I'd had a third one brought in. It made the space a little cramped, but we were used to inns where just one bed could fill the whole room. Besides, we had this decadent meal laid out on the table, the aroma of freshly cooked food tickling our noses.

As soon as the staff finished dropping off the food, I opened a bottle of booze and chugged nearly half of it. Only then did I respond to Sefekh. "I thought it'd be easier to splurge in a place like Veronica. Not that it's makin' a real dent in our pockets..."

I skewered a piece of meat, tearing into the juicy cut like an animal and washing it down with more liquor.

"May I have some?!" Khemet asked before stuffing his face with the meat as well.

Sefekh merely sighed. She seemed shaken by the events of this afternoon, particularly the weird run-in with that creep. There was no way she could've guessed I'd bring her a whole country away from the guy. Once we left the castle town in Freesia, I'd activated my special power and whisked us away at top speed. Maybe my recklessness

gave away how I felt about the whole thing, but I got us to the kingdom of Veronica in no time at all. And that trip usually took two-plus days by carriage!

Now we were lounging in this high-class inn built for vacationing nobles and other folks in the upper crust. The staff would bring us meals, clothes, and even a carriage if we asked for it—so I'd requested the inn's finest beds, booze, and food. We didn't have to wait long, since even that was nothing compared to what the aristocrat types asked for.

There was a time when none of us could've dreamed of such luxury, but it barely made a dent in our reward money from Stale. I had no clue how I was going to spend it all. The red-light district or a gambling den would've done the trick, but it wasn't easy to bring kids to places like that. Besides, I'd get an earful from Pride if she ever found out I took Sefekh and Khemet to a place like that. So instead, we splurged on this resort destination. Freesia had plenty of ritzy areas for vacationing in as well, but I wanted to avoid the risk of ever running into that creep again.

Khemet piled a serving onto a plate and handed it to Sefekh. "You have some too, Sefekh! It's delicious!"

Sefekh used to be the one serving him, but Khemet had started taking charge. She dug into the foreign dishes, and the gourmet flavors perked her right up. "It's delicious!" she cried, then lunged for the other dishes.

Khemet grinned, happy to see his big sister enjoying herself.

"I've never tried this food before."

"We had this one at Leon's castle."

"I want seconds."

"Eat up, Val!"

"Let me try a bite of that, Val!"

I reclined on the sofa and stared at the ceiling, the brats' fussing grating on me. Taking a swig from my second bottle of booze, I stuck my plate out at the kids and watched as they speared thick slices of meat with their forks. By the time I was on my fifth bottle, they'd finished most of the food. Khemet and Sefekh didn't leave a single crumb or drop of sauce.

After the staff came and cleared our table, Khemet and Sefekh joined me on the couch. Khemet rubbed his eyes as I drained a seventh bottle; it was time for bed. I sprawled out on the nearest one, not bothering to change, while Khemet and Sefekh hopped into the other two. They landed with a soft *fwump*, stretching without bothering to crawl under the covers. Just lying on top was comfortable enough on its own.

With the kids in bed, I turned off the lights. Recently, I'd discovered that I could use the sand in my mailbag to extinguish lanterns. I'd learned to use my enhanced special power in spurts without touching Khemet directly anymore.

"Good night," Khemet called out.

I grunted a response, but Sefekh was strangely silent. I put my back to the kids, figuring she'd either fallen asleep or still had a lot on her mind. Then I picked up a faint rustling as one of them got out of

bed. Pushing away the sheets, the kid plopped down. I sighed, refusing to turn around as quiet footsteps padded toward me. Then the little brat crawled into my bed without a care.

"Yours is over there, Sefekh," I grumbled without looking at her.

Soon enough, Khemet sat up too. Sefekh ignored my remark and clung to my back, pulling my share of the covers over herself. "I'm cold."

"How the hell're you cold?"

It was summer, and we had a great room in a fancy inn with all the ventilation we could ask for. The place wasn't any colder than wherever we usually slept, especially when we had to camp outside. Nevertheless, I gave up with another sigh and closed my eyes.

The other kid got out of bed, this time racing over with no attempt at stealth. I groaned, but I couldn't say I was surprised. "I'm cold too!" Khemet happily declared as he clambered into bed, snuggling up against Sefekh's back.

While the bed was big enough for all three of us, I knew I'd wake up to Sefekh hogging all the covers like always. I snapped at them to bring their blankets over, but they didn't budge.

"Fine. Do whatever you want," I growled, squeezing my eyes shut tight.

Even sleeping on the *floor* of a room like this would be better than camping. Then again, what was the point in moving to the floor when there were two perfectly good empty beds?

No one said a word until Sefekh's meek voice broke the silence.
"I think...I knew that man."

Knowing her, I couldn't believe how quietly she'd said it. If we weren't lying so close, I wouldn't have been able to hear her at all. I curled up, as though warding off whatever was coming next, while Khemet stroked her brown hair.

"That man... He's my—"

She stopped short, shuddering like her whole body rejected the thought. It had been seven years since her life turned around, and she acted like it was all a distant dream—but the nightmares obviously lurked deep, a stain on her heart and body she couldn't scrub off. She clenched her teeth and tried to scoot away, as if it'd keep me from noticing her shaking.

Right then, I rolled over to face the kids head-on.

Sefekh squeaked, startled. For a second, she gaped at me like I was going to jump out of bed and leave, but I shifted so she was square with my chest. She looked up to see me staring down at her, my brow furrowed. Khemet seemed just as surprised; his hands were still in Sefekh's hair.

Without a word, I reached out, wrapped my arm around both kids at once, and hugged them close, squeezing them tightly against me. Sefekh was pinned between me and Khemet, but after a beat of stiff shock, I felt her relax. Khemet giggled and clung to her back even tighter than before. Sefekh twisted my shirt in her hands and pressed her forehead to my chest. A ragged breath exploded out of her, like

she'd been holding it all this time and only now felt safe enough to release it.

"He...he knows my old name."

SEFEKH

THE MOMENT I REALIZED that man knew my old name—my old life—a whirlwind of disgusting feelings began raging violently in my chest. Only lying there snugly between Val and Khemet did I finally feel like I could put it into words. In all these years, I'd never once been called by my name—not until Val gave me one.

Years ago, I spent my days holed up in a dark room, trying to make myself small and quiet. But it was never enough to avoid the smacking and hair-pulling.

"I hate how your face looks exactly like that whore's! Just looking at you makes me want to puke! Your blood is sullied, and that's why you can hardly speak! It's all your fault, all your fault, all your fault!"

Whenever she was done with me, an act more dreadful and stomach-churning than any beating or tongue-lashing was forced upon me in the name of "comfort."

"Ah, you poor thing. She's suffering too, so try to forgive her. You understand, don't you? I know you're a good girl."

Even before I fled from the manor, I didn't know if that other name of mine really existed. Maybe no one had bothered giving me a name in the first place. If I *did* have a name, I wanted to know why they chose it, what it meant, and why they never once—

"But he didn't call me by it."

My voice emerged faint, weak. Maybe I just couldn't remember being called by name. Or it was a name that had no value, one people hesitated to let pass their lips. I couldn't stop thinking about it, but the answers lay well out of reach.

Khemet hugged me, firmly but tenderly. I'd met him when he was only three years old, and I had to wonder if he too had a name he no longer remembered. He had no memories of his parents—something I was suddenly intensely jealous of.

Val's chest expanded with a breath that turned into a slow, deep sigh. When he muttered my name, I was afraid I'd annoyed him, that he would tell me to shut up and go to sleep. So I didn't respond.

He repeated himself, his voice softer than before. "Sefekh."

This time, I looked up at his call. My eyes had adjusted to the darkness, so I could meet his intense stare. I gulped, but Val simply addressed me once more.

"Sefekh...do you really need another name? If you do, I'll steal one for ya."

He sounded indifferent, but I sensed a kindness beneath that had my lip quivering. I shook my head, rubbing my forehead against Val's chest, and looped my arms around him without bothering to hide my trembling. The answer I'd held inside myself all along welled up alongside my fresh tears.



"No, I don't!"

I didn't need another name. That truth surged up straight from the depths of my heart. The two most irreplaceable people in my life called me Sefekh, so I could never imagine going by anything else.

That man could have called my old name, even begged and cried for me to return, but I would choose to leave with Val and Khemet every single time. *This is where I want to be forever.* I had absolutely no desire to return to that manor and deal with that man ever again. This was where I belonged, and I had no need to go searching for any other home.

The past made no difference. I only really started existing when I met Khemet and when Val gave me a name. If I wanted to run away, I would run to them. Tears welled up in my eyes at the thought, and I buried my face in Val's chest. Khemet held me close.

"I want this name," I choked out as Val wiped away my tears. "I want to be Sefekh. I don't want to be anyone else."

Wrapped in an embrace safer than anything I'd ever known, I didn't dare move a muscle. Val kept his vigil even as I slipped into sleep, my cheeks still damp with tears, letting me stay cradled against him all through the night.

Though I dozed off before I could catch it, Khemet reached over me to place his hand on Val's arm, nuzzled against my back, and—with one last smile—closed his eyes just as Val did.

LEON

"AAH... AAAAAH... No... No... Please, no, no, no..."

My teeth chattered, and I clutched my head with trembling hands. My life now consisted of this horrid cycle and nothing more. I hid in a corner of my room so no one could find me, covering my ears and focusing solely on the sound of my own ragged breathing. The ray of early evening sunlight leaking through the curtains stabbed a knife of pure terror into my heart. The setting sun was so red...so bright and red...

"You're going to make me jealous."

The moment those words replayed in my mind, my heart kicked and my pulse pounded. I let out a desperate wail, trying to drown out the wicked voice in my head.

No, no, she's—she's gone now! Sh-she really, truly left already! She's gone, she's gone, she's gone! Don't worry, there's no one, no one else here!

While I struggled to calm my mind, my body thrashed around in throes of panic. The spot on my head where she'd touched me felt warm and filthy, as if she'd poured blood over me. Her voice had penetrated my ears in a way I couldn't be rid of.

I'd spent the past two years living out this "life sentence." I screamed and pleaded for mercy until my lungs burned, but it never brought the slightest relief to my constant state of terror. I yearned to see the people of Anemone again. I ached for their voices and their smiles. Were the people I saw just before I left still doing well?

No sooner had the thought occurred to me than a flash of bright red washed through my thoughts, sweeping them away. Now matter how hard I squeezed my eyes shut, it couldn't absolve me of my sins.

None of my people were well. I'd brutally slaughtered their dear neighbors with my own hands.

In the end, the Anemonian people had suffered thanks to my greed. I couldn't remember how we spent our time together in that tavern back home, but those people—my victims—had been forced to come to Freesia, which would be their burial ground. They never got to set foot in their homeland again.

"I'm sorry... I'm sorry... I'm sorry, I'm sorry..."

There was no forgiveness for me. It was my fault, my fault, *my fault* that the Anemonians ended up in Freesia. I'd spent two long, long years locked inside my room, replaying those events like they happened yesterday: the splatters of crimson, the rending of flesh, those final screams of agony. Their shrieks were vivid and visceral even now, tormenting me every day.

"Ah... Aaaah! No... No, no, no, no, noooo!"

I couldn't control my own voice. I tugged on my long hair almost hard enough to tear it out, struggling in vain to yank out the memories. *No! No, no! I need to carry these sins for the rest of my life. No, no, no, no, no! Why do I still want to go home, want to go home, want to go home?! I'll do anything, even become a slave, just let me go back to Anemone, back to Anemone, back to Anemone!*

"Freesia will be invading Anemone very soon."

"N-n-nooo!"

No, I can't go back. I have to stay here. I have to live, have to live however she...however she asks of me.

With my jaw clenched and tears streaming down my face, I begged myself to find some hidden reservoir of strength. Instead of drying my eyes, I gripped my head in my hands. I could never admit aloud that I wanted to go home. The consequences would be dire. Anemone would *burn* if she heard me speaking like that. She might even slaughter more Anemonian citizens. That was the one thing I—

Knock, knock!

I let out a girlish shriek at the sound, hugging my body. I pressed myself into a corner, horrified that she was back...but the door opened to reveal two palace maids.

"Pardon the intrusion," one said as she set out food and clean clothes.

The other one noticed me quivering and asked if I was all right, but her kindness was lost on me.

"Ngh! Aaaaaah! Stay back! Don't come near me! Stop it, stop it, stop it! No, go away, I hate you, I hate you, I hate you, I hate you, I hate you, I hate you, I hate you, I hate you, stay back, stay back, stay back, stay back, stay back, stay back!"

I can't take it, I can't take it, I can't take it, I can't take it! I'm too terrified of other people!

In my haze of horror, the maid's concerned face threatened to become a shower of blood raining over me. I could picture her hand, extended toward me in kindness, severed by a sword. They would gouge out her gentle eyes, and blood would spew from her mouth as her screams echoed off the walls. I lost track of her words amid the gory hallucination, but I knew she wasn't screaming "help me" or "kill

me.” Yet even as I watched, her face transformed into a visage of the Anemonians I’d betrayed and tore open the wounds in my heart.

No, no, no, no, I’m going to... You’re going to be killed again! I’m going to... The queen, the queen is going to murder you! It’s—it’s going to happen again, just because you spoke to me!

Even I didn’t understand what I was screaming at her, but I thrashed to keep her away. She shrieked at my disgraceful behavior, grabbed the other maid, and fled the room. The door closed with a *thud*. I tried to catch my breath, dirtying the carpet with my sweat and tears.

“Ngh... Ugh... Aaaah...”

I was an ugly person. The blue hair and jade-green eyes I’d inherited from my honorable parents didn’t suit me, a wretch terrified of other people. A waste of a human like myself would only hurt others, perhaps even get them killed, because even the simplest interaction with me could incur her wrath. I couldn’t bear for anyone else to suffer over a failure like me.

Please, just stay away from me, everyone. There’s nothing I can do except drive innocent people to their deaths. Aaaaaaaaah! But... but...if I can have just one thing, then let me wish for what I want, so long as it stays in my mind. Somebody, somebody, somebody, please...save me!

I yawned as the carriage rumbled to a halt. *Oops. I zoned out for quite a while there.* I covered my mouth, embarrassed even by this private display of absent-mindedness. The prime minister and my

servants asked if I was tired; I answered honestly as I peeled back the carriage's curtains.

"Are you sure we can't open these?"

Why bother having a window if the curtains hid my view? I'd closed my eyes, straining my ears so I could at least hear the citizens, but that was when my mind started to wander. It was probably because of those nightmares I'd had this morning. I couldn't recall the details, but supposedly, I'd cried out in my sleep enough to frighten my maids.

"Please be patient, Prince Leon," the prime minister said with a sigh. "As you can see, the carriage won't go anywhere once people learn you're the one inside. At least we've arrived."

I chuckled. At first, I'd waved to people as we passed, but then women started fainting and crowds swarmed after me until we had no choice but to keep the curtains shut. In truth, I was very disappointed.

My servants and knights finished their preparations and opened the carriage doors. A chorus of cheers flooded in from the Anemonian people waiting outside. My heart swelled as their words finally reached me.

The guards kept a watchful eye as I exited the carriage, eliciting another whoop from the crowd. As I waved at the people calling my name and savored their shrieks, a part of me hoped they hadn't injured themselves. The fervent shouts could be a bit frightening at times.

I shook the hands reaching through the crowd and exchanged words with those I passed until a familiar farmer pushed through the throng, holding a basket of crops. A concerned knight raised his weapon on reflex, but I gestured for him to stand down. I greeted the farmer, and he grinned from ear to ear.

"Prince Leon! It took two years to grow these, but they're finally nice and ripe. Please enjoy them. I have more to offer to the castle too!"

He opened his basket to display the large vegetables inside, then handed the whole thing to a knight so the dirt wouldn't get on my clothes. I'd seen people trading these vegetables with other countries before. Their bright-green hue shone in the sunlight, suggesting the farmer had picked them this very morning.

"Wow! Thank you for this. I'll have them for dinner tonight."

I could hardly contain my astonishment at this wonderful bounty. Our kingdom might've traded the crop, but nothing compared to a fresh harvest. Not only that, but the farmer had come all this way just to show it to me! I took the man's hands despite their dusting of soil and expressed my gratitude. With the carriage dropping me off outside the castle town, I was meeting many of these citizens for the first time. It was a relief to have found a familiar face.

Crime had fallen in the castle town. Even alleyways posed no threat to civilians, and we'd severely cut down on shady dealings with foreign countries—something that had plagued Anemone only a few years prior. These days, you'd be hard-pressed to catch so much as a rumor of anything criminal.

The farmer offered a few bows and disappeared back into the crowd, and a woman stepped up to take his place. "I feel safe walking anywhere at night now!" she said. "Thank you for everything you've done, Prince Leon."

I smiled at her...only to watch her stagger, perhaps overcome with a vertigo spell. I reached out to steady her. Squeals and yelps erupted from the crowd, and the woman sank to the ground.

"I-I'm all right! I can stand!" she insisted, her face beet red. She accepted a nearby friend's hand and fled into the crowd.

I hope she isn't ill. The whole display was a bit concerning.

"Prince Leon, I support your ban on slave labor! We'll prove to you that we can support Anemone with our own strength!" a young man called out, clapping a hand over his heart. He was a smart-looking fellow with glasses and clutched a book in his arm.

I thanked him, and the other Anemonians' faces lit up. A few of them voiced their agreement from behind him.

"I'm with him!"

"Same here!"

"No slave labor!"

Anemone had begun the process of ending slave labor roughly two years ago, and now most people supported the change. Fewer traders relied on slave labor, creating more job opportunities for Anemonian citizens themselves. Public sentiment swayed even further in our favor when the shift led to a new wave of prosperity. Soon we

could abolish the practice entirely, and then we could trade directly with the kingdom of Chinensis.

At present, we could only trade indirectly with them thanks to our deal with King Lance and King Yohan. Gold from Cercis and gemstones from Chinensis were in high demand here in Anemone; they sold out as soon as they went up for sale, even at market price.

The call to abolish slave labor intensified when the people learned it would therefore allow even steadier trade between Anemone and the United Hanazuo Kingdom. As the people declared their intention to support our country without enslavement, pride and delight swelled within me.

“Prince Leon! Hey, Prince Leon’s over here!”

I thought I recognized this next voice, and I couldn’t seem to drag my attention away from it. After shaking hands with the bookish young man and watching him head off toward the library, a bright future surely ahead of him, I turned toward the group of women I’d heard. They blushed as I approached, though my knights held up their hands to stop them from getting any closer. Even the men surrounding them called out to me when I neared.

“Hello. Prince Leon Adonis Coronaria, at your service.”

They squealed when I smiled at them. Some of the blushing women gaped at me with their jaws hanging open. We couldn’t possibly converse like that, but I kept my smile on regardless, and the woman closest to me very nearly collapsed. The man at her side caught her, let out a hearty laugh, and warned her, “Don’t get too excited, now!”

Another woman called out to me, determined to speak. "I'm so honored...to meet you!" Despite her bright-red face, she extended her dainty hand and heaved a blissful sigh.

I grinned, shook her hand, and thanked her—then waited as she desperately tried to string coherent words together.

"You're truly...*truly* beautiful! Aaah, I'm sorry! I shouldn't call the prince beautiful! But you're just so lovely!"

Even *she* didn't know what she was saying. She covered her mouth, then her entire face. The men around the group burst out laughing and asked teasingly why she was acting so out of character. She shot them a glare, turned back to me, and blushed all over again.

"I'm honored to receive your praise," I said, "but I must say, you're much more beautiful than I am. Please don't hesitate to tell me if you run into any trouble here in Anemone. I promise I'll be here to help you."

I meant every last word. The woman squeaked, and then one of the men beside her pushed his way to the front.

"Prince Leon!" He pointed down a nearby alleyway. "I...I run a small tavern over there! Please, we'd love to have you stop by. If you're in the mood for it, of course."

"Idiot! You really think His Majesty would ever come to a filthy little spot like yours?! Aha ha ha ha!"

"Shut your mouth, you drunkard!" the tavern keeper shot back.

The blushing, staggering women snickered at their exchange; perhaps they were regulars of the tavern themselves.

Ah, I understand now.

"That sounds wonderful," I said. "I'd be happy to visit. Do you have time right now?"

I confirmed my plans with the prime minister and my knights. A fresh wave of excited tittering bubbled through the crowd while the prime minister asked me to repeat myself. I voiced my desire to see how the Anemonian people lived, and the knights arrayed themselves in a protective formation to escort me to the tavern.

The tavern keeper himself seemed more shocked than anyone. He could barely stammer out a word, but he led the way nonetheless. The regulars cheered and followed behind us.

"I'm really looking forward to this," I said.

I'd met my people once again—this time, the proper way. As that reality set in, my heart thrummed with joy.

"As it turned out, the tavern was quite nice inside. It was pretty small, but the atmosphere was inviting and all the regulars were good peop—"

Val cut me off with a click of his tongue, holding a bottle of alcohol in one hand. "Do I look like I give a damn? I'm not gonna remember some tavern from two whole years ago."

The evening after my visit to the castle town, Val, Sefekh, and Khemet had stopped by my castle on their way back from a delivery. They told me they hadn't visited in a while because they'd been so busy, but Pride had recently granted them a monthlong break. When

I'd suggested they spend that break enjoying themselves in Anemone, Val bluntly answered, *"Who the hell could ever relax around you?"*

I had no room to argue. Why, here I was now, forcing him into a conversation with me.

"You're outta your mind, y'know that? Only a crazy person would wanna go back to the tavern where they almost lost everything."

"It wasn't their fault, now was it? They were all very nice."

"That's not what I mean..."

He clicked his tongue at me again. Val wasn't wrong; the tavern hadn't been a place of fond memories for me. Nonetheless, I'd rejoiced at standing in that place again after everything I'd been through.

The tavern keeper was certainly pleased to have me there. He'd cleaned up the place and invited me inside before they opened for the day—even telling me the seat I took at the counter was going to become a tourist attraction. Though a bit embarrassed, I'd gladly accepted his enthusiasm. A regular patron had asked me to sign my name on the wall to commemorate my visit. I'd only signed my initials, but for some reason, the tavern keeper nearly fainted. I couldn't help worrying about him still.

"Oh, that reminds me," I said. "Thank you for making that delivery to the royal order. It was a big help. Our knights can't transport as many weapons as you three can."

I handed Val a fresh bottle of liquor. Arthur, one of Pride's imperial knights, had celebrated his birthday two months ago. I'd

asked Val to deliver new weapons to the royal order as an official birthday gift from my country.

It wasn't my original plan. Val had just happened to show up the evening before I planned to make my knights carry out the delivery themselves. When I'd asked him to do it instead, he initially refused, but since he was already on the way back to Freesia to deliver a letter to the queen, he eventually agreed...for a price. I then asked if I could count on him to make a delivery for Alan's upcoming birthday as well.

"Depends on the pay," he'd answered simply.

Although he'd scowled in annoyance when I assigned him the delivery date, he agreed to it in the end.

"How was your vacation? Did you get to relax?"

I was hoping they'd used their monthlong break to stretch their legs after all of that work. Yet, for some reason, Val didn't want to answer. He broke eye contact, and I followed his gaze to the sofa where Khemet and Sefekh lay cuddled up together, fast asleep. The pair were normally glued to Val's side while we spoke, never taking their eyes off me until they grew bored enough to retreat to the sofa in my room. I was glad to see they felt more at home now.

However, Val regarded them with a strange expression this time. He caught me staring, turned his attention back to his bottle, and gulped the alcohol down.

"It didn't start out so hot," he grumbled.

The tinges of melancholy and contempt in his voice left me strangely anxious. "Did something happen?"

After yet another tongue click, Val actually *explained* things. He was much more alert than usual, constantly stealing glances at the sofa and keeping his voice hushed. Fuming, he told me about the man they'd met a month ago, whom he described as "connected" to Sefekh.

"I see. What a stroke of bad luck."

While I couldn't gauge how Sefekh and Khemet felt, Val made it clear that this wasn't a good situation. The name "Baztert" wasn't familiar to me either. It must've belonged to a family of Freesian nobles, but if I didn't know the man, he couldn't have ranked much higher than a viscount or baron.

"I just wish I coulda killed the guy with my bare hands like I would've before..."

Val's drinking pace had slowed for the explanation. He wasn't more open than that about his opinion, but his hunched posture said plenty. Perhaps that was why he'd stayed away from Freesia and Anemone, its neighbor, for so long. I certainly would've put as much distance between myself and that man as I could have, in his position. Plus, Val made it sound like the man still had some attachment to Sefekh. If he decided to abuse his powers and take Sefekh back by force, there was little Val, a former criminal constrained by a fealty contract, could do to protect her. *But still...*

"You haven't told Pride or the Freesian prime minister about any of this?"

Val currently served as the appointed deliveryman for the royal family. He had closer connections to them than any other member of

the nobility.

"Of course not," he said.

When I pressed him further, he said it had nothing to do with them and clicked his tongue at me for the umpteenth time. It was clear he wanted to avoid getting them involved. *I'm sure they'd take action as soon as you said something to them...but oh well.*

I rose to retrieve a stronger bottle of booze, placing it in front of Val. "Very well. I assume you'll want me to keep it a secret from Pride and the others, then, right?"

"The hell?"

"Er, sorry?" I hadn't expected him to react that way. Was he really that confused by my offer?

He cocked a brow at me and asked, "What're you blabbering about?"

"Am I mistaken?"

"About what?"

We definitely weren't on the same page. I was used to him shooting down my offers of help, but after everything he'd just told me, how could he reject my assistance?

"Did you...have too much to drink?"

"No, you're just actin' funny."

I tilted my head and crossed my arms. Val mussed his hair and glared at me, baring his sharp teeth in a snarl. Did he think I was mocking him? Well, maybe that was the better outcome if he didn't

understand me. Perhaps he didn't want to acknowledge that, intentional or not, he'd basically asked for my help.

"It's nothing," I told him. "How about we just drink?"

I refilled my glass, then Val's—not that he'd drunk much since this conversation began. This time around, he guzzled it down in one gulp before I could finish topping mine off. He recoiled at the bite of the stronger alcohol I'd chosen, but he must have taken a liking to it, as he snatched the liquor away as soon as I was done pouring and started drinking directly from the bottle.

"I'd recommend you stay away for the next *two weeks* or so," I said. "The three of you will stand out if anyone's *looking for you*. And we wouldn't want that. Not for the next *two weeks*. Would we?"

"Yeah, you're right," he muttered, barely seeming to hear me.

Though he agreed, he clearly didn't catch my drift. It was strange hearing him respond without his signature sharpness. He drank hard enough that I worried he'd be even more disorderly than usual, but he never got that far, even after we emptied seven bottles of the strong liquor together.

Val woke the children and left before sunrise. Usually, he'd depart with an insult or nothing at all, but this time he muttered, "Sorry for takin' up so much time." Perhaps he still had enough wits about him to leave with one last grumble.

I bade them goodbye and prepared for bed.

I don't think he realizes how much he revealed.

Perhaps he'd never had someone to talk to, or never bonded enough with someone to do so. Yet for a man who always stubbornly hid his feelings, he'd let them burst forth tonight. Whether or not he was aware of it, he'd done something truly special for me. I sympathized with his concern for Sefekh, but at the same time, I treasured his honesty. He'd chosen *me* to share his feelings with over Pride and the Freesians, even though I was just as much of a third party to the matter as they were. This evening, Val had let me into his heart, if only slightly.

"First thing tomorrow, I'll have the seneschal investigate this 'Baztert' fellow and send him an invitation to the castle... I suppose I could report my findings to the Freesian prime minister if I conduct the investigation in my name. That is, if I dig up any dirt on him."

I murmured to myself as I got into bed, but when I closed my eyes, I thought of Val. He'd maintained his composure despite his obvious anxiety over the issue. If anything, he didn't seem to realize how worried he was. When I'd watched him slow his drinking so he could explain the entire ordeal, I knew one thing for certain.

"I'll have to live up to his expectations."

I chuckled at myself. *I'll have to get started first thing in the morning. After all, I've wanted to become friends with Val more than anyone else, and now he's come to me for advice at last.*

Taking a deep breath, I caught a whiff of the rich drink we'd shared. The lingering aroma of fine alcohol on my skin lured me into a pleasant slumber.

"I'm sorry, Lord Baztert. It seems I've won again."

One week later, I was entertaining a lone guest in the castle parlor with a game of cards.

Despite his defeat, the baron grinned and said, "I just can't seem to beat you."

The Baztert family lived in a mansion near the Freesian castle, but their domain consisted of nothing more than one lonely section of a farming village. A personal invitation from the Anemonian royal family was therefore quite unusual, but I'd told him that I wanted to learn more about the Freesian way of life—as they were an ally—and that I'd heard rumors about the baron's good reputation. My guest had accepted the invitation with high spirits.

"I apologize," I replied. I took advantage of my androgynous features, flashing him my signature smile. "For some reason, I never seem to lose when it comes to card games, even though I don't play them too often."

"It's quite all right, Prince Leon."

Card games were a way to entertain a guest, so in a way, the true victory came in allowing your guest to win. Said guest sat before me, sipping his wine and enjoying himself. I'd heard his village regarded him as an upstanding character, so anyone who found us in the parlor would see nothing more than two men enjoying a pleasant game of cards.

"That's probably why I've struggled to find anyone to play with," I went on. "I appreciate you joining me today."

"It's an honor, Your Highness. I'll play as many hands as you please."

I smiled wider as I gathered up the cards. "Our discussion has been most helpful, Lord Baztert. It's difficult for me to visit your farming village consistently. Your residents live together in harmony, and you have a lovely wife. It's all so wonderful."

With a sad smile, the man shook his head and told me his wife had passed away six years earlier. I cast him a sympathetic look, and a thought occurred to me.

"Oh, that's right—I recently met with some crew members from a trading vessel, and they taught me a way of using cards for divination. Would you mind if I tested it out on you?"

"Really?!" The baron threw his hands up, both delighted and surprised.

"Of course."

"I never knew such a thing existed. You're just as knowledgeable as I expected, Your Highness."

I shuffled the cards and split them into piles. After placing a few cards in a circle, I took whichever ones remained and laid them out in a line, one by one. "First, it appears you're someone with a lot of romance in his life."

The man kept his face composed, but I could tell his pulse had picked up. He smiled and admitted that he'd had an active love life prior to meeting his late wife.

I paid this no heed and continued with the next card. "Second, you're surrounded by many people every single day. How incredible. I wouldn't think that barons could throw such lavish parties so frequently."

The baron shivered, regarding me like I was peering directly into his mind. He told me he had connections with many other nobles, in addition to the villagers, and that was why he hosted so many social events. Upon saying as much, his tone softened for the first time all afternoon.

"Third...you're carrying a grave secret. It would seem barons keep a lot of things hidden, don't they? And this secret isn't very nice at all."

His polite smile fell away as he realized I'd invited him here for far more than a card game.

"Fourth...improper charges. Your tax rate is too high. I believe Freesia lowered their tax rate a few years ago. Not only did you ignore this, but you actually *raised* your rate a bit. It seems none of your villagers are aware of this."

My voice began to lose its gentleness. This man had deceived his people, betrayed their trust, and used them to line his own pockets. I would not go on shielding him from my contempt.

"Fifth...the women you did away with."

Those words settled in the cold, quiet room with finality. I'd already dropped my gaze, but the wretched baron proceeded to tear his away from me. Pain had cut through my voice, as though I knew one of those women personally or perhaps their family members,

though the baron would never know if that was true or not. After all, he'd spent only a single night with most of them.

He sat paralyzed, incapable of denying my accusations. The baron had many ways of silencing the villagers if it ever came to that, but he would not muzzle the crown prince of Anemone so easily. No matter how he fought, there was no getting out of this. He shuddered violently enough to nearly unseat himself, and I stood, eyes still fixed on the floor.

"The Freesian knights should be paying your village a visit right about now. They'll be there with the earl who manages the territory, as I've made Prime Minister Gilbert himself aware of the situation. Even more Freesian knights await you outside this room. I'm sure you understand why they're here."

All smile and cheer had drained out of my voice. My jade eyes were cold and detached, filled now with nothing but an icy rage. The baron sat in silence, sweat rolling down his face as I gathered up the playing cards.

"One of the women you erased has a happy life of her own now. She found people she cherishes...and people who cherish her. I don't want you to defile her heart ever again."

I clutched my chest to contain the anger and, above all, the sorrow boiling up inside me. Merely knowing of the baron's misdeeds felt like a sin, sinking its claws deep into my heart.

He would be prosecuted under Freesian law. All I could do was bring his crimes to light and leave the rest in the hands of Prime

Minister Gilbert. To the prime minister's credit, he had been quick to act once I told him of this crime committed on Freesian soil.

Lord Baztert was no doubt full of questions in the wake of his sudden condemnation by a man he'd never seen before. He couldn't have known how long someone had been investigating him, let alone how that person possessed both the connections to launch said investigation and a direct link to Anemone's crown prince.

Stuck alone with me in this room, he had no recourse. I could have killed him if I wanted. No one would ever convict the crown prince for slaying a criminal if I claimed it was self-defense. I could tell the baron realized all this, as his trembling grew so fierce that he slipped out of his chair and couldn't climb back into his seat. Instead, the pale-faced man looked up through the back of the chair to find me glaring down at him.

"Don't ever involve yourself with her...no, with *any woman* ever again. I don't care if they're blood relatives, married, single. I don't care how old they are. If I find out you've resorted to those same crimes again, be aware that I will not be kind to you."

I hoped my absolute conviction penetrated the man's every cell.

He seemed to understand just how horrific a fate he faced if the future king made good on that threat. If my sadness spiraled into rage or obsession, his punishment would defy his worst nightmares. I glared as the baron desperately nodded. Then I snapped my fingers, and Anemonian and Freesian knights surged into the room to surround the baron. He put up no resistance as they hauled him away.

After watching them go, I set about the next item on my agenda.

"Sefekh...was lucky."

She'd escaped from those hellish days and met Val and Khemet. The mere thought of her landing in such good hands brought a tiny smile to my lips. Sefekh had spent her life in a dark room, cut off from the outside world, nothing more than an outlet for others' resentment and desire. Yet she'd overcome all that and managed to find her own happiness. I hoped I'd helped protect that happiness, even if only a little.

"Save me."

Cries echoed out of the past—silent screams Sefekh never let escape her lips. Once powerless myself, I could only pray I'd managed to reach and aid that suffering girl.

"Oh, that reminds me, there's no need for you three to avoid the royal capital anymore."

Three weeks had passed since Val's previous visit to Anemone. Sefekh and Khemet were snoozing on the sofa once more, exhausted from their travels. I'd made sure they were out cold, then explained to Val that he and his charges had no more cause for concern.

Scowling at me, Val raised a brow. "What's that supposed to mean?"

He'd already emptied a few bottles and was acting like he didn't recall the incident with Sefekh and that man. I flashed a charming

smile and set out two bottles of the same strong liquor we drank last time, setting a similar scene as his last visit.

"Prince Stale happened to mention it when I met with him the other day," I said lightly. "I believe you said his name was...Baztert? Well, I've been told he's in custody now."

Val let out a hoarse "Huh?!" before quickly checking the sofa where Sefekh and Khemet slept. Then he lowered his voice, asking, "The hell did you do, Leon?"

"The Freesian knights were the ones to apprehend him, and from what I hear, it was Prime Minister Gilbert who denounced him. At the very least, I can guarantee that no one other than myself knows about your connection to the man."

Val narrowed his eyes in suspicion.

I knew it all sounded a bit *too* perfect, but I kept my cool and continued, "Supposedly, he was getting kickbacks from his peoples' tax payments, but they uncovered other issues too. He was stripped of his land, his title, and his fortune, but that wasn't the end of it. Freesia imposed even heavier punishments on top of those. Do you want to know more?"

As I filled his glass, he shot back, "Like I give a damn." Though Val's glare was aimed at the drink, I knew I had his full attention. I smiled, relieved by his swift response.

"I see," I said simply, my words floating over the drink. Then I poured a glass for myself. "By the way, this is the same strong liquor we had last time."

"What, you couldn't tell me that a little sooner?"

I wondered if Val was actually holding a grudge from last time. He glowered at his glass, checking it over as if I'd poisoned it.

"Do you want to know about Sefekh?" I asked him. I'd finished pouring my own glass and set the bottle aside. While Val wasn't interested in the baron himself, I thought I'd confirm the same was true for other aspects of the matter.

"Nope. Even if I did, are you tellin' me *you* know that stuff?"

"Of course not. I merely heard about the case secondhand. It's just, well...I get the feeling you can protect the two of them wherever you go now."

I smiled politely. Smoothing down my blue hair, I suddenly realized Val had yet to even touch his glass. He'd seemed pleased with the liquor last time, but he wouldn't so much as taste it now. Only when I raised my own glass did Val reluctantly take his own in hand.

Clink!

He tapped his glass against mine, then turned his gaze away and took a swig. He seemed irritated, but I was plain astonished. Only after his second gulp did he finally look at me again.

It was the first time Val had ever clinked glasses with me. I could hardly believe it. After all, that was the sort of thing *friends* did.

Dumbstruck as I was, it took me a moment to say, "What was that?"

"Dunno."

Val was merciless as always.

He shifted away from me and sipped his drink. I realized I should do the same...but in my bewilderment, I took too big a sip and choked on the strong liquor. My throat burned with each cough, and I quickly set the glass down so as not to spill it. Val didn't miss an opportunity to watch me embarrass myself for once. In fact, he outright pointed and laughed. His shrill cackling echoed through my room.

"I can't believe...you can just gulp this stuff down," I choked out.

"Damn right! I'm a lot stronger than a certain Mr. Fancy-pants."

Val snickered while I covered my mouth and took slow, deep breaths, cheeks hot from coughing so hard. Still choking a little, I poured a different drink into a fresh glass and downed it in one go. He smirked as he watched me gulp it down more desperately than usual. The first glass calmed my throat, but I went back for a second one immediately.

He gestured toward the glass I'd left on the table. "There's still some left."

"I know..." I groaned, dispirited, then took a careful sip. "Yes, the liquor itself is actually quite delicious."

His chuckling had yet to subside. He drank slowly, clearly savoring my embarrassment as much as the alcohol. I glanced over at him—and froze.

Val was smiling. Not smirking but truly *smiling*, looking more relaxed than I'd ever seen him. His usual scowl returned when he caught me looking, but I knew what I'd witnessed.

"What's with you?" he growled, whipping away from me once more.

"I was just wondering if we'd grown closer to being friends."

The words slipped out before I fully realized what I was saying. Val raised an eyebrow and downed the rest of his glass. His throat was bound to be burning, though he bore it better than he had last time he was here.

In lieu of a retort, Val grabbed the bottle of stronger stuff and drank straight from it. This act confounded me, but I merely polished off my beverage without a word.

Val's eyes drifted from me to the sofa where the children slept. Sefekh was out cold and half sprawled on top of Khemet. I waited for him to say something, my eyes fixed on Val as he observed them. His lips softened into something approaching a smile, and his gaze held a tenderness I wouldn't have expected, especially because he knew I was watching him. *Maybe he is drunk after all.*

"I don't hate it," Val murmured deeply, as though he'd let his inner thoughts slip.

"Huh?" When he said nothing further, I pressed, "The liquor? Or do you mean—"

"Dunno."

Val shot me down, slamming his empty bottle on the table hard enough to shake it and the rest of the room. At the *thud*, Khemet and Sefekh shot up on the sofa, rubbed their eyes, and blinked at Val.

"Are we leaving?"

“Is it time to go?”

They trotted over to his side, still half asleep. Sefekh and Val each took one of Khemet’s hands. Val slung his mailbag over his shoulder, gave the children a half-hearted reply, and ignored my attempts to stop him from leaving.

“See ya, Leon.”

Val waved at me without even turning around. Sefekh and Khemet were stunned, looking back and forth between us for an explanation. They would find no answers from either of us—me with my jaw hanging open in surprise, and Val no doubt wearing his typical scowl.

I followed them outside to watch them head through the hallway like always. As soon as Val turned the corner and disappeared from my sight, Sefekh and Khemet waved goodbye to me for the very first time.

It happened so fast, I didn’t even get a chance to wave back. The shock of it left me frozen outside my room well after the trio had gone.

I was lost for words, though my heart pounded with delight.

Chapter 4:
The Vice Captain of the Eighth Squadron's Concerns
HARRISON

"W_{AIT!"}

A man's voice stopped me in my tracks. I turned to see him heaving as he struggled to catch up. *Oh, him again? Hold on, "him"? Who is he?*

When he finally reached me, he needed a moment to catch his breath. I waited quietly until his blue eyes flicked to me and his lips parted.

Why is he...? Ah, I see. I must have been walking in a daze. Or I'd just been too focused on the future...and on recalling the past. Mind and body now clear, I regarded the man—the memento *they* had left behind.

"Please explain yourself!" he said. "Commander Harrison, I—"

"You're the commander now, Arthur Beresford," I corrected him without hesitation.

Arthur Beresford pressed his lips into a hard line and wrinkled his brow. Those blue eyes of his shone with silent protest. His short silver hair rustled in the wind.

"Comman—*Harrison*, I was just promoted to captain last month! I barely have any experience doing that. How can I be the commander?"

"You meet the requirements."

If a commander was still alive, he could promote another knight to replace him. Being a captain was more than enough; the knight's length of service and unit didn't matter. As commander, I could retire from the royal order and choose my own replacement if I pleased.

Besides, Arthur Beresford was already much more popular with the other knights than I was. Not a single one of them criticized my choice to promote him again. He lacked experience, to be sure, but everyone seemed to find him a better fit than me. Or did they just not want to say anything bad to the young man left behind by those who passed? Arthur Beresford was the spitting image of the former commander, and perhaps the knights saw in him their dream of rebuilding the royal order.

He shook his head and continued to pepper me with desperate pleas. "It can't be me! There are better knights for the job. What about the vice captain? And why are you retiring?!"

"I'm not obligated to respond," I said simply.

The wrinkle in his brow deepened.

Ah, you remind me of him when you make that face.

"Arthur Beresford, you...resemble the commander."

His eyes went wide, and he staggered backward. "You mean... my dad?!"

I crossed my arms, looked him over from head to toe, and nodded. "Yes, that's right. It's not just your appearance. Everything from the way you speak to how you act resembles him. Even the

dignity with which you stand... It's like seeing him reborn right before my eyes."

Arthur Beresford bowed and thanked me, but my words cast a shadow over his faint smile. He was clearly happy he resembled his father, but it made him upset at the same time. *What is it that he wants, exactly?*

"You even became a member of the First Squadron, just like he did years ago. It's like you're following in his footsteps."

He'd also mastered the art of the sword. Arthur Beresford possessed many hidden talents. The commander and vice commander would have been so proud to see him now, but each time I thought of that, my chest constricted and squeezed the breath from my lungs.

"You're similar to the commander in every way."

He smiled wider and told me he was honored, but a dark cloud hung over his expression. I tried to put my feelings into words for the first time.

"That's precisely why...seeing you breaks my heart."

It was impossible not to think back on those two men from long ago. The time I'd spent serving under the commander and vice commander was brief but fulfilling. The more Arthur Beresford resembled the commander, the more keenly I felt the loss of the vice commander. While the commander's spitting image walked among us, there was no trace of his cohort. The sentiment pierced my heart, a jab constantly reminding me that both men were gone.

Arthur Beresford spoke, but the vice commander's voice wasn't there to answer him. He smiled, but the vice commander wasn't standing beside him. He criticized me, but I wished it were the commander or vice commander doing it instead. It happened over and over again. He bowed to me, looking and sounding so much like that commander I so respected. He followed my orders, but his face, his voice—they only agitated the searing wound in my chest. Over and over again, I found myself wishing he looked like someone else. I was living in the present while my mind was stuck in the past, his very presence a cruel joke.

His mouth hung open at my response. His face stiffened and he averted his eyes, his clenched jaw trembling. He squeezed his fists until they shook, perhaps out of guilt.

"I'm...so sorry!" he said. Those words contained a pain even greater than my own.

"Your wish will probably come true if you become the commander."

He raised his head. His deep-blue eyes widened as he peered into my face, searching for meaning.

Ever since he first joined the royal order, something in those eyes told me he'd come to us with a purpose. I never knew what he was after, but it was important enough that it drove him to accomplish one feat after another, climbing to the top. I watched him so often, it was easy to see.

Did he want to become the commander like his father? Or was his goal to rebuild the royal order? Whatever the case, once he'd

reached the peak of the organization, he could do whatever he pleased. There was nothing left for me to accomplish as a knight with Arthur Beresford at the helm and his desire within reach. Getting him to this point was the only reason I'd stayed in the royal order as long as I did.

I spent what felt like an eternity waiting for the day he became captain. I couldn't let the royal order crumble before he became its commander. I couldn't give up my seat at the very top until it was time for him to replace me. I kept my position even after losing my reason for being a knight. All that was left for me was to wait, day after day, for him to grow.

"Until next time, Arthur Beresford."

Having said my piece, I turned away from him. I'd offered up my honor and my title as a knight. There was nowhere for me to go now. All that remained...was the one thing that I still needed to carry out.

Arthur Beresford called after me as I left, but I ignored him. There was no need for him to know, no need to give him further attention. The only thing left for me was to—

"I joined the royal order...to learn the truth about what happened to my dad, Roderick Beresford!"

He raised his voice to a shout. It made him sound even more like the commander, if a bit more youthful.

I froze, then whipped around before I realized it. Arthur Beresford's sword trembled in his grasp. His piercing gaze, almost a

glare, was a dagger in my chest. When I asked him to repeat himself, he said something else, but he was no less resolute.

Keeping his voice low so he wouldn't be overheard, he muttered, "If it turns out that my dad was set up from the start...then I'll get my revenge. The true reason I became a knight was so I wouldn't have regrets about what happened to him."

I knew exactly whom this "revenge" was meant for. He didn't need to say her name. Arthur Beresford was yet another prisoner of the tragedy from seven years ago.

"I know you and all the others have high hopes for me...but I'm not the ideal knight my dad was. I'm a disgrace who's only capable of copying the standards he set. There's no real 'me' for me to be."

This wasn't mere modesty. Arthur Beresford hung his head, voice laced with agony as his genuine shame and self-disgust spilled out. He ground his teeth so hard, the sound could've been mistaken for creaking metal.

"I see."

I could say no more. Someone like the vice commander or Callum Bordeaux could have addressed his feelings better, but it was impossible for me. I couldn't comprehend why he'd revealed his truth to me out of everyone in the royal order. Was it because I was no longer a knight? His words were a confession of sorts, as if he believed he was already backed into a corner.

He was a member of the royal order who understood all of his mistakes, shame, sins, and disgrace. The two of us were no different in that regard.

"Arthur Beresford."

I turned my back to him again. I'd already surrendered my knight's uniform. Bereft of that familiar jacket, the cold wind nipped at my body. I failed to find the words to comfort him, nor did I even know where to start. I wasn't like the other knights. Perhaps someone else could offer him kind words in my stead. But if he really *was* searching for a purpose, like I was—if he wanted someone to grant him a role that could take him beyond his disgrace, his mistakes, his sins...

Eyes fixed straight ahead, I raised my voice over the sound of the wind and delivered my brief message: "Take care of the royal order."

He didn't respond. Here I'd expected the young man to shout in his familiar way, but he didn't. Lacking the courage to face him, I used my special power to bolt from the scene.

"Vice Commander..."

I thought of him as I ran. I'd tried to grant Arthur Beresford a purpose and a role with my words, but I didn't know if it was the right thing to do. I just hoped those two things could motivate him as they had for me. Those words were the only thing that kept me going when I lost my reason for living.

Racing onward, I stared up at the sky. The setting sun peered over the clouds.

"I did it. I fulfilled the duty you entrusted me with," I said, but I was speaking to a ghost. He was no longer with us.

A lump clogged my throat, and I bit down hard on my bottom lip. *Yes, I really did it. I granted the vice commander's last wish.*

I still remembered the day he'd asked me to take care of that boy if he ever showed up at the gates of the royal order.

"From here on out...I'm going to do as I please."

No longer did I have the honor, the title, or the uniform of a knight. I had nothing but my own body, my sword, and the renewed determination that had dwelled inside me ever since that fateful day.

A meaningful life and a meaningful death. That was all I wanted when everything was said and done.

"...tain! Vice Cap...arrison..."

Huh?

"Vice Captain Harrison!"

My head is burning up... It's like my whole body is on fire.

Where am I?

I couldn't get my thoughts in order. It was so hot, and my body was so heavy. Fearing I was undergoing torture, I tried to move. *It's no use. What was I...? Where am I, really? Was I...dreaming?* I couldn't recall the details, just that it was a bad dream. *Or maybe it wasn't?*

"Vice Captain Harrison! It's time for training! Everyone's assembled already. Are you still asleep in there?!"

The calls from the other side of my door finally brought me to my senses; the voices belonged to the Eighth Squadron. *Damn. I*

overslept. Then I remembered Arthur Beresford was away for the day, so I was in charge. *What time is it?*

My brain wasn't working quite yet. I dragged myself out of bed and trudged to the door in whatever I'd slept in. My long black hair was actually getting in the way for once. Everything in my field of view, including the bangs I cut myself, was going fuzzy.

After another round of harsh knocking, the knights were fed up. The door flew open, and they launched into a lecture. "You're late! What are you doing? Captain Arthur is gone today."

I'm...

Bang!

An impact bounced off the inside of my skull. The ground rushed up to meet me, cool against my skin. My head wasn't working right, but I could hear people yelling and calling my name. The sounds faded in and out, and as my consciousness dimmed, I realized it had been a long time since I last came down with a cold.

"My word. Sneaking into the queen's room in the dead of night? Tell me, where did you come from, little rat?"

It was a pitch-black night, the moon absent from its post. The queen smirked at me and sat up in her enormous, plush bed. When she saw her guards' blood soaking my clothes and dripping all over her floor, she sneered.

The sight of her triggered a surge of violent thoughts, and pure rage coursed through my veins. She clutched a pistol in one hand and

snickered when I didn't respond, a putrid sound like acid rain hissing in my ears.

"You don't need to know," I said.

I'd met her many times as the commander of the royal order, but she didn't seem to remember me without my uniform. Tonight, I wore a black jacket with the hood pulled low over my face, but my voice should have given me away. Yet it seemed even I, the knight commander, wasn't worth remembering.

I glared at the grinning demon and gripped my sword.

"Why not?" she asked. "I *want* to know. You're the first man who's ever managed to sneak into my room. Tell me, how many guards did you kill?"

"I stopped counting after thirteen."

"Aha ha ha!"

The queen clapped, unafraid. I searched the room for a trap but saw nothing but dead guards, victims of the queen's madness. The seneschal was out of the country on business. I'd chosen this date so she couldn't escape with that pesky special power of his.

"Answer my question before I kill you," I said.

I'd slaughtered any guard I saw before they could so much as cry out. I had time before the royal order, much less the foolish guards, realized anything was wrong—time to question the queen before I claimed her head.

"Giving orders to a queen? You're certainly arrogant," she said in singsong. Then she lifted her hand with the gun to examine her

fingernails. I didn't know if she'd already accepted her fate or if she was buying time, but I pushed on regardless, resisting the urge to kill her before I got my answers.

"The cliff collapse from seven years ago...and the death of Roderick Beresford. Did you set it all up?"

"Seven years ago?! What in the *world* are you talking about? How would I ever remember something so—"

"He was the commander of the royal order!" I screamed, and my voice broke. "He went with the rookie knights and the vanguard unit, where they died alongside their ambushers!"

My breath quickened as I glared at the queen. She covered one ear and scowled, like I was too loud for her. After a moment's thought, she let out an "ahh" of realization.

"Oh, is that what you're talking about? Don't tell me you're one of the survivors? Or a friend or family member of one of the dead knights? Aha! Now that I think of it, I *have* seen your face before."

"Just answer me! Or do you want me to cut your head off?!"

I lowered my voice enough that the guards wouldn't hear me, baring my teeth and pointing my sword at the queen, but she remained unfazed. She sized me up, then slowly aimed her gun at me. It wasn't a threat; she was testing me to see how I reacted.

"I suppose I could tell you about that. That is, if you can..."

Bang!

"...dodge my bullet. Ha ha! You tried to get behind me before I could finish my sentence. Don't you have any manners?"

"Ghk... Augh!"

How?!

I clutched my stomach and collapsed to the floor. Blood gushed from my wound, staining my tattered jacket. I pressed down hard on it with my palm, but I couldn't staunch the bleeding. The bitter taste of iron welled up in my throat as blood spewed from my mouth.

How?! I used my special power to get behind her while she was still speaking! I wanted to sever her right arm before I cut off her head! How did she predict the position I was aiming for?! It's like she knew I would race toward her and raise my sword before I even did it!

My mind reeled as reason left me. I was done trying to stop the bleeding. This time, I wouldn't hesitate to go for her head and—

Bang! Bang!

"Argh! Aaah!"

"Aha ha ha ha ha ha ha ha!"

The queen howled with laughter as I wailed. It had happened again. She'd shot my right arm and leg before I could even lift my sword.

Pain seized my entire body. I bit back my cries but dropped my sword in the effort. Though I desperately told myself that it was just a bullet wound, that I could pick my blade back up...my right arm wouldn't move. She must have destroyed the joint. It hung uselessly at my side, throbbing with pain. I could still move my legs, but my

arm was just in the way. I endured the waves of fire shooting up my shoulder as I reached for my sword with my left hand.

"You can still stand?" the queen asked, obviously enjoying herself. She pointed her gun at me again, making sure I saw every second of it.

Bang!

"Wow, I'm so impressed! I wouldn't think you could still walk with those legs. Do you have the same special power as Stale?"

While I managed to hold back my screams this time, the queen had shot my left leg before I could reach her, and I crumpled like an empty suit of armor. I sprawled on the floor, my legs useless. I abandoned my sword, putting all of my strength into my left arm and pulling myself closer and closer to that woman. Pain sizzled in every nerve as I dragged my stomach wound over the floor.

I clenched my fists, glaring at the giggling queen. She twirled her gun, making a show of just how much she was relishing in the moment.

"All right, tell me. Do you want it in the head or in the heart?"

Seeing me utterly helpless, she stepped toward me. The queen pointed the barrel of her gun at my head and then my chest, cackling as she waited for my response. *She's a monster.*

I extended my only functioning arm toward her. *I'm so close! If only I could move my legs! I could crush this demon's tiny throat with one hand! I could strangle her to death like it was nothing!*

But my hand didn't meet its mark. Instead, it landed on her arm, the one aiming the gun. I squeezed as tight as I possibly could, and for the first time, pain flashed across the queen's face.

"Answer me! What did you do to them...seven years ago?!"

Blood poured from my mouth as I snarled at her. The act of screaming aggravated my stomach wound, stealing what little time I had left. My wounds burned like raw fire, even as the rest of my body grew cold.

The queen was spellbound, taking in every last inch of my face. "Whatever should I do?" she purred, false concern dripping off every word. Her disgusting lips never once broke that smirk of hers.

"Tell me! Did you kill the commander?!"

I squeezed her arm with every ounce of strength left in me. If nothing else, I could break her arm—but then I coughed up blood, and my grip weakened. I'd lost too much blood and couldn't stop trembling. Still, I clenched my teeth and mustered the strength to crack her bones.

"About that..."

Her lips parted; her smile cut across her face like a gash. I gulped. Had she murdered the commander after all? I waited and waited for her to confirm, but then...

"I'm not telling!"

You monster!

"There's no point in hiding anything," she said, "but this way, your death will feel even worse, won't it? Aha ha! Hey, be sure to look

me in the eyes when you die, okay? It's so dark. I wouldn't want to miss that lovely expression."

The queen placed the gun in front of me, then easily pushed my weak, trembling hand off of her arm. She stepped on my left hand and crouched close to me, pinning me down with her weight. Jaw set in humiliation, I glowered at her. With all my limbs immobilized, the queen stroked my cheek and lifted my chin so I had no choice but to look up at her. Nausea roiled my stomach as I realized I'd become her plaything.

I spit the rest of the blood in my mouth at her, spattering the queen's face the same color as her hair. She cried out as she scrubbed it off her skin and out of her eyes, stomping on my left arm over and over. After digging her heels in, she targeted the gunshot wound in my right arm. A bolt of pain seared through me, but at least my left hand was free. I pretended to writhe in agony while reaching into my breast pocket to grab my gun and—

Bang!

"That's not going to work. Aha ha! It's so easy to dodge when I know where you're aiming."

It's no use. She knows where my sword will land, and even where my bullets will hit. Have all of this country's queens been such monsters?

I fired more shots at the queen while my left arm could still function, but she nimbly sidestepped each bullet and sneered at my struggle. The moment I ran out of bullets, the queen strutted away

and snatched a spear off one of the dead guards. Then she thrust it right through my back.

"Aaaaaagh!"

The pain of my flesh rending stole the air from my lungs. My gut tensed, but that only sent blood gushing from my wounds. The queen howled with laughter. She wasn't going to call for more guards at this point. She simply plunged the spear into my body again, delighting in my anguish. My body quaked with unbelievable pain until the sensation started to dull. Death's icy fingers slowly took hold of me.

She grew lazier with her stabbing the more I drifted away; she must have grown bored of me already. But I still had enough life left in me to grope around with my left hand. I'd lost so much blood, I was shaking violently, and I lacked the strength to pull myself forward. Yet my hand connected with the tip of the spear before she could jab it through me again. I raised my head as high as possible to glare at her sickening face, then used the last of my strength to address her, bloody spittle flying out of my mouth as I spoke.

"Your reign...will come...to an end!"

If I couldn't reach her with my body, the only weapon I had was my words. However, the queen broke into a surprised and delighted grin at this last bit of defiance. I spat blood, dug deep for the last bits of life inside me, and used them to try to make my voice reach her.

"You're going...to pay for what you've done! Some righteous soul...is going to come...and make you pay with your life!"

Her face fell. The corners of her lips twitched, as though she'd recalled something unpleasant. The giddy light in her eyes faded.

Seeing her like that, I managed a smile. I was going to keep hurting her with my words so long as my body had life in it. "This country...will rejoice over your death! They'll hail the hero who did it! The new ruler will be—"

Bang!

Forgive me, Arthur Beresford. I couldn't get the answer. I only wish I could have killed her before your hands were stained with blood.

That queen had sullied the death of our beloved commander, stolen a friend from the vice commander, and taken the vice commander away from me. She'd destroyed the knights' way of life I so loved and robbed my existence of meaning. All this time, I'd shared Arthur Beresford's desire to kill her.

But for you, it's possible.

He'd given new life to the commander's blood and honor. He embodied the vice commanders' final hopes for the royal order.

Arthur Beresford had received their love and affection, and even now, the other knights all placed their faith in him. He was much more brilliant and skilled with a sword than I had ever been. Yes, he could really be the one to do it. He was already the proudest, most outstanding knight of them all. I was certain of that after watching over him all this time.

"What? I don't care who he is. I'm sure he's just another one of those rats."

Ah, now I see...

"Just throw his body in the usual dump site."

I should have...told him all that myself...

"Good morning, Harrison."

Where am I?

"Are you feeling better?"

Arthur Beresford was staring down at me. I watched him slowly pull his hand away from my forehead. He sighed, equal parts relieved and exasperated.

"I can't believe you. How long have you been sick? You should have told me if you were under the weather."

Another sigh gusted out as he took his seat at my bedside. *This is...my bedroom?*

"What are you doing here, Arthur Beresford?"

"I came back to the training grounds and heard you'd collapsed. They told me you had a cold, so I'm...just here for a visit." He scratched his cheek, breaking eye contact. "Do you even realize it's evening already?"

I sat up in bed. When he asked how I felt, I touched my forehead and realized my fever and aches were gone. My vision had returned to normal, and my mind was clear.

"I'm fine. I'll go back to my training exercises now."

"No, they told me they'd give you the day to rest. Here, have some of this." He retrieved a bowl of vegetable soup from the bedside

table. Steam curled off the bowl, carrying an appetizing aroma to my nose.

"What's this?"

"I asked the mess hall to make it for you. It's still fresh, so eat it while it's hot."

He practically forced the bowl and spoon into my hands, then insisted he wasn't leaving until he watched me eat. I had no choice but to obey. *I don't see why it matters. I'm fine now...*

I took a spoonful of perfectly fresh, piping hot broth and vegetables. While I chewed, the savory flavor of the vegetables spread across my tongue. My body relaxed, and only then did I notice how warm my room was. A sidelong glance revealed that the fireplace I'd never used had been lit for the first time.

As I was quietly enjoying my meal, Arthur Beresford leaned closer. When I met his gaze, he frowned. "When was the last time you ate anything?"

"I don't remember."

He hunched over with a groan. Impressively enough, he'd timed this soup for right when I woke up. I took another spoonful, and Arthur Beresford spoke again, his eyes on the floor.

"The vice commander told me eating and sleeping has always been a hassle for you. He said you get sick and collapse a few times a year. It's the middle of winter, yet you haven't even been using your fireplace, have you?"

He pointed at the corner of the room and told me knights from the Eighth Squadron had brought me firewood. When I didn't respond, he lifted his head.

"I've hardly ever seen you eat either, Harrison."

This time, I was the one to look away. I chewed a wedge of potato and swallowed it with a spoonful of broth.

"Hasn't the vice commander told you to take care of your health?" he asked.

"He doesn't order me to eat or sleep."

My old habits of skipping meals and feeling detached from communal living still plagued me. I preferred sleeping intermittently as well. But as busy as the vice commander had been, he'd taken the time to teach me a few practical life lessons—not that he could watch over me *all* the time.

"You're spending your winter without any heat, and you're hardly eating or sleeping. Did you really think it wouldn't catch up with you?"

"It hasn't in a few years."

I'd managed to go without collapsing ever since Arthur Beresford joined the royal order. My health hadn't been as good in recent weeks, but I didn't see the need to dwell on one bad episode.

Arthur Beresford held his head in his hands, but he stopped himself from scolding me anew. He ruffled his hair, clearly struggling with something. "Are you really not going to ambush me like you used to?"

"There's no need."

He slumped again. I didn't understand why he'd ask that now; our duel had confirmed his strength. The other knights didn't need to see a vice captain attacking a captain at random.

Arthur Beresford crossed his arms and muttered, "I didn't think so..."

If he questioned my strength, he was more than capable of coming at me, but that didn't seem to be what he was looking for.

"Then how about I give you orders as your captain?"

Surprised, I met his blue eyes.

"Starting today, please eat breakfast with me." He held up two fingers. "And join me for two sparring sessions a week."

Huh? I don't understand.

"Is that a no?"

He must have seen the shock on my face, but if these were his orders, I had no reason to refuse. I simply didn't understand their purpose.

"Fine," I answered.

He sighed with relief, then bowed to me and said we'd start tomorrow, which I agreed to.

"You *really* oughta take better care of yourself," he said. "We have Princess Tiara's birthday party next month, and then—"

His mouth suddenly fell open. He squinted up at the ceiling as if he'd just remembered something important. After a moment, he

returned his attention to me, saw that I'd finished my soup, and quietly asked if he could discuss something. I nodded and straightened up in bed.

"Keep this confidential for now," he began. "Would you be interested in becoming one of Princess Pride's imperial knights?"

I blinked, confounded by the words coming from his mouth. The spoon slipped from my hand and hit the bowl with a *clang*. Taking stock of my confusion, he provided an explanation.

"I'm sure you're aware that now that I've been promoted, Vice Captain Eric is the only imperial knight who isn't a captain of any squadron. That means...he has to defend Her Highness all on his own when the captains gather for their meetings."

I knew that, at least. We'd tried several times to arrange the captains' meetings to fit around the imperial knights' schedules: having them arrive at the palace after the royal family's breakfast instead of before, holding the meetings late at night or early in the morning, and so on. Now that there were three imperial knight captains, they took the same measures as they had during Callum Bordeaux's and Alan Berners' suspension period. Eric Gilchrist took turns with other knights standing in for the three captains so they didn't have to miss their meetings. There was always a big fight about who would get to guard the princess when the time came, but ultimately the imperial knights or the commander himself selected the candidates.

"We obviously don't want the same imperial knights absent every time, but it's not right that a captain can't attend the captains'

meeting,” Arthur Beresford said with some measure of effort. “Even Prince Stale has said as much. We need someone who can take over for us when we’re off duty.”

Arthur Beresford rubbed the back of his neck as he spoke, though he never took his eyes off me. He smiled stiffly.

“Personally...I want to give you the job, Harrison.”

It seemed Arthur Beresford had a gift for making me happy. As before, I couldn’t hide my surprise. He scratched his cheek shyly and looked away, but when he realized I was lost for words, he continued on.

“Prince Stale and Princess Pride requested you too. So did Captain Alan, Captain Callum, and Vice Captain Eric.”

“But why me?”

I fought back the emotions welling inside me and pressed him. My heart had skipped a beat at the name “Princess Pride,” but more importantly, I wasn’t suited to protect people. Alan Berners and Callum Bordeaux were just as aware of this as I was. Why hadn’t they stopped Arthur Beresford from offering me such an honorable position?

Arthur Beresford worried the fabric of his shirt between his fingers, squeezing his other hand into a fist. *Was he lying about the recommendations from the others?*

Before I could question him, he said, “I’m absolutely certain she’s someone you’ll protect with your life, no matter what.” Heedless of my silent bewilderment, he went on, “Maybe it’s presumptuous of

me...but you're really, really strong, and you manage to carry out every single order you're given. I'm confident you'll keep Her Highness safe once it's your duty. The others feel the same."

The young knight took a deep breath before meeting my eyes again. Calmer, he sat up straight and spoke in a deeper tone, sounding for a moment just like his father. "I've been watching over you all along, Harrison. Even *I* can tell you're a trustworthy man."

He's been watching over me. My heart nearly leaped out of my chest. Emotions surged within me like a raging river, rising through my throat until I could hardly breathe. *Ah, yes, he's...*

"Heh... Ha ha ha... Ha ha ha ha ha!"

The dam broke, all that emotion bursting out as laughter. I covered my face, but I couldn't stifle my excitement.

Arthur Beresford recoiled from the display, throwing his fists up as though to defend himself. "Wh-what's with you, Harrison?!"

I laughed and laughed until it was out of my system. When the fit passed, I climbed out of bed. My illness was not simply gone; I felt *wonderful*.

"You should order it, Arthur Beresford."

I gazed down at the dumbstruck knight. I brushed my hair away from my face, picked up my sheathed sword, and freed it to point the tip at Arthur Beresford's throat. He lurched back just in time, his wide blue eyes blinking up at me. I didn't care that I wasn't wearing my armor or my uniform. He, and no one else, had chosen me! He

trusted me! He wanted to give me the honor of protecting Princess Pride Royal Ivy!

"I'll do as you command."

My only job was to carry out my orders. Vice Commander Clark, Commander Roderick, Princess Pride, and the man before me were the only four people in this world worthy of my devotion.

Arthur Beresford... If my captain desires it, it shall be done.



Chapter 5:
The Royal Prince's Concerns
CEDRIC

"I 'M COMING IN, Bro."

I'd called out as I knocked, but I didn't expect a response. When I entered, I found the room dark and the curtains shut. The guards and servants silently slipped out, as they always did during my visits. I didn't try to talk to them or even look them in the eye as they bowed and left; my gaze was fixed on my brother, lying in his bed. It wasn't like I'd never thanked the staff for their round-the-clock care and protection, but the fact that Lance's life was in their hands whenever I left terrified me.

I don't know who might betray us again.

My golden hair, the same color as Lance's, fell over my shoulders. My eyes, fiery just like his, stared down at him.

I crept toward the bed, the jingle of my accessories breaking the silence with each step. Lance barely responded. He wasn't having violent fits like he used to, but that didn't mean his condition was improving. Rather, it simply meant he'd grown so weak, he couldn't move anymore.

"Ah... Ngh... Ack..."

Indecipherable sounds escaped his hoarse throat. His wide, dry eyes stared at nothing, occasionally twitching in an unsettling way. I could close his eyelids for him, but he'd just open them the next time

he groaned. His body had wasted away beneath the blankets. A lone trickle of sunlight squeezed past the curtains to illuminate him.

"The gold mining is going well, Bro. We'll probably be able to make another shipment to Freesia this month."

Fargus, our prime minister, and Dario, our seneschal, had put this system in place after Lance's condition deteriorated and Freesia demanded our gold. We were expected to provide huge amounts on a monthly basis, but a one-way trip to Freesia took ten days in the royal carriage. The strain of the arrangement accelerated our country's decline. We weren't worried about running out of gold yet, but it was our people who had to mine it, process it, and transport it to Freesia, so we weren't getting out of this unscathed. Even *I* thought Fargus and Dario had sold us out to Freesia when I first heard about it.

I'd quickly found ten tutors to educate me on industry and trade. From them, I learned that this wasn't a mistake, at least for the time being. I started taking control of the system myself once I understood it better. Someone else could come along and demand our gold in the future, but if we wanted to guarantee Cercis's safety, we couldn't let the quality or quantity go down. Thus, I felt most comfortable when I alone controlled the system. To that end, I'd filled my head with all the knowledge I needed for the job.

"Bro, they're saying that Big Bro...that the place once called Chinensis...shipped out another group of slaves."

Chinensis, like the rest of Rajah's territories, began selling people into slavery once they were conquered. According to what I'd heard, they'd only sent criminals so far...but they would run out of

convicts soon. Chinensis had once been a kingdom full of kindhearted, deeply religious people. They always welcomed me back warmly when Lance and I visited, even gifting us things like home-cooked meals. All of them had been proud that Lance, Yohan's good friend, was going to be the next king of Cercis.

Now, Chinensians hated our country with all of their hearts. They believed that we'd betrayed them, set them up, and sold them out to the Rajah Empire—that we'd formed a secret pact with Freesia and tricked their beloved King Yohan so we could protect our country.

It wouldn't have been so bad if I were their only target, but they'd cursed Lance and our citizens too, labeling all of them criminals. A large wall went up between our kingdoms to separate us. That order could only have come from the country once called Chinensis...from Yohan himself. They couldn't forgive us...couldn't forgive *me*.

Our citizens responded, declaring that Lance and I never would've done such things. They believed we'd been tricked and threatened into cooperating with Freesia. Then, after Chinensis had been robbed of everything they held dear, our people accused them of being traitors who wanted to harm us.

It wasn't just government officials who despised each other, as had once been the case; hatred seethed between the entire populace of each nation. *But I know it's not everyone! There are people who care about each other, but all they can do is pray for the other's safety now that there's a wall between them!*

I clenched my jaw, squeezed my fists, and glared at the floor. Lance wouldn't respond no matter what I said to him. All he could do was inhale through his parched throat and grunt. There was no point asking him anything. Everything was my fault. If I weren't so stupid...

"Unwanted Child."

Yohan's words replayed in my mind, and I shuddered. Tears spilled from my eyes. I wiped them away and desperately tried to think about something, *anything* else, but it was too late. I scratched at my throat as emotion welled up to fill it.

If Yohan hated me, then someday the Cercian people, who only liked me for my looks, would probably turn on me too. Maybe they already had.

"I'm going to leave the castle for a while, Bro. I'm getting engaged to a Freesian princess. Sorry that I'm gonna be the first one engaged, but don't let it bother you. After all..."

I tried to sound hopeful to lighten the mood, but my words failed me. The smile slid from my lips.

"After all..."

The words that should have followed were far too cruel. Even one year earlier, when I was still such a fool, I could hardly face the notion. It was too great a horror for a member of royalty, let alone an ordinary person.

After Lance got sick, I spent my time absorbing knowledge from every book in the country I could get my hands on. The more I

learned, the more I discovered just how stupid and ignorant I'd been all my life. The guilt nearly crushed me.

I bit my lip and let my head hang, wiping at my tears and dragging my hands over my aching throat. I clenched my fists and shook my head with a hard gulp. *Why am I hesitating after all this time?*

My hands were already stained with the blood of innocent Cercians and Chinensians. What would taking one more life matter? It was my only means of preventing even more bloodshed.

"You should be happy, Bro. It won't be long now."

I could hardly believe how small my voice sounded. My tears weren't going to stop anytime soon, so I raised my head and looked at my brother, a great man reduced to little more than skin and bones.

"I won't be able to see you for a while...but please, stay safe."

I didn't know who might try to take his life or protest our rule. The people of the former Chinensis could launch an invasion. There was no one I could trust. *That's all the more reason I...*

"I'll be back sometime within the month. I have to leave again after that...but I'll get the job done as soon as possible."

I gripped Lance's bony hand, conveying how much I meant it. His skin was hard and knotty, like withered branches. There was no trace of the strength that used to overpower me. I squeezed his utterly limp hand, and though I felt no response, I poured my earnest prayer into the touch.

"So, please! Please wake up already..."

Even as I lifted his hand to my brow, he didn't react. Lance's hand was pale and lifeless, like it wasn't part of a human being at all. He groaned quietly, a sure sign my words hadn't reached him. Still, I grasped my faint thread of hope.

"Big Bro might come and visit you if Chinensis is freed! Are you really going to let him see you like this?!"

I didn't care if Yohan hated me; I deserved it after what I'd done. Yohan had everything he loved stolen from him because of my idiocy. But I didn't want him seeing Lance in this state. *He doesn't deserve...to go through any more pain!*

"Bro, I...I already have blood on my hands! A guy like me isn't fit to be king! What this country needs is King Lance!"

I clung to his arm. I tried to let everything out...but my heart was full of sludge. Anything I touched only became dirtier, smudged with my impurity, and I lost more and more of myself in the process.

"I promise I'm going to get Chinensis... I'll get Hanazuo back! Then no one will need me anymore! You'll be all that matters! The people will rejoice, and they'll reunite..."

I closed my eyes, thinking back to when I had everything I could ever ask for. The people smiled. Lance and Yohan were at my side.

Then I threw it all away.

"Bro, I'm...I'm going to do something bad again! So please... wake up soon, take your throne, see Big Bro, and then...make me pay for what I've done!"

I can't call myself your little brother anymore. You should strike my name from history and bury me as an unwanted child. You, the legitimate king, can put me on trial in front of the people of Hanazuo.

"I...don't trust anyone anymore! Not Big Bro! Not the citizens! Not Dario, Fargus, or anyone else on this earth! I don't believe in anyone but you, Bro! Everyone betrays me! Everyone...hates me!"

No one was trustworthy. When I looked at people, I could *feel* their hatred and resentment toward me. Every last one of them was waiting for me to let my guard down so they could trick me and steal more of the things I loved. Lance was the only one I could trust.

Even so, I wanted to protect the people and the countries my brothers loved. I wanted to save them. That contradiction resulted from my own ego. In my arrogance, I foolishly believed I could help those people.

The queen had demanded I make the second-born princess fall in love with me before I took her life. If I succeeded, Chinensis would be free from Rajah, and the queen wouldn't turn Cercis into a Freesian colony. It could be another setup, but what other hope did I have? Our country was no match for a land of monsters like Freesia.

"If I manage to do it right..."

Looking down, I clenched my fists. My rings rattled, digging into my trembling fingers. I only needed a bit more blood on these hands before I could give Lance and Yohan back the things they cared about most in this world. It was a simple exchange.

The second-born princess, Tiara Royal Ivy, shared blood with the queen. I had never met her and knew nothing about her other than

her name, but a girl like her was probably powerless. She would turn sixteen, take me as her fiancé without any suspicions—and then I would murder her. It might've been a little easier to kill her if I focused on her connection to the queen...but it was no use. Having a demon for an older sister didn't mean the princess was an evil person. After all, Lance himself had a disgrace of a little brother.

"Until next time, Bro. I'll be back."

I gave his twiglike arm a squeeze, then gently tucked him back into bed. I rose, placing my hand on Lance's head in farewell. His golden hair was all the more striking against his ashen complexion. He used to be the one who rested his hand on my head, but here I was, clinging to him out of desperation. Anyone else probably would have found the whole scene laughable.

My feeble brother, who could do nothing but groan and grunt in his slumber, probably had little time left. His doctor had told me as much. I didn't know if he'd be alive by the time I got back; if some traitor didn't kill him, his body might simply give out. Were the circumstances not so dire, no one could have torn me from his side.

"This is all I can do to protect the country you loved so much."

When I tried to smile, it became a self-derisive sneer. I left Lance with that, removing my hand and taking a few steps back. After one last look at his waning face, I finally turned away.

The door lay just ahead, the carriage waiting outside. I wouldn't dare show up late for Princess Tiara's birthday party in eleven days. In fact, I needed to reach Freesia early and visit the queen in her throne room.

"Ce...ric!"

Huh?

There was a whisper of a voice. It sounded like Lance, but when I whipped around, he lay in bed with his eyes shut, letting out the same grunts he always did. It must have been my imagination. Lance was long past the point of speaking, so there was no way he could call my name.

I must have been hoping he'd stop me. I wanted my big brother to tell me to knock it off, that a member of the royal family should never take an innocent person's life. I wanted him to tell me it had to be another trick, and we'd find some other way.

"I'm still...such a fool."

There was only one path left for me and nothing more. Reminding myself of that, I left the room for good. I told the maids waiting outside they could go back in, then headed for my carriage.

Behind me, the door to Lance's room clicked shut.

"Bro! I'm comin' in!"

The guards opened Lance's door for me, revealing a dark room; the curtains were drawn over the windows. I passed the maids and marched straight to his bed.

Lance was still asleep under his covers. My brother was a deep sleeper, and since my voice was so familiar, he didn't stir at the sound. He lay there motionless, staring up at the ceiling like he was dead. I strode to his windows and yanked his curtains open.

The sun had hardly crested the horizon, but the light made him cry out like it burned him. He covered his face with his sturdy arms to shield himself.

"Weren't you the one telling me we've gotta finish up work before we head to Freesia today?" I urged him. "We're gonna miss Anemone's ship at this rate! C'mon, I'll help!"

Lance groaned. "Oh, yeah..." He rubbed his temples and sighed. "Cedric... You're already dressed? When did you wake up?"

I grunted an answer, and he finally clambered out of bed with a yawn. I took a seat in front of his desk while the maids helped him dress, looking over his pile of half-finished paperwork.

"I just happened to wake up early this morning," I said. "Figured it was a sign to get out of bed."

I'd woken up feeling sluggish, like I'd thrashed through nightmares all night. In all likelihood, I hadn't slept well because I was anxious about today. Lance asked if I'd fallen asleep at my desk again, but I denied it. I wouldn't have done anything to risk oversleeping on such an important day. I'd hopped out of bed before sunrise, changed on my own, then hurried over here.

I flipped through his paperwork, scanning every page. The documents pertained to export restrictions on gold, indicating that our country's gold and gems would rise in value as exports decreased. It was good news. We had plenty of resources, but if we distributed them recklessly, someone was bound to take advantage of us. There was no point supplying other countries with more than the trickle we already sent Freesia.

"Hey, Bro, are the research materials you need to finish this stuff around here somewhere?" I asked, nodding toward the books and documents sitting at the side of his desk.

Lance had mentioned needing to get through everything on that desk today. Fargus had compiled information about the countries we planned to trade with and the conditions of those deals. There were only a hundred pages about our current trade partners, but the actual books were incredibly thick. I quickly set the papers aside and picked up the tome that looked like it would take the longest.

Hmm? I leafed through the book at random, glanced at a few pages, then inspected the cover. The title and all the rest were familiar. *I knew it.*

Unpleasant memories reared their heads, but I stuffed them down and laid eyes on Bro's paperwork instead. Resting my elbows on his desk, I held my head in my hands. "I've read all these books before," I told him, my voice coming out a bit deeper than usual. "Just ask me if there's anything you want to know."

"Is something wrong?" he asked.

My eyes lingered on the array of research materials before me. "I read these fourteen years ago. I'm glad it's gonna help you, but I'm still pissed."

I would never feel a lick of gratitude toward *those* people, but at least something they'd forced on me was useful. Knowing Bertrand, I doubted he'd cared about anything but making me memorize the thickest books he had.

Lance smiled at me in understanding. "The fact that you can say that proves how much you've grown." He was right; the old me would have bottled up my pain and refused to speak of it.

I swiftly returned to skimming the texts, flipping page after page. The documents outlined even more new information about foreign countries. Anemone came up along the way, and with it, an incredible list of products for import. That list alone took up two pages.

"Anemone's amazing, aren't they?" I said. "They've increased their imports, exports, and clients so much in just two years. We already import from them, but we're going to start exporting gold and gems to them too, right?"

"Yeah. Chinensis has their own conditions, so they can't export gems to Anemone directly, but Yohan said he'll let them go through us instead."

Chinensis's religion forbade slavery, a condition that prevented them from trading directly with Anemone for now. But that didn't mean they weren't grateful for Anemone's help during the defensive war. Yohan had come up with a system wherein Chinensis would sell their gems to us so we could resell them to Anemone.

"Slavery will probably be outright abolished in Anemone before long," my brother said.

I believed it. Once that was official, Anemone and Chinensis could trade under even better conditions.

Lance closed his eyes, his smile one of relief. "The Chinensian people think highly of both Yohan and Prince Leon. If they didn't, we

couldn't travel on Anemone's ship today, could we?"

A trade vessel from Anemone would be arriving soon. Prince Leon himself had offered to take us to his kingdom once he finished his business here. It took ten days to reach Freesia from Hanazuo by carriage, but if we departed from Anemone instead, we'd cut our travel time in half. We were incredibly grateful for His Highness's offer. Most of all...

"I'm looking forward to our voyage with Prince Leon," I said. "It'll be my first time on a ship."

Our country had been closed off to the world for so many years. We had harbors, but they housed nothing but fishing vessels. Lance, Yohan, and I had never set foot on a ship before.

At my excited admission, Lance replied softly, "Me too." He once told me he'd always yearned to go out to sea after reading about it in books long ago. Now he finally had a chance to make that dream a reality.

"I hear Prince Leon captains the ship himself," I went on. "I hope he'll teach me some basics."

"Then ask him. Just make sure you're not rude about it."

I returned to the pile of paperwork before me. "Obviously."

Even I had read about maritime voyages in books, but the accounts all took place in the past. Nothing could beat the real deal. I doubted Lance or Yohan would suffer from that ailment called "seasickness" either. Sailing couldn't be *that* different from being in a carriage.

"I imagine we'll reach Freesia six days before Tiara's birthday, at the earliest," I said. "It'll give us a lot of time to speak with Pride and the others."

Prince Leon had offered for us to stay with him for a while, but we declined due to the circumstances between Yohan and Anemone. Instead, we were granted five or six days to stay in the Freesian royal residence, depending on when we arrived. That would afford us plenty of time for meetings about the establishment of our international postal service.

"Let me remind you that just because we might get six days in Freesia, that doesn't mean you'll get to spend them all talking to Princess Tiara."

I raised my head to find Lance smiling mischievously. "I know that!" I said with a huff, but he simply chuckled.

During our last visit, I'd finally managed to convince Tiara to accept me as a marriage candidate...yet the idea of getting engaged to me had apparently been horrible enough to make her cry.

Still, marrying me would give her a way to stay in Freesia as long as she wanted. If I could help unburden her of even the slightest bit of grief, I wouldn't ask for anything in return. That just left the matter of who Princess Tiara *actually* loved. Perhaps there was another candidate outside of Prince Stale or Prince Leon. Or maybe there was no one she—

"Princess Tiara will be busy during her birthday party, so make sure you don't bug her too much," Lance said. "Princess Pride and

Prince Stale wrote in their letters they were eager to see you, remember?"

Pride. I gulped, nervous at the mere thought of reuniting with the woman who was essentially a god in my eyes. But my joy surged past the anxiety. Pride had done so much for me, even after the defensive war. All this time, I'd been stuck on the receiving end of her mercy and goodwill, but I would finally get a chance to return the favor once I took on the role of postmaster general. *I owe her everything. I'll never be able to repay her.*

If not for her, I would've lost every blessing I had in my life. I shivered just imagining her ditching me after I'd embarrassed myself and treated her so badly. My cheeks flamed as those scenes returned with perfect clarity. I tugged at the front of my shirt and took deep, calming breaths, but it was no use. The memories clawed their way into my brain and threatened to stop my heart.

I clutched my head in my hands, abandoning the documents before me, and Lance muttered, "Not again..."

"Pardon me. I couldn't help myself. Your hair was simply too beautiful."

"I have a feeling the three days I spend here will be very enjoyable."

"I hate you!"

"What the hell do you know about any of it?!"

A yelp slipped from my lips as the memories sent me back to some of my worst moments. I'd trained myself to stay composed in

front of Pride and Prince Stale these days, but at home, with no one but Lance, all I wanted was to slam my forehead on the desk. Steam might as well have been gushing out of my ears.

Once Lance finished changing, he came to my side to give my head a light smack. "Calm down, Cedric. Just be sure not to act like that once you're the postmaster general."

"I-I know that."

I could control myself around other people, but my face was burning red with only him around. It would have been less painful to see portraits and descriptions of my own misdeeds instead of reliving these memories with perfect clarity.

I rubbed my head where Lance had hit me, and he set his hand on top of mine.

"Come, let's get a move on," he said. "We'll need your help to finish up our work during the trip to Freesia."

His encouragement convinced me to lift my head—but when I did, I found him grinning at me.

I offered him a smile of my own. "Right!"

Lance ruffled my hair in response. I let him go back to his desk, taking some documents to the sofa with me. He asked me about different countries as they came up in his work while I read through the batch of papers in my hands.

Tiara's birthday was eleven days away. I could barely contain my excitement. How could I *not* be overjoyed to see the woman I loved making her societal debut? Queen Rosa would also use the occasion

to formally announce the international postal service run by the United Hanazuo Kingdom and Freesia.

This time, I was going to stand next to Lance and Yohan with my head held high.

Chapter 6:
A Story Worthy of a Prequel
PRIDE

FIVE DAYS REMAINED until Tiara's birthday. The three guests from the United Hanazuo Kingdom arrived at our castle just as the country was settling down. They'd sailed to Anemone with Leon on one of his trade ships, as he just happened to be in Hanazuo on the day of their departure, then taken a carriage here to Freesia.

Leon had steered the ship himself, and the party had arrived safely in Anemone as scheduled. However, they'd only set out for *our* country the next morning. I knew sea voyages sometimes stretched on longer than intended, so I hadn't found it particularly surprising when they didn't make it to Freesia yesterday.

But once I actually spoke with the party, I learned that they had indeed reached Anemone after only five days of sailing—the fastest possible journey. It was King Yohan's intense bout of seasickness that delayed their trip to Freesia. None of them had ever set foot on a ship before, and while King Lance and Cedric were unaffected, King Yohan had been queasy from the second day onward.

It might have been worse if Leon and the crew hadn't taken measures to ease King Yohan's ailment. They hadn't needed to turn back or stop at any ports along the way, but King Yohan had been confined to bed the moment he fell ill. With the king barely able to stand by the time they reached Anemone, they'd stayed overnight at

the Anemonian castle rather than forcing His Majesty into a carriage in such a state.

King Yohan flushed red with embarrassment as he told me this story. He, King Lance, and Cedric hadn't wanted to stay in Anemone at all due to the circumstances with Chinensis, but the king of Chinensis himself had forced their hand. By the time he finished recounting the tale, King Yohan was covering his face in shame over the whole ordeal. King Lance and Cedric just laughed, but a dispirited King Yohan muttered, "I'm thinking of taking a carriage home on my own..." Clearly he didn't like making trouble for Leon either.

As for Cedric, he'd spent most of his time around the ship learning all sorts of things from Leon and the crew. He had spent the journey in high spirits, speaking with Anemonians during his stay at the castle too.

King Yohan enjoyed the trip as well—at least until the seasickness struck. In fact, the topic of the ship itself made him smile as brightly as his two companions. No other subject in our conversation caused him to light up so.

Thus, once King Yohan had recovered, Hanazuo's representatives completed the journey to Freesia. The trio would be staying at our castle until the day after Tiara's party. Cedric and Tiara danced around each other as awkwardly as ever... It seemed she was still angry with him, though she managed to stay more composed than in their previous meetings. She stood quietly by my side as I chatted with the three men.

Right as we wrapped up our conversation, it was time for the imperial knight shift change. After Stale confirmed that Arthur would be on his break, he turned to Cedric nonchalantly and offered him an invitation. "Would you care to spar with me?"

That's a little frightening... I feel like Stale just raised a death flag for Cedric. Not only had Cedric once eaten food meant for Stale and Arthur, but he was now a marriage candidate for their dear Tiara.

"We'll see you later, Elder Sister." Stale grinned as he bade me farewell. Cedric had jumped at the offer, so he, Stale, and Arthur headed off together.

I smiled stiffly, my lips twitching. "Have a good time..."

Frankly, it was like watching a soldier march into a hopeless battle. When I waved, my hand quivered. Cold sweat plastered my dress to my back.

"Um...!" I hesitantly called out, and we faced one another.

"Is something wrong?" Stale asked.

"Please go easy on him, okay?" I told him, too terrified to express myself any less bluntly.

Stale's smile only grew. "What are you talking about?"

My blood ran even colder.

STALE

C*LANG, CLANG!*

The shrill sound of metal against metal echoed off the walls as I exchanged blows with Cedric. We each landed the occasional hit

between bouts of intense defensive maneuvers, carefully calculating our every move.

"I'd expect nothing less from you, Prince...Cedric!"

I knocked Cedric's sword aside and lunged at him. Cedric leaned away, flicked his wrist to snap his sword into the proper grip, and returned my strike.

Clank! Our blades collided. Cedric knocked me back enough to throw me off my guard. He seized the opportunity and went for a thrust. I dodged, turning my momentum into a cartwheel.

"You speak too highly of me, Prince Stale," Cedric said, amazed. "You're far more talented than I am."

The Cercian prince smiled, eyes blazing. He tightened his grip on his sword, waiting for my counterattack. When I charged in as he anticipated, Cedric jumped back, evaded the thrust, and struck my sword. I pushed to keep Cedric from disarming me, and our blades were forced downward in tandem.

Cedric was off-balance thanks to the recoil, but he used the momentum of his fall to cartwheel away as I had. He landed, took to his knees, and prepared to jump up for another attack, but I lowered my sword. Cedric did the same as he rose to his feet.

"I didn't think you'd be such a match for me," I said. "I'm a bit disappointed in myself. I thought I was quite good with a sword."

I smiled sadly, wiping the sweat from my brow. I'd been sparring with Cedric for an hour, but we both refused to give any ground.

"You exaggerate," Cedric replied humbly, clutching his chest to catch his breath. "I've learned many things from my instructors, but I believe you're stronger than any of them... No, you're stronger than any soldier in our entire country, Prince Stale! Your swordsmanship resembles the knights who fought in the defensive war. I can hardly believe a member of Freesian royalty managed to reach this level!"

Apparently, Cedric had studied many things after the defensive war, two of them being swordsmanship and hand-to-hand combat. Despite stealing his techniques from Elder Sister and the Freesian knights, he'd already surpassed his instructors and soldiers when it came to one-on-one matches. His tutors must have given him only the basics, and my style was far more advanced—yet he still managed to absorb my techniques and test them out for himself. The longer we fought, the more skills he added to his arsenal.

"No, I'm nothing so impressive. But I see the rumors are true, Prince Cedric. It's frightening how you can absorb absolutely any technique I throw at you. I wouldn't be surprised if you manage to steal all my skills."

Arthur watched from the sidelines as I slouched and Cedric broke into a grin. My friend's jaw had been hanging open throughout the entire match. He knew my skill with a sword better than anyone. The more he watched Cedric steal my techniques in real time, the more he too must have realized just how abnormal the Cercian prince was.

"It felt like I was fighting multiple knights at once," I added, raising my sword. "Thank you for giving me useful experience, as I

don't have many people to spar with."

Upon seeing me ready myself, Cedric lifted his sword as well. We flowed into a light series of blows that almost resembled a normal sparring match. *Clink! Clink!* Even the sound of metal colliding softened into something less harsh.

"You're the only person who's been a good match for me too, Prince Stale. I see why Pride thinks so highly of you, and why Tiara is..."

My smile faltered when he mentioned my little sister. "What was that about Tiara?!"

He batted my sword aside as sadness welled in his eyes. He put some space between us, lightly sweeping his blade as though trying to brush aside his own feelings. "May I ask you...something discourteous?"

Clang! Our swords collided in time with the question.

Once I nodded, Cedric thanked me and schooled his expression. "How exactly do you feel about Princess Tiara, Your Highness?"

"How do I...feel?"

The answer was simple enough, but I didn't understand Cedric's intentions. Rather than taking a moment to tilt my head in confusion, I continued to deflect Cedric's attacks until the prince quietly cast his eyes down to his blade.

"Princess Tiara turns sixteen today," Cedric said. "I wanted to know if you...will still refer to her as your 'little sister' from here on out."

"Excuse me?!"

My yelp hardly suited Cedric's grave tone. I scrambled to get my thoughts in order as we exchanged blows anew, but a certain prediction crept into my head.

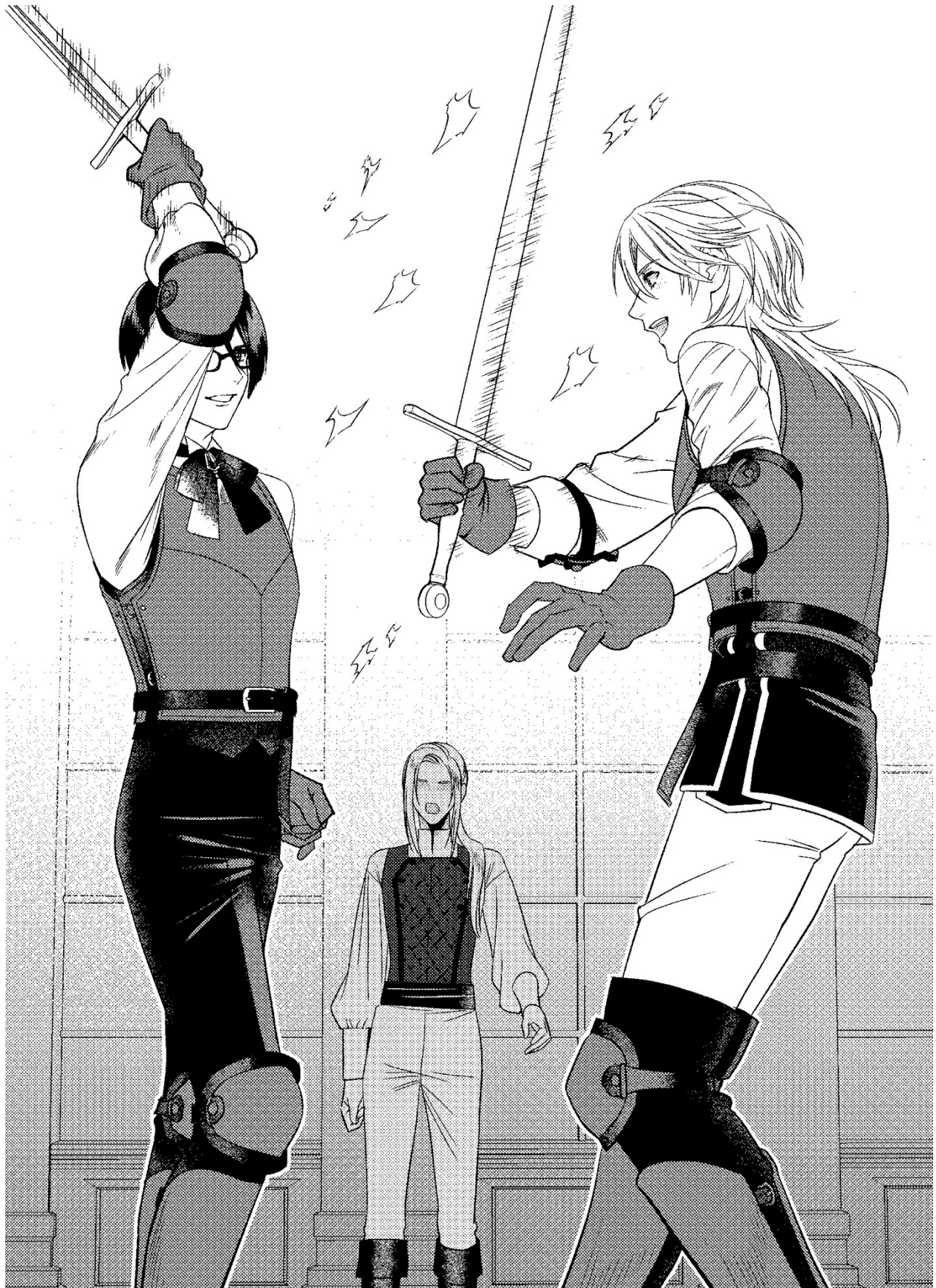
We were too quiet for Arthur to overhear, but the second I let my shoulders slump again, I figured he put two and two together.

"Princess Tiara...or rather, *Tiara* is a wonderful woman," Cedric said. "I'm sure she's stolen the hearts of many men, not just my own. That includes...men who may have fallen for her long before I did."

Something in his gaze alluded to a deeper meaning he had yet to divulge. Words escaped me, and I found myself hoping Cedric would fill the silence for me. I steeled myself to hold back a laugh as the quiet stretched on.

"I'm also aware that there are others out there more suited for her than I am," Cedric continued. "Wouldn't you agree that if it weren't for the issue of her remaining in Freesia, Prince Leon would be the better choice?"

For the first time, I had to acknowledge that he was correct. Problem was, Leon was Pride's ex-fiancé. *Then again, what if...?*



"Can I ask *you* something, Your Highness?" I said, and Cedric nodded. "How much do you know about Prince Leon?"

This question surprised him, hesitant as he was to expand on his thoughts.

"Please don't hold back," I coaxed him. "I don't mind if you include speculation."

That finally convinced Cedric to speak. "Prince Leon Adonis Coronaria is the firstborn prince of Anemone. He's a well-known man, being the heir to the Anemonian throne. Anemone itself is one of the greatest trade hubs in the world and an ally of Freesia, whom they've maintained friendly relations with for many years. They formed an alliance just seven years ago, but they've grown incredibly close since then."

Cedric prattled on and on, hardly pausing to breathe.

"Prince Leon attracts a lot of women at formal events and ceremonies, thanks to his good looks. He's also a man of upstanding character and extremely popular with his people. They say he's making great progress in developing Anemone's trade relations as well. He's a brilliant trader, negotiator, and ship captain, and his subordinates place great trust in him. He also treated my brothers and me very well during our voyage. During the defensive war, he protected the Cercian gates with only a few men, and he lent his aid to our country's people after that..."

I continued throwing blows at him all throughout this, but his every word only confirmed my theory. Cedric possessed the gift of perfect recall; he was in the middle of recounting every last fact he

knew. The more he spoke, the more he shifted from Leon to Anemone itself, like he was reciting descriptions from a book or an encyclopedia.

As impressive as it was, it was also pretty amusing. Cedric had all that knowledge in his head...yet he had no idea Leon was Pride's ex-fiancé.

Finally understanding why Tiara had been so mad at Cedric the last time they met, I struggled to stifle my laughter. Cedric had begun to wrap up his speech, so I tried to focus on his words. But then...

"I believe Prince Leon is likely one of Tiara's marriage candidates."

At that, I had to whip my face away from the dead-serious prince. I knocked Cedric's sword aside, trying my hardest to bite back a mocking smile, and peered at Arthur instead. The knight blinked at the look on my face.

I fought the urge to tell him everything, forced myself to act composed, and turned back to Cedric. "I-I see..."

It was a struggle to respond while tamping down my laughter, but Cedric didn't seem to see through my act and continued right where he left off. "Tiara...feels very strongly about you, Prince Stale. It's almost comical how much more she loves you than me."

Cedric's voice, more melancholic than before, hit me like a ton of bricks. The helplessness with which he said each word honed them into blades pointing at his own chest.

At length, he repeated his question from earlier. "What are your feelings toward Princess Tiara, Your Highness?"

I'd correctly pinpointed Cedric's massive yet amusing misunderstanding. I maintained a stern expression while tensing my shoulders to keep them from trembling.

Evidently, Cedric took my silence to mean something else entirely. He doubled down, almost pleading with me. "Prince Stale, I love Tiara very much! All I want is for her to be happy. If you love her too, then I will—"

"Th-that's enough, Prince Cedric! For both our sakes, don't say any more!"

Voice strained, I smacked Cedric's sword right out of his hand. Cedric furrowed his brow. He opened his mouth, wondering at my refusal to answer...and then gave in.

"Forgive me," he said, as though he'd overstepped in asking at all.

I fanned my face to cool it down; I'd flushed from the sheer passion behind Cedric's words. Then I smirked, sizing up the despondent prince. "Prince Cedric, shall we have a real match this time?"

Cedric lifted his head. "A real match?"

Suppressing a chuckle, I told him, "If you win, I'll answer any question you have for me...even if it's about Tiara."

Cedric flinched. "Do you really mean that?"

I smiled and nodded. Even *I* felt this was a bit mean-spirited, but I allowed the moment to stretch on.

"Very well. I accept your challenge."

Once Cedric made his determination known, I shot a look toward Arthur. My friend paled as he met my gaze, but he obediently hurried over despite his unease.

I placed my hand on Arthur's shoulder when he joined us. Ignoring his confusion, I addressed Cedric instead. "The rules are simple. We'll have a mock battle using hand-to-hand combat in addition to our swords. If you manage to land one hit on Arthur or myself, victory will be yours."

"Huh?!" Arthur blurted out. He snapped his mouth shut, but his wide eyes screamed, *What the hell are you talking about?!*

Instead of addressing Arthur, I resumed my explanation. "You lose if you take a knee, collapse, or drop your sword. You win if you strike your opponent with your blade. As a knight, Arthur will fight without a weapon. I won't use my special power either."

This time, Cedric was the one taken aback. He didn't seem to mind me not teleporting, but Arthur would be unarmed. The knight was going up against a sword with no weapon of his own, not to mention a much shorter reach. It wasn't just a disadvantage; Cedric could end up hurting Arthur by mistake.

When Cedric blanched, I assured him, "Don't worry. Arthur is one of the imperial knights who protects my elder sister. He's rather strong, I'd say."

I patted Arthur a few more times—a bit proudly, or so it would seem. He, on the other hand, was confused about the point of going through this whole mock battle. "Um...could someone please explain this to me?!"

I grabbed his shoulder and pulled him close, whispering into the knight's ear, "This is revenge for the food. Don't go easy on him." Arthur gulped. I gave him one last slap on the back, sending him out in front of Cedric. "Okay, go ahead and begin."

Cedric readied his sword. "By the way, Prince Stale, what happens if you both beat me?"

Even Arthur, preparing himself for their match, looked at me for an answer. Unlike Cedric and myself, he was wearing full armor and had a sword at his hip.

I stepped back to get out of their way, mischief all but shimmering in my gaze. "If you lose to both of us, then you won't get to ask about anything we've discussed. How does that sound?" I asked with a smirk.

Arthur flinched, and though he didn't say as much, I would've bet anything that I reminded him of Gilbert in that moment. Just like the prime minister often did, I'd put forth a sly proposal to do away with what I deemed inconvenient. Arthur looked guilty when Cedric asked if that was really all. Arthur sighed, removed his armored gloves, and left them on the ground.

"You don't...want to keep those on?"

Perplexed, Cedric eyed Arthur's bare hands. He and I were both wearing gloves ourselves.

"It will be safer this way," Arthur said.

Arthur kept his sword in its sheath at his hip and fell into a fighting stance. Cedric seemed dubious about Arthur's claim, but the

knight had insisted; the other prince must've assumed he simply wanted to free up his hands or something along those lines.

At my signal, Cedric darted forward. He charged at Arthur, thrusting his sword, but the knight jumped out of range. Cedric stumbled but didn't pursue, instead taking three steps back and bringing his sword up. This time, Arthur kicked off the ground and flew up to Cedric's chest...all from the momentum of that single kick.

Cedric cried out in shock. Arthur had closed the distance between them far faster than he'd expected. He arched back and raised his sword to block.

Wham!

Before he could defend himself, Arthur's fist connected with Cedric's stomach.

"Oof!"

Cedric wore training armor, but the hit still knocked the wind out of him. The Cercian prince managed to stay on his feet, unable to do much aside from clutching his stomach. He flicked his sword back into the correct grip and swung it at Arthur's blind spot now that they were so close.

Arthur grasped his hand mid-swing, leaned forward, and tossed Cedric over his shoulder. Cedric slammed into the ground, armor and all, a look of purest shock in his wide eyes. The intensity of the impact knocked the breath out of him all over again, and it would be a while before he could get back on his feet.

It was over in the blink of an eye.

Cedric stared at the sky, dazed. Yet no matter how many times he replayed that moment with perfect clarity, he'd never make sense of it. Arthur had moved so fast, Cedric was on the ground by the time he realized the knight had his arm. His mouth hung open as he tried to contend with the match ending so quickly. He'd never let his guard down, but Arthur was just that much stronger than Cedric had imagined. He lay there for a while, completely befuddled, until Arthur peeked down at him with a face even paler than his own.

"I-I'm so sorry, Prince Cedric! I didn't mean to! A-are you hurt?! Please forgive me!"

My friend dropped to his knees, placed his hand on Cedric's back, and gently helped him sit up. Cedric stared at the knight, unable to reply as he took in Arthur's horror. Only once he realized Arthur was checking him for signs of fainting or injuries—something the knight definitely had experience with—did he scrounge up a response. "It's no big deal."

Arthur breathed a sigh of relief, stood up, and offered his hand to the prince on the ground. "I'm truly sorry. I didn't think it would be so..."

He hung his head. Cedric shook his head, waving off the apology. He studied the knights' bare hands, and understanding dawned on his face. That "safety" precaution was for Cedric's sake, as he was the one taking the hit. Cedric shuddered, surely imagining how much force the armored gloves would have added. It had already been an intense blow, and Cedric had protection too. Without those precautions, Arthur would've had no trouble breaking his ribs.

As Arthur frantically apologized, I spun away and hunched over in a fit of laughter, hand clapped over my mouth. I could tell Arthur had truly given the practice battle his fullest efforts. The Cercian prince had assumed Arthur took off his gloves to go easy on him, but it was the exact opposite! Now Cedric knew full well that Arthur *did* have some lingering resentment, despite hesitating to participate at first.

Not only had Cedric made severe missteps in the past, but he'd eaten food meant for Arthur and become a marriage candidate for Tiara, who was like a sister to the knight. Deep down, Arthur probably harbored a childish grudge about the misunderstandings Cedric had caused over his relationship with Pride too.

From the moment I first suggested a mock battle, I was certain Arthur would land a good punch on Cedric, if nothing else. And Arthur could've done a lot worse with that shoulder throw, so he must have held back.

How could Arthur, of all people, beat up a prince?!

Laughter threatened to overcome me again, but I couldn't let Cedric think I was mocking him in his defeat, so I bit my cheek to hold it in. Once I'd safely assumed a serene smile, I approached the pair and asked if they were all right.

Facing Arthur, I went on, "I shouldn't have expected anything less from you. Even I was surprised to see how quickly you overpowered His Highness."

Not that the overpowering part was a surprise, I thought as I took my place next to Arthur.

"What did you think?" I asked.

Cedric's response was instant. "I can tell how incredibly skilled you are, being one of Pride's imperial knights and all! That's something I could never imitate."

Despite the beatdown, his tone was surprisingly cheerful. Being unable to imitate someone was highly unusual for Cedric, but there was no copying the raw power Arthur had mustered up for that first punch.

Cedric showed only a newfound respect for the knight, so I figured it was time for him to face me. I stepped forward, taking Arthur's place, and asked if the prince needed a break. Cedric shook his head.

"All right, then. It's my turn." I rolled my shoulders and picked up my practice sword. Arthur took note of my good mood and backed up a few steps, clearly skeptical.

Unlike Arthur, I was at a similar level as Cedric when it came to swordplay. Neither of us had extra restrictions either; we could end up at a stalemate once again.

At Arthur's signal, we sprinted at each other. We initially stuck to blocking and parrying like last time. When Cedric found an opening and swung, I predicted the trajectory of his blade and sidestepped just in time. I sent back an answering slash, and Cedric sidestepped in the exact same manner I had.

Clang! Clang! The sound of blows echoed off the walls once more. It was a battle of stamina, but Cedric looked like he doubted his

ability to prevail. While I'd had some time to recover, he was dueling back-to-back.

Cedric grounded himself in his stance, sending that strength into his arms when our swords met. Using this tactic, he pushed with his full body weight behind the blade—granting him a physical advantage. I bent backward, taking a step back to steady myself, and dug my heels into the ground. Just as our swords started to rattle against each other from the pressure...

Struggling to maintain my balance, I met Cedric's eyes. "I'm grateful to you, Royal Prince Cedric."

At first, Cedric narrowed his eyes, like my flattery was some mere distraction. He kept his guard up and met my gaze. Having already lost to Arthur, this fight with me was his last chance.

"In all honesty...Elder Sister and I were saddened by the idea that Tiara would move away," I said, smiling sadly. "It's a big relief to know she'll be able to stay in our country, as embarrassing as that is to say."

Cedric frowned as a series of emotions flitted across his face. To him, it might've seemed that my expression concealed my true intentions. Perhaps I spoke as a man, perhaps as an older brother. We pushed our swords together as hard as we could, while I twisted my already bent back to remain in perfect alignment with Cedric.

"Not only that, but Elder Sister has also wanted to implement an international postal service for three years now. It's thanks to you and Hanazuo as a whole that we've managed to put that in motion."

My smile softened. I used every last bit of strength I had, all while revealing the tenderest expression Cedric had ever seen on me.

"Truly, I want to thank you. I expect great things from you as the postmaster general, and I'll do whatever I can to help you. Let's make the postal service the best it can be."

Cedric was startled by my earnestness. His eyes widened as it dawned on him that I was giving him my approval, and some of the tension eased out of his posture. When he caught himself relaxing, he clenched his jaw and snapped out of—

"But still..."

Suddenly, my voice pitched deeper than before. I did it in a blink to throw Cedric off-balance.

"I don't think you're the right partner for Tiara, nor do I have the slightest intention of forgiving you for how you mistreated Elder Sister."

Grinning, I sprang backward to leave Cedric teetering. He doubled over for a second, but that was all the time I needed to swipe his legs out from under him.

Before Cedric could fall, he stuck his sword in the ground and tried to rest one foot on it to keep himself upright. That was when I grabbed his shoulders. For a brief moment, Cedric's red eyes met my jet-black ones, and then I yanked on him. As Cedric pitched forward, I pushed off his shoulders, using them as a springboard to smoothly jump over him. I twirled through the air, landed behind Cedric, and kicked him in the back without even turning around.

Arthur caught my evil smile as I sent Cedric flailing. The force of the kick finally knocked him down. He threw his arms out to catch himself, but since his knees hit the floor, it was over. Cedric had lost.

He crouched there in a stupor, struggling to comprehend how he'd been rapidly trounced yet again. His hands curled in bitter disappointment.

"I'm not going to get in your way, though," I told him. "Now, can you stand?"

I stood in front of Cedric, returning to my usual gentlemanly demeanor. Kneeling, I offered him my hand. Cedric thanked me and took it, face gloomy as he brushed the dirt from his pants. It seemed my words had come as a greater shock than his defeat.

He knew I'd never fully forgiven him for how he treated Elder Sister, but hearing me say as much—as well as that he wasn't the right partner for Tiara—had rendered Cedric speechless. He'd experienced defeat on every level today. The prince blushed as though reliving his cruelty toward Pride, though the look in his eyes carried a hint of something more intense.

"We should probably head back. I need to return to the seneschal soon, and isn't it almost time for your training exercises, Arthur?"

Cedric smiled through his sadness at my chipper tone. When I suggested as much, he headed toward the changing room.

After teleporting Arthur away, I stood in front of a separate changing room. Before entering, I called out, "Prince Cedric?"

The slumping Cercian prince, his messy blond hair caked with dirt, turned and took in my pleasant smile.

"Just so you know, Tiara is my dear sister. She's family to me, and that will never change. Tiara feels the same way about me too."

With that, I made for the changing room, leaving Cedric rooted to the spot. He didn't budge when I left him with that parting message, his eyes wide and mouth hanging open. Fresh hope blazed in his red eyes.

"Does that mean...?!"

His dumbfounded look shifted into awe. He reached in the direction I'd gone, though there wasn't much point to it. Cedric trembled, mouth flapping as though he wanted to speak, but nothing came out.

Little did he know that I was moments away from smirking to myself in the changing room, having gotten my revenge at last.

PRIDE

"HHEY, PRIDE, that reminds me! Can I spar with your imperial knights again?"

It was the third day after Cedric and his brothers had arrived at our castle. While everyone prepared for Tiara's birthday party in two days' time, Cedric enjoyed his stay in the castle to the fullest.

"I don't mind, personally..."

Tiara and I had been reading in the garden when Cedric appeared, his eyes sparkling. I glanced at Captain Alan and Captain

Callum behind me, who agreed so long as Cedric and I both approved. All was well, save for the slight twitch in Captain Callum's eyebrow.

Once they set a time, Cedric thanked us and headed for the library, where he'd been spending most of his time. I'd feared he might ambush Tiara with his feelings now that he was back at the Freesian castle, but our books had drawn him in instead. Tiara had spent the past month working with Mother on her birthday plans, so it was better that he leave her be while she was so busy.

Our massive castle library was filled with mountains of the rarest books in all the world. Cedric could only read the ones we made available to people from all countries, but he spent hour after hour absorbing their indispensable knowledge. He sought a better understanding of Freesia to facilitate living and working here, so he blazed through the books about our homeland: our laws, our terrain and geography, our history, our culture. It was almost frightening how every last detail lodged permanently in his head.

The last time we spoke, he shocked me by revealing he'd already memorized the entirety of our laws, terrain, and geography. It was a matter of time before he had the other subjects down too. At least Stale hadn't been around to hear that. He'd only finished memorizing all of Freesian law one week ago, and if he heard that Cedric did the same in a mere three days, even *Stale* wouldn't have been able to hide his shock. I had been dismayed as well, having taken years to memorize those laws myself.

On top of that, Cedric had mapped out the entirety of the castle and its facilities using nothing but blueprints and the glimpses he

caught from his carriage and bedroom windows. He didn't have the interior memorized yet, but it was amazing enough that he'd learned both the royal palace and all the unused facilities and towers on the castle property. Even after living here all my life, such a feat impressed me. It took over a day to tour the entirety of the castle, so Cedric said blueprints weren't sufficient and he needed to see everything with his own eyes next time.

If he followed through on that, he would witness the egotistical expansions past queens had made: vacation homes, spires just for stargazing, and isolated towers used for confinement. He would even witness frightful relics such as the gallows, towers used for torture or storing corpses, and gravesites. I wanted to avoid Cedric memorizing those abominable pieces of Freesia's history, if possible. Worst-case, he might get the wrong idea and think we still used those dreadful places.

"Gosh, that Prince Cedric sure is something, huh?" Captain Alan said, scratching the back of his neck.

"I just hope he doesn't do anything reckless like he did yesterday," Captain Callum muttered, looking concerned as he fiddled with his bangs.

Their gazes were fixed in the direction Cedric had gone. Tiara was reading her book next to me, but she shot a curious glance at the retreating figure of the prince.

"Well, he's certainly enjoying himself," I said, watching him with a half-hearted smile. "Please don't hesitate to refuse him if he's tiring you two out."

They thanked me and said it wasn't a problem, so I returned to my book.

After Cedric's sparring matches with Stale and Arthur, he'd come to me asking for matches with my imperial knights as well. Tiara and I had been concerned after Cedric's defeat by Stale, but thankfully he'd returned to us in perfect health. I didn't understand why he suddenly wanted to spar with them in the first place, but it seemed his enthusiasm hadn't cooled even after another day. "*Please don't go easy on me!*" he'd begged the knights.

In the end, Arthur and Captain Callum took turns knocking Cedric to the ground. Frighteningly, Cedric smiled the entire time.

The prince was no match for Captain Callum or Arthur—something I had expected from the beginning. Facing down sword slashes and unarmed strikes was vastly different from watching someone else do it, so Cedric struggled to steal moves from the knights he sparred with. It was also possible that they were simply too fast for him to keep up.

Cedric put up a surprisingly good fight against Arthur in the world of the game, but in reality, he was defeated soundly, even when Arthur removed his gloves as a handicap. The Arthur I knew here was probably much stronger than the one in the game.

I was told that Cedric suffered a nearly instant loss during his practice battle against Stale too. "*I don't think I'll ever be a match for Prince Stale,*" Cedric had said, a smile on his face. He requested more sparring rounds from Captain Alan and Vice Captain Eric once they changed shifts, whereupon he was completely and utterly pummeled

once again...even though Captain Alan had removed his gloves *and* his boots for their bout. Vice Captain Eric said it was too dangerous to fight Captain Alan hand-to-hand otherwise. Even with that, Cedric ended up on the ground again and again.

The prince had done a good job crossing swords with the imperial knights at first, but it was over once the knights fought with their full strength. "God's Child" could memorize sword techniques, but he couldn't copy the raw power and speed of his opponents. But for some reason, that made him oddly happy.

Arthur sent him flying through the air, Captain Callum scored a hit within five seconds of their battle beginning, Vice Captain Eric knocked his sword out of his hands and shoved him to the ground, and Captain Alan kicked him right off his feet. Yet each time, Cedric panted out, "*Please do that one more time!*" Frankly, it was a little bit frightening. Still, the more they battled, the more Cedric learned to predict the knights' attacks and evade them, so at least it wasn't the thrill of defeat motivating him to continue.

The more talented a person is, the scarier they are.

The knights probably felt guilty for beating up on the royal prince of Cercis, so Captain Alan instructed Cedric how to attack in midair, Captain Callum taught him chokeholds—both how to use them against a stronger opponent and how to avoid them himself—and Vice Captain Eric demonstrated how to make the most of subtle moves and weak points that could knock an enemy unconscious.

It's great that the captains and vice captain are so thoughtful, but still!

After the sparring matches were over and Cedric changed back into his normal clothes, he went straight to Mother and received permission to observe this morning's training sessions at the royal order along with the kings of Hanazuo. It was so like the man who'd come to Freesia all on his own to negotiate an alliance; he took the initiative in everything. He would certainly acquire even more skills by watching the knights fight each other.

"I'm looking forward to the next session!" Captain Alan said. As someone who also knew about Cedric being "God's Child," he probably expected the prince to show up with new moves in his arsenal. "He's been getting harder and harder to beat! I wonder if he could already beat a rookie knight!"

"Alan, this is the royal prince of Cercis you're sparring with. Don't forget that."

Yesterday, Captain Alan had swiped Cedric's feet out from under him and kicked him in midair before he hit the floor. It was a bold move, but Captain Callum had cut in to remind him who he was smacking around.

"I know that," Captain Alan replied, and then something struck him. "But...we should probably refuse if he wants to spar tomorrow morning." He scratched his head, smile faltering.

Captain Callum tapped his lips in thought, gaze focused on the ground. "You're right," he said seriously.

"We have a captains' meeting tomorrow morning...so Harrison will be taking over our shift."

Tiara and I exchanged glances. *Oh no...*

Captain Harrison used to be Arthur's superior officer, but now he worked underneath him as the vice captain. Arthur's promotion meant that only one of my imperial knights ranked lower than a captain.

Until recently, three other knights had accompanied Vice Captain Eric for his shifts while the captains were busy with their meetings, but we'd finally reached the point where I needed a new imperial knight to cover the gap. Stale insisted the imperial knights' shift schedule remain consistent while they protected me as much as possible, and as a result, Vice Captain Harrison had been assigned to take over whenever the others were absent. He was going to guard me during captains' meetings and when the others had the day off, so I would always have two imperial knights at my side.

When we first determined we needed another imperial knight, Arthur was the first to suggest Vice Captain Harrison. I agreed, as I knew the vice captain was extremely strong. According to Stale, Vice Captain Harrison idolized me, so he trusted Arthur's recommendation and the vice captain's ability to keep me safe. Vice Captain Eric supported the choice too, although he tensed when he realized that meant pairing up with Vice Captain Harrison during every single captains' meeting. Evidently, he found him as frightening as most others did.

I'd asked Captain Alan and Captain Callum for their opinions when they arrived for their shift after that. They mostly agreed with Stale; their only hang-up was whether Vice Captain Harrison would accept the job. They said that his past misdeeds, the ones that had

prevented him from joining the main forces, still burdened him, and that he believed he had nothing to offer except his combat prowess. Though he'd surely accept the job if it came as an order from Commander Roderick or Vice Commander Clark, Stale didn't want Vice Captain Harrison taking on the role unless he genuinely *wanted* it.

In the end, they went with Captain Alan's suggestion: *"He'll definitely agree if Arthur asks him, won't he?"*

Vice Captain Harrison adored Arthur, so we left him in charge of scouting my fifth imperial knight. He got Vice Captain Harrison's approval by the very next morning. Not that it came as a surprise.

Arthur told me the vice captain was taken aback at first, but he readily agreed once he heard the full explanation. He even burst into laughter by the end, though I felt that *had* to be the effect Arthur had on him and nothing to do with the job.

When I next met with the vice captain, he eagerly informed me he was ready to put his life on the line for my safety. Of course, as soon as those words left his mouth, he broke eye contact and said no more than the bare minimum, as usual.

Unfortunately, I doubted he "idolized" me as Stale claimed. He scarcely said a word even while on duty with his beloved Arthur. I was starting to fear he actually hated the job and only accepted because Arthur asked.

"I think Harrison will go easy on Prince Cedric if we order it," Captain Callum was saying, "but if His Highness asks him not to hold back, like he did with us, then Harrison will take it literally and try to kill the guy."

Captain Alan nodded his agreement. In Vice Captain Harrison's case, "holding back" meant anything short of killing his opponent. I shivered. Vice Captain Harrison had wiped out every last foe trying to break through the southern Chinensian border during the war. Captain Alan and Captain Callum's stories painted a vivid and terrifying picture of Vice Captain Harrison in battle.

I was starting to get pretty scared. I just hoped Cedric would spend the next day in the library, enjoying an entirely peaceful time with his books.

"Good morning, Your Highness."

It was the day before Tiara's birthday. Vice Captain Harrison and Vice Captain Eric arrived for their imperial knight shifts, greeting me with bows.

"Good morning, Vice Captain Eric, Vice Captain Harrison. Thank you for escorting me today."

Heading down the hall, I soon found Tiara and Stale. The five of us continued as a group. Tiara had already grown accustomed to Vice Captain Harrison and greeted him with a hearty, "Good morning!"

He dipped his head in response. Despite the blunt cut of his bangs, his long black hair spilled in front of his face when he bowed. Tiara actually had yet to hold eye contact with him. The same was true for me, as he quickly looked away as soon as our gazes met.

"Vice Captain Harrison, may I ask what you do in your free time?" Tiara said.

She'd been asking him questions off and on during his shifts, trying to get to know him. Of course the friendly Tiara showed no fear, even in the face of someone as intimidating as Vice Captain Harrison. Hearing the other knights talk about how much he doted on Arthur likely went a long way in dispelling his menace.

Stale didn't speak to Vice Captain Harrison much, but that wasn't a sign that he didn't trust the knight. At their first meeting, he beamed at the vice captain, shook his hand, and told him to take good care of me.

"I know you defended King Yohan's life and the southern region of Chinensis. I'll be expecting even more great things from you in the future."

Vice Captain Harrison's eyes glinted at that.

Those "great things" Stale mentioned consisted of slaughtering a bunch of enemies...

"I train."

The taciturn Vice Captain Harrison had nothing more than two words to say in response to Tiara's question. I knew it didn't mean he was upset with her, but his curt answer left Vice Captain Eric and me a bit uneasy.

"Of course! That makes sense!" Tiara replied, not taking his brevity personally at all.

My heart ached at how much she could enjoy even this conversation compared to the ones with Cedric. *No, that's only because she's friendly with everyone other than him...*

Tiara had accepted Cedric as a marriage candidate, but even now, I had trouble reading her true intentions. Things seemed to be going well for them only for the briefest of moments, but ever since he upset her again, Tiara had been avoiding him. Aside from basic greetings, they'd barely spoken in the four days after his arrival. Or perhaps it was more accurate to say she was too *busy* to speak to him.

My sister had lots of ideas about the important occasion of her sixteenth birthday and spent her days planning the event with Mother. Her schedule was packed again today, so I doubted she would speak to Cedric. I pitied him, as it seemed Tiara might have accepted his proposal just so she could stay in Freesia. Not that he seemed entirely dissatisfied with that.

Stale headed to Uncle Vest's office after eating, so Tiara and I passed the time before our studies began in the garden. She would have to work on the final preparations for tomorrow's party after our lessons, while I had a meeting with Mother and our guests about the postal service announcement. Tiara and I held hands and stepped into the garden, eager to get a little fresh air while we still had time.

Just then, a breeze blew past us, carrying with it a subtle but palpable rage.

The strange gust sent a chill down my spine. Then a scream cracked through the garden, followed by a bellow, the rumble of quaking earth, and the clang of something metallic. I whirled around to find Vice Captain Harrison gone.

"Vice Captain Harrison?!" Vice Captain Eric called out.

Panicked, Tiara and I made a mad dash for the commotion.

"Damn it! What the hell do you think you're doin'?!"

Once that second shout reached my ears, a wave of relief washed over me. *Good, he's still safe for now!*

Vice Captain Harrison was attacking a figure down near the palace gates. They were too far away to make out, but those dirt walls could only belong to one person.

"Stop, Vice Captain Harrison!" I shouted frantically, sprinting toward him.

The vice captain swung mercilessly at Val, who fended off the sudden ambush with the dirt at his feet. He knocked the blade and even the knight's bullets away with his sand. *Clang, clang!* Even at a distance, the sounds rang out clearly.

Sefekh blasted the vice captain with water, but he zipped past it. He didn't hesitate to fling his knives in retaliation, but Val blocked them using the earth as a shield. Val turned his sand into thornlike daggers and launched them at Vice Captain Harrison, who swiftly dodged the sand. I knew right away that Val was trying to protect the two children from the knight's assault. His fealty contract would've stopped him from attacking in any other circumstances.

Finally, Val gathered the earth around him into one massive wall, triggering an earthquake large enough to make me stagger. From a distance, it looked as if Vice Captain Harrison was battling a giant, but he never faltered. Instead, he tore at the earthen wall before him. I

could hardly believe my eyes as he steadily chipped away at the thick structure with nothing more than his sword.

When Vice Captain Harrison penetrated the wall, he was met with a jet of water from Sefekh. He evaded it, breaking through again, but each time his sword punctured the wall of dirt, Val patched it back up. Seeming fed up, Vice Captain Harrison raced *up* the wall using his incredible speed. He made it to the top and jumped over before I could do more than shriek. *This is really bad!*

Khemet screamed again as Val roared on the other side of the wall.

At last, I made it close enough for my voice to reach them. "V-Vice Captain Harrison! You can't kill them!" I was so out of breath, that cry alone nearly sent me to the ground.

The other side of the wall fell silent, and I broke into a cold sweat.

I straightened as I caught my breath, then inhaled for one more shout. "They're my delivery people! Please don't hurt them!"

No response. I had a *very* bad feeling about this. My throat went dry, and I started heaving again. Tiara trembled beside me, covering her mouth with both hands.

Step by step, I advanced toward the wall until I could reach out and touch it. I gave it a knock, but there was no way the sound could penetrate such a thick barrier. Then I tried to walk around it, only to find the structure was closer to a dome than a simple wall. Perhaps Val had been trying to make a protective dome and was interrupted

when Vice Captain Harrison attacked. *I bet Sefekh and Khemet are terrified.*

“Val! Can you hear me?! Please tear your wall down!”

Crack! Fwooooosh!

His special power deactivated in response to my voice. The relief that hit me was so powerful, I almost fainted. Vice Captain Eric steadied me so I didn’t crumple where I stood. I took Tiara’s hand, and we backed away.

The scale of the giant wall had attracted a group of guards and gardeners—the latter of whom were relieved to see that the threat to the palace gardens had been neutralized.

When the wall fell, a cloud of dust rose into the air. Figures slowly materialized in the haze. The tall one was definitely Val, with Khemet clinging to his side. Sefekh had her hands up, poised for an attack. Vice Captain Harrison stood frozen in front of them...his sword just shy of Val’s throat. Between his black locks, the vice captain’s purple eyes shone as he and Val glared at each other.

As I approached, I found Val had covered his neck with sand to protect it from the blade. Vice Captain Harrison could have easily sliced through it, however.

The tip of the vice captain’s sword trembled against the sand wall as he struggled to hold back his urge to thrust it. Val and Sefekh looked ready to jump him, but if they made one wrong move, Vice Captain Harrison would slit Val’s throat.

Val leaned his head back, turning his glare on me this time. His eyes said, *What the hell's goin' on?!*

"Forgive me, Vice Captain Harrison!" I called out. "I never explained this to you! This man is my personal deliveryman, not a threat."

I slid carefully between them so as not to set them off. While I explained about Sefekh and Khemet too, Tiara placed her hands on the children's shoulders in a show of trust. The terrified Khemet still clung to Val, and Sefekh glared ferociously at the knight with tears in her eyes.

"It's all right! This man is here to protect us!" Tiara cried out in desperation. Unfortunately, she would fail to persuade either of the children while Vice Captain Harrison's sword was at Val's throat.

"Please, lower your sword," I said slowly, like I was negotiating with the knight. "He's not going to hurt anyone anymore."

Finally, Vice Captain Harrison brought his sword down. The sound of the blade sliding into its sheath broke the tension, but he never tore his eyes away from Val. As for Val himself, he righted his posture and dropped the sand now that the immediate threat was gone. He rubbed his neck with one hand, confirming it was unscathed, and stepped aside to keep Sefekh and Khemet behind him.

"Mistress, what the *hell's* wrong with this knight?"

Val looked between the vice captain and me. He was more than just angry—each sharp breath was laced with deadly intent.

Frightened, I locked up on the spot. I was standing right between him and Vice Captain Harrison, who was just as bloodthirsty as Val.

My first order of business was to get them acquainted somehow. "This is Vice Captain Harrison. He's going to serve as my imperial knight from time to time. Vice Captain, this is—"

"I'll never forget him!" Vice Captain Harrison exploded before I could finish, his murderous rage flooding past his lips. "He's that wretched criminal from seven years ago!"

My hunch was right.

Puzzled, Val blurted out, "Huh?"

With Sefekh and Khemet listening, I motioned for Vice Captain Eric and Tiara to cover the children's ears. Still on high alert from this whole ordeal, they flinched and yelped at the slightest touch. As soon as Val turned to look at them, Vice Captain Harrison drew his sword again.

"You pulled the trigger on our commander! Even *death* would be too good to pay you back for what you've done!"

"Oh yeah? Too bad for you, but I already had my trial. If you don't like it, take it up with Mistress over here." It seemed Val had finally caught on.

Vice Captain Harrison whirled toward me, a pleading expression on his face. His eyes demanded an explanation. Thus, I recounted everything—from the fealty contract to Val's delivery work—but Vice Captain Harrison wasn't comforted in the slightest. Only after I informed him that the commander and vice commander had approved

of the arrangement and begged him to lower his weapon did he finally return the sword to its sheath.

Taking a knee, he said, "As you wish." Just as I thought I'd won him over, he stood and shot Val another vicious glare. "There won't be a next time. If you ever interact with the royal order again, I'll kill you."

"Sounds like we're on the same page. The last thing I wanna do is hang out with some damn knights."

Val flashed a menacing smirk, drawing even more ire from Vice Captain Harrison. I stepped back between them in case the animosity came to blows again, then nudged the conversation to whatever Val and the children had come here for. In truth, I'd been hoping to use their visit as an opportunity to reintroduce them to Cedric—this time as a future member of their industry—and explain the new postal system, but clearly that would have to wait.

The trio explained they'd come to deliver birthday gifts and cards for Tiara's party the next day. Behind them sat a pile of items they'd carried here with their special powers. They'd probably dropped the gifts when they had to defend against Vice Captain Harrison's attacks. Thankfully, the sand carpet they traveled on sat low to the ground, so nothing was damaged in the fall. The guards were already gathering up the gifts, and though I felt bad about it, I asked that they carry them into the castle. Right now, I needed to focus on getting Val and the children away from the castle as soon as possible.

I stood in front of them as I took their letters, blocking them from the vice captain's sight. "I don't have any letters to send out

today, so please return in one week. Make sure you wait the *entire* week."

There was a captains' meeting coming up to review protection measures for Tiara's party. A few of my imperial knights were taking days off too, so I wanted to play it safe. I said I was sorry once more, thanked the trio, and gave Val's back a push to urge him away from the castle.

"This is why I hate knights," Val grumbled with a click of his tongue.

I would apologize again the next time I saw them. It was my fault for not explaining things in advance. Vice Captain Harrison adored Commander Roderick—of *course* he and Val, the man who'd ambushed the royal order, would get on like oil and water.

Vice Captain Harrison watched as I ushered the deliveryman away. "Why did you choose a criminal like him, Your Highness?"

Val grunted at the knight, and I had to raise my voice to drown out whatever sharp retort he was surely preparing. "A-a lot happened along the way, but he's someone very precious to me now! Please forgive me!"

Val's shoulders twitched, perhaps because I'd yelled so close to his ear. I gave him a harder shove, and he heaved a sigh. When I looked up, he was scratching his head in blatant bewilderment. He then pointed at the children, beckoning for them to join him.

They clung to Val as they waved goodbye to me, casting wary glances at Vice Captain Harrison all the while. I was afraid they would grow to share Val's hatred of knights. Val himself didn't seem to be

taking Vice Captain Harrison's attacks personally. I gave him another push, called out, "See you next week!" and watched as Val raised his hand in a silent goodbye, not even turning to look at me.

"I apologize for my actions," Vice Captain Harrison murmured once Val and the children left.

When I faced him, he bowed his head deeply. I wondered if he felt guilty for causing this whole incident with Val. Vice Captain Eric apologized too, and Tiara followed up with, "Well, there's a lot of history at play!"

I told Vice Captain Harrison to raise his head. He seemed strangely gloomy. I'd heard he believed combat skills were his only strength, so perhaps that was weighing on him again.

"This whole thing was my fault," I said. "I'm sorry I never explained this to you, Vice Captain."

I smiled to show him I wasn't angry, but the gloom hanging over him did not recede.

"I should have informed him much earlier," Vice Captain Eric chimed in.

No, neither of you did anything wrong! I'm the one who's in charge of Val!

"You two bear no responsibility. In fact, you've proven what an outstanding knight you are, Vice Captain Harrison."

Both knights looked at me. Vice Captain Harrison studied me closely, seeking an explanation. His face had shifted from crestfallen to shocked.

"Even from a great distance, you spotted someone you believed to be my enemy and rushed in to protect me," I said, my smile growing. "If it had been someone truly dangerous instead of Val, you would be commended for your actions."

Of course, Val *was* a dangerous criminal, but we hadn't known he was nearby when the vice captain sprang into action. That just went to show how observant Vice Captain Harrison was.

Vice Captain Harrison's lips were softly parted. Maybe he'd expected me to reprimand him, but I didn't want him thinking of me as a cruel princess. With Tiara still beaming at the two of us, I finished, "I'd expect nothing less from you, Vice Captain Harrison. I see why Arthur recommended you for the job. I anticipate even more great things from you."

I gave him my most heartfelt smile, and his eyes widened. It was the longest we'd ever made eye contact, and that put me at ease. The previous record was when he flashed that terrifying grin at me during the defensive war. In this case, I'd likely kept his attention because I'd mentioned Arthur, and he treasured a recommendation from the former subordinate he doted on.

We were still gazing at each other when Tiara did something very unlike herself: She approached Vice Captain Harrison and peered into his face.

When he noticed, he blinked and faced her. "What is it?"

The impish Tiara kept her eyes firmly fixed on the vice captain. "Your eyes are the same color as Big Sister's. How lovely! I'm glad I finally got to see them!"

Her glee startled the knight. My curiosity got the better of me, and I joined her in scrutinizing Vice Captain Harrison's face. He recoiled, but not before I glimpsed a pair of purple eyes just like mine. It was a rare color in our country, and this shared trait made me feel a deeper connection to him.

"You're right! It's an honor to have the same color eyes as you, Vice Captain Harrison. Although...yours are much more beautiful." Unlike my sharp, imposing eyes, Vice Captain Harrison's were like shimmering amethysts.

His throat bobbed as he swallowed, and he looked swiftly away. Maybe he was uncomfortable being stared at. *I hope it's not that he's trying to avoid me specifically.*

The thought was just beginning to depress me when he disappeared. A breeze blew past me. I sucked in a breath and blinked—only to see the vice captain standing about three meters away. He held his head with one hand as though overcome with a dizzy spell, then whipped around so we couldn't see his face.

I had no idea he was so upset. Was he humiliated to have his eyes compared to a woman's? Or had he gotten shy after the adorable Tiara peeked up at him with puppy dog eyes?

I called his name. After staring at the ground for a beat, he apologized and said he was fine, but his voice was unexpectedly meek. This was a far more human side of Vice Captain Harrison, and Tiara and I smirked at each other—rude as that might've been.

Once we set off, Vice Captain Harrison swept in behind us, acting no different from usual. To my relief, the shadows over his face

had dissipated, and I offered him my hand. "Please keep up the excellent work, Vice Captain Harrison."

The vice captain stared at my hand for a moment before gently taking it in his own. I squeezed, and he did the same, returning my handshake. We'd shaken hands when he first arrived as an imperial knight, but for some reason, he was much more hesitant this time.

He blinked over and over, trying to make sense of my actions. I'd never realized he was capable of such human expressions. Despite almost getting off on the wrong foot, I was thrilled to have another imperial knight I could rely on.

Chapter 7: Opening Curtain

I*T'S FINALLY TIME for the happiest ending of them all.*

"Happy birthday, Princess Tiara!"

Elegant music lilted through the crowded ballroom. Tiara, Stale, and I were awash in a sea of eager guests. In anticipation of the event, we'd tightened security all over the castle. Knights were stationed in the ballroom, the royal residence, and all the way down to the castle gates.

We'd also informed our guests that people with the powers to detect heat signatures or see through objects would examine each of them. Those inspectors stood at the gates, along the castle walls, and at the ballroom doors.

This was no normal ceremony, as our added safety precautions demonstrated. The scale of this birthday party trumped all that preceded it. It was an extra special occasion, just as my sixteenth birthday and Stale's seventeenth birthday had been, as Tiara was officially reaching the age of adulthood.

That was largely why so many guests from our allied nations and amiable neighbors packed the ballroom—though Freesia's expanding relations with other countries during the last few years also played a big role in the hubbub. Not only would we be celebrating Tiara, but we'd also greet nobles and royals we otherwise never encountered. As a result, we Freesian royals were incredibly busy.

We'd already finished greeting various guests from the royal order—as well as Captain Callum, who'd shown up with Leon—Anemone, and the United Hanazuo Kingdom. Normally, this would be the opportunity to catch our collective breath, but there was no time to spare. The three royals from Hanazuo had arrived late, which was unfortunate because their presence would've drawn some attention away from us, but they were of little help. Once we were done chatting with them, it was straight on to the next guests.

The sheer number of attendees—many more than I'd seen at my own party—had me reeling. I could only imagine how overwhelmed Tiara must've felt as the star of the show. She wore an all-white dress with gold embroidery, attracting even more looks and conversation partners than I was. It was also possible that my crimson dress was too conspicuous, scaring off guests who opted to talk to Tiara instead. Compared to the sweet and angelic Tiara, I looked like an evil noblewoman who would “accidentally” spill wine on someone's clothes. *Well, I am the final boss.*

Stale and Tiara had complimented my dress, but I knew it stood out, and not in a good way. I had to wear all this red to keep it from clashing with my hair, though. As if all that wasn't depressing enough, the “sexy” cut of the dress revealed a bit of cleavage. *Meanwhile, Tiara gets to dress like a graceful, feminine goddess!*

Embarrassed at myself, I flushed red. The duke I'd been speaking to asked if I was feeling all right. I shook off my thoughts, then glossed over my slipup by pleading thirst and taking a sip of my

drink. The duke used the break in our conversation to change subjects.

"That reminds me," he said, "I've heard rumors that Princess Tiara has planned a special event for the occasion. Is there any truth to this?"

"Yes, there is. I can't say anything yet, but you'll find out before Mother addresses the room. I do hope you'll enjoy it."

"Oh my!" The duke broke into a wide smile.

Tiara's event wasn't far off. I'd been looking forward to it ever since she explained her vision to me. The duke said he was excited as well. His wife offered a smile, which I returned. Then the duke offered me a graceful bow before departing with the duchess in tow.

They were far from the last guests I had to greet. I eyed the line; so many new faces waited to chat with me. Mother had spent her rule forming alliances and peace treaties with different countries, and I'd only met a handful of these people before. Many were total strangers.

Just as many female guests had attended Stale's birthday party, the majority of Tiara's guests were male. Perhaps that also played a part in the many first-time visitors. There was a big difference in who attended a prince's party versus a princess's when they reached a marriageable age. Not only was the guest list quite different from normal ceremonies, but the ratio of young men and women changed as well.

"It's an honor to make your acquaintance, Princess Pride Royal Ivy. I am the second-born prince of the kingdom of Misumi."

Another new person. We exchanged greetings as I committed his face to memory. The prince hailed from a new ally of ours, so I would need to address him by name when we next met. Mother had warned us to stay focused during the party and look out for just these sorts of encounters. Fortunately, I had a pretty good memory, even if I wasn't on Cedric's level. The intelligence of the last boss Pride came in handy for things like social settings and politics.

I greeted the prince politely, then took another drink from my glass. The flurry of the party left me parched. As I sipped, careful not to indulge too much or too quickly...I suddenly found my glass empty. I must have overdone it. I scanned the crowd for a maid carrying drinks before another guest could approach me.

A glass appeared before me. "Please have this if you'd like, Princess Pride."

Alarmed, I whirled around—and was relieved to see a familiar face. "Thank you very much, Prime Minister Gilbert. You really came to my rescue!"

"Of course," he replied with a kind smile. "I just thought you might be getting thirsty."

I'd have expected nothing less from a man like him. He would have made an excellent butler or waiter if he weren't the prime minister, though perhaps that was a rude thought to have.

I took a sip. Whatever he'd brought me was far less potent than my previous drink, so I could indulge without worry. I looked up at Prime Minister Gilbert, and someone behind him caught my eye.

"Mari—I mean, Mrs. Butler! I'm so happy to see you!"

My voice came out louder than I intended. Mother and Tiara would be just as delighted as I was. *Oh my goodness, I'm so happy!* It was the first time I could recall Maria ever attending a ceremony at the castle.

"Stella's finally old enough to stay at home without me," she said. Her pale-pink hair tumbled over her shoulders, making her as much of a goddess as Tiara was, though in a different way.

Prime Minister Gilbert smiled and explained that the servants at their manor were looking after their daughter tonight. He wrapped an arm around Maria's shoulders as he spoke. Ah, what a lovely husband and wife they made! Gorgeous, both of them.

The prime minister said he'd finished greeting the most important guests and was now introducing Maria to people. He was always so quick to complete his work, but I wondered if he'd wrapped up his business faster than usual out of a desire to show off his lovely wife.

"I'm so happy to finally meet you in a formal setting, Princess Pride," Maria said with a cheerful curtsy. "We wish Princess Tiara a very happy birthday!"

I thanked her and shook hands with them both. She and the prime minister were as beautiful as they'd ever been, as if they never aged. *I'm pretty sure Prime Minister Gilbert hasn't been using his special power on either of them...*

"The next formal event we meet at will probably be the birthday party where your and your sister's fiancés are announced...or perhaps

even your coronation,” Prime Minister Gilbert said.

Maria agreed, and it raised my spirits to learn she’d be attending future events at the castle as Mrs. Butler. “I’m so glad I can stand alongside my husband in public like this once more,” she said. “It’s all thanks to everyone’s efforts.”

By “everyone,” she was including Father, Mother, Stale, and Arthur.

“I’m glad too,” I said, and joy bloomed on Maria’s pretty face. It was hard to believe someone so youthful and stunning was already a mother—though I found it less strange when I remembered she was friends with my own mother, who was just as striking.

When I expressed my disappointment at missing Stella, the pair invited me to visit their home again. I told them I appreciated the generous offer. After that, Maria and Prime Minister Gilbert left to chat with Stale. Maria’s presence would surely lift his spirits just as it had mine.

As the couple moved on, new guests rushed in. I said hello to a few familiar faces until a man I didn’t recognize reached the front of the line. Just as I was wondering what sort of prince or nobleman he might be, voices rose in the center of the ballroom alongside a blare of fanfare. Every last guest fell silent and turned toward the noise.

It was time for Tiara’s special event. I quickly finished my greetings and hurried to the middle of the room, knowing she’d need me for this. *This is something I absolutely can’t be late for!*

“We shall now commence with a dance party, as organized by Princess Tiara Royal Ivy!”

My heart raced as gasps of excitement filled the ballroom.

Tiara had first presented me with the idea of a dance party about a month ago. She'd wanted to use her birthday party as an opportunity to announce something of her own creation, just as I had announced the establishment of a Freesian school system on my sixteenth birthday, so she had gone to Prime Minister Gilbert for advice. Mother, Father, and Uncle Vest had joined in to help, resulting in a project organized by Tiara herself.

Such a lovely scene never existed in the game, of course, as Tiara spent her days locked away in an isolated tower.

"Thank you for joining me, Big Sister, Big Brother!"

She grinned at Stale and me, and we beamed back at her. The birthday dance party wasn't all that grand, as this was Tiara's first attempt at planning such an event on her own. The three of us would simply dance with guests in the center of the ballroom.

Stale would choose a different female guest for each song, while Tiara and I were to select from the men who offered their hands. Perhaps it was closer to a dance exhibition than a dance party.

Princesses our age normally danced with their fiancés, but we were still keeping our marriage candidates confidential at this time. Therefore, Tiara's first pick was going to draw a lot of attention and speculation.

She walked elegantly in time with the musical prelude, walking past the many men extending their hands toward her. It was an honor to dance with a member of the royal family, and every man she passed reached eagerly for the opportunity: young, old, engaged,

even married. If she'd invited them to this party, they were already worthy of dancing with a princess.

Tiara approached the crowd with small, careful steps...and took the hand of none other than Cedric.

It happened so suddenly that Cedric's eyes nearly popped out of his head. With the entire room watching, she smiled sweetly at him, every bit a perfect princess. Cedric's mouth fell open as he flushed bright red. Only once Tiara pulled him closer did he finally manage to snap it shut.

It had been a long time since Tiara offered the prince much more than a glare, so it wasn't hard to guess the effect her smile must've had on him. Maybe I was mistaken, but Tiara's cheeks also appeared to glow slightly pinker than usual. She was definitely nervous in leading her very first event.

The two kings at Cedric's sides chuckled at his reaction, clearly pleased with this whole display. They covered their mouths to hide their smirks, watching Cedric fondly as he joined Tiara on the dance floor.

During our time in the United Hanazuo Kingdom, we'd all participated in a celebratory dance. That had inspired Tiara to recreate the occasion in Freesia. Our country held large dance parties in our castle and at other social events, but guests didn't get to dance with the royal family. That was the custom Tiara was eager to bring to the kingdom, starting at her own birthday party.

Cedric had his own reasons for not dancing with us at that celebration one year ago, but now he had the chance to dance with

Tiara for the very first time. I could only imagine his joy. Their golden hair fluttered elegantly with each step as they reached the center of the dance floor. I let out a dreamy sigh, captivated by how they sparkled under the lights.

Eyes lingering on Tiara and Cedric, I chose my own partner. I gave his hand a squeeze, and he did the same. Pleased, I tore my eyes off Tiara and Cedric to smile at the man I'd chosen.

"Thank you, Stale."

"It's my pleasure."

The event would begin with a dance between me and Stale. As the star of the party, Tiara had selected a partner, whereas Stale and I would dance as brother and sister. But if the tradition continued, Tiara would probably dance with Stale first at my next birthday party.

Stale had been my partner at many other dance parties already, but the attention of all the guests left me anxious regardless. It would be just the four of us dancing this time, surrounded by a massive audience.

Hand in hand, Stale and I joined Tiara and Cedric on the dance floor. We kept enough distance to avoid colliding with them, turned toward the guests, and bowed. Then the music began.

We locked eyes and placed our other hands on each other's.

It was time for Stale, Tiara, and I to have our first dances.

STALE

A*H... IT FEELS LIKE my heart is going to explode.*

A beautiful melody floated through the ballroom. The lights illuminated the center of the room, which had everyone's attention. Tiara strode across the marble floor and selected Prince Cedric, drawing a cheer from the crowd.

The attendees had sometimes tittered when a new guest was announced, but Tiara's bold selection raised the excitement in the room to a whole new level. The furiously blushing Prince Cedric joined Tiara on the dance floor.

I shoved down my mixed feelings about that man standing next to my younger sister, but I didn't have the luxury of dwelling on it; the woman beside me had my heart pounding.

"Thank you, Stale."

It took everything I had to respond normally. "It's my pleasure."

Pride and I headed for the best-lit place on the dance floor. I breezed by the guests, showing them that it was my right to have the first dance with the most wonderful woman in the world. The clacking of Pride's heels filled the expectant silence. When we bowed, everyone's eyes fell upon us.

We slowly turned to face each other once the music began. Our eyes met. Bathed in the bright lights, Pride smiled. How radiant she was.

I placed one hand on her waist and took her hand in mine. We'd danced as brother and sister many times in the past. Yet here and now, it was just the four of us, with everyone watching. Only in this moment could I take her hand and dance with her like this.

I'd never felt more special in all my life.

We began to sway. Each time our steps carried us closer to the guests, their sighs slipped under the music. Electricity crackled everywhere my skin met Pride's. I tensed at the sensation of her smooth skin against mine, shuddering.

"Stale...are you nervous?" Pride whispered.

Our bodies were so close. I only needed to glance down to see her staring up at me. I could almost feel the caress of her breath. Without thinking, I averted my eyes. "No. Sorry...just a little. I've never experienced anything like this before."

She chuckled at my excuse. Startled, I snapped my gaze back to her. "Me too," she said.

The teasing smile on her face made my heart leap all over again.

"I'm glad you're the first one I'm dancing with," she went on. "I think I would have been a lot more nervous with anyone else."

My chest clenched around those words. One of her next partners might be a marriage candidate—the man who would stand by her side someday. I knew such a man existed, though I'd ruled out Prince Cedric. Captain Callum was a possibility, but that still left two others. Logically, they had to belong to dukedoms or royal families of our close allies.

I cut off that train of thought. I was wasting the valuable opportunity to dance with Pride by getting distracted with speculation. Right now, I needed to commit this moment to memory.

Smiling back at her, I said, "I'm honored."

Pride's delighted reaction filled my heart.

"I'm so glad to be your adoptive brother," I added, putting my joy into words. "It's the very reason I have the special privilege of taking your hand."

This was the last place a commoner like me should have ended up. I still loved my mom and my late dad, and I still considered my birthday significant because it was the day I got to write a letter to my mom. But...from the bottom of my heart, I was glad the royal family had adopted me. It was how I'd met Pride. My position allowed me to stay by her side, and I wouldn't trade it for anything in the world.

My response took her aback. I guided her across the dance floor, leading her through a gentle spin. The crowd cheered.

Amused, she offered me a smirk. "I'd still dance with you even if you weren't my brother."

I gulped. Though I didn't know exactly what she intended, heat crawled into my face regardless. I only grew hotter when I remembered all those guests watching us, and I desperately tried to calm my racing thoughts.

"Stale?" Pride whispered, concerned.

I told her I was fine, then concealed my emotions with a question. "You would really dance...with just *me*?" *Even if I weren't your brother?*

Pride smiled again, tickled by the question, and squeezed my hand lightly. "Absolutely. You're very special to me, Stale."

She made it sound like it was the most natural thing in the world, and it nearly brought me to tears. I swallowed around the lump, lest it grow into a sob. *Even if I were someone Pride had no obligation to dance with, she would still choose my hand out of everyone's. Even if I was just another face in the sea of guests. Even if I didn't outrank any of them. She would still find me.*

Pride had acknowledged me not as her adoptive brother but as Stale the human being. My heart felt so full, it threatened to burst.

We continued our dance. She moved with light steps, leaning into me.

I gazed at my smiling reflection in her purple eyes. "Thank you."

Overcome with emotion, I pressed my lips together and turned my attention to the guests. Several men had their eyes locked on her, every last one of them eager to be her next partner. The realization yanked me out of my daze.

"If anything happens, be sure to call for me or Arthur."

"Huh?" She didn't understand.

I calmly looked back at Pride—the most beautiful woman in the world. Her red dress blazed like fire, and her jewelry reflected the lights like stars kissing her skin. That long, crimson hair—the color of passion—made her pale skin stand out even more. With her standing so close, her chest lingered in my peripheral vision, emphasizing that she was womanly indeed.

Even if she weren't crown princess, she would've stolen the eyes of men all the same. I searched for a way to tell her this, but I came

up empty and instead focused on the dance.

We were nearing the end of the song when I finally stumbled across the right words. "You're just...far too attractive tonight."

She and I flowed through the final moves. Before the song ended, Pride took in the guests, then herself—stealing a glance at her own chest before squeezing her lips together bashfully. It seemed I'd made my point. The song concluded, and I released her hand. We stepped apart and bowed to each other to the sound of thunderous applause.

I closed my eyes. My next dance was with Tiara. I took a deep breath to compose myself, then felt something soft brush my cheek. My eyes shot open to find Pride had closed the distance between us once more, stroking my face with her fingers. I stared back at her, lost for words.

"Thank you for looking out for me," she whispered into my ear, drowning out the applause.

I stiffened. When I realized she was responding to my warning, I nodded.

"Even if you weren't a prince, I don't think anyone in this world would dare refuse to dance with a wonderful man like you."

After that, she wished me good luck on my next dance and gave me a light slap on the back. I mumbled some sort of response, adjusted my glasses, and caught my breath as I approached Tiara. It was hard to see through the steam fogging up the lenses. Tiara smirked mischievously and took my hand.

"A wonderful man," she said. Those words reverberated in my ears, the moment replaying over and over. My heart thrummed with whatever energy my body hadn't already used up, each beat like a hammer to the chest, the shock waves rippling through my body.

Tiara giggled. "Your face is still red, Big Brother."

Our dance proceeded smoothly, though I couldn't stop thinking about my warm face. I fluidly led Tiara through the steps, my hazy vision drifting toward Pride. Perhaps it was pathetic, but I sighed with relief at the sight of her next dance partner.

Surrounded by my beloved sisters and my friends, I was the happiest man on earth.

LEON

ONCE HER DANCE with Prince Stale had ended, Pride took slow, careful steps toward the crowd of men offering their hands. I joined them, extending my hand as well. I did my best not to stand out—to hide my eagerness from the others, if only for this one moment. I wanted them to think this was nothing more than a polite gesture.

Pride barely scanned the crowd, like she'd already made up her mind...until we locked eyes. Disbelief stole my breath away. She walked right up to me and took my hand with a relieved smile. The sensation of her skin against mine was almost ticklish.

"It would be my pleasure."

Thrilled and honored that she'd selected me, of all people, I took her hand and led her gently to the dance floor.

"I really didn't expect you to choose me."

Those feelings tumbled from my lips as soon as the dance began. Pride and I were good friends, but I was also her ex-fiancé. Our engagement had fallen apart, though not because of any real drama. There were nobles and royals at the party who would provide much more value as her dance partners. Furthermore, this dance party came laden with extra meaning. We paired up with the eyes of every last guest in the room fixed on us. In choosing their partners, the princesses were revealing who they felt the closest to—even who they considered friends.

Pride smiled, understanding my outburst. "But," she began, looking up to meet my eyes, "you're my sworn friend, Leon."

Such a simple statement, yet it robbed me of my breath anew. Pride had called me her "sworn friend" for the past two years, but it still lit a fire in me each time.

"I see."

Her smile of acknowledgment merely boosted my affection.

"I'm so happy I get to dance with you," I told her. "It feels like I'm dreaming."

My immense joy had made me buoyant, like I was floating over the dance floor. I was already in heaven at the sight of her smile up close, but we were actually *dancing*. *Ah, how could I ever ask for anything more in life?*

As I savored the moment, she twirled under my arm with light steps, then placed those delicate hands back on mine. "I'm happy too," she said. "It's so nice to see you smile at me like that."

She stared off into the distance for a moment before a heartfelt grin lit her face. Her smooth skin brushed against my clothes as she rotated behind my back. I copied her motions until we both circled around, our bodies naturally coming back together. Her warmth seeped through my clothes when I held her again. When we first met, she never had this kind of effect on me, but tonight I was burning up from her touch.

I wanted to touch her more and more. I wanted this moment to last forever. I wanted to live inside every second.

It didn't matter if I couldn't spend my life at her side; ruling neighboring countries was more than enough. She was going to find someone she loved, and then I would...

"But of course," I told the pleased princess. It was hard not to chuckle at her comment. *You make it sound like it has nothing to do with you, but you're the reason for every one of these smiles, my dearest.*

An outpouring of love welled in my chest. I wanted those purple eyes on me every precious second; I basked in her gaze.

Pride blinked in surprise, and a flush stole into her cheeks.

Aaah, you're simply too sweet.

She was adorable, beautiful, and feminine, not to mention overwhelmingly captivating in that dress, as red as ripe fruit. I ached to grab her and pull her closer. *But I wouldn't dare.*

"As a prince of Anemone, I couldn't be any happier than I am in this moment."

Pride grinned at that. We twirled together, the wind lifting her bright-red hair. She softly wrapped her hand around my back, as if caressing me with it, and leaned her weight against me so she'd be easier to lead.

"Then Anemone and its people must be happy too," she said, gazing up at me with barely concealed glee as we transitioned back to simpler steps.

We moved gracefully toward the center of the dance floor, her body warm against mine. She giggled as I cocked my head in question.

"After all, their future partner is someone who loves them so much!"

She entrusted her body to me, falling backward into a dip. The crowd gasped.

Once again, she'd stolen my heart. Just how many more times could she manage such a thing? How many more times would she make me fall in love with her?

There wasn't a shred of doubt in my mind: Were she not the crown princess, I would have continued to pursue her. I would shower her with gifts of flowers, visit her every single day, and tell her how much I loved her.

It reminded me of a romance novel I'd recently read. Such a passionate depiction of love used to be utterly foreign to me, but now I smiled as I imagined doing those things with her. I'd been so lonely, so broken, so miserable, yet now I treasured the memory of every last second I'd spent as Pride's fiancé. I was always thinking of those

times when she'd touched me, stroked my hair, held me in a warm embrace, comforted me with her voice, and urged me on with her powerful words.

"Pride, I'll be an Anemonian until the day I die."

"That you will. And I'll be a Freesian until the day I die."

She echoed my own love for my people. Nothing could have made me happier.

We danced gracefully toward the song's conclusion. I yearned to keep touching her, feeling her body heat, and bathing in her gaze. I didn't even realize I had a tight grip on her hand until she squeezed back.

"Leon...I'm glad I was able to dance with you."

When she called my name, her eyes lit up with fierce happiness. She valued the time we shared together, even though I was the one who'd broken our engagement.

The song ended. I loosened my hold so we could separate. My heart ached that she hadn't said the words I desired most, but given what she *did* say to me, I knew I would get another opportunity like this someday. Even if she was engaged to someone else.

My spirits soared at the thought. "As am I."

I am the prince of Anemone. I focused every cell in my body on that fact as I bowed to Pride and then to the audience. The crowd erupted with applause as I made my way back to them. Some of the women in the front row turned red and wavered on their feet, perhaps because the ballroom was so warm. The men and maids near them

cried out in concern. I made sure someone was looking after them, then turned my attention to one particular spot in the room.

Mother and Father, the rulers of Anemone, stood amid the crowd. I lifted my head, greeted the two of them, and received tender smiles in return.

The second my gaze returned to Pride, I spotted her plucking her next partner out of the crowd. Prince Stale offered his hand to the woman next to him as well. Cheers rang out as Tiara settled on another partner of her own.



My heart thumped as I watched the Freesians enjoy their next dance, though it wasn't an unpleasant sensation.

"I can't wait to get home and speak with the Anemonian people again," I murmured to myself.

Once, the world snatched my happiness away from me. Pride was the one who'd given it back.

Instead of bouquets, I'll bring you days full of blessings, my people. I'll leave my castle to see as many of you as possible. I'll never stop coming to speak with you.

Only one thing surpassed my feelings for Pride: the love I had for my country.

GILBERT

"GOODNESS... It's an honor, Princess Pride."

The music started as I took her pale, dainty hand. The girl I once knew had grown into such a lovely young woman. That thought moved me as the two of us headed for the dance floor.

"The honor is all mine," the princess replied shyly.

We flowed into the very first steps of the dance.

"I'm delighted. I've never been able to dance with you before, Prime Minister Gilbert."

"Yes, it's our first time, isn't it?" I answered with a smile.

Princess Pride glanced at Prince Stale. "I hope he didn't startle her..."

When I realized she was genuinely concerned, I had to stifle a laugh. "Please, fear not. My wife does, in fact, know how to dance."

"No, that's not what I...!"

My smile grew as Princess Pride struggled to clarify in a hushed voice. It truly was an honor to dance with her. Prince Stale had chosen Maria, my wife, as a partner, while Princess Tiara danced with Vest.

I had to admit I was surprised when Princess Pride first chose me, but then Prince Stale selected my wife—as if to challenge me—and I nearly burst out laughing. Was his next partner going to be Vest's wife? These choices surely tormented the many women in the audience whose eyes remained glued to him throughout the event. *Then again, Princess Pride and Princess Tiara are doing the same thing to the men.*

"Thank you so much for helping Tiara with this dance party," Princess Pride said. "You've made her so happy."

Princess Tiara was beaming as she danced. Even Vest, who carried out each step with impeccable precision, seemed more relaxed than usual. The younger princess's lovely smile had that effect on people. *And to think she was so dispirited at first.*

The first time we discussed holding an event at her birthday party, the tone had been very different. The mere memory made my heart ache.

I closed my eyes, shaking my head to banish the gloom. Regardless of the past, Princess Tiara seemed perfectly happy now. I

needed to focus my attention on Princess Pride.

"Prime Minister Gilbert?" Her Highness murmured.

I apologized, raised my head, and caught Albert's eye from across the dance floor. He was glaring daggers at me. I smirked at the prince consort, who sat next to Rosa. Albert answered by scowling even harder. *Yes, that's the friend I know, all right.*

"There's nothing I wouldn't do for your sake, Your Highness," I said.

Those words wouldn't reach Albert on the other side of the dance floor. Princess Pride was a little flustered, but she smiled and twirled in time with the music when I raised my hand. Her beautiful crimson hair fanned out around her, drawing dreamy sighs from the guests. I placed my hand on her hip when she returned to me.

"I should have known you were a good dancer," the princess said when we launched into the next steps in tandem. It seemed she was genuinely impressed.

Pleased, I replied, "As the prime minister, it's only natural that I learned to dance."

As the prime minister? No, it was more than that. I'd mastered all the culture and customs any palace official would need. After I requested Maria's hand in marriage, she helped me practice dancing. She had grown up in a wealthy family and was therefore much better than me. That is, until she fell ill.

During her recovery, Maria relearned how to move her body. We danced to help her practice her coordination. Though her steps

faltered more often than mine, she still beamed up at me with bliss. It was like falling in love with her all over again.

I glanced over at her. She wore a gentle smile as Prince Stale carefully led her through the dance, making sure their steps were in time. *What a kind young man he is.*

"I don't deserve all this happiness."

My emotions had overwhelmed me without warning. Princess Pride's eyes widened. I quickly smiled to cover up my stumble, feeling guilty that I'd made her uncomfortable, but Princess Pride pulled me closer.

"I... No. Mother, Father, Stale, Tiara, and I are all happy because of you, Prime Minister Gilbert."

That earnest declaration caught me off guard. I gazed into her purple eyes and found not a single shred of falseness. All the people she'd listed brought *me* immense joy.

When I went quiet, Her Highness smiled gently at me, like Maria always did. "You're going to protect this country and its people...even once I'm gone. That alone is enough to make the future full of unknowns for everyone seem bright."

Ah, she's no different than she was five years ago. That light never faded from her eyes, no matter what happened. If anything, it had only grown brighter, leaving me dumbfounded.

Before I realized it, I was chuckling. I couldn't cover my mouth while we were dancing, so I hung my head instead, but Princess Pride had almost certainly caught me. I called her name and delicately led

her into the next steps. The beautiful princess swayed like a lapping ocean wave, drawing the eyes of every guest as our dance carried us closer to them.

"I've been granted the gift of living alongside you, the future queen," I said. "No matter how many hundreds of years I live...it will be the honor of my lifetime."

Someday, you'll leave me and depart this earth.

My beloved wife, friends, daughter, and everyone else around me would grow old and pass away before I did. Yet I would never forget the things Princess Pride had given me. I loved it all, both the mercy and the punishment she'd bestowed upon me. I would carry out my vow to her no matter what, even if I was to live another thousand years.

I would have been so horribly empty without her. Even if I *had* managed to save Maria...they could have put me to death for my crimes. Princess Pride had rescued me when I lost sight of myself, when all I could do was act out in fits of madness and despair. Now I could die with a smile, even if met with a wretched, miserable end a thousand years in the future.

You gave me back all the things I would have lost. So long as it means carrying out what you desire...

"Leave it all to me," I told her. "I've already offered up my life for the good of the Freesian people you so adore."

Princess Pride smiled tenderly at that as we spun in a circle. "Just don't work *too* hard, all right?" she said kindly.

The end of the song drew near, so we slowed the pace of our steps.

"Be sure not to overexert yourself either, Princess Pride. I want you to come and discuss things with me, *whatever* they might be." I lowered my voice to an ominous whisper. "You understand what I'm saying, don't you?"

Her shoulders lurched, and she let out a tiny shriek. I couldn't help but smile. Completely flustered, she bobbed her head in agreement.

During the defensive war, Princess Pride had taken a blood oath in a Chinensian ceremony without informing me ahead of time. It required her to burn at the stake alongside Chinensis's king if she failed to protect their country. While I was somewhat glad I'd only found out about this after the war, her foolishness enraged me. The princess would have paid with her life if the unthinkable had happened and Chinensis suffered defeat. My own life would have been a much more appropriate sacrifice. I could only hope Her Highness would abandon those self-sacrificing ways in the future.

Then again, if she weren't the sort of person to risk her own life for others, she likely never would have forgiven my own sins.

This time, I kept my voice gentle so as not to frighten her. "I'll say it as many times as it takes, Your Highness."

She relaxed, her eyes searching my face as we took our final steps in time with the song's finale.

"Everyone cherishes you so dearly."

No matter how often I repeated those words, it would never be enough. That certainty dwelt in my heart.

Our steps slowed to a stop as the music ended.

"We all care for you just as much as you care for us."

It was proof of how much she meant to us. She wasn't merely the firstborn princess; she was invaluable because of her pure heart. I only hoped she could understand that.

Princess Pride and I parted and bowed. When she raised her head, she pressed her lips into a tense line.

"I'll be waiting for the day you finally realize that."

I smiled, took her hand one more time, and kissed the back of it. She kept her expression calm and collected, but she locked up on the spot, fingers twitching. Her reddening cheeks spoke to how little she'd changed since the last time I did this. Warmth seeped through my chest at the sight.

"Thank you, Prime Minister Gilbert."

To soothe her nerves, I maintained a kind, tender expression. "And thank you as well, Your Highness."

I would dedicate the remainder of my long life to this country, its people, and the royal family.

I would never forget the vow I carried in my heart...not for all of eternity.

ARTHUR

"H-HOLY crap..."

Captain Alan was the first to break the silence.

The chandeliers glowed in the ballroom. Gold and gems glittered on gowns and around limbs, the white marble blinding under the lights. My mind was spinning amid the sweet perfumes, the crowd's excitement...and that red dress. I couldn't manage to close my mouth, convinced I was dreaming.

"She looks lovely..." Vice Captain Eric murmured, entranced by the princess's elegant dancing. I fared about the same.

None of us could look away from Princess Pride and the man she was dancing with. She'd looked gorgeous already, dancing up there with Stale. I was pretty sure I hadn't blinked the entire time. As her imperial knight, I'd watched her dance with people before...yet every time, she stole my breath away all over again.

I couldn't contain my awe. "Yeah, she's amazing..."

She'd moved on to her next partner after Prime Minister Gilbert—someone I'd never seen dance before. I was starting to wonder if the whole thing really *was* a dream after all.

Princess Pride twirled when her partner lifted his arms, her bright-red dress fanning out around her. He supported her through a dip, drawing a cheer from the crowd before he pulled her back to her feet. I could have watched them dance forever.

"Commander Roderick's actually doing really well," Captain Callum said. "Vice Commander Clark too."

He'd left the rest of the guests to join us knights, and we all nodded in agreement. Princess Pride was dancing with my dad, the

commander, while Tiara was partnered up with Vice Commander Clark.

My heart nearly leaped out of my chest when the princesses first approached our group. I'd assumed Princess Pride would choose Captain Callum, but I had offered my hand like the rest, even though it almost killed me to do so. Thankfully, they'd chosen Dad and Clark. The crowd cheered at that, just as they had for Leon. Dad's eyes widened, like he thought this was some sort of joke. Clark just smiled and gave Dad a light shove before heading onto the dance floor himself.

Stale joined them with Seneschal Vest's wife. His eyes flitted from Dad to me, and he chuckled. The last thing I ever expected was to see Princess Pride dancing with my own father. Not only that, but Dad and Clark were both amazing dancers!

Sure, they're both a little cultured, but neither of them have ever danced in front of us! Why the hell does it have to be them?!

At least, that was what I thought at first, but the more I watched their incredible dancing, the less I fretted. Dad and Clark were perfectly in sync. It was like watching the same person dance with two different partners. They matched Stale's pace as they led Princess Pride and Tiara through their steps. The princesses seemed to be enjoying themselves, and Clark was having a ball too. Even Dad cracked a grin.

Princess Pride chatted with Dad as they danced, just as she had with the other guests. I couldn't hear a thing over the music, but

whatever Dad said made her shake her head, expression shifting from a half-hearted smile to pleading. Then she even blushed a little.

Before I could guess why, her face went stiff. Had Dad scolded her? But soon after, she smiled and said something that had Dad furrowing his brow suspiciously. He twirled Princess Pride in her bright-red dress—and suddenly all the questions building up in my head vanished.

When the dance ended, they smiled at each other, hand in hand, and bade each other farewell. The whole thing seriously had to be a dream.

Dad bowed to Princess Pride, then joined Clark in heading back to us. Princess Pride and Tiara were following them, so I knew it was probably Captain Callum's turn. All the guys offered their hands as the princesses approached. Although they knew they weren't going to be picked, just attempting to attract the notice of the princesses was enough to make their palms sweaty, same as m—

Princess Pride took my hand. "Shall we dance?"

My breath fled as she looked me straight in the eye and smiled warmly. A murmur rippled through the crowd as my eyes boggled. Even when she gave my hand a squeeze, I didn't take a single step forward, still struggling to parse her words. She wrapped her other hand around mine and tugged me toward her.

"It'll be all right! Just leave it all to me," she said.

There was no resisting Princess Pride. Her hands, her words, and her smile conspired to draw me in, convincing me to move. We walked under the bright lights, but I couldn't look at anything but her.

The sound of our shoes clacking on the marble floor echoed in my head. My eyes were glued to our overlapping hands as the fire rushing into my face scorched away every other thought.

Once we reached the center of the ballroom, she changed her grip. Our palms met, the warmth of her skin lapping against mine. I couldn't speak, but Princess Pride placed her other hand on my shoulder—her gentle touch sending my blood pressure to deadly levels.

"Follow my lead," she told me.

Her soft voice drained every thought from my mind except one: *I can't embarrass her.* I focused on that singular ambition as I squeezed Princess Pride's hand and placed my other hand on her waist. The smooth fabric of her dress hugged every contour of her body. My heart jolted violently against my ribs.

As the music began, we swept into our first steps. I matched her movements, dredging up past dance practices in my mind. But I was still terrible compared to everyone she'd already danced with. While the thought was sobering, it at least allowed me to raise my eyes from the floor.

Stale was partnered up with a young noblewoman, one I didn't recognize, while Tiara danced with Captain Alan. I'd stood next to him throughout the whole party, yet I hadn't even realized he was on the dance floor with me. He looked a little nervous, but was holding his own pretty well.

"You're so good at this, Arthur," Pride said. "Have you danced before?"

Pride's kind words snapped me out of my daze. I rejected her compliment, muttering that knights received the bare minimum in etiquette training when we joined the main forces. "But it's my first time dancing with someone like this..."

My first dance was with none other than *Princess Pride*. I couldn't possibly ask for a better partner. When the knights taught me, I assumed I would never use this skill; now I could've fainted from the relief of knowing I had the basics down.

"You're doing amazing for your first time."

Her Highness lifted my arm and twirled beneath it. Up close, her beauty dazzled me, blinding me with her radiance. She could probably hear my heart pounding in my ears... The embarrassment of it nearly killed me. Internally, I screamed at my body to calm the hell down.

"See? That's great!"

She smiled and heaped on the praise even though she was obviously the one leading me. I merely had the privilege of gazing upon her gorgeous face, putting my hands on her body, and watching her twirl. I was so flushed with joy, I could have died on the spot.

In fact, I was so captivated by her, I realized I'd totally forgotten to respond. I tried to focus but flailed instead. She stared up at me expectantly as we swayed.

Damn, I was being rude. Just as that thought struck me...

"You're so cool, Arthur," she said with a giggle, another lovely smile blooming on her lips.

My heart erupted and my fingers stiffened. I nearly jerked to a halt, feeling like I was on fire. I couldn't deal with my body's betrayal in a place like this. I kept my feet moving out of pure reflex while I struggled to get my mind in order. She spoke to me from so close, our bodies pressed together, lost in a secluded world where I was the only one allowed to touch her. Those feelings threatened to devolve into burning desire if I couldn't rein them in.

Princess Pride didn't notice. "When Tiara finalized her plan for this event, I knew I wanted to dance with you no matter what."

She said such unbelievable things with a giant grin on her face. Someday, that habit of hers would burn me to a crisp.

"How come?" I choked out.

The princess spun and said, "I mean..." She landed in my arms, and her smile turned teasing. "I want to show off my incredible knight to the whole world."

Her beauty *suffocated* me. I locked my knees to keep from collapsing, but I was so dizzy that I couldn't even make out her expression anymore. Even if she was just being polite, to hear I'd become a knight she was proud of nearly overwhelmed me with joy. I wanted to cry. I was just so happy to be her knight.

She was so important to me. I yearned to pull her into an embrace.

"I think...you're incredible too."

It took an effort to wrench those words from my lips. Serving as her knight was the honor of a lifetime. Knowing she was proud of me,

I could hold my head up high for the rest of my days.

Princess Pride squeezed my hand tenderly. Sparks shot up my arm, burning me from fingertips to shoulder. We swayed together until the music wound down. She lingered in my arms, beaming at me. If this was only a dream, I prayed I would never wake up.

Regrettably, the music stopped. Princess Pride and I bowed to each other. The crowd applauded, reinforcing the idea that this was all some sort of crazy dream.

"Thank you, Arthur."

I should've been thanking her, but she beat me to the punch. I wrestled control over my tongue to reply, "Thank you very much." With that, Princess Pride gave me one last wave goodbye.

Once I regrouped with the other knights, Princess Pride finally began her dance with Captain Callum. Tiara took Vice Captain Eric. The crowd stirred, recognizing what an honor it was for the princesses to choose every attendee from the royal order.

My chest hummed with warmth as Princess Pride led Captain Callum to the dance floor. I was simply far, far too happy to be that woman's knight.

PRIDE

"I'M NOT SURPRISED to see you're a skilled dancer, Captain Callum."

He led me gracefully in time with the music. His face was as red as Arthur's, probably because he was nervous to have so many eyes on him, but his steps remained calm and fluid.

The captain's fingers twitched. "It's an honor!"

I giggled at his timidity, a stark contrast to his usual calm composure. His eyes went wide, and his face grew even redder.

Oh no. He must have assumed I was mocking him! Here I was only thinking he's so cute right now...

"You're wonderful, Captain. You're a brilliant knight, you're wise and compassionate, and your dancing is—"

"Th-that's enough! You truly honor me, Your Highness."

Captain Callum leaned away from me, his hand twitching again. While the captain was a nobleman, he probably wasn't used to dancing in front of people after serving as a knight for so many years. I sympathized; I'd been nervous at first too, but Stale and the others helped me feel a lot more comfortable.

I gave his hand a gentle squeeze to calm him, but his shoulders lurched from the unexpected sensation. He needed a distraction, so I changed the subject. "Your lordly ensemble looks as lovely as ever. And I believe you're getting acquainted with Leon, right?"

The captain was attending this party not as a knight but as the son of a noble family—just as he had for Stale's birthday. Leon had tagged along with him to say hello to me, and I heard the same went for Stale and Tiara. In my case, it was more like Leon was *escorting* Captain Callum than simply tagging along. Leon had a way of catching other people up in his imposing aura, but I was still surprised, as I'd hardly ever seen the captain interact with Leon outside of his imperial knight duties.

"Yes, we've been discussing books and such," Captain Callum said. "Prince Leon has been looking out for me in all sorts of ways. I owe him a great deal."

Though he smiled awkwardly, he had finally relaxed. He led me in time with the music and spun me around. I'd once embarrassed him in a public setting, so it was nice to see he'd found a friend not as a knight captain but as a lord. Leon was a wonderful person and probably felt a connection with a fellow gentleman like Captain Callum. I'd even heard that rumors surrounding the connection between Captain Callum and me had died down ever since Leon started spending time with him. No one in high society would dare say anything rude in front of my ex-fiancé.

Ever since the day we announced the marriage candidate system, rumors swirled about all of my picks, not just Captain Callum. The names flitting around included royals and noblemen, but Captain Callum stood out as the only genuine candidate among them. I didn't know what had spurred such intense speculation—perhaps Captain Callum's sudden emergence as a lordling? When I first heard about the gossip, it reminded me of my childhood, when those rumors about my horrible personality spread throughout the country—only to cease all at once. *No, these couldn't have come from the same source...*

I was relieved that Captain Callum could spend the party in the company of his fellow knights sooner than I'd feared. I would've been racked with guilt if the curious guests bombarded him with questions again.

"I'm incredibly glad to be able to dance with you this evening. It's an honor to the Bordeaux name."

Swaying in time with the music, I smiled at Captain Callum's kind words. When I told him the pleasure was all mine, his expression suddenly calmed. Now *I* was the one twitching in surprise. We pivoted around the dance floor together.

"May I ask what you were discussing earlier with Arthur and Commander Roderick?"

I hadn't expected him to ask, but as soon as I thought back to my conversation with the commander, my mind went blank.

Captain Callum recognized my hesitance and apologized for being impolite. "Forgive me if you already spoke of the subject I'm about to touch on. I can only speak of it here, as we'd be overheard elsewhere." With the music drowning out our voices, Captain Callum went on, "The royal order has grown much, much larger than it was seven years ago. Some of the men who were rookie knights at the time now serve in the main forces. Vice Captain Eric, for example."

He and I circled around and around, keeping up our steady footwork. Captain Callum never took his eyes off me. I nodded in acknowledgment, prompting him to continue.

"We owe it all to you, Princess Pride. It's a legacy we're passing down to everyone in the royal order...but those members from seven years ago respect you deeply and are grateful for what you did."

I couldn't look away from his gentle smile. Captain Callum's deep love for the royal order was undeniable.

"I'm here today as my father's proxy, but I intend to live and die as a knight. To me, that's what it means to be honorable."

His eyes lit up, and he smiled proudly—a smile completely different than the ones he'd worn before. *Ah, yes, this is the true Captain Callum.* He was the captain of the Third Squadron and an outstanding knight.

"On a personal level, I'd like to help you however possible. I know Alan feels the same way."

When he said that, my gaze slid to Captain Alan. He'd finished his dance with Tiara and was now grinning at us from ear to ear. The moment our eyes met, his grin fell away in surprise. But Captain Callum's words had me so pleased that I just kept smiling at the other knight.

Captain Alan's face went red. Maybe we'd reminded him of his dance with Tiara—or maybe he was frightened, reading my smile as a sneer. I just hoped it was the former.

At that point, Captain Callum delicately removed his hand from my waist and extended his arm to twirl me toward the guests, who let out a cheer. The captain then pulled me back into his arms.

"Treat my body, my name, my title, and everything I possess as if they belong to you, Princess Pride Royal Ivy. I offer you everything that I have. We knights will always love and adore you."

He murmured those words right into my ear as he held me close, with all the intimacy of a marriage proposal. My face blazed at his husky, masculine voice. I knew he didn't mean anything by it, but

my body refused to cool down, so I hung my head and hoped the guests wouldn't notice.

The music slowed for the finale. Captain Callum had me pulled close by the waist, hiding me from the audience, so I nuzzled against his shoulder to keep the heat in my cheeks from spreading.

He gasped. "Princess Pride?!"

I paused to catch my breath before raising my head, then smiled at the knight once my face cooled. "Thank you, Captain Callum." I meant it from the bottom of my heart.

The heat seemed to have affected him as well, his cheeks reddening even as he smiled.

Our hands drifted apart as the music died down. The crowd broke into thunderous applause—loud enough that we couldn't even hear each other.

Before Captain Callum could return to the other knights, I whispered something in his ear. "I love you as a knight too, Captain Callum."

His face was an even deeper red when I pulled away. He bowed twice to me, returning somewhat stiffly to the crowd with Vice Captain Eric. Perhaps he was walking like that because his feet were tired from dancing.

Everyone in my life is truly so kind.

Soon, the event neared its conclusion. The dancing wouldn't go on much longer. I would only have two or so more partners before the evening wound down—or before Tiara ran out of stamina.

This time, I chose a prince from another allied country. I wanted to dance with Cedric and his brothers too, but it was best not to favor any foreign country over the rest. Tiara and Stale were dancing with royals and nobles from other countries too.

Tiara's event ended after one last lovely dance between Mother and Father. It was a huge success. After a break, I would announce our international postal service. I was extremely nervous, my heart pounding as I waited for the big moment.

STALE

"SPLENDID JOB OUT THERE," Prime Minister Gilbert said, handing me a glass. "You danced brilliantly, Prince Stale."

"Thank you," I said, accepting it with open reluctance.

After the dance party, Pride, Tiara, and I had joined Mother and Father at their thrones. Tiara and Pride were still eagerly discussing the dances, but at least that kept other guests from approaching them. I'd lost my chance for a short break when the father of the last noblewoman I danced with accosted me for a chat. Honestly, Gilbert's intrusion to offer me a drink served as a huge relief...as much as I hated to admit that.

"I'd expect nothing less from you," he went on. "You stole the hearts of many princesses and noblewomen, didn't you?"

"No, I only danced with four of them," I said. "That's not exactly 'many.'"

I'd hoped to dance strictly with married women, but drawing the ire of the crowd wasn't worth it. I had reluctantly moved on to the

women I'd interacted with the most, but I never expected one of them to come approach me with her father after our dance. It wasn't as if I hated women; I simply had no interest in entertaining their feelings for me. I was already swamped with my seneschal and prince consort work.

"My daughter is eager to make this work."

I hadn't known how to respond to that.

I surreptitiously surveyed the crowd, careful not to make eye contact, and found a flock of noblewomen and princesses watching me over Gilbert's shoulders. This sort of fawning wasn't uncommon for me, but it had gotten much more intense after I turned seventeen.

"I hear you've captivated countless women from the moment they laid eyes on you."

This time, I faked a smile. "I'm honored. They're all so lovely."

"Of course," Gilbert agreed. He was just being polite, but his nod made me feel like we were on the same team or something, which just pissed me off even more.

Indeed, there were many beautiful women at the party. Some were older than me, some younger, but every last one dressed to impress and conducted themselves with the utmost elegance and grace. Even the invitees' partners and guests who *weren't* noblewomen or princesses were beautiful and graceful. But I never felt any particular attraction to any of them. I was too used to spending time around Pride, Tiara, and Mother—women no one could hope to outmatch. I was very much aware that this was a flaw of mine.

"Even my wife was pleased," Gilbert said. "She told me she quite enjoyed her time with you. Should I bring her to future events so you can see each other again?"

"No, it was nothing. I was merely *returning the favor*, as you were kind enough to entertain Princess Pride with a dance." I put enough sting in my words that Gilbert would understand my true meaning.

"I see," he said with an unflagging smile.

I wasn't exactly lying. Anger had flashed through me when Pride took Gilbert's hand, so I thought I'd offer my hand to Maria. *Well, to be honest...*

"My dance with Her Highness will be a lovely memory to look back on. It's excellent motivation to continue carrying out my work."

"I'm glad to hear that. You're our country's cherished prime minister, after all. I look forward to seeing your *earnest efforts* from here on out," I said, sipping from my drink.

"Of course," Gilbert replied as I savored the taste. He had picked the perfect drink, unsurprisingly. "How is your work going, Your Highness? Are you getting the hang of things yet?"

I looked up at his quiet tone. He wore a smile of genuine concern that left me speechless for a moment. I'd been spending more time with both Uncle Vest and Gilbert as of late. It pissed me off, but still...

"I am, thank you. I'm quite inexperienced, but I get to learn from the very best."

Gilbert's eyebrows shot up. He was silent for a beat, lost for words himself. At length, his gaze softened and he murmured, "I'm honored."

"Her Majesty should be speaking soon. I'm looking forward to it."

"As am I."

He wore a fond expression, and I honestly felt the same. Mother was going to introduce Pride, who would announce the establishment of an international postal system. The institution would connect all of our allied nations and amicable neighbors.

Not only that, but this was a joint undertaking with the previously isolated United Hanazuo Kingdom. When other countries heard about that, they might offer to let us build hubs and stopovers, expanding the system even further. That would result in more consistent deliveries and also bolster Pride's reputation.

Prince Cedric had made things a bit difficult at first, but I couldn't deny how much he'd helped in the end. He was the royal prince of the United Hanazuo Kingdom and possessed a brilliant mind. The man would no doubt adapt to the new system and handle it deftly.

"It makes me happy to know my elder sister will have yet another accomplishment under her belt."

On the heels of her schooling system, this service would show the masses yet more of Pride's hard work, hence my dedication to working on this endeavor myself.

"I couldn't agree more," Gilbert replied softly.

After everything he'd done to Pride in the past, I was itching to scold him for that—but his happiness for Pride was real this time.

"Princess Pride will be thrilled to have a wonderful person like you as her seneschal."

I wanted to smirk and scoff at him, but we were in public, so a simple thank-you and a nasty smile would have to suffice.

Gilbert merely grinned. "That reminds me... Have you thought about settling down now that you're seventeen years old, Your Highness? I'd be happy to introduce you to any number of—"

"No, I'm quite all right. I've left Mother and Father in charge of everything relating to my marriage."

I had raised my voice so he'd hear me clearly, causing the women behind him to cry out in anguish. *Damn him for bringing that up!*

Since I wasn't a princess, Mother and Father would pick out candidates for me and allow me to meet them before making a decision. They hadn't broached the subject with me yet, but that was probably intentional, since I was so busy working under Uncle Vest and carrying out prince consort duties. I didn't mind one bit; I couldn't bear to cut down on my work or time with Pride and Tiara because of those silly social formalities. In fact, I would've been perfectly happy remaining single for the rest of my life.

"I'm going to go check on Elder Sister and Tiara now!" I said, lacing every word with my anger but keeping my smile pasted on.

"Please, enjoy the rest of the party, Prime Minister Gilbert!"

Gilbert shrugged. "Certainly. Thank you, Your Highness."

Just as I turned to head in the opposite direction, it hit me that our conversation meant those other women wouldn't try to approach me anymore. I could go be with Pride and Tiara without anyone stopping me. That was probably why Gilbert had come over for a chat in the first place.

When I glanced over my shoulder, Gilbert asked, "Is something wrong?"

I couldn't help but respect his cleverness. Facing him, I crooked my finger to beckon him closer. He leaned in, and I gently tugged on his ear and whispered one last line. "I honestly *did* want to dance with Maria."

Gilbert blinked. I kept my facial expression a generic but polite one, and the prime minister smiled back at me. "Yes... I'm aware."

"I'm sure you are," I shot back, refusing to let him get the better of me.

Only when I spoke with him did social settings become such a nuisance. Childishly, I resolved to let him have it during work the next day.

Things would get even busier from here on out. Pride's postal service was about to launch, so we needed to pin down locations for hubs, recruit personnel, make our hires, inform other countries, and seek their cooperation. Every palace official was going to be

overwhelmed with work, including my parents, Uncle Vest, and Gilbert himself.

"Prime Minister, let's put our noses back to the grindstone tomorrow."

We'd only be spending more time together after this. I was in charge of assisting him just like I did with Uncle Vest. We would work together tomorrow, and the next day, and the day after that... probably for the rest of my life.

"Of course. I look forward to it, Prince Stale."

He bowed, and suddenly I wondered if the unaging, immortal prime minister would be the one to care for me when I was too old to do it myself.

Perhaps it really *was* best to get married if it meant someone else would look after me in my final days.

ARTHUR

"**O**H MY GOSH! I never imagined we'd *all* be invited to join them on the dance floor."

Vice Captain Eric smiled from ear to ear. The rest of us knights nodded.

I was just as shocked as everyone else. As the event wrapped up, I stared at the dance floor I'd stood on a little earlier. I expected Her Majesty would give a speech once the festivities died down, and Princess Pride would make her announcement to close out the evening.

"Pride is always telling me how deeply she trusts her knights," Prince Leon said. "If anyone was undeserving of being her partner, it was me."

"Not at all, Prince Leon," Captain Callum said with a smile. "You're Her Highness's sworn friend. It was only natural she would select you, her closest relation among all of Freesia's allies."

I wasn't sure when those two had gotten close, but it wasn't a huge surprise, considering how Captain Callum was. Of course he could befriend royalty and not just other knights.

"You all danced wonderfully," Prince Leon went on. "I couldn't look away from the commander and vice commander in particular."

They bowed to the prince even as they batted away his praise. Honestly, I agreed with him. I'd had no clue Dad could dance like that.

"We never saw them dance before either," Captain Alan said, shooting Dad a curious glance.

Clark was stifling his laughter as he slapped Dad on the back.

"Well, it's only natural that knights have such skills," Dad said, scratching his head and casting his eyes down.

"You...were quite brilliant too, Arthur." Prince Leon's voice quieted as he praised me. As soon as he flashed that charming smile, the other knights all turned toward me, eyes shining with some mixture of pity and amusement.

"No, not at all!" I replied, flustered. My face flushed just thinking about it. *I was the only one who couldn't do more than the basic steps!*

Everyone around me, from the knights to the nobles and royals, was a *way* better dancer than I was. I was the only one who'd embarrassed himself out there. I glanced at Dad, wondering if I should ask him to teach me to dance, but he turned his head away.

Clark smiled like he understood my intention. "Want me to teach you sometime, Arthur?"

"No! I wouldn't want to *bother* you, Vice Commander."

You're the last person I'd let teach me how to dance! I know you'd just laugh at me!

I glared at him, but Clark seemed to find all this hilarious. "I see. That's too bad." He punctuated his reply with a sip of his drink.

"You never know if they're gonna do another event like this at the next party," Captain Alan said, elbowing me. "Wouldn't it be better to practice before then? We should know how to dance, just to be safe."

Heat rushed back into my face. *Next time might be just as humiliating!* My heart raced at the thought. *But what if I manage to dance better next time?*

I recalled the dreamlike moments I'd shared with Princess Pride on the dance floor. Her heat lingered on my skin everywhere she'd touched, assuring me that dance wasn't just in my head.

"You're a good dancer too, Captain Alan...though it surprised me a little. When did you learn such a thing?" Vice Captain Eric asked with a chuckle.

Captain Alan simply grinned, but the vice captain had a point—I could've pictured Vice Captain Eric and Captain Callum dancing before this, but Captain Alan seemed too singularly dedicated to his knight training to have bothered learning to dance.

"At first, I stopped around the same level Arthur did." Raising his glass aloft, Captain Alan proudly puffed out his chest. "But I hoped I'd get the chance to dance with Princess Pride someday, so I started practicing really hard!"

How does he say stuff like that so casually?! I almost spit out my drink. I managed to choke it down, then started coughing from the effort. Captain Callum and Vice Captain Eric were sputtering just like me.

"Wow, that's amazing. But aren't you a little disappointed that you danced with Tiara instead?" Vice Captain Eric asked.

"Not a bit!" Captain Alan said without the slightest shred of shame. "It was a huge honor to dance with Princess Tiara. I'm really glad I practiced as much as I did."

Dad and Clark massaged their brows. The captain truly had no fears at all.

"It's too bad about Harrison," Captain Callum said once he got his coughing under control. "He might've gotten to dance as well if he was invited to the party."

Not every imperial knight had received an invitation, since it was Tiara's birthday this time. Vice Captain Eric and I were invited to represent the imperial knights, just like we had at Stale's birthday party. Captain Callum, the highest achiever in the royal order, had

been invited as a nobleman. Thus, Captain Alan had received an invitation as the second-highest achieving member of the royal order. The four of us weren't usually allowed to attend events together outside of Princess Pride's birthdays, but the circumstances were different this time.

Curious, Prince Leon echoed, "Harrison?"

It seemed the prince had never been introduced to Vice Captain Harrison. Clark explained who he was, and Prince Leon's eyes lit up.

"Can he dance too?"

"Well..." Clark offered a strained smile, then pointed at me. "I'd guess he's at roughly the same level as Arthur."

*Doesn't that just mean we both know the bare minimum?
Actually, I almost can't believe Harrison knows how to dance at all.*

Prince Leon nodded, fixing us each with a sharp look. "In that case...I'll have to be sure none of you surpass me, including this 'Vice Captain Harrison.'"

I cocked my head. The other knights didn't know what to make of it either, but Prince Leon's charming smile never faltered.

"As Captain Alan said," the prince went on in hushed tones, "it's quite possible they will hold this event again someday. Pride seems to think this was a one-off occasion, but if it happens again, I'm sure she'll want to dance with the knights she skipped this time. After this one was such a success, they're bound to host more dance parties in the future."

Captain Callum and I nodded in agreement. Dad and Clark seemed to have already reached the same conclusion. I could definitely see Princess Pride feeling that way. She would probably choose Harrison as her partner for the next dance party, or maybe it would be...

"Whoa!"

I recoiled at the sight of Captain Alan and Vice Captain Eric. The two of them were so red, their heads were practically boiling.

I get how they feel, but Captain Alan was so calm just a minute ago! That's what got him all embarrassed?!

Vice Captain Eric was covering his mouth, but Captain Alan's jaw hung open. I shook his shoulder, concerned, and the limp knight swayed.

"Not again..." Captain Callum muttered.

Prince Leon chuckled at our reactions. "I look forward to that day, don't you?"

We all nodded in response; it was an easy answer. I downed the rest of my drink, thinking I'd have to tell Harrison about this tomorrow.

He'll definitely be here next time.

Harrison would surely receive an invitation to Princess Pride's birthday as one of her imperial knights. Truth be told, he still freaked me out a little. I didn't understand him very well, but I was glad Princess Pride had gained another person capable of protecting her no matter what.

I truly wanted to keep Her Highness safe for the rest of my life.

PRIDE

"P RIDE, TIARA, PRINCE STALE...you all danced brilliantly out there."

Stale had joined Tiara and me once we finished our recap of the dance party. Seeing this as their chance, Cedric, King Lance, and King Yohan had approached the three of us. The Hanazuo royals wanted to chat with us before the announcement of the international postal service that their kingdom would help us run.

"We couldn't tear our eyes away," King Lance said.

"It was a wonderful event," Cedric agreed.

Tiara and I ducked our heads, bashful in the face of the praise. "Thank you, Cedric," I said with a smile. "You did a great job too."

Not only was he the first guest selected to dance, but Tiara—the star of the party herself—had chosen him. In that moment, he'd stepped into the role of a true leading man. Stale was popular with women too, but the entire ballroom had swooned at the beautiful, flaxen-haired couple whirling on the dance floor. Thanks to them, I'd spent my own dances in incredibly high spirits.

"No, it was nothing," Cedric said.

Still smiling, I shot Tiara a pointed look. She stepped back, as if to hide behind me and Stale, and directed a little scowl up at Cedric. Her puffed-out cheeks were an adorable sight. "Thank you...for dancing with me! I-I really wanted to dance with...someone from the United Hanazuo Kingdom."

"No, I'm the one who should be thanking you," Cedric told her. "Dancing with you was like a dream."

He smiled at her, though his face reddened along the way; perhaps he was reliving the moment. With his cheeks tinged and his gaze soft, the look he directed at Tiara was almost sensual. It was too much for her; she flinched, ducking behind me and Stale for shelter.

"I-I just happened to spot you first, before I saw His Majesties!"

Tiara's squeak didn't discourage Cedric in the slightest. He just went on smiling, even though he couldn't see her anymore. "That's all right. I'm overjoyed to know your eyes landed on me out of all the men in the room."

I understood Tiara's dilemma. The passion in his words threatened to leave *me* blushing as well. Stale nodded sagely as he looked between the three of us. *What could he possibly have figured out at a time like this?!*

King Lance gave Cedric a light smack to stop his embarrassing remarks. "That's enough."

King Yohan covered his mouth, but his shoulders shook with laughter.

"By the way, Cedric, are you prepared for all the questions you'll be receiving soon?" I said to change the subject.

Tiara was still hiding behind me. She seemed just as upset with him as ever...or perhaps she was just feeling shy over the embarrassing things he'd said.

The party would end as soon as I made my announcement, but I expected a flood of questions for me and Cedric, whom I'd introduce as the postmaster general. He would be staying overnight in the castle as a representative of the United Hanazuo Kingdom. Depending on how people reacted, he could get stuck at the party until every last guest had left.

Cedric grinned and thumped his chest. "You bet! I already have it all in my head. Construction of the hub is going smoothly, and I'll be securing employees as soon as I'm home."

He planned to use a building on the border between Cercis and Chinensis—where the wall once stood—as a base of operations. Construction had begun soon after the defensive war. Originally, they'd intended to use the building as a public institution connecting the two countries, but once the idea got rolling, they had decided to turn it into the postal service's main hub. Chinensians and Cercians alike could access the facility with ease, which made it simpler to scout employees.

Cedric proceeded to boast that, as a member of the royal family, he was devoting himself to learning everything he needed to know. He'd already absorbed a frightening amount of knowledge from our library since arriving in Freesia, but it sounded like he was doing the same back home in Hanazuo. It was only a matter of time before he memorized every last book in their country. I had to mentally prepare myself if he intended to do the same in Freesia.

"My country will spare no expense in assisting with the postal service," King Yohan told me. "Please don't hesitate to inform us if

Cedric causes you any more trouble.”

King Lance chuckled. “We’ll take it upon ourselves to force him to step down from his post.”

They weren’t joking about that. Cedric insisted he wouldn’t make any more trouble for us, but his face turned red again.

“It feels like a dream,” King Yohan added with a soft smile. “I never imagined there would be a day when Hanazuo could stand before so many other countries like this.”

He clutched the cross pendant at his chest, his golden eyes sparkling with joy. King Lance nodded, emotion likewise shining in his eyes. He pulled King Yohan and Cedric flush against him, strong arms flexing, then turned so all three faced me. The crimson flames in his eyes burned brightly.

“Princess Pride.”

I straightened, overwhelmed by the force of his conviction before he’d even said my name.

“There aren’t enough words to convey our gratitude to you all. Yohan, Cedric, and I will do everything in our power to assist you from here on out. We hope you’ll keep treating us with the same graciousness as before.”

With that, he slapped Cedric’s shoulder, prompting the prince to bow his head. That last bit was mostly about Cedric. King Lance was going to be separated from the little brother he’d looked after for so long. If anything, his love for Cedric seemed more like that of a father than a brother.

I flushed when King Yohan lowered his head as well. Two kings, bowing to me in a room full of witnesses! Cedric bit his lip, his fiery eyes blinking away tears at his big brothers' display.

"Cedric...no, the royal prince of Cercis is going to be indispensable to our country," I said. "I'm certain of that. I hope you continue to treat us amicably as well. Now, please raise your heads."

Tiara peeked around my back and joined Stale and me in bowing this time.

A loud, clear voice suddenly resonated through the ballroom. "It is time for a statement from Queen Rosa Royal Ivy."

The guests' chatter ceased at once.

Mother stood from her throne and greeted the crowd, as elegant as ever. She thanked the guests for attending the birthday festivities and wished them all well. When she praised the now sixteen-year-old Tiara for her work arranging the dance party, everyone broke into applause. Tiara blushed shyly. She'd never engaged in such a large undertaking before, and this was her first commendation from the audience. My heart swelled to see that Tiara had grown into a truly wonderful princess.

I smiled at my sister. Even Stale wore a tender expression. As her big brother, he had to be so proud of her growth. We basked in those emotions until Mother spoke again.

"We have an announcement to share with you all." She beckoned me forward. "You will now hear from my daughter, Princess Pride Royal Ivy."

The crowd's applause engulfed me as I stepped in front of Mother. I gazed out over the entire ballroom. My heart raced, but I raised my head high. Friends and strangers alike watched me avidly.

I cleared my throat and slowly parted my lips.

"Thank you for the introduction. I am the firstborn princess, Pride Royal Ivy."

I'd done this many times, yet nerves always bubbled up when the moment to address the crowd arrived. Unlike the dances, which I shared with my partners, I was alone now. Mother made it even worse by stepping back and giving me the stage. My throat went dry.

I started simple, thanking the guests for attending. Then I donned a bold smile, willing myself to stay steady as I addressed the —

At that moment, something descended upon my head.

"This evening, I would like to...to announce to you all...that..."

Terror seized hold of me. My tongue wasn't moving right. My breath caught in my throat. The guests' faces changed as I trailed off into silence. I moved my mouth, but I couldn't form words. Instead, what escaped my throat was...

"Ah... Aaah... Aaaaahhhhh! AAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHH!"

...an earsplitting scream.

I gripped my head with both hands as if I could fight the sensation off, but my skull throbbed like it was about to crack open, cutting off any hope of rational thought. I shook my head violently and tried to suppress the feeling, but the screams tore from me again

and again. My mind flickered back and forth between white and black like a busted television, threatening to drive me to madness.

I couldn't breathe! I sucked in as much air as I could, but every scream expelled the breath. All I could do was cry out in a futile attempt to stop the pain.

My head's going to split in two!

"Elder Sister!"

"Princess Pride!"

"Big Sister!"

"Someone get the doctor!"

Though voices drifted to me between my screams, I couldn't process them through the agony. I clutched my head madly, letting out bloodcurdling shrieks as I fell to my knees.

This feels so familiar.

I screamed and screamed and screamed, blood draining out of my face. Someone grabbed me. They called my name, but the pain overwhelmed my ability to comprehend the words.

"Your Highness! Can you hear me?!"

"Princess Pride!"

"Someone call the doctor! We must tell the queen and prince consort what's happened!"

"The princess is hurt!"

Yes, it's exactly the same as back then.

I writhed, kicking from the unbearable pain. Thoughts blinked in and out of my head as the fiery ache split me apart. Behind it all was a single, ice-cold thought.

Ten years ago... Ah, that's right. How did I forget?

I could no longer keep my eyes open. As I ran out of oxygen, my head burned and my consciousness tumbled toward darkness.

"Don't move your head! Princess Pride! Can you hear me?! Princess Pride!"

"Lock every door in the castle! Don't let anyone out!"

"Arthur!"

I remember now...

The pain was dwindling, but the madness ate its way into my body, bringing with it a strange sort of pleasure. Eventually, there was nothing left but a pitch-black void. Someone was touching me and calling my name, but I couldn't move so much as a finger.

The world around me went as fuzzy as a dream. In what remained of my mind, I confronted myself.

Ten years ago...what was it that had me so terrified of Queen Pride's future?

Why was I so convinced that I would end up corrupted in that future instead of bringing about a new one?

Why didn't I ever train personal maids like the ones Stale and Tiara already had?

Why did I always use my knowledge of the game as an excuse,

never once questioning the existence of my “precognition”?

Because I already knew.

Ten years ago, I didn’t simply remember my past life.

I experienced *precognition*.



No matter how much I struggle, how much I resist, how fiercely I cling to a righteous life...someday, I'm going to "go back" to myself. And yet... Aaaaahhh! How...how did I forget that?!

"Please wake up, Princess Pride!"

"Pride! *Pride!* Hey, stay back! This isn't some spectacle!"

"Why?! Why won't she wake up, damn it?!"

Questions swirled through my mind.

Why did I feel the need to form my fealty contract with Val as "the future queen," even when I knew during his trial that Tiara was this country's true queen? When did I decide not to entrust anyone with my ultimate punishment? Why did I desire that Val "survive" if he lost a place to belong? Why did I tell Mother we still had time?!

Something about it had always felt strange. Over and over and over again, I knew something was wrong!

So why did I end up selecting my marriage candidates?

Oh, that's right. It wasn't as if I'd forgotten entirely.

Captain Callum and Arthur... They were proud of being knights. Stale spent his days working hard, training to one day serve the people as seneschal. None of them would ever want to abandon those lives to become the prince consort. But when Mother presented me with that list of candidates, I didn't hesitate for a moment.

I chose all three of them without a single thought.

"Please allow me to confirm one thing. Are these marriage candidates to be announced two years from now, and never before?"

As long as their candidacy remained secret, I wanted it to be them. As long as they wouldn't be punished or treated coldly by the public for being my marriage candidates...they were my first choices.

After all...I wanted to spend my final days with the people I loved, if only to be with them a second longer.

I would get to spend more time with them once they became marriage candidates, just like I had during my engagement to Leon. They would take priority in every single matter. That was why I chose them as my candidates, and no one else. They were three of the people who'd treated me so kindly throughout the entire time we'd known each other.

It was like I knew my life was drawing to a close.

Here I'd been operating under the assumption I was the crown princess, slated to become the next queen, but a deeper part of me *always* knew the truth: I would never be queen. My happy days would end. My life would play out exactly as it had in the game.

I hadn't forgotten...yet the memories faded away over time. With each passing year, I believed more in the future laid out for me as crown princess until eventually, I stopped questioning it.

What a fool I've been.

I'd entrusted things to Stale and Arthur. I'd taught Tiara the things she would need to know as queen. I'd dodged every bullet using my power of precognition.

Over the past ten years, no one knew more about the experience, the *sensation* of precognition than I did.

"Pride... Pride! Wake up!"

"Princess Pride! Please...open your eyes!"

May I never open my eyes again.

The next time I woke up, I would hurt everyone around me. I prayed that these would be my final moments in this world.

If that's too much to ask for...then at the very least, may this world have the same happy ending that the game did.

"Princess Pride!"

"Pride! It...it can't be! How could this happen?!"

"Pride! *Pride!* What's going on?!"

May they kill me once and for all...

"Pride!"

"Princess Pride!"

...before I destroy the country I love.

"Big Sister!"

Chapter 8:
**“But All of That Wouldn’t Happen for Ten More Years, on the
Day of Tiara’s Sixteenth Birthday.”**

STALE

HOW MANY HOURS had passed?

“Pride...”

To all appearances, the woman before me was only sleeping—yet she wouldn’t wake up. We’d carried Pride to her bed, where she remained unconscious, never moving so much as a finger. Her personal guard, her imperial knights, her personal maids, and a few doctors crowded her room. Outside, more guards and knights patrolled the hallway.

Everyone held their breath, waiting for Pride to open her eyes. Tiara sat in a chair at her bedside, her eyes red from crying as she clutched her sister’s hand. She never left Pride’s side, and neither did I.

Earlier this evening, Pride had suddenly collapsed at Tiara’s birthday party. Just before she fell, she’d clutched her head and screamed in a way we’d never heard before. Without warning, her slender body thrashed, writhed, and contorted in front of all the guests.

I’d called for a doctor right away, and as I held her still, she went limp and lost consciousness. Arthur had rushed through the disturbed crowd and touched Pride, but nothing changed. *Not even the power to heal all diseases could save her!*

I didn't understand. How could Arthur's special power have no effect?!

The doctors couldn't tell us anything other than that she was unconscious. She had no visible injuries. We checked the last glass she drank from and every guest's belongings, but to no avail. We sealed off the castle and sent the knights and guards around to patrol, but they didn't find any intruders.

Everyone had seen the moments leading up to Pride's collapse and could verify that no one had approached her until after the fact. The only possible culprits were a slow-acting poison we'd never heard of, the onset of an unknown illness, some kind of subterfuge by the Freesian royal family or Hanazuo—the final people to interact with her—or a Freesian guest using a special power.

I gave the latter option more consideration. All of the attendees from our kingdom were nobles, including those of middle or lower rank. Gilbert and I had been thoroughly auditing Freesian nobles as of late, so perhaps they had banded together in an effort to obstruct our investigation, or they were simply out for revenge. Maybe they hated the royal family or were enraged by their omission from Pride's list of marriage candidates... *Augh! Whatever it is, my blood is boiling!*

Wham! I slammed my fist into the wall behind me without thinking. A couple people flinched and glanced my way, but I couldn't take my eyes off Pride.

Pride's collapse had sent the ballroom spiraling into chaos. Even after we began our search for the culprit and the cause, many of the guests were disturbed by her condition. The knights, as well as the

guests from Anemone and Hanazuo, had taken it particularly hard. Even Gilbert's face had been white as a sheet.

When she fell unconscious, the knights and guards had formed a protective ring around the royal family. I'd managed to catch her before she hit her head, but there was nothing else I could do for her in the moment.

We urged people to return home after our thorough search of the ballroom and its occupants, but guests from all of Freesia's allied countries, near and far, wished to stay at the castle until they knew Pride was safe. Prince Leon was especially vehement in his request to stay, but having already invited so many people—Freesians and foreigners alike—we couldn't take on any more. Tiara's birthday party was just that big of an occasion.

The Freesian royal family couldn't confine our royal and noble guests to their rooms indefinitely, however. Once the knights had confirmed no one was acting suspiciously or carrying anything they shouldn't have, the guests from neighboring countries went home as scheduled. Those who planned to stay overnight were shown to a special palace.

Fortunately, just about everyone cooperated. They feared Pride had some sort of chronic ailment, and aside from those who'd requested to see her, we managed to send the rest away without incident.

Gilbert and I apologized to the representatives of Hanazuo for the delay in our joint announcement, but they were far more concerned with Pride's health. King Lance and Prince Cedric quietly

inquired about the man with the special power to cure diseases, but I couldn't yet inform them we'd already tried that.

Tiara wept the entire time, even after we brought Pride to bed. Her bright future had abruptly vanished. She was much, much more upset than when she stayed by Pride's side after the defensive war.

The knights were equally rattled. Pride's four imperial knights opted to safeguard her overnight while the rest of the order protected the castle. Commander Roderick had wondered if they should put two of her knights on patrol, but they all asked to stay in Pride's room until she awoke. They would call Vice Captain Harrison in the morning so they could keep four people on duty at a time and take turns resting. If she didn't open her eyes, then...

Anxiety and dread pummeled me at that thought. My stomach tied itself in knots, leaving me nauseated. I tensed, but my fingertips, my hands, my arms—they trembled despite my best efforts. I had to focus on taking deep breaths just to get any air. *No, that's impossible! She couldn't possibly leave us like that!*

I clenched my fists to fight off the lump forming in my throat, but it was no use. I couldn't let anyone see me dissolving into tears. *I promised Arthur! If I let him see me now, it would be the same as saying Pride is never going to wake up. That's the one thing I can't allow!*

Desperately battling my emotions, I sucked in a loud breath.

The doctors said they didn't know if Pride would wake up. She was utterly motionless, to the point that she could have passed for dead. Even her breathing had slowed until it seemed it might stop at

any moment. The doctors checked her pulse, her breaths, the color of her face. Yet no matter how many times they examined her, no matter who called out to her, she never responded.

There was nothing we could do but wait.

Knock, knock.

Jack, Pride's personal guard, came in through the door. "Prince Stale, Seneschal Vest has summoned you." He was usually very calm, but even he couldn't keep his worry off his face.

I told him I was coming, then stood and joined Tiara at Pride's bedside.

"Big Brother..." Tiara whimpered.

I stroked her head before she could start crying again, then took her tiny hand in mine. We clasped Pride's hand together, our elder sister's warmth washing over us. I couldn't even hear her breathing. It was like she'd been turned into a doll.

"I'm going now, Pride. You can open your eyes at any time, you know."

I could have scoffed at the despondency in my own voice. I was all but offering a prayer. With my free hand, I ran my fingers through Pride's scarlet hair, spreading it out over the bedsheets. I asked the people in the room to report to me the second she opened her eyes. Then I released her and Tiara, already missing her warmth.

Before I left, I approached the imperial knights standing a step behind Tiara. They wore the carefully controlled expressions they'd maintained throughout the entire ordeal. Captain Alan and Captain

Callum still had some life in their eyes, but just like me, they were berating themselves for failing to protect Pride. Vice Captain Eric was as pale as a ghost. He tried to compose himself, but I could see he was biting his cheek to manage it.

"Ar—Captain Arthur."

Arthur flinched when I addressed him, then muttered an apology for not keeping his eyes ahead of him. He was in the worst shape of all. Though technically conscious, Arthur's gaze was vacant. Hollow. He paled as he stared down at his own hands, guilt scrawled across his face that his special power couldn't save Pride. "I'm so sorry..."

"I'm going to see Seneschal Vest now," I told him.

My friend grunted in response. He didn't seem entirely aware of what was happening around him.

"So," I continued, and he went stiff, "I want you to sit with Tiara and Elder Sister until I return. You're the only one who can do it."

You're the only one I can rely on.

Arthur blinked at me in bewilderment, clearly thinking he'd misheard. Vice Captain Eric gave him a gentle shove on the back. I guided him toward Tiara's chair. He took slow, careful steps toward Pride's bedside, where he bent down to crouch at the same level as Tiara.

Tiara glanced at him, then he set his hand on top of hers and Pride's. He winced, probably from the sensation of the faint warmth lingering in Pride's body. Arthur squeezed his eyes shut for a moment. Once he opened them, they were fixed solely on Pride while he

stroked Tiara's back with his free hand. I watched the three of them for a moment before finally exiting the room.

Someone shut the door silently behind me. As soon as I could no longer sense Pride's presence, my chest clenched. I squeezed my fists and bit my cheek hard enough to draw blood. "Pride..."

It's all right. It's all right. She'll surely wake up tomorrow. She'll smile like always and apologize for scaring us. Maybe Uncle Vest summoned me because there was some sort of development. Will she wake up first, or will we find the cure before that? That's all there is to discuss. Arthur will be here with her too. It's all right.

I desperately tried to convince myself as I willed my legs to carry me away. It took fierce determination to muster up even a single step. I couldn't have left that room at all if it weren't for Arthur. I walked faster and faster, hurrying to speak with Uncle Vest.

All the while, I prayed that this nightmare would soon end.

ARTHUR

DAWN TIPTOED along the horizon.

I was *sure* it was time—that Princess Pride would wake up any minute now. I watched over her until sunlight streamed in through the window. I'd been looking at her face all night, holding her hand the whole time, but she never moved an inch. Nausea roiled in my gut each time the doctors checked for signs of life. I glanced at Tiara, but she wore the same grim look on her face and stared down at our interlocked hands while I kept stroking her back. She shook her head fiercely when I asked her if she wanted to get some sleep.

"I'll probably have bad dreams," she replied, smiling even though she looked on the verge of tears. I'd never seen her smile with so much pain.

No matter how long we waited, Princess Pride didn't show the slightest sign of stirring. Stale had yet to return, though I was sure he'd come rushing back as soon as he concluded his business. His absence only added to my unease.

It all happened so fast, from the moment Princess Pride started screaming all the way up to her collapse.

The other knights and I ran toward her as soon as the shrieks began. The second she was in pain, we sprang into action before our minds even processed the situation. My heart stuttered at the agony twisting her face. I ran as fast as I could, but it felt like each step was too slow. I almost couldn't breathe in my urgency to reach her quicker.

We forced our way through the crowd...but by then, she wasn't moving. My vision blurred. The world quivered around me, everything I'd once known suddenly unstable.

Stale was even paler than Her Highness as he cradled her in his arms. He bared his teeth like a wild animal at anyone who dared to approach. Stale shouted for everyone to make way when he spotted me, then passed Princess Pride into my arms...but my power didn't work like it usually would have. His look of despair was seared into my mind even hours later.

I squeezed Princess Pride's hand, touched her neck, put my hands on her head, but not only did she stay asleep, I couldn't even sense my special power anymore.

"Why?"

I closed my mouth before anything more could slip out. It wasn't right for me to speak of it, not as things stood.

Until now, I'd been able to heal anyone. I was so proud of that gift, so happy I had the power to save people... So why did it have to fail on *her*, the one person I wanted to heal most? I could have cursed myself. Staying at her bedside didn't ease the burden on my heart in the slightest. Instead, the sight of her lying there squeezed my chest until I could hardly breathe. Horrible, painful thoughts played on a loop in my mind.

I prayed that she might wake up, that this was all just a dream, but such things were out of my hands.

I traced the lines of Princess Pride's hand between Tiara's fingers, feeling her smooth skin and faint body heat. At least she wasn't gone yet. *Wait, "yet"?*

A chill shot through my body. No one had any idea when she would wake up or what did this to her. When the doctor had said, "*If she doesn't wake up at all...*" my vision went black.

Her screams and her tormented face were already scorched into my memory. But when I thought about what came after, ice washed through my veins and my throat burned, my whole body trembling. I accidentally gripped the princesses' hands harder.

When Tiara noticed, she leaned her head against my shoulder. Stale had kept up a tough front as well, though I'd nearly choked at the contorted smile he gave Princess Pride. Never had I seen such

strong emotion overcome him. Never had he shouted like that in front of Freesia's guests.

It wasn't just Stale either—Captain Alan's face was ashen, Vice Captain Eric was crying out, and Captain Callum's hands trembled. This was my first time witnessing them in such a state.

Dad wore a grim expression as he issued orders to us, and Clark's face was equally somber as he watched us leave. This could have been an attack or assassination attempt, so every last knight locking down the castle was ready to kill the culprit if we found him. When I looked at Princess Pride's pale, lifeless face, my stomach wrenched itself into a knot.

Please, please...wake up soon...

It was a simple wish.

But in that moment, it was the one desire left in my heart...after I'd been so utterly powerless.

CEDRIC

"GOOD MORNING. Why, it's another lovely day. Don't you agree, my dearest Tiara?"

I had come straight to her room in the Freesian castle after finishing breakfast. She spooked at my approach, her beautiful golden eyes wider than usual, but eventually returned my greeting.

"Did you sleep well?" I asked, and she smiled shyly.

"Yes, thank you." Her face had a healthy color to it, so she probably wasn't lying. She politely responded by asking how I'd slept.

To be honest, I'd barely slept at all. Only a day had passed. When I pictured Lance still asleep in that bed, unresponsive and unmoving, any hope of a good night's rest had fled from me.

I smiled at her regardless. "Unfortunately, I didn't sleep a wink. How could I when I had someone as sweet as you on my mind?"

As I purred the words, I set my fingers under her chin—careful not to scratch her with my rings—and tipped her head up.

Peering deep into her eyes, I added, "I wanted to see you as soon as possible."

Her cheeks flushed red. *Yes, this is so easy.* She watched me, never turning her pink-tinged face away, and I caught a sweet scent on the air.

Tiara jumped like a nervous little critter when my hand drifted toward her ear. I smiled, combing my fingers through her soft, golden hair—strands the same color as mine. The sun pouring in through the window only enhanced the flaxen glow. Her hair, finer than mine, kissed my skin like silk.

"Would you...sleep by my side tonight?"

Drawn in by her scent, I kissed a lock of her beautiful hair. Tiara grew redder and redder each time I stole a glance at her, until her lips were trembling. I waited for her response, but she was too flustered to form a coherent sentence.

"P-Prince Cedric, what're you...?!" my new fiancée blurted out.

The queen had made the official announcement a day ago. I'd heard Tiara had spent her entire life closed off in a tower, and it

seemed she wasn't used to being around men yet. When she'd blushed upon meeting me last night, I assumed she'd be an easy target—someone who'd fall in love with me right away.

"Pardon me, I just couldn't help it," I said. "Your hair is too beautiful."

I flashed her the type of smile that had made women swoon all my life. I let go of her hair, my bracelets jingling with each motion. Tiara was frozen, but I took her hand and kissed the back of it anyway.

"Is this what you'd prefer?" I asked.

She twitched and stood up straight. "Um..." she began, her entire body flushed like her heart might explode. When I released her hand and closed the distance between us, she scampered back to the other wall.

"What's wrong? We're engaged, aren't we? This is how one betrothed greets another."

"B-but we only just met last night!"

I wasn't used to someone so inexperienced. Back when I lived with Lance and Yohan, a few of the women in town had reacted this way when I'd ventured there. I was determined to keep her in this flustered state.

Thud! I slammed my hand against the wall next to her so she couldn't escape, my bracelets jangling. Pinned between me and the wall, she stared at the arm blocking her escape.

"Looking away from me, hm? I guess I didn't get my point across."

When I chuckled, Tiara finally looked me in the eye. I leaned closer, and she blushed harder and squeezed her eyes shut. So she *was* prepared to receive me as her fiancé, at least to this extent. She clutched her hands over her heart, standing as still as a statue and keeping her eyes closed as tears pricked the corners. *Oh well.*

I kissed her cheek instead of her lips. She flinched, but once I backed away, she blinked like she'd expected more.

"What, wasn't the cheek good enough? You can be honest if you want me to keep going."

I brushed my hair back, and she flailed all over again. "N-no! I-I-I just thought you were—" She cut herself off, not daring to say more.

Sweeping a thumb beside her eye, I said, "I'm not into stealing kisses from crying girls. But I guess I don't hate *making* them cry."

I took her hand and suggested we go outside, then led her down the spiral staircase of her isolated tower. Tiara flushed anew at our joined hands, turning away shyly when I smiled at her. Despite the adorable reaction, I knew...someday, she would come to despise me too.

It was only natural. I'd come to this kingdom to make her fall in love with me before I killed her. No matter how much I charmed her with my good looks, the moment she learned the truth would be the moment she came to hate me—no matter how much love she once

felt. That thought helped push aside the guilt for deceiving her. She was just using me as an outlet to live out her fantasies, after all.

Things like love and romance didn't exist. There was nothing but ugly lust and the greedy desire to tie people down. Ultimately, the only thing I used to trick her was my appearance, not who I was on the inside. She was bound to release my hand the second she discovered all the blood staining it.

"You'll probably fall into my clutches over the next three days," I had said to her when we met the night before.

With the bashful way she blushed and pressed her lips together, I could read her like a book. I was confident I'd be able to keep my promise to the queen. My current trip would only last three days, so I needed to make the most of my chances to steal her heart during this time. I wanted Tiara to feel empty for the next month without me, to leave such a lasting mark on her that she couldn't exist without me. All of this was to get Lance's country back...as well as Yohan's.

I couldn't trust anyone. Yohan himself hated me now; he believed the queen instead of me. But if possible, I wanted to return his country to him too. He'd lost it because of my own foolishness. Even if he still detested me, this was my one and only chance for atonement.

If I just seduced the queen's sister and got a bit more blood on my hands, I could fix everything. Not that I fully believed the queen when she'd offered me that bargain, but it was the only thread I had to grab onto. All I could do was defile the princess's heart, staining it with thoughts of me and me alone.

Then why did I hesitate to steal a kiss from her just now?

I could have given her a goodbye kiss last night too. She never would have forgotten me if I stole her lips right away, even if she *wanted* the kiss. It would have made my work over these three days much easier.

No, I wouldn't keep hesitating. I would steal a kiss in the end. I couldn't satisfy the queen without winning Tiara over enough that she asked for a kiss herself.

But...kisses were important to women. Even the me from one year ago would have foolishly gone in for a kiss on the first day. After filling my head with all the knowledge I could acquire, I understood that women saw kisses as something sacred. I couldn't capture her lips so easily. Only in books did people gaze into each other's eyes and lock lips before they even realized what they were doing, but many women probably dreamed of that sort of thing.

That left me with one last resort. If I didn't use it, I would have to wait for Tiara to fall for me and request a kiss herself. Fate demanded she die at my hands, but I wanted her to remain an innocent maiden until the end. I could at least give her that much.

Right then, Tiara shrieked; she must have been spacing out. She stumbled, and I rushed to wrap my arm around her and pull her close.

"I'm sorry!"

I released my hold on the blushing princess. "I'm glad you weren't injured. Did you hurt your ankle?"

"No, I'm all right."

She averted her eyes, embarrassed by her clumsiness. *What a truly innocent young girl.*

"You aren't injured, are you, Prince Cedric?"

I told her I was fine and took her dainty hand in mine. This was all so frivolous. Not only was I uninjured, but I was plotting to kill her someday—and here she was more concerned about me than herself.

No, none of that mattered. She was just being polite. Someday, she would look at me with disgust. In her final moments, Tiara would hate me so much that she'd want to kill me. I didn't need to show her that much concern. Our engagement was only for show.

I didn't trust anyone but Lance. I wouldn't let anyone else get close to my heart.

That was the lesson I'd learned when everything I loved slipped from my hands, and I made up my mind for good.

"I know you're awake in there, Cedric," Lance called as he knocked.

I wasn't sleeping, but I must have been in a daze; I hadn't even noticed his approach. The guards opened the door to reveal Lance, with Yohan standing behind him. Both looked awfully pale, not that I was doing much better.

None of us had slept a wink after last night. How *could* we? We had watched alongside everyone else as Pride, the woman who was absolutely irreplaceable to me, abruptly fell unconscious.

"We checked in with the castle's guards and knights, but they haven't heard anything yet," Lance said.

My heart throbbed painfully. *She's still not awake?*

When I closed my eyes, the moment replayed in my mind with perfect clarity. With each repetition, my head ached and my throat tightened. I'd clawed at my neck in the middle of the night, unable to bear the pressure. Now, the scratches stung anew.

"I wish there was some way we could help...but there's nothing we can do except pray for her recovery," Lance said in an unusually gloomy voice. Yohan's face darkened even more.

He was right; there was nothing we could do. I just wished I could have stayed with Pride overnight, but she was an unmarried princess. Not only that, but we were on the list of suspects. There was no chance of requesting a visit now. We had gotten permission to stay in the castle, having come from so far away, but we had yet to receive word of her waking.

Most of the other royal guests from distant countries had refused to leave as well. Everyone was waiting for Pride to open her eyes—that was just how much she meant to people. Everybody loved her, desired her, relied on her, treated her like a guidepost. Yet no one had any way of helping her. *Not me, not Bro, and not Big Bro!*

We had inquired with Prince Stale and learned even the savior who healed Lance couldn't rescue her. *Pride is the one who saved the three of us and our countries! But I'm still completely powerless.*

When I looked at my brothers' faces, I saw all the hallmarks of sleep deprivation. Yohan's fingers shook as he squeezed the cross at

his chest.

"We should be able to request a visit with Pride after a while," I told them. "I'll be the one to go. Are you two coming?"

"Of course."

"We'll join you."

Their voices rang with determination, reflecting my own feelings.

Pride had used up all her strength screaming and thrashing, then went so still she looked to be dead. My heart stopped when I saw how pale her face was. A chill shot down my spine whenever I recalled it. Tiara had screamed Pride's name over and over as tears streaked down her cheeks. I couldn't get close to her. I just stood nearby and called Pride's name, like everyone else.

Prince Leon had shoved his way through the crowd to reach us. Panic replaced his usual cool composure. His already pale skin was almost blue as his teeth chattered and his eyes went wide. When I looked out at the crowd, I found the guests all trying to get a peek at Pride.

Is Pride really not awake yet? Tiara adores her sister, so how is she feeling right now? Is her heart broken?! What about Prince Stale, Captain Arthur, Captain Callum, Captain Alan, Vice Captain Eric, or Prime Minister Gilbert?!

I struggled to breathe when I thought of all the people suffering right now. Pride had spent that one night with me long ago, when I could do nothing but wail over Lance's misfortune. How could I be so helpless, unable to do anything for all the people she loved so much?!

Without thinking, I slammed my fist on the table with all my strength. Lance said something, but it wasn't enough to make me unclench my fist. I needed to know if Pride was okay. I needed to see Tiara.

I want to help her, to help the people she cares about like she did for me! But...I can't!

At that moment, someone knocked on the door behind Yohan.

LEON

"P RINCE Leon!"

The sun had risen by the time I arrived at the Freesian castle—*Pride's* castle—in my carriage. I'd returned to Anemone for a few hours before setting back out for Freesia. I absolutely needed to see Pride after her sudden collapse the night before. The moment she was allowed visitors, I was desperate to be the first.

Mother and Father were extremely concerned about Pride too, so they had given me permission to return to Freesia at once, only requesting that I send word as soon as I learned anything about her condition. Pride meant so much to my parents. They would never forget how much they owed her.

I greeted the castle guards and requested a visit with Pride, telling them I'd wait in my carriage for as long as it took. A swarm of knights joined the usual guards in defending the gates, the whole castle clearly still on high alert. While one of the guards went inside to request permission, I squeezed my hands together, but interlacing my chilled fingers did not tamp down my dread whatsoever.

Pride...

I'd watched her suddenly collapse in front of all the party guests. Those shrieks, so unlike her usual regal voice, still echoed in my ears. I knew a little about medicine—enough to realize how serious her condition was, maybe even life-threatening. *She was screaming and suffering before she suddenly passed out. Anyone could tell her condition was serious.*

Judging by the guards' reaction just now, they were still searching for the source of her ailment. She probably hadn't woken up yet either.

I knew how easy it was to lose the things you loved in the blink of an eye, which made this all the more dreadful if she really *was* sick. As the prince of a Freesian ally, I knew this kingdom was home to multiple people with healing powers, but none of them could cure diseases. I wasn't stupid; such a convenient ability couldn't possibly exist. All I could do was hold on to the ridiculous hope that maybe, just maybe, I was wrong.

Though I'd spent my brief time in Anemone reading about poison and medicine, our books didn't contain anything that fit the description of Pride's ailment. She'd clutched her head, not her throat or her chest. Perhaps it was a sickness, then. Some of Anemone's trade partners had developed advanced medical knowledge; if Pride didn't wake up within the next day or two, I'd have to go to them.

I couldn't bear to lose her. My hands shook at the thought. The trembling took over my entire body until I had to wrap my arms around myself to suppress it.

When Pride collapsed, my vision narrowed until she was the only thing I could see. I was so terribly, dreadfully afraid of losing her. I couldn't breathe as she lay lifelessly on the floor. In truth, I didn't want to leave her side for even a second. I hated how much I regretted ending our engagement. I needed to get a hold of my wishful thinking.

I clenched my fists, released them, and thought back to the dance we'd shared. She had worn such a dazzling smile as she swayed in my arms, and so close to her collapse afterward.

"Please...don't leave me!"

I tried my best to hold it in, but the whine tore from my throat, freed by my terror over losing her. I clutched at my heart, but it did nothing to push down the fear rising within me.

It's too soon for this. I can't break down when it hasn't even been a full day. We don't know what caused it yet. I'll have to be careful with my words if they let me into the castle. I have to believe that Pride will wake up, and that every other outcome is impossible.

Pride lay on the other side of those castle gates. I would've jumped over them if I could. Each second I waited outside stretched on for an eternity. *Please, please, please, please, please!*

Knock, knock.

A knight peered into my carriage. "Prince Leon, Prince Stale has granted you special permission to enter as Princess Pride's sworn friend. Allow us to escort you inside."

When did all that time pass?

Footsteps and hoofbeats sounded around me. The royals and nobles who'd attended last night's party must have been nearby. My carriage, at the very front of the line, was the only one allowed through the gates. The guards followed close behind us as soon as we passed through, but they didn't let anyone else in.

We slowly made our way toward the palace. A knight opened the door, apologized for intruding, and inspected the inside of the carriage. Once he finished checking the interior, he gave me the all clear, bowed, and positioned himself outside the door. He must have done his inspection with a special power.

Keeping such knights outside the castle reinforced my suspicion they were still on high alert. It was already unusual to see knights stationed at the gates, but now they were inspecting the insides of carriages with special powers too. Guards already had special powers, so adding specific knights for security showed a great level of thoroughness. Perhaps Prime Minister Gilbert himself had ordered this.

I exited my carriage, which was parked in its usual spot. A crowd of knights rushed up to accompany me into the castle. I wondered if another special power user was inspecting me even while I stood there.

The knights led me through the palace. I offered Prince Stale my heartfelt gratitude for granting me permission to see Pride while tensions were high. I'd felt as much during the defensive war, but this incident only emphasized what a truly powerful ally the prince was. My heart ached when I imagined the despair he and Tiara must have felt at that moment.

Buzzing with impatience, I followed the knights to Pride's room. All the while, I gritted my teeth and prayed for her to open her eyes.

GILBERT

F *WUMP! Fwish, thunk!*

Albert, the prince consort, flipped through page after page detailing the palace staff and Freesian guests at last night's party. He swept the papers off his desk the moment he no longer needed them. Having joined Albert in his office, I watched as he grappled with the same rage burning inside him as me.

"Why?! Why can't the best doctors in the country figure this out?!" Though I knew Albert to be a composed fellow, he was shouting far more than usual. He took deep breaths, winded by his own anger.

"Some illnesses are extremely rare," I said. "Just because someone is a doctor doesn't mean they're familiar with every single disease."

But I'm not entirely convinced that's what befell Princess Pride.

I paused before I faced Albert again, needing a moment to calm my own emotions. My wife, Maria, had fallen victim to a rare illness herself only a few years earlier. I knew better than anyone that some sicknesses had no easy answer.

"Besides," I told him, "we're not certain yet it's an illness. Someone could have snuck into that large crowd. Seneschal Vest and Prince Stale are looking into the possibility now."

Queen Rosa was busy handling the aftermath of the situation, so Vest assisted as her steward by scouring the list of foreign guests. He was also confirming that none of the spouses brought along by the royal and noble invitees were Freesian. Prince Stale had joined him, so I knew the work would proceed smoothly, but the guest list was incredibly long. Rosa and all the palace officials were working without rest, but we had yet to make the slightest bit of progress.

Albert had secretly asked me if we could get help from the person whose special power had saved Maria, but all I could tell him was that we'd lost contact with the man. I couldn't reveal the abysmal truth—that Arthur had already touched Princess Pride that night without success.

"If a *person* did this, then they were after Pride's life! They tried to kill the firstborn princess right in front of all the guests! It's a declaration of war against our country!"

"Calm down, Albert." I chose my words carefully, coaxingly. "You're the only one who can support Her Majesty right now."

Unable to bear his grief any longer, Albert smashed his fist on the table, scattering documents onto the floor. His already frightening features twisted into something truly villainous. Perhaps he wanted to scream, "*What the hell would you know?!*" to unleash his anger...but I was the one person he couldn't speak to that way.

I understood why he'd lost his head. Princess Pride was his beloved daughter. If I had believed Maria's illness was the result of someone else's actions, I would have been too thirsty for blood to carry out my duties. I respected Albert for his attempts to subdue his

rage as he sifted through the documents. Our country's brilliant doctors were useless, offering only unhelpful commentary all the while.

"We don't understand."

"It seems she's merely unconscious."

"If she doesn't wake up, at this rate..."

I'll never allow it!

I wouldn't leave that wonderful young woman to wither away and die. If someone had caused her agony, putting her fit of madness on display for everyone to see. But even ripping off their fingernails and toenails wouldn't come close to the pain they deserved. I'd memorized the names and faces of every last guest. I had even narrowed down a few who could have motives to hurt our country...to hurt *her*.

Albert met my gaze, clearly finding his own violent fantasies reflected in my eyes as I brooded over whichever malefactor wished to hurt Pride. I hurried to compose myself, but Albert simply sighed and said, "I'm glad to know you're angry too."

He saw right through me. How pathetic.

"I just hope she wakes up before the day is over." His earnest wish sounded more akin to a prayer.

I told him I felt the same. Indeed, one thing was more important than finding the culprit or the cause: How many people would despair or suffer if Pride never opened her eyes?

My darkest nightmares had returned when she collapsed. I thought I would lose everything all over again. But now I knew that nightmare would have been the better outcome. If only Arthur could have cured her illness with his touch... Yet he and Stale had blanched when she remained limp and unresponsive despite the knight's efforts.

Even I had nearly fallen to the ground. I feared the worst and didn't manage another breath until it was clear she had a pulse. Aside from that and her shallow breathing, the princess offered us no signs of life. Her Highness was completely and utterly silent, in sharp contrast to her screaming only moments prior.

Albert and Vest shouted for her. Rosa remained strong, but she didn't move or blink as she stared at Princess Pride. Arthur and Stale propped the princess up, but since they didn't want to move her more than necessary, they stopped there as the doctors and people around them scurried about in a panic.

It was as if time had stopped for Princess Pride—and Princess Pride alone.

"Gilbert, this is an inquiry into the high-ranking noble guests from Freesia. Take it to Vest."

Albert massaged his forehead with one hand and handed me his documents with the other. The stack was a compilation of reports from the servants, attendants, maids, guards, and other guests about which high-ranking nobles had special powers, when they arrived at the castle, what they carried in or brought from their carriages, who accompanied them, and if they exhibited any suspicious behavior. The investigation also covered their statuses, prior relationships with the

royal family, connections to foreign countries, and any links to Princess Pride—as much information as the servants could uncover. My and Maria’s names were listed among them, of course.

The more information, the longer it would take to sift through. Freesians were a bit easier to investigate, but Vest probably had his hands full looking into the many foreign guests. Yesterday’s party had been our biggest event ever. Not only was there a limit to how much information we could acquire, but it would also take far more than a day to dig deeper into every guest.

“Very well.”

We needed to exchange information, little by little. I took the documents with me as I left the room to meet with Vest and Stale.

“Excuse me, Seneschal Vest?” a guard called out. “His Royal Highness has sent the next batch of documents.”

Guards and knights fortified the seneschal’s office, just as they had Albert’s. They opened the door for me once they got permission from inside. Three people were within: Vest was jotting things down at his desk, Prince Stale was flipping through papers, and one other guest sat in a chair beside them...

When I entered, the latter occupant whipped his head toward me. “Oh! Greetings, Prime Minister.”

My wide eyes locked on him. “Prince Cedric...what brings you here?”

Though I tried to hide my shock, my expression betrayed me. I even forgot to hand over the bundle of documents I'd carried here. The prince's golden hair looked drier than usual, but it was still bright enough to make me squint after staying up all night.

Before Prince Cedric could speak again, Prince Stale told him, "Pay him no mind."

The Cercian prince complied and quietly recited numbers out loud. He was already into the triple digits, by the sound of it. I cocked my head, silently requesting an explanation from Prince Stale.

"I called him here," Prince Stale explained. "I knew it was rude to summon him so early in the morning, but we needed Prince Cedric's assistance, and His Highness very kindly informed us he was eager to help. In exchange, we've granted the kings from Hanazuo permission to visit Elder Sister."

His tone was steady, and at a glance, he seemed composed, but I noticed the intensity of his gaze had sharpened compared to the last time I'd come here to deliver paperwork.

"What exactly is he helping with?"

"Prince Cedric tells us he memorized every guest in the ballroom the moment Elder Sister collapsed, so we're comparing his count to the number of guests."

"Every guest?!" I couldn't believe my ears.

Prince Stale granted Prince Cedric permission to speak, so he explained that when he raced to Pride's side, he got a good look at the ballroom from the stage. Even then, I was openly appalled that

he'd counted every last guest at a glance. Vest nodded in sympathy, probably confused to see me so unusually taken aback. When I listened closer, Prince Cedric was still counting up and up.

The prince really *was* counting the guests from memory. It was like the royal prince of the United Hanazuo Kingdom had a special power of his own.

Both Prince Stale and I knew that Arthur couldn't heal Pride. That narrowed down the cause to something other than an illness—hence our focus on potential culprits. I handed the documents to Vest before shooting another look at Prince Stale and Prince Cedric.

While Prince Cedric continued to recite numbers, Prince Stale flipped through each page of the guest list to confirm the total number of people who had actually come to the castle. Royals and nobles sometimes skipped out on big events despite RSVPing, or changed how many people were accompanying them, so the two princes sought to nail down that discrepancy.

"The doctors haven't come to us with any good news yet, which means they don't know the cause," Prince Stale said. "But we have no intention of resting until Elder Sister wakes up or we find a lead. I swear it."

It was nearly a vow. Vest would usually scold Prince Stale for making such a promise, but this time, he kept quiet. The prince radiated tenacity, a dark aura coiling around him.

I knew better than to say anything about it. I took the next batch of papers, the ones Vest had finished looking into, and bowed before departing the room.

LEON

"P RIDE...I'm coming in."

I entered the room with hesitant footsteps. Tiara waited inside with the kings from the United Hanazuo Kingdom—who chose to stand instead of taking the chairs they were offered—and a large crowd of palace staff and guards. A dreary mood hung over the room, and the faint light pouring in through the curtains cast a gentle glow.

Although I said hello to each occupant, my eyes never left the woman slumbering in bed. I picked a spot next to the kings, not letting myself get any closer to Pride. Tiara and Arthur occupied her bedside. If I got as close as them, the shock I'd bottled up during my journey here from Anemone would explode all at once.

Tiara turned my way ever so slightly. "Oh, Prince Leon..."

I waved at her, but my smile fell short of its usual charm. At the pitiful expression on my face, tears sprang to her eyes. Arthur gave me a look as well. He started to rise, just as he probably had when the kings arrived, but Tiara grabbed his arm and stopped him.

"Big Brother left Arthur in charge of us while he's away," Tiara explained, and no one disagreed with that arrangement.

"Princess Pride still hasn't woken up?" I asked.

The doctors and maids confirmed my suspicions. Mary and Lotte, Pride's personal maids, were particularly pale. I'd never seen them with such heavy, grim expressions. I almost didn't recognize them as the two women who were always smiling happily beside Pride.

The doctors said they didn't know the cause of Pride's ailment or if it was even a rare disease at all. I clutched at my chest, trying to catch my breath, and cast my eyes toward the kings from Hanazuo.

King Yohan was squeezing the cross at his chest, praying with his eyes shut. His features, as beautiful and androgynous as my own, were twisted with pain, revealing his despair even though I couldn't see his eyes. King Lance wasn't any better off. I'd never seen the king without a happy-go-lucky smile, but today deep wrinkles creased his brow and his lips were pressed in a hard line, his entire body tense. His clenched fists shook at his sides.

Pain twisted through my chest to see the kings in such a state. Suddenly, I realized Cedric was missing. I asked after him, and the kings said he was assisting Stale. I racked my brain. What could Stale need Cedric for that didn't involve his companions? I'd come to understand Cedric a little better during our sea voyage, but I still struggled to figure out why Stale had requested him so urgently.

Puzzling it out left me a bit calmer. I finally took a proper look at Pride's face, and a surge of emotions struck me all at once. I squeezed my fists to bear the pain, just like King Lance, and held my breath—determined to face reality. I locked my knees to keep from rushing to her bedside.

I felt the blood drain from my face. With her eyes closed, Pride looked like a doll...or perhaps a corpse.

Why did this have to happen to her?

Anger and despair swirled through my body, but I had no outlet for it. Had she fallen ill, or did someone do this to her? Knowing the

answer would give me *some* sort of motivation, but even that was apparently too much to ask of the world.

Having given away the right to be closer to her, I couldn't let myself touch her or say anything now. I would stay in the same position as the kings, as Pride's sworn friend and nothing more.

All I could do now was pray she would open her eyes as soon as possible.

STALE

“WHAT DOES this mean?!”

About an hour after Gilbert arrived with that batch of documents, Cedric gripped his hair and let out that shout.

Struggling to keep my composure, I groped for the right words. “It seems that there were two fewer people in attendance than there should have been, according to your memory.”

I'd made him count from memory without telling him the official attendance number, waiting patiently to see what number Cedric would come up with. It turned out there were two fewer guests than I had any record of. I made Cedric repeat the process to be sure, but the result was the same.

We'd temporarily sealed off all the doors and windows after Pride collapsed. I'd pressed the guards in charge of keeping the perimeter safe, and they'd assured me no one had left the ballroom during that time, not even to use the restroom. No one had returned from outside the ballroom either. But somehow, two people were missing from Cedric's count.

Cedric had scanned the crowd as he ran to Pride's side. From up on the stage, he could see everyone. That made me wonder if two people could have fainted from shock or fallen to the floor in fear, but neither Uncle Vest nor Father had heard of anything like that.

That brought me to a grim conclusion: Two guests had taken advantage of the chaos to hide for some reason. There was one *additional* possibility, but I clenched my jaw and pushed up my glasses when it occurred to me. I gripped the guest list, racking my brain to figure out who those two suspects could be.

This information made it much more likely that Pride's collapse had been triggered on purpose. If Cedric's memory was correct, the ballroom perimeter had been secure, and the final head count of guests was accurate, we had little else to point to. Some of the overnight guests were still here, but the culprit could have fled the night before. Maybe they were on the run right now. If that was the case, we had to narrow down a suspect quickly so we could get them on the wanted list.

I fought down my rising panic and focused on Cedric, my last hope for solving this. "Prince Cedric, I'm sorry to ask, but is there any way you can identify those two people?"

As I tried to keep my emotions in check, Cedric shook his head. Defeated as I felt, I couldn't blame him. Of course he couldn't do something like that. Memorizing the number of guests was practically magic on its own. If he could single out *who* was missing, he would be like a god.

"There were a lot of people our country had never met before!" Cedric burst out. "Maybe I'd recognize them if we'd been introduced before, but I can't match the strangers' faces to their names alone... Forgive me!"

Cedric burned with shame, but Uncle Vest and I perked up at that. *Could it be...?* We exchanged glances.

This time, he was the one to question the prince. "Pardon me, Prince Cedric, but does that mean you remember all their faces and appearances, even if you don't know their names?"

"I do. If I had any talent for art, I could give you perfectly accurate drawings. Not that I've ever tried before."

My heart threatened to leap out of my chest. *That can't be!* My mouth fell open as I grappled with what to do. We could summon a skilled artist, but it would take too much time to sketch every last guest from such a massive party. Uncle Vest and I knew the names and faces of everyone we'd met at least once—just not the extra details, like what they were wearing. I'd also met many people for the very first time that night, as Pride had. Though I had said hello to most of them, there were some people I hadn't spoken to at all.

There was *one* such person, however—someone who attended every ceremony, exchanged greetings with every guest, and memorized all of their unique traits and changes.

Uncle Vest and I shouted for the guards outside the room simultaneously.

"Summon Prime Minister Gilbert!"

"Bring Gilbert here at once!"

ADAM

"**H**A HA HA! Aaaaah, this monstrous country is nothing but fools after all, isn't it?"

I reclined on the guest sofa, propping my feet up on the table with a laugh. My thin, fox-like eyes bulged with excitement, and the corners of my lips curled with mirth. My chief of staff and generals stood out in the hallway alongside the knights Freesia had dispatched to protect me—a courtesy for me, crown prince of the Rajah Empire. I kept my mockery hushed so those *vigilant* and *dutiful* knights would not overhear me.

I'd polished off two bottles of wine since last night. Now it was morning, yet I poured myself another glass. I'd intended to leave along with the rest of the guests, but none of them had even called for their carriages yet. I couldn't return to my country early without drawing suspicion, so I had no choice but to stay in this room until the other guests finally departed. I'd have to pretend I was so concerned about the firstborn princess that I wouldn't even think of leaving. In reality, I couldn't care less about her condition—if she never woke up, I'd consider it a boon.

I savored the celebratory wine between bouts of laughter, barely resisting the urge to muss my slicked-back, dark-purple hair.

My plan was working well. When Pride let out those first screams, it took everything in my power to contain my laughter. I played the part of a dramatically dismayed guest as they carried her

out of the party, being careful not to smirk when the knights and guards questioned me.

This was the first time they'd allowed me to attend a Freesian ceremony. My country had a peace treaty with Freesia, but not an alliance, so I was only invited to the largest, most special events. I'd invited Freesians to my own country on several occasions, but they always claimed they were too busy.

"We can host you on this day."

"We'd love to have you attend our party on this date."

Despite us dishing out so many invitations, the Freesians always had some utterly important plans on those days. I came to believe someone close to me may have been leaking information to them so they could avoid me. Thus, I'd cracked down on my aides with threats, violence, and even torture—half to relieve my own anger, and half to amuse myself. Even with all that, I didn't find a single lead.

"And then that last prince's birthday took place on the same date as the Chinensian king's..."

Hanging my head, I sighed in disgust. I spit on the floor and rubbed it in with my shoe. Freesia's peaceful partners weren't previously invited to simple birthday parties, only to "special occasions."

Normally, I would have jumped at the opportunity when I received an invitation at last, but I had to confirm something first. Servants working for me in other lands had reported that the previously bedridden Cercian king was making appearances before his

people—and that he planned to attend the Chinensian king's birthday party!

It was impossible. Utterly unthinkable! But I had to see it with my own eyes.

Once I infiltrated Cercis, I swiftly found the king alive and well. I couldn't believe it. While I considered killing him right then and there, Rajah would be the obvious suspect if King Lance was murdered at a time like this. I considered killing King Yohan instead, but Freesia's representatives were set to attend his birthday party. They might ramp up security if they saw him die, and that would complicate my future plans. I even thought about targeting the Freesian firstborn princess, who attended as a guest, but unfortunately, that didn't go according to plan.

Prince Stale's birthday happened a few days later, which I also couldn't attend, following that string of failures. My anger had reached its limit—but that was when an opportunity finally arose.

It was the second-born princess's sixteenth birthday.

"Ugh, these people throw their weird parties just because one of the princesses became an old hag? Seriously, a dance party?! How stupid. Don't tell me they're that desperate to get it on with the men? Revolting!"

I snickered, but my lone attendant didn't respond to my tirade. He stood in a corner of the room like a piece of furniture, dressed in an outfit that made him look like a noble.

"Aaah, I just want to go home already. That princess won't be waking up either way. For a minute, I thought she was so weak that

she croaked right there on the spot, but I guess she's hanging on. Oh well. All the better for me."

Without bothering to take my shoes off, I moved to the bed. Gripping my wine glass, I stretched out my legs.

"She was soooo boring! I wanted to see her freak out more and really convulse, but then she went and passed out. I guess it was too much for a puny little princess."

I kicked in frustration, dirtying the bed with my shoes. Once I'd had enough, I snickered and sipped more wine, a bit of the drink spilling from the corner of my smile.

"I bet they're running around looking for the culprit about now. Or maybe they're calling all their doctors? What a bunch of morons."

Quietly, I sneered at the knights outside my door. Despite my criticism of the heavy guard and my inadvertent captivity, I couldn't be happier to have sent all those Freesians into such a panic.

"You're all a bunch of monsters who think your country's special. You'll never figure out what happened to her, much less trace it back to me."

I snorted and downed the rest of my wine, let out an undignified burp, and dropped the empty glass to the floor. I'd grown bored of drinking, so I yawned and rolled over.

"Should I leave things be for a month...no, maybe three? I wanna come pay my respects to the princess when she's down to skin and bones. I wonder how much I can wring out of them when there's no hope left for her."

I covered my mouth with both hands to keep my laughter in check as I pictured the skinny, haggard princess, as well as the despair on the queen's face when she realized she had no choice but to give in to my demands. Would Freesia institute slavery themselves, or would they send their people away to work as slaves? Taking the second-born princess as a fiancée was a trivial component of the plot, but it would all be for nothing if I *didn't* marry her after the firstborn princess died.

"I just don't get why that idiot king is back."

I couldn't contain my one genuine disappointment. No one had ever managed to recover the way that king had. Every last victim withered away until they died with very, very few exceptions. They either died fast with some meat on them or slow as they withered to a pathetic husk of skin and bones. Since the king had managed to recover, perhaps it was Cercis I had to be most wary of.

Heaving a sigh, I offered my most heartfelt desire to the air. "Can't I just go home already?"

Accompanied by only a single servant doing everything possible to avoid my eyes, there was no one around to clean up the room I'd trashed beyond recognition.

GILBERT

"SO THAT'S IT, hmm?"

After Stale and Vest summoned me back to Vest's office, where I'd dropped off those documents, they explained the situation. I nodded along, a hand on my chin.

I'd sprinted out of my office the moment the flustered guards summoned me, only to be met with a development far greater than I could have imagined. We suddenly had an incredibly helpful lead, even if we didn't have any physical proof of a crime yet.

I glanced at Prince Cedric, who seemed perplexed, and realized not even the prince himself understood how abnormal his gifts were. It was ridiculous enough that he could memorize all the guests in the ballroom at a glance, but capturing their appearances and outfits on top of that was unthinkable. As prime minister, I'd need to reevaluate him in light of this extraordinary development.

Prince Cedric was the second-born prince—now the royal prince, with his brother as king—of the United Hanazuo Kingdom. He was also slated to become the postmaster general of the international postal service. Once I'd learned of his outstanding exam results, I realized Pride had scouted yet another person of incomparable talent. I'd mistaken Prince Cedric for a fool during his initial stay in Freesia, but my opinion changed in light of this.

"Prince Cedric," I said, "when I ask you about someone, would you please describe their appearance? They'll be people you've already met, of course."

I needed to confirm the accuracy of Cedric's memory to avoid making false accusations. When the test began, I asked him about royals who attended every ceremony, princes who changed their attire for the occasion, young noblewomen wearing a different color of lipstick than usual, and I even threw in a few trick questions. Cedric described every last guest without fail.

It stunned me to find someone who memorized even more details than I did in my capacity as prime minister. Vest and Stale were equally surprised. They remembered unique conversations, but certainly not the colors of the women's lipstick. Even the colors of their *dresses* were hazy memories for us. While my memory was better than the average person's, even I couldn't contain my shock at Cedric's uncanny perfect recall.

"Your memory is most impressive," I admitted once we were finished. I had to take a deep breath to steady myself. "In that case..."

I turned to Stale and asked if I could borrow the guest list and a pen. Stale complied; it was one of the few times he did so without complaint when it came to me. He looked straight into my eyes, and we traded nods before I returned my focus to Cedric.

"To start, I'd ask that you list everyone who was present when Princess Pride collapsed, beginning with every guest whose name you know."

Cedric readily agreed to the task, drawing a smile from me as he did. He recoiled slightly at the sight.

"Thank you very much, Your Highness."

I reviewed whose names were on which pages, preparing to check them off, and asked Cedric to begin. The prince, still a bit frightened by the looks of it, listed every last person he could remember. Vest and Stale set down their work, watching avidly as I checked off names one by one. Despite the palpable tension in the air, I smirked. The more names Cedric recited, the closer we drew to an answer.

We're finally going to have a lead.

I alone seemed to have total confidence in both my and Cedric's memories. My smile only grew. Once he finished listing names, we moved on to describing the appearances and characteristics of the guests I hadn't checked off. This would surely lead to someone we could question.

If we could just get the culprit to reveal how they did it, we'd be able to do something about Pride's condition. If it was poison, there had to be an antidote. If the assailant was a Freesian guest—someone using their special power—we could capture them and make them deactivate the power.

I snapped out of my fantasies and asked the prince to pause. Then I told the maids outside to bring Prince Cedric tea to soothe his throat. Right now, he was our only link to the culprit and the truth behind Pride's slumber. We couldn't abuse him for information, as eager as we were for answers.

Prince Cedric resumed reciting names, and the maids arrived with four cups of tea about halfway through. I passed the prince a cup, as if I'd calculated the exact moment his throat would dry out. Prince Cedric accepted the cup readily before returning to his work. Then, at long last, he reached the end.

We'd narrowed down the list to the double digits, including guests who had escorted invitees. I flipped through the pages and smiled. Stale grinned as well, though he tried to hide the expression from Vest. We were on the verge of pinning down the culprit, and once we had that, the rest would be simple.

Freesia had methods of making people talk—methods more *forceful* than simple questionings. Stale grinned wickedly, as though imagining the ways the culprit would scream and cry as we coaxed the information out of them.

As if in answer to the glint in Stale's eyes, I began, "In that case..."

My respect and gratitude for the royal prince of Cercis and that extraordinary memory of his welled up within me. At the same time, rage burned through my chest at the suspect we were narrowing in on.

"I shall now describe to you the appearances and characteristics of the remaining guests on this list."

HARRISON

"**C**HANGE...shifts?"

Vice Commander Clark Darwin had summoned me in the middle of my training. Other knights guarded the training grounds, but most patrolled the castle. I had only just begun wondering if I should head to my assigned post when the summons arrived.

"That's right, Harrison. Go take over as Princess Pride's imperial knight. I don't care who you swap with. No one has taken a break since it happened."

Fatigue left deep shadows on the vice commander's face. It wasn't a matter of stamina; he feared for the firstborn princess's condition.

Last night, the royal order had received urgent instructions to dispatch knights. Word arrived that Princess Pride Royal Ivy may have been the target of an assassin after she suddenly collapsed. I was the one knight who drew attention to myself, as an aura of pure murder suffused my body. Every knight had gotten a pressing castle assignment to guard the royal family or the guests.

"As you wish."

After meeting with the vice commander, I headed to the royal residence. We hadn't received word of Her Highness recovering or showing any signs of improvement, so I assumed she had yet to open her eyes. Everyone wondered if it was an illness, a poison, or maybe even a special power, but no one offered any confirmation. We could act if we knew the cause or at least determined the attack was intentional. If there *was* a culprit behind her collapse...

"I won't go easy on them."

It was a grave crime to harm the firstborn princess, send the commander and vice commander into action, and attempt to rob my captain of his leader. Spilling our enemy's blood wouldn't be enough. I would use every last skill at my disposal to make the suspects talk. With permission, I'd gladly line them up and interrogate them—even the nobles and royals.

As I walked, I spotted a group of carriages coming and going from the grounds of the royal residence. I knew a long line of carriages waited outside the gates, but activity at the royal residence could only mean guests from faraway countries had stayed here overnight. Perhaps if they were leaving, Her Highness had opened her

eyes. If they knew she was safe, they would feel okay going home...or so I assumed.

I quickly learned I was wrong.

"We'll pray for Princess Pride's safe recovery."

"We hate to leave at a time like this..."

"Please send our well-wishes to Her Majesty as well."

They left these words with the guards as they departed. The royal family were too busy to bid the guests farewell, hence their leaving the task to the guards. These guests must've been heading home due to other circumstances that required their attention. Though they had stayed much longer than usual, they couldn't remain in the castle forever, waiting for Her Highness's condition to change.

We don't know when that might happen.

I passed the departing carriages, wondering if any of them contained the culprits. If they did, I would chase them down, jump on the carriage, knock their horses down, and take the scum into custody myself. All the passing carriages started to feel like suspects fleeing the scene, and my murderous impulses multiplied.

Problem was, we still didn't know if someone had intentionally triggered Her Highness's episode. The knights wouldn't let me question anyone, but if the culprit really was inside one of those carriages, I would chase them down until my legs gave out.

I entered the palace, heading for Her Highness's room. I exchanged terse greetings with the other knights and guards along my path, until I came to the staircase landing with a large mirror. It

reflected a useless knight who could only sit back and wait for someone else to do something. I stopped and stared at myself...then covered one of my eyes with my hand.

"You're right. It's an honor to have the same color eyes as you, Vice Captain Harrison. Although...yours are much more beautiful."

Princess Pride Royal Ivy had looked me straight in the eye and said that without hesitation. My heart had skipped a beat at those words from the firstborn princess. I never realized we shared an eye color before that moment. I didn't care about my own appearance whatsoever—but since then, I'd at least felt proud of that.

In the mirror, Her Highness stared back at me through my own eyes. I couldn't help but think of her, my beloved leader. I would do anything for her. These eyes she praised, the same color as hers, would watch over this country she ruled.

Breaking eye contact with the mirror, I hurried toward my destination. As soon as I started moving again, urgency tugged me down the hallway to the room where she lay. I couldn't possibly lose her now.

I would not go easy on the culprit. For the sake of the vice commander, the commander, my captain, and the Freesian people...I wouldn't go easy on *myself* either.

A crowd of knights and guards clustered outside her door, the air around them heavy with melancholy. I knocked, stated my business, and waited for permission to enter.

Whether Her Highness was a victim of a crime or something else entirely, the truth would come to light—no matter what. Countless

people other than myself were seething with rage, desperate to save her.

A guard let me into the room. I instantly spotted Her Highness asleep in bed. Princess Tiara Royal Ivy sat at her side...along with Arthur Beresford.

A dagger pierced my heart, and a rage I'd never felt swelled inside me. I scowled at the three imperial knights against the wall, and once Arthur finally regarded me, I delivered their orders.

"It's time for a shift change," I said. "I don't care who, but someone needs to switch with me."

Someone had put Her Highness in critical danger. Someone had put that look in Arthur Beresford's eyes.

Whoever it was, I would show them no mercy.

THE TUTOR

THIRTEEN YEARS earlier...

"P-please stop! Please stop, please stop, please stop... Aaaaah!"

Sobs and laughter filled the room. A young boy cackled with delight as he brought a whip down. Another child cried out in pain, his screams echoing off the dungeon walls.

"Ha ha ha! What an idiot! You really think I'm gonna stop?! C'mon, now! If you really hate it..."

Snap! Crack! The slap of the whip rang out. The *thing* tied up in chains, somewhat resembling a human, screamed and begged for mercy with each lash. The boy kicked him in his empty stomach,

howling with laughter when his victim vomited. As the boy's tutor, I stood by in silence.

"Tell me! Tell me, tell me, tell me, tell me! If you can't do it, then get on the floor and beg! Ha ha ha ha ha ha!"

The boy's high-pitched cackling penetrated every corner of the dungeon. This was his daily routine. He enjoyed our "lessons," whipping and kicking his slaves until they ran out of tears. It cemented his position in everyone's minds.

"Did I say you could lift your head? Answer me! I'll kill you if you defy me!"

I quietly exited the cell while my charge indulged in his task. The boy's father would set aside his work to observe his son's lessons and note his progress soon.

I don't think he has any real talents.

I kept that thought to myself. Failing to notice I'd left the cell, the boy continued to amuse himself, completely lost in the act of torturing his victim. He'd already killed a number of slaves before managing to break them, but anyone could kill a person in chains. There was no point to the torture if he couldn't crack their minds.

The boy was the emperor's firstborn son out of thirteen children, but no one expected great things from the crown prince. Many of the emperor's children had been born around the same time; he just happened to be first. Everyone in the imperial family possessed sadistic and savage personalities, so that alone wasn't enough to warrant the throne. The slightly younger princes were much more well

rounded too. I sighed, but the death throes of the victim in the cell instantly drowned out the sound.

I flinched as the final screams spiked, then glanced back into the cell—not making an effort to intervene. Had the boy done it again? My shoulders slumped. I addressed him with exasperation.

“Prince Adam...if you overdo it, this one will die before you can break him.”

ADAM

“OH, LOOK AT THAT. They’re finally starting to leave. God, they’re all so slow.”

I chuckled at the window as I watched the carriages pull away from the castle. I stretched, pleased that I could blend in with them and return to Rajah soon.

“Why do they care so much about some stupid princess? It’s not like they don’t have a spare one sitting around. What a bunch of idiots.”

I opened one last bottle of wine. I wanted to enjoy another glass before the room got all crowded, when the servants came to pack up on my orders.

“I can’t wait to come back. I’ll make it three months...no, half a year from now. Or will she already be dead by then?”

I addressed the question to the person who had attended the party with me. He didn’t respond, yet my smile grew. I sipped my wine, gazing at the helpless knights and guards standing around and watching the carriages leave.

Knock, knock.

I cocked my head at the sound. I hadn't called my servants inside yet. Was someone from Freesia here to shoo me out of the castle? Or had the knights and guards in the hallway overheard me talking to myself?

Whatever the case, I scrunched up my face in irritation and called out to the person at the door. When they responded, they didn't sound like one of my subordinates—but the voice *was* strangely familiar.

"Forgive the disturbance, Prince Adam. This is Gilbert Butler, the prime minister of Freesia."

Gilbert. I remembered that name. He was the meddlesome prime minister I'd met one year earlier.

"Do you have a moment to speak?" he asked.

Sweeping a glance around the room, I calmly told him I did. But first, I ordered the person who'd attended the party with me to cover up or brush away anything that would shock our visitor. Then I sat back against the sofa and told the guards to open the door, revealing the man with the light blue hair and long, narrow eyes.

And he'd brought someone with him.

"It's a pleasure to make your acquaintance, Your Highness. I am Stale Royal Ivy, firstborn prince of Freesia."

Words died on my tongue. I smiled faintly, but my eyes narrowed. What was the firstborn prince doing here? While he and the prime minister were smiling, their polite behavior only put me on

higher alert. I offered a formal greeting, my own smile threatening to falter. The prime minister and prince always made me uneasy in a way that the Freesian queen never did, though I couldn't pinpoint why.

"Considering you're the representative of a nation that has established peace with ours, we've come to you with a request," Prince Stale said with a gracious bow.

When next he spoke, it sounded like anything but a request.

"May we ask that you remain in the castle?" he asked, voice so sharp and low that it pierced me like a dagger. "We'd like to discuss the events of last night with you."

For a brief moment, the intensity of Stale's aura overwhelmed me, leaving me both exhilarated and trembling with rage. I smiled politely yet unpleasantly, careful to avoid further suspicion.

"Why don't we move somewhere else?" I suggested, regretting that I hadn't ordered my servants to pack up and get us home much sooner.

How the hell did they trace it back to me?

With that question buzzing in my mind, I fought back the urge to kill every last person in this room.

CEDRIC

"THE RAJAH Empire?!"

Waves of shock pulsed through the room. Stale, Seneschal Vest, Prime Minister Gilbert, and I had just narrowed down the two missing guests from the party with the help of my perfect memory.

"It was them?!" we cried out.

Anger sent my thoughts racing. In my heart, I knew it *had* to be Rajah. Everyone else looked like they were struggling just as much as I was, resisting the urge to have the knights apprehend the suspects at once. Frankly, I was tempted to do the same even though they weren't my knights to command.

The Rajah Empire was a great nation that had established a peace treaty with Freesia only a year ago. The empire had expanded rapidly due to their slave trade and colonization of other countries. In fact, they relied on both those practices much more heavily than any other nation in the world. They had once sought an alliance with Freesia and tried to force them to implement slavery as well.

Seneschal Vest and Prime Minister Gilbert wore grim expressions, proving they knew well the threat Rajah posed. As the suspected mastermind behind the invasion of the United Hanazuo Kingdom, the empire had left deep scars in my and Stale's memories as well, since we'd participated in the defensive war ourselves.

Of course he knows what they're like.

Stale glanced at me, assessing my reaction to the news.

Tiara's birthday was the very first Freesian event that the Rajah Empire had attended, but they still had a connection to Hanazuo as well. Officially, Rajah said the kingdom of Copelandii, one of their colonies, had recklessly invaded Hanazuo on their own. Lance, Yohan, and I weren't foolish enough to believe such a ridiculous claim.

Furthermore, the guests from Rajah had gotten here long before we did, as we'd arrived a bit later in the evening. Despite spending so

much time at the party, however, they had only formally greeted Queen Rosa and Tiara, the birthday girl. That would make sense if they intended to stand out as little as possible in the moments leading up to the crime. I'd heard Queen Rosa had also warned Stale, Tiara, and Pride long before the party to be wary of Rajah.

"Rajah!" I snarled. "Is it really them *again*?! But this time, they're after Pride!"

My hands shook with fury. I was only just learning that I'd stood in that ballroom alongside Rajah's representatives. If only I'd known; I would've watched them! My anger flared as I imagined it. They'd threatened my homeland, and now they were suspected of harming Pride. I had all the justification I could need to despise them.

"Prince Cedric...I recall King Lance falling victim to a sudden illness just before the defensive war," Prime Minister Gilbert said. "Can you recall what symptoms he exhibited?"

The blood drained from my face. I'd never once doubted the sincerity of Lance's bout of madness, but now I had to consider someone had *done* that to my brother.

"No! Was that another...?!" I floundered for words, too overwhelmed to sort through my whirling thoughts.

Stale stepped in to get me in check. "That all depends on if your brother's symptoms are anything like my elder sister's. When His Majesty fell ill, did he go completely still, as if he was merely unconscious?"

I'd already told Stale about Lance's condition, but I caught my breath and dredged up the memories. "No, it wasn't like that," I said,

shaking my head.

I would have recognized Pride's condition if she showed the same symptoms as Lance did. I hadn't seen Pride since they took her to her room, but according to Stale, she wasn't showing any changes whatsoever. Whatever was affecting her, it was very different from Lance's former madness.

I explained that the servants and guards who witnessed Lance's breakdown described it similarly to Pride's shrieking fit. The room went deathly silent at that.

It was Seneschal Vest who broke the tension. "I believe the guests from Rajah are still in the castle."

Stale and the prime minister lifted their heads at the same time, their eyes darting toward the clock. In normal circumstances, most guests would have long since departed, but we remained in the castle this time out of concern for Pride's well-being.

"They won't be here much longer," the seneschal went on. "I received word that the guests are already preparing to return to their countries."

"Then let's have the knights take them into custody at once!" Stale said, eyes glinting.

He took off toward the door, eager to order the knights outside to keep Rajah's guests in the castle.

"Wait." Seneschal Vest's command stopped Stale just before he put his hand on the doorknob. The seneschal's voice remained calm despite the prince's urgency.

Stale forced himself to a halt and turned with visible effort.

Rajah took a full month to reach by carriage. If they slipped away now, it would take the Freesians ages to apprehend them. The prince looked like he was fighting down panic as he regarded the seneschal.

"We don't have physical proof of anything, Stale. We're basing this all on memories, and it's still possible Pride has simply fallen ill. This is the imperial family of a nation we've formed a peace treaty with. If we arrest them without due process, the fallout will be a lot worse than a fractured relationship." The seneschal shot a look in my direction. "They may even turn their ire on our allies."

His meaning was clear: My kingdom's alliance with Freesia kept us safe, partly because Freesia had established peace with Rajah. If that peace shattered, Rajah could invade Hanazuo themselves this time. I grimaced at the implications. After everything that had happened, my homeland might be a burden to Freesia in this instance.

The prime minister seemed to agree. They knew Pride wasn't simply ill, and he'd believed in my recall when I described all the guests at the party. I also doubted he would assume I was just trying to frame Rajah because of our history. Still, it was true that right now the only proof we had to work with was my memory. That wasn't enough to arrest the imperial prince—especially since his country had a peace treaty with Freesia.

If we acted too hastily, other countries might even believe Freesia and Hanazuo were working *together* to frame Rajah. That

made our next move all the more vital.

"We're not going to arrest them," Seneschal Vest declared. "Let's 'welcome' them instead."

His deep voice resonated through the office, his years of experience as the seneschal coming to bear. *This is a lesson*, I realized as he pointed at the doorknob where Stale's hand rested. He glanced from the prime minister to the prince. "Gilbert. Stale."

When they faced him, he delivered their orders.

"I want the two of you to keep Prince Adam here. I'll use any time you buy us to explain these developments to Her Majesty and His Royal Highness and get their permission to extend his stay. No matter what you do, don't let him get away."

Seneschal Vest's deep tone wasn't meant to scold Stale. He was fuming like the rest of us, his fierce determination clear as day in his delivery. This was the official directive from the seneschal, an honorable man whose power was equal to that of the prince consort and who always valued the rules.

Prime Minister Gilbert quickly lined up next to Stale and bowed to the seneschal. "Leave it to us," they said in tandem. Exchanging a glance, they raced out of the room.

As their footsteps thundered down the hallway, Seneschal Vest sighed. "Prince Cedric, I can't thank you enough for your help. Allow me to apologize for Prime Minister Gilbert and Prince Stale, who left without offering you their gratitude."

I knew the prime minister in particular wasn't the sort to abandon his manners, but he and Stale had fled the office without so much as a goodbye after our collective efforts. Seneschal Vest furrowed his brow, clearly worried they'd lost their cool. They'd seemed composed when we discovered Rajah was our suspect, but perhaps they would have stewed in their violent auras if they hadn't left the office. Or maybe they deserved praise for remaining calm all the way up until they realized the culprits had an opportunity to flee.

The seneschal sighed again, likely just as perplexed by their own prime minister losing sight of his manners.

"No, that's all right," I said quickly, bowing my head low. "It's an honor to be of any help at all. I'm incredibly grateful that Prince Stale sought me out personally."

Seneschal Vest nodded. I'd met him after being selected as the postmaster general, and I hoped my performance today earned me a little favor with him. "Please go and visit Pride now. But keep what we discussed here a secret."

I thanked him for his kindness, and we exited the office together. I assumed he intended to report to the queen and prince consort. We exchanged one last handshake outside the door.

"Stale still has much to learn about becoming a seneschal," he said. "I sincerely apologize for his disrespect."

My face heated. I wasn't expecting another apology just as we prepared to go our separate ways. Running out of the room without addressing the person you brought there was rude, sure, but I'd

already been so horribly rude to Pride in the past that this felt trivial in comparison.

"I do sincerely hope you won't scold them for this." I bowed deeply to hide my red face. The seneschal would be enraged if he learned even a fraction of the ways I'd disrespected Pride.

With my head lowered, I realized I'd become indebted to yet another great person.

STALE

"YOU ASK FOR MY ACCOUNT, but the events of last night came as just as much of a shock to me as to anyone else."

It took everything in my power not to attack the smirking crown prince.

"We apologize," Gilbert said.

But *I* wanted to grab this man and slam his face into the ground. My stomach boiled like lava as I struggled to maintain a cordial smile. I wanted to rip that smirk right off Prince Adam's face and see what lurked underneath.

Prince Adam had wrinkled his brow when Gilbert and I showed up, but he'd quickly agreed to speak with us, suggesting we use another room instead of his. That brought us to a nearby parlor. I'd wanted to question the people traveling with him too, but Prince Adam said they were in no state to see anyone. Instead, we ordered the knights to guard them in Prince Adam's room—a pretense to keep them under surveillance.

Rajah's crown prince sank onto the sofa, leaving his chief of staff and generals to wait outside the room. He crossed his legs, placing his hands on his knee. "I never expected to see Princess Pride in such a dreadful state. It was quite upsetting."

His fox-like eyes narrowed. Despite his claims, he smiled easily. The contradiction only solidified my conviction that he was our culprit.

"I see. Prince Adam...where were you when Princess Pride fell ill?" Gilbert asked.

"I was in the ballroom, of course. I stayed in the very back, away from the others. I wanted a clear view of Princess Pride, if only from a distance."

Oh, really? I opened my eyes wide in feigned surprise. *Now that I think about it, that's a good excuse to explain why so many people might not have seen him, but no one's memory is as reliable as Prince Cedric's and Gilbert's. Ah well.*

We hadn't come here to accuse him of anything—not yet, at least. I reminded myself of that as Gilbert took over the conversation.

"So you were. The other guests did inform us that they hardly saw you for the duration of the party. In fact..."

Gilbert paused and smiled at me, as if seeking my approval. His eyes blazed in a way that defied his otherwise composed expression. Even though we hadn't planned this, I nodded, grasping his intentions.

"That includes the guests who were extremely eager to meet you. So eager, in fact, that they searched *every last corner* of the

ballroom. They told us there was no trace of you anywhere.”

Prince Adam’s lips twitched. We had no proof of his involvement, but the prince had no proof of his claims either.

“Oh dear, it seems I was rude.” His smile lacked any trace of warmth. He stared at us, that phony expression plastered on his face.

“As a country who recently established peace with yours, we insisted you would never do such a thing intentionally, Prince Adam.”

“And it was such a large crowd,” I chimed in. “It’s not surprising they couldn’t find you. After all, many of our allies have never laid eyes on you.”

I kept my gaze locked on Prince—no, on *Adam*, to ensure I didn’t miss the slightest change in his expression. He squinted his eyes, then raised his hand toward his dark-purple hair—combed back on the right side—but stopped just before touching it.

“I’m glad you understand,” he said flatly.

Mustering up my best air of puzzlement, I lowered my voice. “However, there’s a slight problem.”

“What might that be?” he asked, casually uncrossing and recrossing his legs without leaning closer to me at all.

Determined to someday beat this pompous man into the ground, I said, “Our nation, as well as many of our guests’ countries, do not recognize slavery. Unfortunately, they struggle to understand our peace treaty with the Rajah Empire. And after what happened with Elder Sister...”

He picked up on my implications. “I see.”

Gilbert waited for the exact moment when the prince relaxed to add, "We'd like to ask that you extend your stay, preferably until Princess Pride awakens. If that isn't possible, then one week...no, three days will do."

Adam tapped his cheek, pretending to ponder Gilbert's proposal. "I'm quite busy, you see. But, well, if you insist..."

He was trying to fluster us, acting like he had the upper hand. It wasn't going to work. I swiftly followed up with another attack.

"We fear if you leave now, tensions will soar among these foreign countries. They'll believe Rajah was responsible for what happened to our crown princess, demand we break our peace treaty, and cut ties with the United Hanazuo Kingdom."

Adam's narrowed eyes finally widened. An ice-cold expression washed away his smirk. *Yes, that's it. That's the face I wanted to see.*

"We're not supposed to speak of that, Prince Stale," Gilbert chastised me quietly.

Adam weighed us with his eyes. "Who exactly are you referring to?"

I clasped one hand over my mouth, shook my head, and told him I couldn't share that information. "You have my apologies. Those guests shouted baseless accusations when Elder Sister collapsed, and I...repeated them without thinking."

"Prince Stale has always been grateful to you, Prince Adam. It's thanks to the Rajah Empire's assistance that we stopped Copelandii's recklessness last year."

"No, please, don't say that!" I said, playing up the shy act. "I'm too embarrassed."

The ruse worked; Adam let down his guard. "Oh my. I'm so honored."

Eyes fixed on him, I offered a lighthearted grin. "Once the others find out you've extended your stay out of concern for Princess Pride, they'll understand the nature of the peace treaty between our countries. We don't want to sour our international relations in the wake of her collapse and the investigation into the cause. Thus, we kindly ask for your help."

Here I was, bowing my head to the man who'd very likely caused Pride's suffering, but I didn't care. I'd do whatever it took to convince him I was a foolish, tactless prince. The more he felt he could manipulate me, the better.

"I see... If you truly insist, Prince Stale, then I'll comply. But I'm quite the busy man, so I won't be able to stay longer than three days."

Good, that's all we need.

I thanked him and shook his hand. "That's plenty."

Gilbert shook his hand next, but for some reason, Adam's eyes widened—like he was still on guard around the prime minister. Gilbert smiled, not seeming the slightest bit surprised by that.

"By the way, how is Princess Pride?" Adam asked.

"Just between us," I murmured, "she has yet to wake up, though the doctors are doing everything they can for her."

I let my true concern for Pride show on my face...and squashed the rage that rose up at his blatantly dishonest curiosity. Pushing down the anger, I looked to Gilbert so he could continue this conversation in my stead.

"She hasn't opened her eyes even once. We've never seen an illness like this in our country," Gilbert told him. "But what about you? Does the Rajah Empire know of any conditions that could explain her symptoms?"

Adam tapped his cheek in thought. "Let me think..." But just when it seemed like he might come up with something, he sneered at Gilbert. "I'll look into it as soon as I return. However, each leg of the trip lasts a full month, so it will take a little time."

There it is. Once I heard that, I thanked him again for his cooperation.

We walked Adam back to his room, but he asked for a new one, claiming the guest traveling with him had dirtied his current accommodations.

"Thanks for the help," he said, then shut the door behind him.

Our business done, Gilbert and I left the guest palace. Shortly thereafter, we entered a carriage bound for the royal residence, and silence settled between us.

It took a while before I could actually relax. I wiped my hand on Gilbert's pants, trying to remove the sensation of having touched that revolting prince. Gilbert merely offered a sad smile, grasping my

intentions. Slumping a little, he clapped his palms together as if they were dirty too.

"You did a good job staying composed back there," he said.

I looked away when he praised me, leaning my elbow on the windowsill and resting my head in my hand. "It was nothing. I'm doing this for her."

As we traveled, my disgust and anger toward Adam welled up anew. I scratched at my chin as heat built inside me. I gritted my teeth until my jaw ached and glared out the windows—when I felt a simmering rage besides my own. Turning, I found Gilbert staring in the opposite direction, cracking his knuckles. His lips twitched with each snap, light-blue eyes burning with rage.

"He acted as though he knew something, didn't he?" Gilbert said. "He seemed to think Princess Pride wouldn't awaken for more than a month. Perhaps that was the purpose of his words."

I hadn't heard such deep hatred in Gilbert's voice in a long time. His burning fury was palpable, and I tensed up. He was convinced that man had done something to Pride.

"I'll look into it as soon as I return. However, each leg of the trip lasts a full month, so it will take a little time."

Adam made it sound like he knew there would be a delay. Normally, he would have said something like *"I just hope I make it in time"* or *"I'd like to look into it, but our countries are very distant."*

There was no doubt in my mind: He knew what happened to Pride. He'd probably hinted at it because he planned on using Pride's

life as a bargaining chip. Would they ask us to change our position on the slave trade, implement it ourselves, or sell off our own people to other nations?

What a sick joke. Had he really done something so unthinkable to Pride for such a stupid reason? *And besides, a whole month?! He intends to leave her in that state for a month?!*

I won't forgive him, won't forgive him, won't forgive him, won't forgive him, won't forgive him, won't forgive him for as long as I live!

My nails bit into my palm as I clenched my fist. We'd tricked him into revealing something, but we were still relying on very weak evidence. I just hoped that the more tiny bits of proof we stacked up, the closer we would get to the truth.

I set my jaw so tightly that my teeth clacked, not that I could stop myself. *Pride is suffering because of that man! Her life is in danger at this very moment! Don't you dare tell me it will take a full month when even three days is far too long!*

No matter what it took, I was going to save Pride.

A terrifying sight snapped me out of my rage. My mouth fell open as I stared at Gilbert. He gave off the same aura of hatred as me, but every muscle in his face was pulled taut, twisting his expression into a horrid grin.

When he noticed my eyes on him, he blinked. "Is something wrong?"

Defeated, I replied, "I don't know how you held out for those seven years."

His eyes went wide, his face going stiff. I looked away, unable to bear how pathetic and powerless I felt.

Gilbert had watched his wife suffer from illness for seven years. Ever since I'd learned of Gilbert's sins, I knew that if it had been Pride, I would've done the same things he did.

Maria recovered five years ago. After all this time, and with Pride sick, the very same thoughts Gilbert had contended with now plagued me. I still wouldn't forgive Gilbert, of course... I simply thought that maybe I shouldn't blame him so much for it.

"I *didn't* hold out."

When I raised my head, Gilbert was smiling sadly, as if he were confessing his sins. His long, almond-shaped eyes lingered on me even as they drooped.

"I couldn't bear it. That's why I fell from grace the way I did. I don't deserve any appreciation." His shoulders sank, and he shook his head. "Prince Stale, please don't turn out like me."

His warning—and the implication that I hadn't turned out like him *yet*—provided a small but genuine salvation. Eventually, I had to tear my gaze away from his sorrowful expression. As much as I hated to admit it, he was far more mature than I was.

"Of course not," I said, then reminded him that I still hadn't forgiven him for his crimes.

"So you haven't." Even without looking, I could hear the smile in his voice.

The carriage slowed to a stop as we approached the royal residence. I had to report to Uncle Vest...but suddenly, I yearned to see Pride, an overwhelming tide of nostalgia washing over me.

Perhaps Arthur was still at her side. I'd spent the whole night assisting Uncle Vest, so I had yet to go back and visit her. Tiara was probably just as lifeless as she had been when I saw her last. All I wanted was for Pride to wake up, but Adam made it sound like there was little hope of that for now.

"Adam!"

I wouldn't let him off easy if he was behind this. Gilbert was clever in getting Adam to stay for another three days. That was more than enough time to hunt down what I needed to put his back against the wall.

Uncle Vest was probably discussing the development with Mother and Father at that very moment. Maybe I wouldn't deal the finishing blow myself, but Uncle Vest, Gilbert, and Prince Cedric were privy to everything. We all knew Pride could remain in her slumber for over a month, but at least her condition wouldn't worsen. The idea of her never waking up was unthinkable.

I pictured King Lance, stuck in his bed due to madness, and Maria, clinging to the last dregs of her life, and shook my head violently. I would never allow Pride to end up like that.

Adam, crown prince of the Rajah Empire... You can bathe in your self-satisfaction for now, but it won't last once you realize the rope is already around your neck. When they pull the lever and the floor

drops out beneath you, I'll be the one with my legs crossed, savoring it all from the front row!

ADAM

"WHAT A PAIN," I muttered as I lay on my bed with my shoes on.

This whole business of the extended stay seemed like nothing more than a terrific waste of my time. I was incredibly bored, and I had only one guest at my disposal to indulge in my favorite pastime.

"What the hell were they going on about?" I seethed, raking a hand through my hair. "Peace between our countries? That was always a fairy tale. Do these stupid monsters understand *anything*?"

Though I'd requested a visit with Pride after breakfast that morning, they weren't letting anyone see her. I drooled upon imagining how wretched she must look, but unfortunately, it seemed I wouldn't get to witness it myself. Many people had gathered the Freesian castle, hoping to see the princess, and the guards turned everyone away. Only one carriage was allowed to pass: the one belonging to Pride's sworn friend, Leon.

I'd heard rumors that the United Hanazuo Kingdom, a country I was certainly familiar with, had extended their stay as well. At first, it annoyed me that *they*, of all nations, got special treatment, but in the end, I didn't really care.

"Those no-name little countries must have a lot of free time on their hands. I bet that's nice. All you have to do is cozy up to a much bigger country to get what you want. Child's play, isn't it?"

I snickered at Hanazuo's antics. They'd only survived because Freesia pitied them. Maybe they'd even become suspects themselves, being the last ones to interact with Pride before her collapse. That would be a delightful little twist to this story. I killed time fantasizing about all the ways I could tear the two countries' relationship to shreds.

Even as I cackled, I realized I didn't have any slaves to kick or make scream. I couldn't bring them into Freesia, since they opposed slavery. All I had was subordinates and guards, as well as a few servants and maids. I wouldn't mind giving them a beating, but I didn't want any rumors getting out if someone overheard. I couldn't afford to make an enemy out of Freesia—not yet, anyway.

"Now the only people who can get in my way are the queen and that prime minister."

The seneschal and prince consort were stubborn, good for nothing more than furrowing their brows. They were no different from royalty from any other country. Those two merely followed orders, so I had no real use for them. The queen was different, however. A year ago, I'd tried to rattle her by acting like I was the one in charge, but all my attempts failed. She was far more fun when I insulted her daughter, but she still didn't stray from the course by letting me provoke her. Then there was the prime minister...

"That monster. I can't believe he really *is* the prime minister."

I stretched my legs, kicking the bedside table. Putting my hands behind my neck, I stared up at the ornate ceiling. Gilbert was the only Freesian I could stand, but the prime minister would just get in my

way. I wished I could win Gilbert over to my side, but people like him didn't do as they were told.

If he'd made the request alone, I would have made up a reason to head home. I couldn't read his true intentions at all, no matter how politely he spoke. Did he like me, see me as a threat, or think nothing of me at all? It was impossible to tell.

"As a country who recently established peace with yours, we insisted you would never do such a thing intentionally, Prince Adam."

The words had the ring of suspicion, but Gilbert had delivered them like a normal turn in the conversation. It disgusted me either way, like the words were slithering over my skin. But even more than that, they *excited* me. I wanted to pry Gilbert's brain out and compare it to a commoner's.

"Compared to him...that prince is a total fool. Ha ha!"

With a laugh, I climbed out of bed. I didn't mind this delay in the plan if *he* would be the next generation's seneschal. I could wait until the prime minister died of old age and that silly little second-born princess took the crown. At that point, I wouldn't need to keep Pride alive any longer. Tales of the princess's deterioration into skin and bones would make for a nice snack alongside my liquor whenever they invited me back to Freesia.

"Stupid idiot!" I spit at the ceiling, directing my rage at no one in particular.

I burst out laughing all over again. Prime minister aside, that prince might become a useful pawn.

"And it was such a large crowd. It's not surprising they couldn't find you. After all, many of our allies have never laid eyes on you."

They might have their suspicions, but they wouldn't doubt a prince. They would assume my innocence.

"Unfortunately, they struggle to understand our peace treaty with the Rajah Empire."

As a large country involved in the slave trade, Rajah would be gossiped about as a potential culprit. But we'd gone much further than anyone would believe. If the prince didn't suspect us, he was either an incredible optimist or a total moron.

"We fear if you leave now, tensions will soar among these foreign countries. They'll believe Rajah was responsible for what happened to our crown princess, demand we break our peace treaty, and cut ties with the United Hanazuo Kingdom."

No, he's an idiot, I decided. Even a child knew you could antagonize a friendly country by repeating rumors and suspicions. The prince didn't get as far as naming *who* felt this way, but he was a fool to reveal so much in the first place. He'd even said it like a declaration of his faith in Rajah. If he needed a reminder from the prime minister not to blab about such things, I genuinely wondered if the prince was nothing more than a figurehead.

"Prince Stale has always been grateful to you, Prince Adam. It's thanks to the Rajah Empire's assistance that we stopped Copelandii's recklessness last year."

Gilbert had praised me for something Rajah had only done to keep up appearances, even bowing his head in a show of humility.

This prince was too good to be true. I needed to see the look of despair on his face when he found out he'd been betrayed.

"Once the others find out you've extended your stay out of concern for Princess Pride, they'll understand the nature of the peace treaty between our countries."

No one would *really* believe we were on good terms just because I was staying in Freesia a few days longer. Judging by the prime minister's flattery, that whole display had to be the stupid prince's idea. Surely Gilbert was only there to chaperone the brat, who somehow believed it would help.

I'd agreed to the firstborn prince's request anyhow. The official story had changed, but either way I was stuck in Freesia. Now, if I could just use the princess's hopeless situation to unsettle all these Freesians...

"I'm getting even closer to my prize."

My lips curled as I howled with laughter, nearly drooling on myself.

I was surrounded by fools. Everything was going my way. I quieted my laughter so they wouldn't hear me, stomping my feet to make up for it.

ARTHUR

"AARTHUR...it's your turn. Get some rest."

Vice Captain Eric returned from his break just as the sky was growing dark.

"Thank you," I said, yet I couldn't bring myself to pry my hand away from the princesses'.

Princess Pride still won't wake up...

She hadn't moved a muscle. It was like time had stopped for her. Seeing her in such a state, I could hardly breathe. I probably looked pretty bad myself.

Vice Captain Eric set a hand on my shoulder. Then Tiara put her other hand on top of mine, saying, "I'll tell Big Brother you left for your break."

Shoot. I was making her worry.

"Right."

I slowly stood and slid my hand away from Princess Pride's, but the separation left my heart aching. Not being able to feel her body heat made the possibility of losing her all too real. Chills ran up and down my spine. My fingertips were cold, my senses numbing. I squeezed my fist, as though trying to hold on to her lingering warmth.

Even now that I was standing up, I couldn't bring myself to leave. I just stared down at her until Vice Captain Eric grabbed my shoulder. *I know I need to rest if I want my body to function when it matters most, but right now, I desperately want to be—*

An urgent knock broke the tension in the room, and Stale's voice came from the other side of the door. When Jack let him in, a beat of relief hit me—then quickly evaporated. Princess Pride was still asleep, just like the last time Stale had seen her.

Stale hurried into the room, making a beeline for Her Highness's bedside. His face was even more tense than mine, and I wondered if he and the others hadn't made any progress after all. He never tore his eyes from Pride's face as the doctor updated him on her condition, but there wasn't much to say.

Tiara pursed her lips in concern, but when Stale noticed, he stroked her head. "Thanks for staying with Elder Sister all this time, but it's time for you to get some rest."

The younger princess's eyes welled with tears at his gentle tone. They fell free as she rubbed her eyes, so Stale asked her maid to take her to her room.

"It'll be all right," he told her with one last strong hug, like a true big brother.

I was relieved once Tiara finally left to get some sleep. She'd dozed off at my side, but tiny, restless naps weren't enough. Unlike me, she wasn't used to putting her body through that much strain.

Prince Cedric had followed in on Stale's heels, and now he glanced between the door and Princess Pride. His face twisted with pain, he faced King Lance, King Yohan, Prince Leon, and me. "I promise I'll be back," he said, then hurried out of the room. His eyes never left Princess Pride until he was out the door.

"Captain Arthur, thank you for watching over her," Stale said. "I'm sorry I took so long."

After apologizing to me, Stale spoke with the others. Prince Leon thanked him for granting permission for a special visit. Stale expressed

his own gratitude toward King Lance and King Yohan for Prince Cedric's help. Apparently, he'd forgotten to thank the prince directly.

Stale briefly chatted with the maids and the doctor before turning back to me. I gulped at the look on his face. He clearly had something he wanted to say, but he addressed the other imperial knights first. "Could I borrow Captain Arthur for a bit?"

The other knights agreed, telling him it just so happened to be time for our shift change.

"Good," he murmured, shooting me a look.

I followed him out, leaving behind the bedridden crown princess.

We walked down the hall and descended the stairs until we reached Stale's bedroom. Even I had never set foot inside this place in all these years. The only chambers I guarded were Pride's, and Stale and Tiara always came to her room. Their worlds truly revolved around her.

Stale ordered the guards and knights following us to wait outside so we could be alone. I felt guilty at being the only knight granted permission to join him, but before I could say anything, Stale gestured for me to hurry inside.

The smell of books and paper hit me before I even got a good look at the space. It was like being in a library. Shelves packed full of books lined the walls, and a tall stack of tomes perched on the edge of his desk. There were even more bookshelves here than in Princess Pride's room, though Stale kept his decorations uniform in color. All of his shelves and drawers that weren't for clothes were locked. That didn't surprise me, knowing Stale.

I instantly recognized a few items on his desk and the top shelves as gifts from Princesses Pride and Tiara.

"Sit down," he said. "I've got something important to discuss."

He sat on the sofa opposite me, but his words made me uneasy. It seemed like he was holding back his anger, or perhaps some other emotion I couldn't identify. His efforts to calm himself, and maybe me as well, plainly strained his face.

I took a seat on a plush sofa too, sinking into the cushions. Restless and unsure, I leaned forward and planted both feet firmly on the ground. Stale did the same, pressing his hands to his lips as he hung his head. He clearly didn't know where to start, so I sat quietly and waited.

At length, he declared, "I'll get straight to the point."

I braced myself as Stale met my eyes.

"We've determined that what happened to Elder Sister was a crime and not an accident. We also identified the man involved."

My jaw dropped and my eyes bulged as questions flooded my head, but it took me some time to scrounge up the words. "Who is it?!"

Stale pressed a finger to his lips, warning me to hush up and keep this absolutely secret. I snapped my mouth shut. He brought his folded hands back to his lips, muffling himself.

"The Rajah Empire. It's Prince Adam."

Rajah. I knew the name all too well. They were the ones who tried to invade the United Hanazuo Kingdom. They'd claimed

Copelandii had acted without their knowledge and formed a peace treaty with Freesia to ensure Hanazuo's safety. It was...

"You'll die with hatred for your foolish ruler who ever thought to make an enemy of the Rajah Empire!"

Memories of the defensive war flashed through my mind. An enemy general had said those words to me.

My blood boiled. Rajah was our *enemy*. I struggled to breathe, my mouth twisting into a scowl before I could stop it. Moments ago, it seemed like my heart had stopped dead, but now it pounded in my ears. My fingers trembled, and I fought the urge to howl with rage. As my vision turned red, I realized I needed to get a hold of myself.

"We convinced him to stay at the castle for three more days," Stale went on. "He doesn't seem to know we suspect him...but none of us know how he did it either."

He explained things slowly, giving me time to process. He was obviously trying to keep his emotions in check too. I clenched my fists, my blood pumping hotter and faster the longer I listened.

Princess Pride...won't wake up for a month? And that man might be using Princess Pride as a bargaining chip?! They want us to sell off Freesians or start using slaves? That stupid crap is why she's still unconscious?!

Even without knowing this man's face, my vision reddened further as I imagined him sneering and cackling.

"We won't allow such a thing, of course," Stale said. "Uncle Vest already spoke with Mother, and if Elder Sister doesn't wake up within

the three days..."

He trailed off, giving me a chance to catch up through my rage. I met his jet-black eyes, and for the first time in ages...Stale smiled.

"Mother promised she would carry out his questioning using one of Freesia's 'contracts.'"

I nearly cried out in shock. I only knew the basics about this sort of thing, but sometimes in Freesia, a suspect would sign a contract to prevent them from ever breaking certain conditions—similar to a subordination contract or a fealty contract.

In this case, the contract might state that the culprit had to reveal what happened to Princess Pride and how to fix it without any falsehoods, and whoever signed it would have no choice but to obey. Such contracts were rarely used, serving as a last resort.

"Even if we request one now, it will take a week to draw it up, maybe five days if they hurry. So we'll have to find evidence to arrest him in the next three days."

Freesia's royal family wasn't holding back in the slightest if this was their plan. Her Majesty was dead serious if she was willing to go this far against imperial royalty. If we could get proof within the next three days that Rajah was behind this...

Princess Pride would wake up.

If this Prince Adam knew how to heal her, we could force him to do it. My head drooped as relief washed away the tension in my body. *Thank goodness. Having to wait three days or even a week will be rough, but at least we can save her.* Heat built behind my eyes, and I

slapped my cheeks to snap myself out of it. The harsh sound left me reinvigorated.

"We've told very few people about this to prevent leaks," Stale said. "We're still investigating illnesses, poisons, and the potential that other guests were involved, but Father and Gilbert are rushing to prepare a contract with Mother's permission. I plan to help Gilbert when my break ends." As he spoke, Stale let his shoulders sag at last. "We can't let our guards down yet, of course, but now there's a little hope."

"Right..."

I didn't know what else to say. Stale had been working so hard—all to save Princess Pride.

He leaned back against the sofa and gave such a long, weary sigh, it was like he was exhaling all the air in his body. "Sorry it took so long."

I didn't understand why *that* was his response, of all things, and the silliness of it made me laugh.

"What's with you?"

"You're amazing, y'know that?" My voice shook with laughter.

Stale didn't respond, startled by my reaction.

"You did all that in a single day? Seriously, you're the coolest."

All *I* did was mope at Princess Pride's bedside, yet Stale had used everything at his disposal until he found a way to save her. Compared to him, I was pathetic.

Stale blinked, then turned his head away like he was pouting. "It wasn't just me. Uncle Vest, Prince Cedric, and...unfortunately *Gilbert* helped too."

"I doubt they'd have made much progress without you."

When I asked who had involved Prince Cedric, Stale owned up to it. I didn't know the details, but I could tell the Cercian prince had done a lot more than sit back and watch.

"I was able to leave my sisters because I knew you would be there with them."

"Nah, you would've gotten it done without me. I know that much, at least."

I often felt I could never live up to Stale. Not only was he a lot smarter than me, but he was always helping me out. I was so glad Princess Pride had a guy like him for a brother.

At that, Stale pressed the back of his hand to his lips. His face twisted through emotions before he managed to look at me again. "Take care of Elder Sister for a little while longer. I promise I'll find a way to wake her up."

"You got it. Just leave it to me."

He asked me to keep this a secret from Tiara, which made me realize I was the only one he was sharing this with. When I rose to leave, he stopped me.

"You still have time," he said. "You should rest before you go back."

Stale was right about that, but *he* was supposed to be taking a break too.

As though he'd read my mind, he abruptly announced, "I'm going to take a thirty-minute nap. Wake me when it's time to go."

While I floundered for a response, Stale lay down on the sofa. With his head pillowed on his arm, he dozed off—completely neglecting his own bed in the process. I stood around, waiting for him to tell me this was some sort of joke, but he was out cold in seconds. I'd never actually seen him asleep before.

I settled back down on my own sofa and watched Stale. He hadn't slept since Princess Pride's collapse, same as me. Even relaxed in sleep, his face bore deep shadows of fatigue.

"Why don't you just sleep at Princess Pride's bedside?"

Before I knew it, I was lying down myself. Stale no doubt wanted to stay beside Princess Pride for as long as possible, and judging by our discussion, her condition wouldn't worsen. It seemed he had deemed it safe for Tiara and me to leave her side.

Ah, of course. Stale wasn't someone who showed weakness to others, even with Princess Pride in her room. Having clues and leads to work with finally allowed him to relax.

"You're amazing..." I muttered to myself, my words soft in the quiet room.

As I watched him, I noticed Stale's glasses sat askew. Mentally scolding him for not taking them off, I rose and carefully removed

them, trying not to wake him up in the process. I set them on a nearby table and returned to my sofa.

Without glasses, Stale looked even more at ease. I considered sleeping myself, but a glance at the clock revealed I'd run out of time. I had to wake him up soon.

Well, that's fine. I was pretty used to going without sleep. In fact, this conversation left me way more energized than before. I stretched out on the sofa, leaning against the backrest and worrying I might doze off too, thanks to the plush furniture.

I managed to fight off the urge, but my body did get a bit of a break. I spent the rest of those thirty minutes looking around Stale's room.

PRIDE

A*GH... My head hurts.*

That was the first thought that struck me. I couldn't see anything, but I realized I'd only just woken up. It was too much of a bother to open my eyes, so I remained in a twilight state.

Why am I...? Where am I?

I could find the answers if I opened my eyes, but I kept them closed. It was so quiet. Smooth sheets caressed my skin and lay softly atop me. I must have been in a bed, then.

My muscles felt too heavy to move. I searched my memory, but I still didn't understand. I'd danced with everyone, then Mother had introduced me to the crowd so I could announce the postal system... but everything else was a blur. What happened to the postal system?

As I pondered the matter, my thoughts finally took shape. *Aah, that's right.*

Now that my brain was working, I slowly opened my eyes and found myself in bed, as expected. I stared at the ceiling as my vision gradually cleared. Maids and knights bustled around my bed—raising a fuss, running out of the room, shouting for people—but none of it reached me.

It's already been ten years...

So much time had passed. I didn't feel like sitting up yet, so I focused on the ceiling. A doctor and a few familiar faces came to the bedside and peered down at me. Strangely, I didn't want to answer their questions. I was too deep in thought.

Goodness, what was I thinking all these years?

The more I went over my memories from the past decade, the more shame burned inside me. I'd regained my past-life memories. Then I met Stale, Tiara, the knights, Arthur, Prime Minister Gilbert, Maria, Val, Sefekh, Khemet, Leon, Anemone, Cedric, and the kings from Hanazuo.

Ugh... Why did I waste my time meddling in their lives?

I was such a fool. Getting up to that nonsense was just going to ruin everything. Why had I spent ten precious years wasting my energy instead of doing something meaningful?

Lotte, my personal maid, reached out to me when I didn't respond. I swatted her hand away, and everyone around my bed

gaped in surprise. Since everyone was making such a commotion, I had no choice but to sit up.

Mary, my other personal maid, tried to support my back, but I bent to avoid her. Even once I was sitting, my head swirled with troubling thoughts. I didn't care to reply to anyone around me, too full of regret to bother.

Why did I believe I had a future? Why did I assume this world was "reality?" After everything played out exactly like the game from my past life, why did I keep averting my eyes from my true role?

I was Pride Royal Ivy, the firstborn princess and heir to the Freesian throne.

I spent my days with my beloved siblings, forming new relationships and alliances, dedicated to serving the citizens alongside the people I cared about...and now I was a slave to those delusions. Somewhere along the way, I'd stopped doubting the fantasy. Deep down in my heart, did I really think I could beat them? Did I think I'd make do somehow, and that as the chosen one with the power of precognition, there was no one who could defeat me? Did I think no one could kill the last boss? That must have been what I thought. It explained why I spent my life acting like a fool without a care in the world.

Goodness... I can't believe how "prideful" I've been.

"Heh... Ha ha... Ha ha ha ha... Ha ha ha! Aha ha ha ha ha ha ha ha ha ha!"

Ah, how amusing. It was just so funny. I clutched my sides and howled with laughter. I couldn't stop myself, even as I started to

wonder if I was going to die from cackling.

I'd been so stupid. I was the last boss! I was the prideful queen who deserved her execution in the end! How could I ever hope for a different future?

"What's wrong, Princess Pride?"

"Your Highness, please calm down!"

Voices came at me from all directions. *How annoying. Why do they have to ruin my good mood?*

Suddenly, the door burst open. *Wham!* I turned toward the sound and found Arthur and Stale charging into the room. They'd arrived at the same time, like they'd been somewhere together.

"Elder Sister?!"

"Princess Pride?!"

Their pretty eyes went as wide as saucers, but I couldn't stop. My gaze lingered on them as I laughed and laughed.

"Aha ha ha ha ha! Aha ha ha ha ha ha ha ha! Ha ha ha ha ha ha ha ha ha ha!"

My throat was getting sore by the time another figure appeared in the doorway. Her presence finally quieted me.

"Big Sister?!"

Tiara gaped at me from the doorway, perhaps frightened by my laughter. Cedric joined her. Even from across the room, I could see her face was pale with terror. When she took a timid step toward me, something like ice—or maybe bile—lurched up and down inside me. Desperate to keep her away, I grabbed the water pitcher at the

bedside, cocking my arm to throw it at her, but my body was too sluggish to wield it. Without giving Tiara a chance to say anything more, I sloshed the water in her direction.

Splash! The water shot at Tiara, but Arthur swooped in to block it. Of course he'd managed to protect Tiara. Cedric had tried to step in front of her as well, but he was too slow. She'd really become a fitting heroine, having two love interests swoop in to rescue her at once.

Seeing Arthur drenched and dazed and Tiara so frightened, Stale cried out, "What are you doing?!"

Tiara was hiding behind Arthur, so I didn't get the pleasure of seeing her expression, but the knight was scrunching his brows in consternation. Stale blinked in wide-eyed bewilderment. Their expressions were so, *so* sweet.

"Don't speak to me like we're close," I snapped. "I'm Pride Royal Ivy, or have you forgotten? You will address me as 'Princess Pride' or 'Your Highness.'"

I jabbed a finger at myself and laughed, my excitement giving me a surge of vigor.

Yes, I was Princess Pride Royal Ivy. I wasn't someone the protagonist or love interests should call "Big Sister" or "Elder Sister." I was the wicked, destructive last boss. *Maybe it would be fun to hear them call me their sister as they spit hateful words at me.* I decided I didn't much care which form of address they chose.

Everyone was frozen, watching me in horror. A puddle soaked the floor at Arthur's feet. I glared at Mary and Lotte, shouting, "Hey,

you two! Do something about the floor!" The pale-faced women flew into action, and I threw the pitcher on the floor.

Before I could get out of bed, the doctor timidly asked, "Do you feel well?"

"Of course I do," I said, shoving him out of my path. "There're too many of you in here. All of you, get out. You're a bunch of eyesores."

I wore nothing but pajamas, so I headed to my dresser. I worked to sort out my thoughts as I rooted around for a gown to wear. Here I assumed everyone had left when I demanded it, but I turned around to find the dumbfounded group still gaping at me. Angered by their disobedience, I took a deep breath to shout at them once more.

"Pride, what's wrong?" Leon cut in. Confusion dulled his jade-green eyes, and he took a tentative step closer. "Everyone was so worried about you..."

Cedric and the others started speaking as well, finally snapping out of their trances.

Auuugh... How annoying. Don't they understand I have my own problems to worry about?

They were getting in my way and wouldn't shut up. I didn't need those looks of concern and dismay. What I really needed was...

"You won't listen to me. Very well, then."

I kept my tone casual as I surveyed the men in the room, which included everyone except for Tiara and the maids. I shoved Leon back

and began to unbutton my nightgown.

"What are you doing?!" Leon cried.

Once I got to the lowest button I could reach, I fixed them with a look and raised my voice.

"I wonder how many of you men would face harsh questions if word got out that someone raped the firstborn princess? I can't wait to find out."

My lips curled into a smirk. Their bug-eyed, pale expressions sent a thrill through my chest.

How delightful.

"I'll say it again. Get out, all of you. I want to be alone."

It took a while for everyone to leave. Stale and the imperial knights put up the fiercest resistance. Were they really that eager to see the firstborn princess naked? No, that couldn't be the case for my brother or the knights, at least. Maybe they just didn't like taking orders.

I eventually managed to send away the stubborn group, maids and all. Only once I locked the door behind them did I finally relax with a sigh. I sat back down on my bed and crossed my arms, the front of my nightgown still hanging open.

There's not much time left before the end. What should I do first?



My mission was simple. I would destroy several countries and ruin my own. But those attempts would be ruined. By the love interests. **Before I could even begin.**

The nation would rejoice at my death, and Tiara the heroine would get her happy ending. I wouldn't just destroy the country. There was no point. **I needed them to kill me.** First.

It has to be dramatic! My final moments need to make for a happy ending.

I couldn't just ruin the country, and I couldn't just die. I had to *build* a happy ending that tied those two components together. That was the entire reason I existed. It *had* to be me.

A smile spread across my face. My life was nearly over, yet I didn't feel sad about it. In fact, I could hardly wait. There were so many things to do before then, so many options to juggle. I was like a kid in a candy store.

If my life's going to end soon, I should spend these final days having as much "fun" as possible.

"I wonder whose route will kill me?"

My heart sang with pleasure. I giggled and gazed out the window at the encroaching night. When I squinted, I could make out a slender sliver of moon just beginning to cut into the darkness.

"Welcome, I'm bringing *you* your happy ending."

Tiara would only choose one of her five options. I called out to whoever he might be, even though everyone was gone now, and reached for the moon in vain. I could cover it entirely with my finger.

Overcome with mirth, I let out a roar of laughter. "Aha ha ha!
Aha ha ha ha ha!"

I howled and howled. When I'd had my share of laughter, the corners of my lips raised as high as they could go.

Let them hate me. Let them despise me. I'm going to have my fun so that it's worth it when those wounded souls abandon me in the end. I hope they utterly detest me. I'm so excited to see how they fall into despair!

Now, it's finally time to bring about the happiest of endings.

"I'll make sure my death brings beautiful colors to your world."

Changing Hearts

ONCE A YEAR, Freesia celebrated Precognition Commemoration Day, also known as the Precognition Festival. It was the day in which Freesians all across the country celebrated their first queen's discovery of her precognition.

The castle town threw the biggest celebrations of all. They also held festivities for the royal family's birthdays and the anniversary of Freesia's founding, but the Precognition Festival topped all those lesser occasions.

On this day, once a year, the royal family opened the Freesian castle to the public. As the royal family's home, this castle was the most lavish and spacious of any in the country. Only servants and special guests got permission to pass through its heavy fortifications.

The Precognition Festival presented an opportunity for anyone to enter the castle, regardless of their status. Guards and knights protected the front gates, checking the guests and their belongings before they entered. Beyond them stood the castle—something everyone in the land dreamed of seeing.

Once guests passed through the gates, a great hall awaited them with chairs and tables, where commoners could feast on foods and savor spirits normally reserved for the royal family. Under strict guard, they could view other parts of the castle as well. These were places that never opened their doors to the public outside of the

Precognition Festival, places rarely used at all aside from the most significant ceremonies and formal announcements.

With the castle's permission, merchants peddled, artists painted, and musicians performed. The castle invited a theater troupe each year that proved a huge draw for all who witnessed their show. Guests only saw a small portion of the castle, but its sheer size made it feel vast regardless. The people celebrated in the halls all day, and once the sun began to set, the glow of hanging lanterns kept things lively. This was no mere banquet; it was a true festival.

But these weren't the only special events to take place during the occasion.

"Big Sister, would you...like to hold hands?!" six-year-old Tiara asked me.

"Of course," I replied, taking her hand with a smile.

The Freesian citizens gasped. Their eyes lit up as they watched our fancy carriage approach the castle gates. Some even cried, moved by witnessing my family with their own eyes. Though the castle being opened to the public was monumental on its own, the royal family's ceremonial meal with the Freesian people was the biggest event of the whole Precognition Festival.

Since the common folk could not sit with us, the castle set up several large tables for them. They could still observe us up close and watch us eat a meal, however. It seemed more Freesians than usual were participating in the festival this year.

Everyone waited with bated breath to catch a glimpse of Tiara, the princess who had only been revealed to the public that same year, and Stale, the newly adopted prince. They cheered and applauded the moment they finally laid eyes on us, though most people were fixated on my siblings.

"Are you all right, Stale?" I asked, then extended my hand. "If you're nervous, I can hold your han—"

"N-no, I'm fine," he told me, jerking away. "Thank you for your concern."

Stale wasn't nearly as nervous as Tiara, even though they were both attending the festival for the first time. He was scanning the crowd, perhaps hoping to spot his mother. They were not allowed to meet, and the guards would probably turn her away at the gates, but I knew she was on his mind leading up to this day. Yet not only did he apparently fail to find his mother, he likely didn't recognize anyone at all. That wasn't much of a surprise. Anyone who lived far from the royal capital would struggle to make the trip to the popular event.

I could tell Stale didn't like the way people were staring at him and Tiara, though he had to understand the crowd's eagerness to witness their first public appearances. As the firstborn princess, and with my precognition awakening, I'd officially been acknowledged as heir to the throne—yet Stale and Tiara attracted all the buzz. That is, until Stale's face betrayed his emotions, his flitting eyes hardening into a glare. Perhaps he wished they'd pivot to me instead, giving him a break.

But I didn't care about the looks, and Tiara didn't even seem to notice. Mostly, I was just worried about my siblings.

"You're so calm, even in front of such a large crowd, Elder Sister," Stale said. "I'd expect nothing less."

"Well, it's not my first time. You two did great in front of guests at the ceremonies, so I've got nothing to worry about." I covered my mouth and chuckled.

They were nervous, so I tried to cheer them up. I had been a part of the Precognition Festival since I was young, so the crowd didn't intimidate me. My goal was to make this a pleasant experience for my adorable younger siblings. That said, such a massive event wasn't easy to navigate the first time around.

Royal and noble guests attended the castle ceremonies Stale and Tiara were familiar with, maintaining their distance with an air of dignity. But commoners made up the majority of the guests at the banquet. They hooted and hollered over every little thing we did.

"Prince Stale is so adorable!"

"Princess Tiara looked at me!"

Each time they screamed, my heart skipped a beat, and I feared something bad had happened. Even Stale, a former commoner himself, sat up straighter and gulped whenever he drew too much attention. Being looked at not as a person but as something more sacred clearly set him on edge.

"Don't worry," I said. "These people all love you so much. You should keep your heads held high."

I stroked Stale's hair, hoping to ease his nerves after he'd refused to take my hand. He stiffened, lips pressing together. Though he kept his face blank, heat crept into his cheeks. Maybe he was embarrassed to have so many people see me coax him like a child.

The crowd had tensed when I first raised my hand, but they sighed with relief when I brought it down to caress Stale's head. I had a reputation for selfish fits, so perhaps they assumed I'd strike the young Tiara or my commoner brother, even in a setting like this. I drew just as much attention by stroking Stale's hair and holding Tiara's hand, however.

Stale seemed upset by the crowd's rude assumptions, but I smiled awkwardly and ignored it. I knew better than anyone just how poorly I'd behaved before regaining my past-life memories.

Back then, I attended parties with Mother and Father but tried to keep their attention on me and me alone. That just wasn't possible with so many eyes on me, and I'd hated behaving like a "good little princess," so my prim and proper act slipped from time to time. I had wanted Mother and Father's approval without caring what the Freesian people thought of me in the slightest. In fact, I'd wished the citizens at the Precognition Festival would just go away more often than not. At least Stale and Tiara had mastered proper behavior.

When I scowled in self-reproach, my siblings looked up.

"Big Sister?"

"Elder Sister? What's wrong?"

The crowd stirred in confusion as my siblings questioned me. I quickly smoothed my expression, fearing the Freesians expected

another grumpy outburst, and insisted it was nothing. "Anyway, today is an opportunity for you to see the faces of the people you're going to protect someday. Let's enjoy it, shall we?"

I lightened the mood with a grin, and they beamed back at me.

"Yes!" Tiara said, squeezing my hand tighter.

Stale sighed and swept a glance around the room once more. He'd been upset with the commoners up until that point, but I also knew he'd work hard to protect them. He needed to stop acting so wary and embrace the role of a proper prince.

His gaze drifted to my empty hand, as though he was reconsidering my earlier offer.

"Big Sister, Big Brother, it looks like the others are taking their seats!" Tiara said. "Let's join them!"

I agreed and moved toward our table. Stale swallowed when Tiara and I smiled at him. He seemed on the verge of saying something but snapped his mouth shut instead. Ahead, Mother, Father, and Uncle Vest were taking their seats.

"Um...!" Stale began, voice faltering.

We paused, and then Stale extended a trembling hand.

"If...you don't mind, I...would like...to join you..."

Despite his mild expression, the look in his eyes betrayed his nerves. I understood immediately. In truth, his initial refusal had disappointed me, but maybe this had been his goal all along. He was still young, but I was moved by his manly offer of escort. I grinned at this boy, who was both my adoptive brother and my steward. The

crowd peered intently at us, but all I cared about was the warmth swelling in my heart.

"Absolutely," I said, extending my free hand toward him. "Thank you, Stale."

Stale shuddered at my touch, and the crowd squealed with delight. It must have been a shock to him. He turned his eyes down bashfully but otherwise kept his face blank. Honestly, he seemed mostly undaunted by the whole thing, which was pretty impressive.

Tiara hopped with excitement. "Let's go!"

As we approached the royal family's table, our father, the prince consort, said, "Take your seats."

His tone was gentle despite the chastisement. We apologized for being late, and I released my siblings' hands. Careful not to let the crowd see us rush, we found our places at the table.

"Have a seat, Princess Pride," said a calm yet curt voice.

I looked up at the person pulling out a chair for me. Gilbert, the Freesian prime minister and my father's steward, beckoned me toward my seat, bowing politely but refusing to meet my eyes.

Prime Minister Gilbert's expression was tense as he returned to Albert's side. He didn't seem to care that Tiara goggled at him or that Stale coolly assessed him like he would an adversary.

He'd spent the days leading up to the Precognition Festival assigning work to various castle personnel, dispatching knights and increasing security, and preparing tables and food—directing more people than I could count. But the meal itself was for the royal family.

Surrounded by guards, we ate for everyone to see just as we did each year, putting our close family relationship on display for the Freesian people. Since the guests weren't royals or nobles, the prime minister served no purpose at the event. That was why, at least for the banquet...

GILBERT

"YOUR HIGHNESS," I said with a deep bow, "I must leave now, but please enjoy the lovely banquet."

After I saw Princess Pride to her place at the table, Albert granted me permission to leave. I was the one person in the whole country who couldn't join in the festivities today; I needed to get back to Marianne, my fiancée, as quickly as I could.

As the royal family dined alongside the Freesian people under an open sky, my Marianne lay hidden away in a room in the castle, battling her illness. I kept my guard up as I slipped away, hoping no one spotted me. Then I boarded the carriage I'd left waiting for me and headed to the royal residence alone. No one would suspect a thing if I went to Marianne's room on foot after that.

I gazed out the window as the carriage rocked. Freesian citizens strolled the castle grounds, but most of the people I passed were knights. I gently drew the curtains when they tried to catch a glimpse inside my carriage. I had permission, but I would raise suspicions if people found out I'd left the prince consort to return to the royal residence during the festivities. For my beloved Marianne's safety, I couldn't let anyone know my true reason for leaving.

ALAN

"ALAN, DID YOU SEE who was in that carriage just now?"

"No, why?"

I cocked my head at Callum's question and watched the carriage that had just passed us. I'd bowed to it just like Callum had, but I didn't particularly care who was inside. Callum was even worse at tracking moving objects than I was, so there was no way he saw who was inside, but he seemed curious anyway. Since he was still gawping at the carriage, I walked off like I was going to leave him behind.

"C'mon, we've gotta get a move on," I said. "We can pass through the banquet on our patrol route, right?"

"Just be sure not to pass in front of the royal family."

Most knights in the royal order were patrolling the castle. As captains from the main forces, Callum and I happened to be assigned the same area, even though we led different squadrons. I was the one who'd invited Callum to patrol the castle grounds together, mostly because I was afraid I'd get lost on my own. I could keep track of the royal order's training grounds, but the castle had way too many unfamiliar locations.

We'd gotten a thorough briefing and a map beforehand, but I'd still wanted to team up with Callum, who had a very good memory. We'd also joined the royal order in the same year, so Callum was easy to get along with, even though we served in separate units.

Callum turned away from the carriage and followed me, brushing aside his bangs as he looked toward the banquet venue. The

huge crowd of guests was all focused on one table; some had already started eating. Instead of passing through the chaos, we circled the perimeter.

"Real feast going on over there, huh?" I said. "Sounds pretty nice. I bet they've got the best booze too."

"You'll have to wait until tonight," Callum replied. "You can drink as much as you want when you're *not* assigned to watch duty."

As I soaked up the sight of all that good food and drink, Callum sighed. Knights lived on the castle grounds, but instead of getting to indulge in that beautiful feast, we were stuck on patrol. Luckily, once night fell, everyone who wasn't on shift—including the gatekeepers—could indulge as much as they liked.

"Damn, you're strict," I muttered when he insisted I wait. I wasn't *actually* jealous of the food and drinks at the banquet.

This time, Callum took the initiative. "Let's go."

I followed, hands behind my head. If we got on our tiptoes, we could have snuck a peek at the royal family, but neither of us bothered. Instead, we searched the Freesian citizens' belongings and made sure no one suspicious was lurking nearby. We caught snippets of guests' conversations as we passed.

"Prince Vest—I mean, *Seneschal* Vest has really grown, hasn't he? He's got a nice style now."

"Princess Tiara is sooo cute! She looks just like Her Majesty!"

"Is that really Princess Pride? She's oddly mature this year..."

"Prince Albert's still handsome after all this time, huh?"

"Wow, what a lovely profile that Prince Stale has... He's so young, but he already acts like a proper prince!"

"I've seen Queen Rosa at this festival for the past seven years, but her beauty never changes."

Chatter about the firstborn princess had a distinctly different tone than the gossip about the other members of the royal family. Callum had attended ceremonies and said the princess was well mannered, but it hadn't been enough to change her reputation.

I mulled it over as I followed Callum. When I glanced at the gates, I spotted my fellow knights against the walls. The guard included a mix of rookie knights and guys from the main forces, all standing still and stiff as they kept a watchful eye on their surroundings.

"I guess Harrison has watch duty after all," I said under my breath.

Callum scowled. Harrison had joined the royal order the same year we did, but he was still a rookie knight after failing his entrance exam so many times.

That in itself wasn't unusual, but in Harrison's case, it wasn't lack of skill so much as the fact that he kept causing problems. On occasions like these, he landed assignments alongside the main forces, where he couldn't disturb anything. While he was on duty, the others would be the ones actually searching the guests and their belongings before entry.

Callum's eyebrows twitched a little as we watched Harrison check out each guest as they entered—but the other knight paid us no

heed. Sure, the guy was fulfilling his orders by standing at attention outside the gates, but he wasn't suited for this sort of thing. His strength and his special power would have done more good if he were patrolling the town or cracking down on crime. His abilities were plenty to qualify him for the main forces; he just had to fix his attitude.

"Such a waste," I said, hanging my head.

We walked past the gates and the rookies stationed there, who watched us in awe. Unlike Callum and me, whose orders were to patrol the castle on our own, this unit had to move as a group. When we waved, the rookies froze and bowed. They were just itching to join the main forces and become knights like us.

After a moment, they recovered and raced out of the gates like they were supposed to. It wasn't unusual for us knights to cross paths with each other, so they hadn't been stunned for long. The entire royal order was working together today, after all. It was also common enough to run into knights outside the castle, but even more so on castle grounds.

"Those guys we just passed were in the First Squadron with you, right, Callum?"

"I was thinking the same thing."

"We all joined in the same year."

"That makes sense. I wondered why I recognized them..."

ERIC

ROOKIE KNIGHTS spilled out of the castle and into town, chatting excitedly once they were out of earshot of the main forces. Normally, only carriages belonging to nobles and merchants occupied the sole route to the castle—but today, Freesian citizens making merry on their way to the festivities crowded the road.

The knights, on the other hand, were headed in the opposite direction. They flitted around the royal district, home to the upper classes and the shops the royal order frequented.

This part of town was just as lively as the rest. Some shops were open late, trying to capitalize on the festivities by selling fancy food and fine spirits. Many had closed up for the evening, their shopkeepers preferring to enjoy the festival themselves.

Musicians performed on street corners, and the townsfolk danced. Even the middle classes thronged the royal district, which they rarely visited even to shop. For commoners like me, just watching the knights head down from the castle was a form of entertainment. Knights from the main forces patrolled the larger areas of the royal district, while the rookies delved deeper into the neighborhoods where the middle and lower classes lived.

“Whoa, look, more knights! There’re so many in the royal district.”

“Hey, don’t be rude! Stop pointing at them!”

The main forces and the rookies were *very* different, but people unfamiliar with the order couldn’t tell them apart at a glance. They were all part of the Freesian royal order sent out to maintain public

safety. Townsfolk eyed the knights with envy and admiration as they passed by. Their pure-white uniforms fluttered behind them, drawing everyone's attention.

Being a commoner myself, I was no exception. As my younger brother and I watched them go, he said to me, "I thought you wanted to be a knight like them, Eric."

"I'm trying. Don't make it sound like I gave up."

I'd failed this year's entrance exam, but my desire to join the royal order remained unchanged. Plenty of hopefuls flocked to the entrance exam every year, but the royal order screened most of us out. From the rookies to the full-fledged knights—I admired them all. It was still such a faraway world from where I existed now.

"What unit would you choose?" my brother asked. "I know you said there's a bunch of different ones."

"I don't know. I just have to make it in first... Well, personally, I think I'd like the rear guard."

I didn't fully understand the differences between squadrons, to be honest. Only the knights understood the makeup of the squadrons and their specific duties. I struggled to imagine what might exist aside from the rear guard and vanguard, nor could I picture myself in the vanguard after I was so thoroughly defeated in my entrance exam. I didn't even have a special power.

"You should've said the vanguard! It sounds a lot cooler."

"I'm not buying you any more food if you keep complaining. I don't have much money to spare."

With that, I resumed walking toward our destination. My little brother was supposed to help with the family shopping. I purchased alcohol on a special festival discount, drained my wallet on the food my brother pestered me for, and then practically dragged him back to the middle-class district.

The festive mood lingered even as we left the royal district behind, but I couldn't help but notice the lack of warmth in the air. The middle-class district was full of street performers attended by audiences of children, traders calling out to passersby, and restaurants serving huge banquets thanks to financial support from the castle. This way, the middle-class Freesians could fill their stomachs for free without heading up to the castle. Even impoverished townsfolk left the slums on a day like this to sit at tables full of food and beer. All of them, regardless of class, drank heartily.

"Th-thief! Someone, help!"

Upon hearing the scream, I shoved my brother behind my back. A man sprinted away with a drunkard's wallet in hand. A nearby knight chased him down, let out a shout, and summoned more knights to help him. In a blink, the whole thing was over, and the thief was caught.

The knights truly were amazing.

VAL

"HMPH! What an idiot."

I grumbled at the caught and fecklessly struggling thief while I sat at a table eating with my bare hands. A lot of people tried to take

advantage of the festival to line their own pockets. More often than not, they targeted people wandering down alleys and backstreets, too drunk off the city celebrations to realize they were in danger.

If it worked out, the thief could walk away with a nice payday, but I didn't like the odds of getting nabbed by one of those knights or guards sniffing around. Most people in my line of work took the day of the Precognition Festival off. We got to eat thanks to the royal family's donations, even this far outside the castle, so I didn't see the point in resorting to theft during the holiday.

I pulled the hood of my long-sleeved jacket deep over my head, leaning over the table so no one could see my face, and bit into a slice of ham. Then I stuffed my pockets with bread and left the restaurant, still holding a mug of beer. I knew I needed to leave as soon as that stupid thief drew so many guards and knights to the area. Not only did my earthy skin tone make me stand out here, but my villainous features drew suspicion from everyone who noticed me. Of course, I actually *was* a criminal, on top of just looking like one.

I munched on the ham sticking out of my mouth, held my hood down, and set off at a brisk pace. Some little brat blocked my path, so I kicked him aside.

"Ow!"

I just glared and pressed forward. The boy's older brother spun around and yelled after me, but I ignored the brat completely and stuffed the rest of the ham into my mouth, taking a swig from my mug.

Avoiding the road where the knights had apprehended that thief, I slipped into one of my usual alleyways instead. I finished off my giant beer in a couple gulps and dropped it on the ground, where it joined many other mugs and food scraps. My fellow criminals shot me wary glances, but once they realized I was one of them, they lost interest.

I was about to step out onto another main street, lured in by the smell of grilled meat, when I spotted a few brats from the slums chowing down on their free bread and meat skewers. Children normally ran away from me, but they were too absorbed in their meals to notice my approach. I barked at them for blocking my path—stepping on them, pulling their hair, and kicking them to the side. They screamed and cried, abandoning their half-eaten food as they fled. I spit on the remnants of their bread and skewers before stepping out into the street.

“Stupid brats. Everything’s somethin’ to cry about with them.”

I didn’t hate the festival itself, since I got free stuff out of it. The problem was that the usual criminal hangouts and the streets themselves wound up packed with people from the slums, not to mention all the knights and guards on patrol. I didn’t even want to look at those bastards.

“Guess I’ll just drink for a while before headin’ home.”

“Home” was a cliffside area outside of Freesia’s borders, but I didn’t say that out loud. A fellow cliffside resident had forced me to show him the best route into Freesia, since I was Freesian. He’d told me the festival was a great opportunity for us to take advantage of

the townsfolk, but then that idiot went and got himself arrested by the knights and guards only moments ago, meaning my responsibilities as his tour guide were through. I followed the scent of meat to another table full of free food and drinks, ready to eat and drink to my heart's content.

After all, the only place I truly belonged was outside of Freesia.

"Hey, Val! I want to try some too!"

"Me too! Me too, please! Let's all eat it together!"

On the day of the annual Precognition Festival, I returned to Freesia for a delivery. Sefekh and Khemet were tugging at my clothes, begging like crazy. I sighed in irritation. I'd grown to hate the Precognition Festival after Sefekh and Khemet started pleading with me to go back to Freesia for it each year. On top of that, we always had huge shipments of gifts and letters from foreign countries that we had to bring to the royal family for the occasion.

Fortunately, we'd finished our deliveries, so I only had the mailbag on my shoulder at the moment—though I knew Pride would saddle us with another big batch of letters tomorrow.

"Go eat somethin' if you're starvin', damn it. I already gave you money."

"Come look for that food stall with us!"

"Sefekh, I think it's this way! That's the direction the kids came from!"

Children passed with baked goods bundled in paper. Sefekh tugged on my arm, whining that she wanted some too, while Khemet pointed in the direction of the food stall. I truly couldn't have cared less about any of it.

"Shut up," I growled, but in the end, I found the stall for them in no time at all.

Reluctantly getting in line, I scanned our surroundings for someone selling booze. I left the line to purchase three bottles when I found one, having just polished off the last of my stash, then returned to the kids.

Years ago, I'd focused solely on the free food and drinks on offer during this festival, but now that I had money from my delivery work, the idea of wading into those crowds just to eat held no appeal. These days, I could buy whatever I wanted at the marketplace. I still had Stale's reward for my work during the war in Hanazuo. Considering my delivery job would be picking up soon, I figured I'd spend a little money while I had the chance.

The line moved forward until Sefekh could buy some kind of pastry wrapped in paper. She and Khemet lit up at first bite, yelping about how delicious they were. They tried to force the treats into my mouth too, since I was busy carrying bottles instead of holding their hands. Sefekh grabbed my arm—since Khemet couldn't reach my mouth—and yanked me down toward her. After they each stuck a pastry in my mouth, I chewed them up in a flash before washing them down with more liquor.

"Hey! You should savor them! They're really good!" Sefekh said.

"You're the one who shoved the damn things in my mouth," I said.

"They said these are called *échaudés*!" Khemet said. "Did they taste nice with your drink? Why don't we buy some meat too?!"

Khemet clutched my arm while Sefekh scolded me. The damn brats were just going to keep dragging me from stall to stall, and I really didn't feel like tasting every single thing they bought. I just wanted to drink in peace at one of my regular taverns, not in the loud, bustling streets or marketplaces. But the kids were eager to savor the festival and would never agree to a change of plans, so I gave up without even mentioning it.

"Look, Val! Meat! They're selling meat over there!" Sefekh cried.

"I want more sweets! And fruit!" Khemet said.

I heaved another weary sigh as the kids searched for their next stop before even finishing the treats in their hands. Instead of yanking my arms away, however, I let them tow me along through the center of the marketplace.

Just ahead, someone shouted, "Thief!"

Some guy pretending to examine a shop's wares had made off with their money. We watched the culprit flee but didn't do anything about the crime. If this was a delivery job, sure, we might have intervened as per usual. We often apprehended the bandits and criminals we met on the road and dragged them back to the royal order. But we had no interest in resolving issues that didn't involve us.

I tossed my empty bottle on the side of the road and continued toward the stand selling meat.

A commotion rose up as a knight caught the thief around the corner, but that didn't interest me in the slightest.

ALAN

"THANK YOU SO MUCH, Mr. Knight!"

I watched as Harrison accepted the shopkeeper's gratitude and left the thief with a guard who'd rushed over to help him. Looking satisfied that he'd done his part, he sprang up and darted off. A gust of wind blew past startled townsfolk and guards as he disappeared to find his next errand.

He jumped from rooftop to rooftop, not even using his special power to head toward the main street. The guy must've thought it would be easier to spot criminals from up there, where he could get a better view.

"Look at Harrison go!" I said. "If he's coming from the marketplace, I bet he caught himself a thief."

I chuckled at the distant sight of Harrison running across the rooftops. In my role as a captain of the royal order, I'd been using my shift change to patrol the area, something I'd done many times during Precognition Festivals. This was my first time spotting Harrison out in the wild, though, and it was kind of like catching a glimpse of an endangered bird or something.

In truth, I was moved. Harrison was always relegated to backup duties when the rest of the royal order went out on urgent business,

even years later, when I became a captain, but it seemed he'd finally gotten his first assignment to patrol the town.

After Harrison became the captain of the Eighth Squadron and could assign his men to whatever positions he pleased, he *still* took on those modest assignments, thinking he was more suited for them. All that time, he seemed to accept the lookout jobs he did during his many years as a rookie as the most reasonable option, but now that he was a vice captain, he'd finally taken on patrol assignments when the orders came down.

"Guess it's not all that surprising, since the order came from Arthur."

Arthur, Harrison's current captain, was the one who'd ordered him to patrol the town. As Harrison's superior, Arthur had asked him to hand over any criminals he apprehended to the guards. Harrison was finally free to use his agility and quick wit to patrol the festival.

I chuckled, relieved by this development. I'd finished my own patrol and started back to the castle before Harrison's shift ended. Once I made it through the royal district, I took the road up to the castle, crowded by my fellow Freesians. I greeted groups of rookies and other knights as they passed on their patrols, then cut in front of the townsfolk so the gatekeepers could let me into the castle. Groups of knights and guards still surrounded the castle, and one knight in particular happened to pass by: the vice captain of my very own squadron.

"Hey there! Nice work today, Eric." I stopped to say hello as he headed out to make his rounds. "You're patrolling the castle next,

right?”

“Thank you, Captain Alan. Yes, that’s right. Did you just get back from town?”

Our schedules lined up, so I wasn’t shocked to find him here. We’d both planned to be at the castle for the afternoon shift change.

As we chatted, I felt the eyes of patrolling rookies on us. We were the captain and vice captain of the First Squadron—the unit that specialized in fighting at the front lines—so the rookies watched us with blatant envy and admiration, standing up straight and greeting us formally. We greeted them the same way we would any other day.

“I wish our shifts swapped a lot earlier,” I griped.

“Yes, that afternoon shift change is still a long ways off.”

We glanced in the same direction in tandem, both of us knowing that the main event loomed before us. The banquet with the royal family was later this afternoon. Our eyes naturally gravitated toward the royal residence, where we could already picture the preparations taking place.

PRIDE

“I T SUITS YOU SO WELL, Princess Pride.”

I smiled at the praise as I assessed myself in the full-length mirror. Lotte and Mary said the same thing every time I put on a dress for a formal occasion. Still, I thanked them and examined my reflection. Though I often wore red to ceremonies and events, I got to wear softer colors and makeup during these annual appearances before the Freesian people.

This time, I'd donned an elegant purple dress that complemented my crimson hair. I couldn't deny that the color combination made me stick out, though. As the last boss queen, my appearance would always cause a stir.

Still, I appreciated the praise from my beloved maids. "You think so?" I replied, lifting my dress delicately over my feet.

Dressed, I called out for the people waiting outside the room. Jack, my imperial guard, opened the door for Captain Callum and Arthur—my imperial knights.

"What do you think?" I asked nervously.

Brow furrowing, I clutched at my chest. No matter how much my maids liked the ensemble, I was worried about what members of the opposite sex might think. Captain Callum and Arthur both gulped as they sized up the lovely purple gown. My dress matched my eyes, though I never wore such colors to events attended by the nobility. Did they like today's look or think it a shame?

I wore beautiful dresses for every social occasion, including ceremonies and tea parties, yet my knights didn't budge as they appraised me today. I watched them timidly, willing myself to exude at least a *little* charm. The purple color of my dress was so unlike the deep red they were used to seeing me in, but I hoped it made me look mature and feminine.

Arthur and Captain Callum stood as straight as arrows, squeezing their lips together but not uttering a word. In place of the knights, the usually silent Jack said, "It suits you very well."

His voice finally snapped the imperial knights out of their trance.

"You look wonderful," Captain Callum said. "It's a regal color that will put your air of dignity on display to the people of Freesia."

"That dress looks really, really good on you!" Arthur said. "Um, it matches your eyes! You just look amazing!"

Captain Callum's face was stiff and tinged pink, while Arthur clenched his fists, his blush on bold display. They leaned more deeply forward than they had when they bowed to me.

I couldn't contain a smile, though my knights probably just felt compelled to tell me what I wanted to hear. "Thank you."

Even if they were merely being polite, I appreciated their praise. It bolstered my confidence every time I had to wear a formal gown.

"I do this every year, yet I'm still so nervous," I said. "The Freesian people look at me so differently than my usual guests do."

My smile turned awkward. As a child, I'd acted like a strong big sister when Tiara and Stale jittered with nerves at their first Precognition Festival, but the older I got, the more the occasion rattled me. Cold sweat trickled down my back, and my pulse quickened from nerves. My heart was pounding in my ears.

Pathetically, I went through this same ordeal every single year.

Having my past-life memories made me more mature in some ways, but looking back on those earlier Precognition Festivals, I probably could have thought of better ways to cheer up my siblings. Formal ceremonies came with a very different kind of attention than festival banquets, and I wished I'd used that knowledge to empathize

with them. Maybe I could have said something more powerful, like Arthur would have.

My dress had fewer metal fixings than usual, so I could sit more easily at the banquet, but I still found the attire a bit stuffy. I took deep breaths to calm my nerves as Mary wiped the sweat from my brow with a handkerchief.

I plastered on a smile as I tried to steady my breathing, and Captain Callum gently assuaged my fears. "That's perfectly understandable. This is the one day of the year when the Freesian people observe the entire royal family up close, but please don't worry. The people of the castle town look forward to seeing you each year."

CALLUM

DESPITE MY SMILE and my reassuring words for Princess Pride... I'd had no interest in the festival whatsoever until a few years ago. As a knight, I already had plenty of opportunities to walk around the castle and see the royal family, at least from afar, so I never bothered trying to catch glimpses of them at the banquets. I only became interested in the Precognition Festival after the ambush on the royal order.

It felt like only yesterday when I stood on the tips of my toes trying to steal a look at Pride while dispatched to guard the banquet venue. These days, I got to stand close to her on a regular basis.

"Don't worry! We're gonna protect you no matter what!" Arthur chimed in.

While he wasn't great with words, he was doing his best. He thumped his chest with a fist and bowed, but he went too far and stumbled. I hoped both my gentle reassurance and Arthur's powerful declaration resonated with Princess Pride.

"Thank you," she said with a chuckle.

Arthur seemed as puzzled as I was by that laugh. Princess Pride apologized for laughing after we'd earnestly tried to encourage her.

"We were just kids all those years ago," she said, a faraway look in her eyes. "I remember speaking with Tiara and Stale during their very first Precognition Festival. They were so nervous. I wish I could have said nice things to them like what you two shared with me."

Based on what she'd said, her nostalgic smile—not one of sorrow—came as a bit of a surprise. We couldn't know what had actually happened between the siblings back then, of course, but knowing the princess, she'd said exactly what her siblings needed to hear. This was the same woman who'd sent shock waves through the royal order with her heroic conduct at only eleven years old.

Princess Pride shook her head and clasped her hands, ignoring our confusion. Perhaps regretting her response, she changed the subject. "Come to think of it, how did you two celebrate the Precognition Festivals before you became knights?!"

Arthur and I exchanged a startled glance at Princess Pride's cheerful tone. It had been a long time since either of us had celebrated a Precognition Festival, but we accepted her shift to an easier topic.

"My family treated the people of our territory to food and drink, as was tradition," I said. "Precognition Festivals are truly about coming together with the common folk, not strengthening the relationships between nobles."

As the son of an earl, I'd lived with my family some distance from the castle town. Nobles weren't invited to the castle, as per usual during the Precognition Festivals, so we held events in our own territories to bond with our people. We even followed the example of the royal family and dined alongside commonfolk. To me, it was just as valuable an event as the ones meant to strengthen relations between nobles.

Princess Pride and Arthur listened attentively as I explained, but they did not seem surprised. They knew I'd joined the royal order at a young age, but I'd proven intelligent enough to understand my family's traditions and motives before I left them. While Princess Pride nodded eagerly, Arthur cocked his head in puzzlement, noticing something strange about my spiel.

I wasn't exactly lying...but I was explaining my *family's* traditions, leaving myself out of the equation entirely. Until I joined the royal order, I hadn't been able to enjoy the yearly festivals. Once I decided to become a knight, I spent every free moment training, unless my parents ushered me off to some soiree or other. I also had to juggle the studies required of nobles—something my parents demanded I keep up with. Unless they forced me to attend events and socialize, I stayed at home and kept to myself during the Precognition Festivals.

But I wasn't going to burden the others with those unpleasant details. Princess Pride had gone out of her way to keep the subject lighthearted, and I saw no need to ruin that. Besides, I had no regrets, since I had become a knight in the end.

That was more than enough about me. I passed the conversational baton to Arthur, who flinched before responding.

ARTHUR

"AS FOR ME...I helped my mom out with stuff. She runs a small restaurant, so she had her hands full making food for all our neighbors. I always spent the whole festival cooking, serving food, and washing dishes. Before I knew it, the day was over."

Sometimes I headed into town if we ran out of ingredients, but I hardly ever made additional stops or took the long way home. There was a time when I went into town with my friends and enjoyed the festivals with them, but once I gave up on becoming a knight, I never wanted to go anywhere near the castle town—a place where I had to pass by so many knights. I preferred to stay in the restaurant and work with Mom. I didn't have those reservations anymore now that I was a knight, and looking back, I could see I'd been running from my problems.

Captain Callum's and Princess Pride's expressions softened, but they both knew how much I cared about my family and didn't seem surprised by my response. They also knew I'd given up on becoming a knight at one point, but I'd never abandoned my work ethic. I spent all that time helping my mom instead of goofing off.

"The festivals weren't much different for me once I decided I wanted to be a knight," I added casually. Maybe that made me seem even more diligent, since I'd continued assisting my busy mom even after becoming a knight.

"How is your mother doing now?" Princess Pride asked. "She must be so busy without you or Commander Roderick at home to—"

"She's fine!" I said, waving away the concern in her voice. "The neighbors give her a hand, and she only runs the restaurant in the first place because she enjoys it."

Mother's restaurant was more of a personal passion than a job, so she kept it small enough that she could operate it without me or Dad around.

PRIDE

WHEN A KNOCK AT THE DOOR interrupted us, I called out to the visitor before Jack could take care of it. "Yes?"

"It's me, Elder Sister. We should head to the antechamber soon. Tiara's with me too."

I doubted Stale had needed as long to change as Tiara and I did, but his work with Uncle Vest would have delayed him. Tiara had apparently joined him so we could gather before we had to leave. It was something of a ritual, the royal family coming together before setting out for the banquet.

The door opened to reveal my siblings, who looked dazzling. Tiara wore a darling peach-colored dress, while Stale wore a brooch studded with purple and pink gems.

"How lovely!" I cried, beaming at the sight of them.

Tiara and Stale shared my sentiment.

"Big Sister, that dress looks so good on you! I can hardly believe my eyes!"

"Tiara is right. It's beautiful, like a gemstone. That dress wouldn't look as nice on anyone but you."

Though Stale calmly and clearly offered his compliments, it had taken him a moment to follow up on Tiara's joyful cry, as though he was startled or stunned. A flush rose to his face as he stood stiff and ramrod straight, oddly tense before me.

Stale and Tiara knew how nervous the Precognition Festival made me every year. But Stale's praise and Tiara's hands in mine fortified my courage. I thanked them and silently promised myself I'd return their kindness. Tiara always wore such vibrant, feminine dresses, while Stale had made sure to wear a brooch with the colors of our dresses, showing how truly thoughtful and kind he was.

"You *really* look adorable today, Tiara," I said. "I'd give you a big hug if it wouldn't wrinkle your dress. And Stale, you're once again so handsome, I can barely take my eyes off you. But most of all, that brooch looks lovely on you. Thank you both."

Pleased by my praise, Tiara beamed and twirled to show off her dress. Stale bit his lip and maintained his usual blank expression, though I knew him well enough to tell something had stirred him up. Maybe he just liked that I'd noticed his brooch, though I had to wonder if that was enough.

"Are you all right, Big Sister? Are you feeling nervous again this year?" Tiara asked as we walked out of the room, hand in hand.

I took Stale's hand as well, and we descended the staircase. It was a bit awkward to be on the receiving end of their sympathies. When we were children, *I* was the one who comforted them.

"Yes," I said simply.

Talking with them down the hall to the royal palace *did* help ease my mind. We entered an antechamber set aside for the three of us and waited until it was time to leave.

When the imperial knights arrived for their shift change, sweat broke out on my palms. It was almost time. This wasn't a formal ceremony like usual, but that didn't mean I could put on an act in front of the innocent Freesian people. I had visited the castle town on observation trips many times, yet this event carried a whole different kind of weight.

The maids fluttered about, helping with the finishing touches on our outfits, and then the guards arrived to summon us.

"Time to head out?" Tiara said, and Stale offered me a serene smile.

With their encouragement, I headed out to the carriage—only to see Mother and Father boarding their own. We climbed into ours in the usual order, with me and Tiara sitting side by side across from Stale. Then we returned to our leisurely conversation.

"If Prince Leon attends again, I hope to speak to him a whole lot today!" Tiara said.

"Me too," I agreed. "Cedric told me he was curious about the holiday as well, so I'd like for the two of us to chat."

"Yes, I hear neither Anemone nor Hanazuo have any festivals like this," Stale said.

As someone who adored his people, Leon seemed jealous of our custom of eating a meal alongside the Freesian citizens. Neither nobles nor foreign royalty could attend on this occasion, which only deepened Leon's interest in the holiday.

"That's right, although I believe Hanazuo has a festival where they open parts of their castles to the public. I've heard they carry out large worship services in Chinensis's giant cathedral."

Stale and Tiara seemed surprised by this revelation, but I was simply repeating what I'd learned from Cedric. Despite our alliance, the United Hanazuo Kingdom and Freesia still had much to learn about each other. Tiara had flinched at hearing Cedric's name, but the smile returned to her face a moment later.

The carriage slowed to a stop, and cheers immediately leaked in through the windows. I squeezed my lips together, but Stale and Tiara reached out, placing their hands over mine. Even through their gloves, their warmth reached me. When I looked up, Tiara's grin and Stale's intense gaze filled my vision.

"Big Sister, let's enjoy the festival again this year!" Tiara said. "Everyone loves you and Big Brother so much!"

"Keep your head held high," Stale said. "You always conduct yourself perfectly around the Freesian people, so Tiara and I can

assure you that you'll be all right."

For a moment, my eyes went wide. Did they remember after all this time or was that just a coincidence? I was certain they'd just echoed the things I'd said to them ten years ago—on that same day I was just reminiscing about. I broke into a smile. My siblings cocked their heads in confusion when I started to giggle, but soon they couldn't help but laugh along with me.

My imperial knights opened the doors for us. Guards stood in a row outside our carriage. As the cacophony of the crowd reached us directly, Stale and Tiara spoke at the same time.

"Let's go, shall we?"

I squeezed their hands, rising from my seat. Stale and Tiara exited before me. When I emerged as well, thunderous applause and raucous cheers greeted us.

Standing between my siblings, I spoke quietly enough that only they would hear. "Today is an opportunity for you to see the faces of the people you're going to protect someday. Let's burn them into our memories, okay?"

My words—those of a big sister above all else—emerged with a smile. Here with Stale and Tiara, I truly felt like I could stand in front of our people with my head held high. My eyes sparkled, as I was filled with happiness to have people like Stale and Tiara here with me, holding my hands.

Mother, Father, and Uncle had already exited their own carriage. They watched us with warm smiles as we entered the banquet hall. While the crowd cheered, we bowed alongside the queen, waved at

the guests, and offered smiles of our own. Then we followed the adults to our designated table.

STALE

"HAVE A SEAT, Elder Sister."

"Thank you, Stale."

I pulled out a chair for her—a small gesture, but one that drew a cheer from the crowd. Uncle Vest, the Freesian seneschal, wore a smile tinged with nostalgia as he watched us.

I moved to my own seat and found Gilbert waiting for me. I carefully tucked away my scowl and took my seat when the prime minister pulled it out for me.

Gilbert had offered chairs to Father and Pride in the past, but he took on this role for me starting at the second Precognition Festival after my adoption. At the time, I'd refused to let Gilbert offer Pride her seat as a way of displaying my hatred of the prime minister. But I was also Pride's steward. It made Pride and Tiara seem happy to see Gilbert offering me a chair without either of us snapping at each other.

GILBERT

WITH STALE SEATED, I stepped gracefully to Albert's side. I leaned in and, with a smile, whispered into his ear, "I'm pleased to see Princess Pride has overcome her nervousness this year."

As prime minister, I kept my tone formal due to the public setting. Albert quietly agreed with me. He sighed, glancing at his wife, but the queen was as calm and composed as ever. It was hard to

believe she was the same woman who, in the antechamber shared by the three of us alone, had been so anxious about her children.

"Do you think the three of them are nervous? Goodness, I'm so delighted to be dining with them!"

Food arrived for those of us at the royal family's table. Unlike the dishes the guests enjoyed, this food had been checked for poison. All of this was quite ordinary for the royal family, though their guests found it an extraordinary sight—even those who were accustomed to being around the royals.

ERIC

"PRINCESS PRIDE is so damn beautiful, isn't she, Eric?"

"Please don't speak that way, Captain Alan," I chided him.

We'd taken over for Callum and Arthur. We kept our voices low, our lips hardly moving. Imperial knights got the best seat in the house, as we could observe Pride and the royal family up close.

I tensed at Alan's remark, trying to hide my displeasure. This was a dignified event, and we needed to keep our nerves from showing. My warning about Alan's manner of speech wasn't very persuasive, but the royal family and the Freesian people were both watching us. They wouldn't tolerate us goofing off.

Still, I understood all too well how such a comment could escape Alan's mouth. After all, the princess was smiling beautifully in that purple dress of hers. Upon arriving for our shift change, both of us had blushed the second we laid eyes on her. It was like she stole our hearts anew every time she appeared in a different dress. No one

could forget that she was a fully grown woman, far more mature and elegant than the eleven-year-old girl we once knew.

A mass of Freesian citizens surrounded the venue. Not only did they want to dine on the high-quality food, enjoy the expensive alcohol, and take in the performances, but the banquet was also their chance to commit the sight of their beloved royals to memory.

Some of our knights were trying to catch glimpses through gaps in the crowd. When I spotted some of them jumping to see over the others' heads, I couldn't keep my distaste from showing on my face. The tables and chairs were full, the spots to stand and eat were occupied, and even the separate lines for observers couldn't accommodate any more people. Other knights passed by the throng on their own business, but I knew *exactly* who they were all trying to get a better look at.

Everyone watched as the royal family began their meal, eating carefully so as not to make so much as a *clink* with their utensils. Alan and I picked up on the eager voices bubbling out of the crowd.

"Seneschal Vest... His style never changes, no matter how many years I see him."

"Princess Tiara is so pretty, isn't she? She and Princess Pride look adorable when they're side by side like that."

"So that's the Princess Pride everyone talks about?! She's beautiful!"

"I've heard rumors of how she stole the hearts of many princes and noblemen. But what else would you expect? She has Queen Rosa's blood, after all."

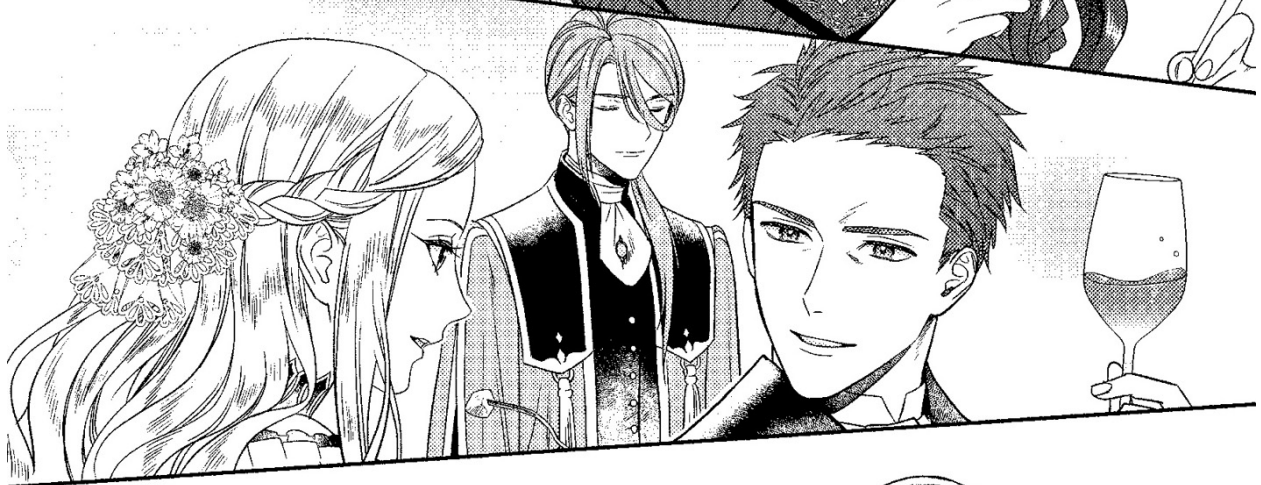
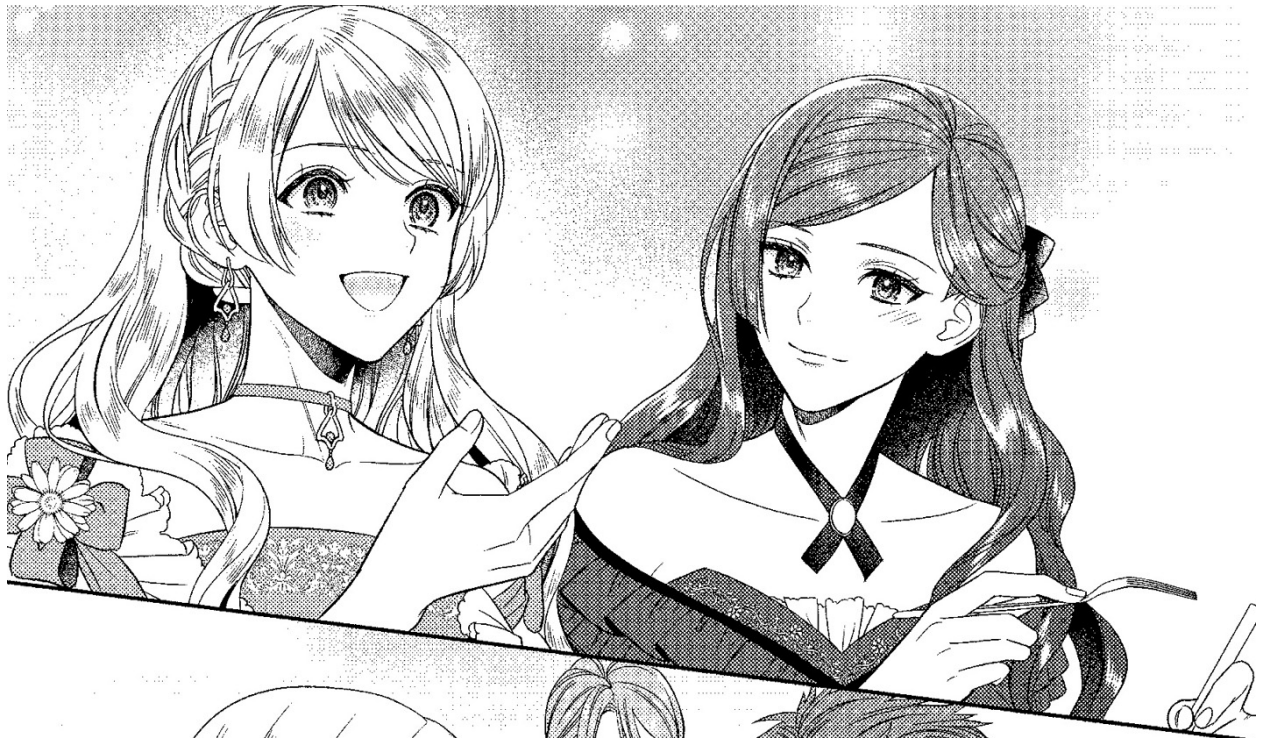
"Prince Albert has such an intense look. I think it's lovely."

"Oh my gosh! Prince Stale just looked at me! His face is like a work of art. Aaaah, he's so handsome!"

"I've seen Her Majesty at this festival for the past seventeen years, but her beauty never changes."

Over the past decade, the Freesian people had only grown to love and support the royals even more. Ten years later, Princess Pride's reputation was completely different from how it began.

Awash in the warm words of the guests surrounding them, the royal family enjoyed a peaceful banquet.



Marionettes

TIARA

"ARE YOU SURE I can touch it?!"

My eager voice bounced off the walls of the great hall. The royal family was attending a party thrown by a duke with close family relations to us. I'd been absolutely dazzled by the puppet show that captivated the rest of the guests as well.

The puppeteer seemed both moved and humbled by the warm reception. He offered me the marionette I'd shown the most interest in.

With his instructions, I worked the strings. The marionette wobbled awkwardly, but all the guests applauded my efforts nonetheless.

"Look at that, Tiara," Pride told me. "You're so good at it."

"No, it's really hard! Would you two like to try?!"

The audience was surely only being polite, but my big sister's praise elicited a shy smile from me. Unable to move the marionette as skillfully as the puppeteer, I made it bow its head apologetically to my siblings as I suggested they take over.

"Um...why don't you go first, Stale?" Pride said.

"If you insist, Elder Sister. Although I wouldn't say I have much confidence. It looks quite difficult."

Stale accepted Pride's offer with a bow. He left his glass with a waiter and took the marionette's crossbar one hand at a time.

Following the directions from the puppeteer, he managed to move the marionette much more fluidly than I had. The crowd gasped and applauded, though it was hardly surprising to see Stale display that kind of skill.

I could make the marionette stand and bow, but Stale's bow included subtleties like hand movements. The smiling doll moved elegantly, like it had a soul of its own. Pride and I curtsied in return, charmed. Even Stale smiled a little as he thanked the puppeteer and carefully passed the marionette to Pride.

My big sister looked like she wanted to decline, but in the end, she timidly accepted the crossbar. Her shoulders stiff, she followed the puppeteer's instructions...and stopped almost right away.

"Oh... It's no use." Her face fell. "The strings got tangled. I'm sorry."

Pride was a force of pure destruction when it came to any skill not required of a queen, and the marionette was no different. The crowd smiled politely, and she returned the doll before she ended up ruining one of the tools of the puppeteer's trade. He untangled the strings with ease, put the marionette into a pose, and handed the crossbar back to her.

The guests applauded warmly now that Pride was holding the doll the puppeteer had kindly posed for her. Though they treated her a bit like a child, she managed to smile back through her embarrassment.

When she accidentally wrenched the marionette's right arm into a painful-looking pose, she quietly apologized to the doll once again.

Afterword

HELLO, this is Tenichi.

Thank you very much for purchasing *The Most Heretical Last Boss Queen: From Villainess to Savior* Volume 9, or *Last Boss Queen 9*.

It's thanks to all of you that we've finally arrived at this volume. When I first received the offer to publish my series, never in my wildest dreams did I believe it would go this far into the story.

This volume depicts the "happy ending" arc, where each character sets out on the path toward their happiness. Pride is also making progress toward a "happy ending." Allow me to share one comment I left on the web version for those of you reading the novels:

This was something I had planned from the very beginning.

I wrote this volume's bonus chapter while focusing on the changes that have occurred during the ten years of Pride's story. I hope you'll enjoy the reminders of the growth everyone has made over those mere ten years.

If you've read this far and have any particular characters or episodes you enjoy, please check out the web version published on *Shousetsuka ni Narou* as well.

Thank you, Suzunosuke-sensei, for another batch of beautiful, powerful illustrations. The cover in particular is even lovelier than

usual, and I've caught myself staring at it many times. I'm so moved by the care you put into the wonderful design and presentation.

Akiko Kawano-sensei and Misaki Kogawa-sensei's manga version is finally reaching Val's arc. Their adaptation is very lovely, so please check it out if you haven't already.

Finally, to everyone who purchased this book, those who've been reading the web version, Suzunosuke-sensei, Akiko Kawano-sensei, Misaki Kogawa-sensei, those who sent me fan letters, everyone at Ichijinsha, those who helped with publishing and novelization, those who sell this book, the managers who placed my books at the front of the store, all bookstore employees, the editor who supported me, my family who cheers me on, and my friends—I offer you all my most heartfelt thanks.

I hope to see all of my kindhearted readers again in the future.

...If I could make one more wish, it would be that the very ending of this story reaches all of your hands in the form of a novel someday.



Thank you for reading!

Get the latest news about your favorite Seven Seas books and brand-new licenses delivered to your inbox every week:

[Sign up for our newsletter!](#)

Or visit us online:

gomanga.com/newsletter

Table of Contents

[Table of Contents](#)

[Color Inserts](#)

[Table of Contents Page](#)

[Inovels](#)

[Title Page](#)

[Characters](#)

[Copyrights and Credits](#)

[Chapter 1: The Unconcerned Princess Reflects on the Past](#)

[Chapter 2: The Prime Minister's Concerns](#)

[Chapter 3: The Deliveryman's and the Trade Prince's Concerns](#)

[Chapter 4: The Vice Captain of the Eighth Squadron's Concerns](#)

[Chapter 5: The Royal Prince's Concerns](#)

[Chapter 6: A Story Worthy of a Prequel](#)

[Chapter 7: Opening Curtain](#)

[Chapter 8: "But All of That Wouldn't Happen for Ten More Years,
on the Day of Tiara's Sixteenth Birthday."](#)

[Changing Hearts](#)

[Marionettes](#)

[Afterword](#)

[Newsletter](#)